

KING OF TEETH



KING *of* TEETH



THE BLOOD CODE · BOOK ONE

AURELIA THORN

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and events are the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, is coincidental. New Orleans is real. Its vampire court, as far as the author knows, is not.

This book contains explicit sexual content, graphic violence, and themes intended for adult readers. A full content list follows.

First edition, 2026.

For every girl who's ever been the ghost in the room.

He sees you.

He bites.



BEFORE YOU BEGIN



This is a dark romance. It is not a safe book, and it is not trying to be one.

Lucian Croix is a vampire king who feeds on the people of his city and erases their memory afterward, and he does not apologize for it. He is not a good man. He is not going to become one. If you are looking for a hero who learns to be gentle, put this down now and go in peace. He learns other things.

What you'll find inside, so you can decide:

- Blood drinking, on the page and often. Feeding as sex. Feeding without sex.
- A first encounter where he feeds on her in a back hallway, believing she's under his hypnosis. It doesn't take, and he doesn't know that yet. His power could never make her want him. She wants him anyway, and that is the whole problem.
- Dubious consent, from his side of it: he thinks she can't refuse. She could, and she doesn't.
- Explicit sex, a lot of it, described plainly. Oral. Anal. Rough sex and tender sex.
- Breath play and choking, with a signal and a man who keeps to it.
- Restraints. Degradation and praise. Name-calling she asks for.
- Blood play, including a scene where she opens her own wrist to feed him.
- Graphic violence. A massacre in a dining room. A beheading under the law.
- Murder of the heroine's parents (in the past, described).
- The death of a young secondary character, and sex as comfort in the raw aftermath of it.
- Grief, revenge, and a heroine who spends the whole book planning to kill someone.
- Stalking, attempted murder, poisoning.
- Strong language. She's a bartender. He's four hundred years old. Neither of them is careful with their mouth.

Every character in every sexual situation is an adult.

There is a happy ending. It is earned, and it is not soft, and the door is left open for what comes next.

If you're still here, you already know what you are.

Welcome to New Orleans. Mind your throat.

◆

Prologue

C A S S I A N

THE BOY SHOULD see this. He never will, and he'll spend the rest of his life deciding what it was.

Lucian is across the river tonight, holding a line his father drew this morning, and he asked no questions about it.

He has never once asked Aurelian a question, and his father has never once needed him to.

I came in through the east door, which has been open to me since before this city had a name.

The chamber smells of a slaughterhouse and a kennel at once. Wolves came through the gallery windows in numbers nobody credited. They are dying in numbers that make my point for me.

Gaspard's young, most of them.

Boys.

Somebody told them there was a door, and they believed it. Why wouldn't they?

Aurelian stands in the middle of it with his coat off.

He is beautiful when he works, and a man his age has no business still moving like that. There are wolves on their knees at his feet, every throat open, who learned it too late to use it.

His shirt is ruined, and his forearm is open to the bone and closing while I watch.

Nobody gets ahead of my friend. Who would be fool enough to try?

You can only be somewhere he isn't looking, and I have spent a long time learning where that is.

I cross the floor, and he sees me, and his face does what it has always done.

Relief.

He turns his shoulder to bring me in beside him, where I have always stood.

It is the one place at his side he has never had to check.

He's already talking, something about the gallery, something about sending for the boy. Does he hear me breathing? He never has.

I am not listening to the words, only to where he is standing.

I take the blade out of my coat.

He gave me his blood once, as a promise, and I kept the jar. Steel quenched in a man's blood will not let his body close.

It goes in under the ribs, upward, the way he taught me.

His fingers come down on my wrist, slowly.

The grip of a man steadying someone who stumbled into him.

Then he looks down.

I have seen him take a spear through the chest and keep talking. I have seen him lose a hand on a Thursday and use it on Friday.

He looks at my grip on the hilt and waits for the wound to close. Why wouldn't it?

It does not close.

It will not close tonight or in an hour. He has minutes, and he will be awake for all of them.

He looks up at me with blood at his mouth and his knees starting to go, and I wait for it. Rage, I think, or grief? Which would be worse?

I have imagined the accusation on that face for longer than his son has been alive. I built a life out of expecting it.

What he does instead is recognize the blade.

“You kept it.”

— ◆ —
L U C I A N

THE HALL DOORS have been open since morning, and every mourner who came through them was let in by somebody.

I can't put that down, and I've been trying since the courier found me. My father died in a room he'd opened himself. So who walked in?

They've come from everywhere, all in black, every one of them early enough to be seen arriving.

At the front, the account of his death is being given by the only person here who is actually destroyed by it.

Cassian's voice carries without effort, and there's no performance in it.

I've watched men perform grief, and they leave little pauses for the room to fill. He isn't leaving any, and his grip is on the rail because he needs the rail.

He is telling them that Aurelian Croix fed wolves from his own table, and that they came through his windows and killed him for it.

The room agrees.

The room has been waiting three hundred years to agree with that.

It's also the last fucking thing my father and I ever fought about.

I told him mercy was a thing you could afford until the night you couldn't. I told him the Code was a leash he'd put on his own throat.

He heard me out, as he always heard me out.

Then he said the only justification for power is what it declines to do, and asked me to pass the wine. Who says a thing like that and then asks for the wine?

Eight days later somebody opened a door.

Somebody sees me, and the silence moves up the hall like something spilled, and Cassian turns.

Whatever I see when he finds me is not politics: his whole expression breaks open. He comes down off the platform and the Elders part for him, and then his hand is on the back of my neck, the way it was when I was small enough for that to mean something.

"Boy," he says.

"Were you there?" I ask him. "Did you see it?"

"I was there. God help me, I was right beside him."

He says nothing else and doesn't need to, and I lean into the hand for a second, because he has earned it.

"They're saying wolves," I tell him, low.

"They're saying a great deal, boy. Let them. Grief makes people loud."

"And you?"

"Grief makes me tired." His thumb moves once on my neck. "Go and look at him. I'll be right here."

Then I go to the front and look at what's left of my father.

What I feel, looking at him, is a question.

Wolves came through the windows, and every account says so. My father was still standing when the ones who ran got out.

Somebody finished him after that, somebody who was already inside the room.

Who was close enough? Who did he let that close?

I turn and face the room instead of the body. Every House in the city and half the continent, all of them dressed for a war they want me to declare.

Marguerite is already rising to talk about the crown. Of course she is.

Who among them opened the door? I tell them I'm glad they came.

Every one of them.



CHAPTER

One

SELENE

THE MAN AT the end of the bar says *condolences* and means *opportunity*.

I know because it has two shapes: in English it's a hand on a shoulder, and in wolf it's the sound a door makes when it unlocks.

He's been here an hour in a good suit and no tie, with a bourbon he ordered by name and hasn't fucking touched. Who orders a bourbon by name and doesn't drink it? He watches the room as if he's working out which chair is about to be empty.

I pour him a refill he didn't ask for because it keeps me close enough to hear.

"Terrible thing, isn't it?" he says to the woman beside him. "A king like that, in his own house."

She nods, and she has no idea what she's nodding at.

"Awful," she says. "Do they know who did it?"

"Wolves, they're saying." He turns his glass. "Aren't they always?"

"Makes you wonder what's next," he says. "For all of us."

In wolf, *all of us* has a fence around it: the pack, the blood, the people who sleep under the same noise, and never the woman on the next stool.

He means his people, and a door has come off its hinges somewhere above him, and he's here to see what falls through.

I wipe the bar in front of him. Does he see me do it?

Nobody does.



AT A QUARTER to nine the street door opens and one corner of the room forgets how to breathe.

The humans keep talking, the band keeps tuning, and Antoine keeps losing an argument with the ice machine.

But the man at the end of the bar sets his glass down so carefully it doesn't make a sound, and why would a man do that?

I look. Holy shit.

He's tall and dressed for a funeral, because there's been one. Black coat, dark hair pushed back as if he did it with his fingers in a moving car, and pale, in a city where everybody's a little sunburned. He stops inside the door and reads the room: windows first, then the kitchen door propped open with a mop bucket, then the alley exit behind the stage.

He doesn't look at the people, only at how they got in.

And my body does something it has never fucking done in my life.

Wolves are a sound I can almost hear, and this is the opposite. The air goes out of one corner of the room and my skin notices before I do. The hair on my forearms lifts and my mouth goes dry. What the hell? Low in my belly, everything I am goes very still and very interested, and my nipples go tight against my shirt.

My mother used to say there were things in this city that were cold all the way through. You'd know one, she said, because your body would try to make itself small.

My body isn't trying to make itself small.

So what the fuck is it doing?

He crosses to the end of the bar without hurrying and stops behind the man in the good suit, close enough to be felt, without touching him.

"Sire," the man says, to his bourbon.

English says that's a title, but the grammar underneath says it's a man checking whether he's still allowed to be alive.

"You were in the house on Tuesday." The voice is low and doesn't carry, and every word of it lands at my end of the bar anyway. I've spent my whole life listening to rooms, and this one voice is easy.

"I was with the Aldrics all night, Sire. I left before—"

"Say it again."

The man's throat works. "I was with the Aldrics all night."

"And tonight you're on Frenchmen Street explaining to a tourist what's next." He leans down, barely. "For all of us."

The man goes a color I've only ever seen on things pulled out of the river.

"Go home," the tall one says. "Stay there. If I hear my father's name in your mouth again, I'll take the mouth."

The man leaves too much cash on the bar, and the bourbon, and the woman on the next stool, who watches him go and turns back to her phone like the stool emptied itself.

And the dead King's son sits down in the chair he left.

What does a vampire want with a bar on Frenchmen Street?



Sire. There's exactly one person anybody in this city calls that this week, and he's in my bar, in front of a drink that isn't his.

I take the old glass away and pour him a new one, because what else do I know how to do?

I set it down just as he reaches for it, and his fingers close over mine on the glass.

Cold.

Inside-of-the-ice-machine cold, brass-rail-in-January cold, and it runs up my wrist and keeps going.

He doesn't move, and his fingers stay over mine, and neither of us lets go of the glass. My own pulse is knocking against his fingertips like it wants his attention.

"Thank you," he says.

He doesn't look at me when he says it, because he's watching the street door for something.

Then he takes the glass and my hand is just a hand again, sitting on the bar with nothing in it.

He doesn't drink, just gives the glass one slow quarter-turn on the wood and watches the windows, the kitchen, the alley exit, like he's reading a lease for the clause that screws him.

I watch him.

I shouldn't, with a two-top waving at me and a ticket printing and Antoine yelling about limes, but I watch him anyway. The rain beads on the shoulders of his coat instead of soaking in. There's the line of his jaw, and his mouth, which is some bullshit, frankly.

My thighs are pressed together under the bar, and when did I do that? Jesus fucking Christ, Selene.

He's a vampire, *the* vampire, or will be the minute somebody puts a crown on him. His people own half the buildings on this street. His father just died on a floor, and the wolves are getting the blame. I'm standing here with my pulse in my underwear over a man who looked through me like a window.

He tucks a fifty under the glass and stands.

He never once looks at me.

I'm used to that, but I'm not used to minding.

The street door closes behind him and the air comes back into the corner of the room. The woman on the next stool finally puts her phone down.

"Who was *that*? Do you know him?"

"Nobody," I say. "Some goddamn tourist."

"Honey." She looks at the door, then at me. "That was not a tourist."

"How the fuck would you know?"

"Because tourists look at the menu, and that man looked at the exits. My ex-husband was a cop. I know the look."

"Was he any good?"

"At the job? Sure. At the rest of it? Shit, no."

"He tipped like one. What else do you need to know?"

"His number, for a start."

"Get in line, lady. There isn't one."

It's the first lie I've told in this bar that I wanted to keep.



AROUND TEN there's a woman at the door. Wolf.

I catch it like I always catch it, a sound at a frequency I can almost place. The back of my head sits up and pays attention before I've decided to.

She's young, my age or younger, in a good coat, and she holds the door for the man behind her. That's a wolf thing, where the one nearest the outside holds the barrier. In English that's courtesy. In pack it's perimeter.

She gets a few steps into the room before she catches whatever I am on the air.

Her nose lifts a quarter-inch, as if she's caught a bad note in a song.

Then she looks at me.

I've been looked at like that by wolves my whole life. Hatred would be a goddamn improvement. It's the face a person makes when they bite into something that tastes like two things at once and can't work out which one is off.

And here's the part I don't tell anyone.

My body reaches for her, goddamn it, every time. Under my skin, the part of me that has reached for wolves since I was old enough to stand in a room with one leans toward her, a plant turning to a window. Nobody asked it to.

She flinches and the reaching falls short, and the gap between us fills up with the ordinary air of a bar on Frenchmen Street.

My whole life of that. How many times can a body get told no before it quits asking? More than I've got, apparently. My body saying *there, that one, go* and the other body saying *wrong, spoiled, away*. I've been refused in a language I was born speaking, and the refusal never gets softer. It just gets as familiar as a song you fucking hate.

She turns to the man behind her. "Something died back there," she says, loud enough to carry.

"Yeah," I say. "My will to live. What can I get you?"

She doesn't answer, but the man with her does.

"Two Abitas," he says, without looking at me. "Bottles, not glasses. And don't touch the tops."

"The glasses are clean. You want to inspect them?"

"Bottles."

I give him bottles, caps on, and he opens them himself. They find a table near the window, away from the bar.

Away from me.

She's put a room between us, and pack calls that quarantine.

And an hour ago the coldest thing in this city sat at my bar, and did my body flinch? Not once.

It leaned in.



AFTER MIDNIGHT the crowd turns over and I take my break in the alley behind the kitchen.

It smells like grease and rain and the dumpster from the po'boy place, which has opinions. There's a crate out here I've sat on long enough that it has my exact shape in it by now.

Antoine comes out with a cigarette he's not supposed to have and sits on the other crate.

"Your tourist tipped fifty on a drink he didn't drink," he says. "Who does that?"

"Maybe he's in recovery. Maybe he's got a sponsor and a chip and a real sad story, and you're sitting out here judging him on one shitty bourbon."

"Maybe he's a narc. You think he's a narc?" He blows smoke at the rain. "You were looking at him, weren't you?"

"I look at everybody, because that's the fucking job."

"You were looking at him like he was the last shrimp on the plate, you know that?"

"Antoine, shut the fuck up."

"I'm just saying you're allowed, girl."

"I'm allowed to finish my break without a fucking TED talk."

"Fine, no talk." He takes a drag. "Shit, you're touchy tonight."

"I'm always touchy."

"Tonight you're touchy with a face on." He flicks ash at the rain. "Did he at least get your name?"

"My name? He didn't even fucking notice I had a face."

"His loss. You want me to go find him?"

"I want you to go inside and fix the fucking ice machine." He doesn't move, so I give him the rest. "He's not a tourist, Antoine."

"No shit, tourists drink." He points the cigarette at me. "Somebody in this city ought to look at you, girl, and it might as well be a rich one."

"I'm going to put you in the goddamn ice machine. Headfirst. With the limes."

"The limes didn't do anything to you."

"The limes know what they did."

He laughs, and stubs the cigarette out on the wall, and goes back in, and for a minute the alley is mine again.

I take my phone out to no messages, same as every night. I have three numbers that aren't the bar: my landlord, my dentist, and a woman in Tremé who sells me the tea my mother used to make. That's the whole list, and I'm not feeling sorry for myself, I'm being accurate.

My father was a translator who did contracts, shipping and some legal work and court business he never brought home. He was good at it. He could hear what a sentence meant underneath what it said. He taught me to hear it too, sitting at the kitchen table with two versions of the same document and a pencil he never sharpened.

"What did they say?" he'd ask, and tap a line with the pencil.

"That they'll deliver by the fifteenth?"

"Now, what did they *mean*?"

"That they won't."

"Why?"

"Because nobody promises a date that hard unless they're scared you'll ask about the month."

He'd laugh like I'd pulled a coin out of his ear. "Two languages, Leenie. Never trust the one they're speaking."

And a ledger, his work ledger, with every job, every client and every fee written in handwriting so neat it looks printed. I've had it since the funeral and never opened it past the first page, because the first page has his handwriting on it. His handwriting is the last thing of his I'm not ready for.



MY MOTHER WAS a wolf.

She was born Marisol Boucher, and she left the Thibodeaux pack to be with my father, which in pack custom is not a departure. It's a contamination.

English says *she left*. Pack has a word for what she did, and it means the limb the body cuts off. Rejected, not removed. The blood stops going there and the flesh makes its own decision.

She stopped being pack the day she chose a human man, and nobody told her, because nobody had to. The blood just stopped.

I got her face, and whatever makes my nose work sometimes and never when it fucking counts. I got whatever wolves smell when they pass me, which isn't wolf and isn't human. Something unfinished.

I didn't get the shift.

That's the sentence and I'm not going to dress it up. Wolves shift, and I don't, and I never have. My body reaches for it as a tongue reaches for a missing tooth. Nothing is there, and nothing will ever be there.

My mother could run four-legged through Barataria in the dark. And her daughter? Her daughter can pour a clean Sazerac and hear both sides of a conversation.

That's what came down.



THEY WERE KILLED four years ago.

Rémy Thibodeaux came to the house on a Thursday, the Alpha's son, twenty-seven and big. He did it with his hands, and my mother was between him and the door, so he did her first.

Everyone in Barataria knows it, and nobody asks the obvious question.

What nobody says is *why*. A pack son doesn't kill a woman for leaving, because pack has a long memory and a short arm: they stop calling, and the blood makes its own decision.

So why?

The official version, the one I've heard in pack grammar from three different wolves in three different bars, is that my father was into something. That he had a finger in business that got people hurt. That Rémy did what was necessary.

In wolf, *necessary* is the same word as *clean*. Both mean: there is no further obligation.

That word has kept me awake ever since, because nobody ever says what the business was. What business? Whose?



HERE'S WHAT I've built.

A job and a routine, and a body that can handle a double shift and a walk home at three in the morning through a city that is not as safe as it has decided to be.

My father's knife in my bag, kept as sharp as other people keep a car washed.

And an intention so clean I can see my own face in it.

I'm going to kill Rémy Thibodeaux, and I don't mean in a fantasy, or as a comfort I take out at night and put back in the fucking morning.

I mean as a plan, with steps I've been taking for four years, each one small enough to pass for a life.

Learn their schedules, their bars, who talks too freely, and what a wolf says when he's decided you don't matter enough to be careful around. I'm fluent in a language that does not want me.

What I don't have is a way in. How do you cross water that doesn't want you?

Barataria is pack ground, where a wolf who smells wrong doesn't cross the water without being noticed, and a woman who can't shift is a woman who can't leave the way she came if it goes bad.

I need somebody the wolves are afraid of, and I've been waiting a long time for one to walk in.



ANTOINE IS closing out the register at the end of the night.

"You hear the King's dead?" he says.

"From every goddamn person in this room tonight."

"Terrible thing, huh?"

"Yeah. Terrible."

"You know what's gonna happen, right? With the wolves?"

"Something. Why?"

"Something *bad*. Mark my words, girl, something real bad." He shuts the drawer. "Their boy's been down there all week, the son, and people are talking."

I keep my grip on the rag and my face on the glass I'm wiping.

"Which son? There's more than one son in this city."

"Thibodeaux's kid, Rémy." Antoine shrugs. "Somebody saw him at the fuel dock yesterday, fueling the boat and not going anywhere. Just there."

"Huh," I say. "Weird as hell."

"Weird? Girl, that's a man daring somebody. You don't sit at a fuel dock all day for your health."

"Maybe he likes the smell of diesel."

"Nobody likes the smell of diesel, Selene. Not even the boats."

My voice comes out completely normal, and somebody should get me a goddamn medal.

To a wolf, staying visible is the opposite of hiding. It's a declaration. You put yourself where people can see you because you want it understood that you are not ashamed of the ground you're standing on.

He's in the city this week, and he's not running.



I GET HOME a little before dawn.

Two rooms up a flight of stairs off Esplanade, a window painted shut, and another one that opens. I drop my bag on the table and the knife inside it hits the wood with a sound I'd know in my sleep.

I don't turn the light on.

I peel my shirt off on the way to the shower and stand under the water until the bar comes off me. Lime, rag water, somebody's spilled Abita. The pipes in this building take their sweet time deciding on hot, and by the time they commit I'm already out.

I lie down on top of the sheets with my hair wet and the bedroom door open, and I don't sleep.

The problem? I can still feel his fingers.

The shape of them is gone, but the temperature isn't. Hours later, after a shower and a walk home in the rain. The back of my right hand still thinks it's holding a glass with a dead man's hand over it.

English calls that a reaction, but my body is using a much ruder word for it.

I press my thighs together, and that's a mistake.

Everything between them has been awake since the street door opened. It has no plans to go back to sleep.

"Absolutely not," I tell the ceiling. "Do you hear me? Absolutely fucking not."

The ceiling doesn't care, and neither does my pussy.

Fine. It's the middle of the night, nobody's watching, and I'm a grown woman who has had exactly two boyfriends, one of whom thought a clit was a rumor. I'm allowed.

I slide my fingers under the waistband of my underwear, and I'm wet.

Soaked, slick all the way down to my ass, as if I've been at this for an hour instead of lying here arguing with plaster.

Jesus Christ, Selene.

I start with the lazy circle that usually gets me there fast if I think about nothing. I try to think about nothing and think about his mouth instead.

Some bullshit, frankly, that mouth.

I think about the cold, and what it would feel like on the rest of me, on the inside of my wrist where the pulse sits. On my nipples, which are al-

ready tight in the draft from the window. Cold fingers under my jaw, tipping my head back so he could look at my throat the way he looked at that room. Windows first. Then the exits. Then the exact place he was going to get in.

My hips come up off the mattress and grind into my own palm, and I pinch my nipple hard enough to sting.

Oh, fuck.

I know what they are, because everybody who works a bar on Frenchmen knows about the court, the same way you know the river is there. They drink from people, and the people go home and wake up tired and don't remember why. That's the whole story.

It's supposed to scare you, isn't it?

My body has apparently decided it's a pitch.

So I think about teeth, and run my tongue along my own and feel stupid, and wet, and very awake.

I think about him leaning down the way he leaned over the man in the good suit, barely, close enough that his voice didn't need to carry. Only it's my throat. His breath on my skin, cool where a man's breath should be warm. The points of his teeth resting there while he decides. Would it hurt? Would I care?

I push two fingers inside myself and my back comes off the sheets, and I'm so wet I can hear it.

That's new. Nobody hurting me has ever done a thing for me, and I don't think this is that. I think it's the other half of it. Being wanted so hard by something that dangerous that it forgets to look at anything else in the room.

He didn't look at me once.

I spread my knees wider and put my thumb on my clit, and the circles stop being lazy.

My heel digs into the mattress and I'm breathing through my mouth while the rain ticks against the screen. I'm fucking my own fingers and thinking about a vampire's tongue on my throat, which is a sentence I'd like struck from the record.

"Look at me," I say out loud, to nobody.

That's what does it.

I come so hard my thighs clamp shut around my own wrist. My whole body curls up off the bed around it.

I bite the heel of my other hand to keep the sound in, because these walls are made of wet paper and Mrs. Guidry next door goes to early mass.

It keeps going, longer than it has any right to. The last of it drags through me in slow pulls, my pussy still clenching around my fingers, and leaves my legs shaking on top of the sheets.

Then it's just the dark again, my fingers sticky and my thighs wet, the rain still on the screen.

I lie there with my heart slamming, my thighs still shaking and my face hot, and I start laughing into the pillow, because what else do you do?

"You need therapy," I tell myself. "Or a hobby. Or a boyfriend who's heard of a clit."

Nobody argues.

When my legs work, I wash my hands and take my father's knife out of the bag. I sharpen it as I do every night and set it on the nightstand where I can find it in the dark.

That part of me was here before the vampire, and it'll be here after him.

He's the dead King's son. He isn't my problem, and I'm not his, and in a city this size we will never be in the same room again.

Rémy Thibodeaux is my problem.

And he's right across the water.



C H A P T E R

Two

L U C I A N

THE DOOR TO my father's study has been unlocked since Tuesday.

I could fix it in an afternoon, but I sit down in my father's chair instead and look at the door from the inside.

He kept this room open because he wanted people to come in. The people who could walk through it without knocking were few enough to count on my fingers, and every one of them was chosen.

Chosen is what I keep getting caught on. Which one of them did he choose wrong?



THEY COME FOR me before noon.

Marguerite first, because Marguerite is always fucking first: my father's sister, twice my age, who has held the council together since Tuesday with nothing but a voice and the correct use of the word *traditionally*.

"You look terrible," she says.

"I've been traveling. Where do you think I've been?"

"You've been sitting in that chair." She crosses to the window and opens the shutter I closed. "Ambroise says you haven't fed."

"Ambroise talks. Doesn't he ever stop?"

"Ambroise is a physician, and you are the last Croix, and you are not starving yourself to death in my brother's chair, do you hear me? And if you'd like a list of the things I've had to say out loud this week to keep that from sounding like a problem, I can provide one."

She doesn't sit, and she never sits in here. She stands where she can see the door, and at her age it isn't a decision anymore.

Then the rest of them arrive behind her, and the room stops being my father's and becomes a chamber.



ALDRIC IS THE first one to speak, because Aldric is always the first one to speak when there isn't a king in the room.

He's been occupying chairs and calling it governance since before I was born. This week he finally has the room he's wanted, one with nobody at the desk.

"The wolves came in through the gallery and the wolves took the King. The court requires an answer."

"Which court? Yours?"

"The court that buried him, boy."

The room tightens around *boy*, from a man who couldn't hold a fucking door against me if I leaned on it with one shoulder. Every head in this chamber turns toward me instead of him.

I stay seated.

"Say that again."

He blinks. "Which—"

"The last word."

The silence in this room is the kind you can feel against your teeth. Marguerite hasn't moved, and nobody else has either. Which half of my father did I get? They're waiting to find out, and this is the moment they get to look.

"I misspoke," Aldric says. "Surely you can see that?"

"You didn't." I look at him, just look, with nothing in my face he can use as a reason and nothing he can use as an excuse. "You wanted to see what would happen, didn't you?"

He doesn't kneel because I told him to, and that's the part the room will misremember. Let the bastards. I didn't say a word about it, didn't raise my voice, didn't stand.

He kneels because standing has started to be a decision, and he isn't ready to make one.

"The wolves are not your concern tonight," I tell him. "They're mine."



HERE'S WHAT they want, and none of them say it in one sentence, so I'll say it for them.

They want a crown on me by the end of the fucking week, and why the rush?

Marguerite makes the case properly: the city has no king, and the continent has noticed. Three Houses that owe House Croix nothing have sent condolences worded as questions.

What she leaves out is that a crowned king can be advised, and an uncrowned heir can only be waited on. Marguerite has been waiting since Tuesday and she does not enjoy it. Who would?

"There's no contest to your claim," she says. "You're not weighing that, because there isn't anyone to contest it *with*."

"I'm aware."

"Are you? You are what this House has, a born heir, and every one of us has been alive long enough to know how rarely that happens."

"Say it again."

She stops. "Which part? I've said a great many things this morning, and all of them were true, and you've listened to none of them."

"That there's nobody to contest it with."

"There is nobody to contest it with."

I turn it over while she watches me do it.

Because it cuts the other way, and I don't think she's looked at the other edge. If there is nobody who gains the city by my father's death, then nobody killed him to get the city.

Which means whoever did it wanted something else. What?



BASTIEN IS in the corner with a folder he hasn't been asked for.

He's the youngest creature in this room by centuries. He's been holding that paper against his chest the whole conversation, waiting for a gap.

"Sire," he says, into the first one.

"No."

"Sorry. My lord, your—" He gives up on it. "I pulled the door log for the house, who came and went, the week of."

Marguerite's head comes around as fast as a gun.

"Nobody asked you to do that," she says.

"No, ma'am."

"Then why have you done it?"

And he looks at me instead of at her.

He's decided, in the last second, who he answers to, and I watch him decide it. I know what it will cost him.

"Because he asked who was in the room," Bastien says. "He asked it on the first night, and nobody wrote it down."

The room does a thing I don't like, and it closes a little.

"Give it to Silas," I tell him. "Not to me, not to anybody else in this house. Silas."

"Yes."

"And Bastien?"

"Sire?"

"You were right to pull it."

He goes out of the room taller than he came into it.



"He's a child," Marguerite says. "Did you see him?"

"He's a hundred years old, for Christ's sake."

"He's eighty-nine, and he worships you." She turns from the window.
 "Lucian. The crown. Please."

"No."

"Give me a reason I can carry out of this room. Can you do that much?"

"Grief," I say. "Use grief. They'll take it."

"They will take it." She doesn't blink. "It isn't what it is."

And there it is, and I'd forgotten she's my father's sister and not my father's courtier.

"No," I say. "It isn't."



SO HERE IS the reason, and she will get one sentence of it and no more.

The moment they put that thing on my head, the first business of my reign is a war vote, and it's already drafted. Somebody in this house has had it drafted since Wednesday. I could name the men who'd move it, and the ones who'd second it before the wax cooled.

And the moment that vote passes, the question of who killed Aurelian Croix is answered forever. Not investigated — *answered*. The wolves did it. It goes into the record in those words, and every year after that, anybody who reopens it is a man insulting a war.

Uncrowned, I am a son with a grievance and no procedure, and I can ask anything, of anyone.

Crowned, I'm the one thing in this city that isn't allowed to wonder.

"I'll take the crown when I have a killer," I tell her.

"They'll read it as weakness in about a month, you know that?"

"Yes."

"Your father would have taken it on the first night," she says. "And then done as he pleased."

"My father had four centuries of everybody assuming he was decent. I have a room full of people wondering which half of him I got."

That lands, and she lets it.

"One month," Marguerite says. "I can hold them a month. After that I'll be holding them against their own interest, and I am not going to do that for you."

"Understood."

"Can you give me something I can tell a man in confidence to keep him quiet?"

"Tell him to go to hell. No — tell him this." I look at the door, my father's door, open since Tuesday. "Every door in this house is open because my father wanted it that way. If someone walks through one and touches what's mine, I'll remove the hands, and then I'll remove the door."

She says nothing for three seconds, which from Marguerite is a standing ovation.

"That's not evidence, is it?"

"It's not meant to be."

"Then find the evidence." She goes out. "And eat something."



CASSIAN COMES in after the room empties, as he always does.

He waits until the noise has gone out of a place, and then he's in the doorway without knocking, because he has never had to.

"Boy."

"Come in."

He looks at the chair I'm in and doesn't say anything about it. He crosses and takes the seat across the desk. He sits down as if he has nowhere else to be today.

My shoulders let go.

"She's been at you about the crown, hasn't she?" he says.

"She's right, damn her."

"She's very nearly right, which is worse." He settles back. "Go and see Ambroise, and take him upstairs and make him drink something. He'll refuse twice, and then he'll tell you more than his report does."

It's genuinely fucking useful, and he's handed it over as easily as a coat. How does he always know?

"Cassian."

"Mm."

"Where were you, in the chamber?"

He doesn't hesitate and he doesn't perform the thinking. "Behind the west range of columns. With wolves coming through the gallery I went for the platform, and by the time I got there your father was already down."

"Who was closest to him?"

"I was," he says evenly. "I was the first one to reach him. I've been asking myself the same question all week, and the honest answer is that I don't know what happened in the last part of it, because I was looking at the wolves and not at him."

"Nobody was."

"No." A pause. "Nobody looks at anything else, in a room with wolves in it."

He leans forward and rests his fingers on my forearm, briefly, and then takes them back.

"How is your mother's house in Toulouse?" he asks. "Do you still keep it?"

"Standing, but I haven't been."

"Go, when this is finished."

"I will."

"You won't, will you, you stubborn devil?" He stands, and smiles, and it reaches his eyes, because with him it always does. "But you should."



HE GOES, and the door doesn't close behind him, because it has been open since Tuesday and nobody in this house is going to be the one who shuts it.

Wolves came in through the gallery windows, and three hundred people saw the glass come down.

Wolves did not open the east range from the inside. Somebody in this house did, somebody with a key or who never needed one. My father would have walked past him on the way to his own death without putting a hand up.

I've asked who twice now, and both times somebody has answered me about the fucking wolves.

I'm not going to be crowned over my father's fucking body.

I'm going to be crowned over somebody else's.

So I get up and find Silas in the hall.

"Names," I tell him. "Every goddamn one who was in that chamber when he died. By dark."

"And then, sire?"

"And then I start with whichever one is out drinking tonight."



C H A P T E R

Three

L U C I A N

THE COUNCIL wants a war and hasn't said so yet.

I can tell because they've dressed for it: there's a formality in the room this morning that wasn't here last week, collars done, seats taken by rank, and nobody's glass has been touched. When vampires stop drinking in a room together they've already decided what the room is for.

Marguerite has given me two days since the last conversation, which is all the patience she has. She's used it properly, and now she's at the long table with a quorum and a face that says she's finished waiting.

"Barataria," she says.

"Yes."

"Six of Gaspard's were seen north of the canal last night, armed, and three of them shifted."

"In the city?"

"On Tchoupitoulas." She folds her hands on the table. "Tchoupitoulas is not contested ground, and it is not neutral ground. It is a street where our people keep houses, and three wolves ran down it with their teeth out."

Somebody at the end of the table says, "Traditionally—"

"Be quiet," I tell him.

He shuts up, and the room adjusts around the silence, and I let it go long enough to mean something.

"How many of ours saw them?" I ask.

"Eight," Marguerite says. "One of them is Aldric's man, and he'll want it in writing."

"He'll get it. Will it shut him up?"

"He'll want more than writing, Lucian. You know that?"

"I know what the bastard wants. He wants a war he doesn't have to fight in."

"They all want that, Lucian. That's what a council is."



HERE'S WHAT the room wants, and why won't any of them put it in one sentence?

They want a strike on Barataria, hard enough to hurt, fast enough that the pack can't call it a battle, quiet enough that the humans don't fucking see it.

It's a good plan. Fuck them for that.

If I send the court in tonight, the next thing that happens is a vote for war. The question of who killed my father becomes a question nobody is permitted to reopen.

"What are you proposing?" she asks.

"A retaliation, not a war."

The room shifts.

"Targeted," I say. "Fighters only: nobody who isn't armed, nobody in a house, nobody on the docks after the boats are in."

"That's a list of things you're not doing," says Henri Aldric, a cousin of a cousin, who has been waiting for this sentence since before I walked in. "What are you doing?"

"I'm going into Barataria with Silas and taking back what they took from us on Tchoupitoulas."

"That's a raid, not a fucking retaliation."

"It's a raid at the volume I choose." I look at him. "And it's mine, not yours."

"The court—"

"The court can witness it or wait for the report, and either way, the scope is mine."

Marguerite watches me over her steeped fingers, a woman who has lived through every argument this room has ever had, measuring this one against all of them.

"You're drawing a line?" she says.

"I'm drawing a line."

"On our own retaliation?"

"Yes."

"Your father—"

"Would have drawn the same one."

That lands in the room as hard as a palm on a table. A few of them agree with me, and that's useful, and a few of them think I'm quoting a dead man's philosophy because I haven't built my own yet, which is also useful.

One of them, Henri, thinks I'm weak. Is he wrong?

Fuck him, I can work with that.



SILAS IS IN the hall when I come out. He doesn't ask how it went, because Silas has never asked how anything went. He reads a room by how people come out of it.

"Tonight," I tell him.

"Tonight? The court's going to hate that."

"The court can go to hell. It's been going there all week without my help."

"How many?"

"You, me, and six of ours, traveling light."

He nods, his hands in his coat and his eyes on the door behind me, reading who's coming out after and in what order.

"Rules of engagement," he says. It's not a question, because he's heard there are some and he wants them before the hall fills.

"Armed wolves only, nothing civilian, nothing domestic, and nobody gets clever. The first man who gets clever answers to me, and he won't enjoy the conversation." I stop at the window. "If a man puts his hands down and goes back, he walks."

"It's a good list," Silas says, as he says everything, as if he ran out of spare words before the Civil War. "Aurelian had one."

"I'm aware."

"His was longer. Took him an hour to read it out."

"I'm aware of that too."

He almost smiles, which on Silas is a loosening around the jaw that lasts about as long as a match.

"The Marchand house," he says.

I look at him.

"Silas."

"It's on the route, between the canal and the water." His eyes go to the window. "I'd like to skip it."

"Why would you skip it?"

He doesn't answer, and his hands come out of his coat and go back in.

"Because it's neutral ground," he says. "Ondine Marchand has kept it neutral since before you were back in this city, and she's never asked us for a thing, and I'd rather not put men through her yard."

"Fine, skip it."

"Thank you."

He goes fast, because Silas has never learned to leave a room slowly.

There's a delivery van at the kitchen entrance below, and I can hear the driver's pulse from up here. Steady. Warm. Stupid with trust.

I don't let myself count how long it's been since I fed. Four days? Five?



MARGUERITE finds me at the stair. Of course she does.

She's alone, about to say what the council would want to hear. She doesn't want them to hear her saying it.

"You're right to keep it small," she says.

"Thank you."

"I'm not complimenting you, I'm telling you I agree, so that later, when someone in that room claims I didn't, you can say otherwise." She adjusts her cuffs, and the gesture is so like her brother's that for a moment the stairwell has someone else in it. "How long can you hold the line?"

"Depends on what comes back. What do you think comes back?"

"What comes back is what always comes back: dead wolves and a court that liked the taste of it." She looks up at me. "Your father held it for forty years after the truce. He held it by being in the room every single time someone wanted to open the door wider. If you're not in that room, someone else will be."

"I'll be in it."

"You'll be in Barataria tonight."

"And in the room tomorrow."

She considers that, and then she says a sentence that has no business in a conversation about a raid. It passes between us without either of us stopping to look at it.

"We don't leave," she says. "This city, this house. Whatever happens with the wolves, we are not going anywhere. If someone in that room suggests relocating the court, even temporarily, you put that down immediately. Do you understand me?"

"Nobody's going to suggest— who the hell would suggest that?"

"Someone will." Her face is calm about it. "They always do, when there's blood. Someone will say it would be prudent to move operations to Baton Rouge for a season, or to the Roche estate, or to anywhere that isn't here. And you will tell them no."

"Why would they want to leave?"

"They won't want to, and that's not the danger." She's already moving past me down the stair. "The danger is that someone proposes it who sounds reasonable, and the court agrees because the court is frightened, and then we are not here. And we have always been here."

She says it like the walls are stone, a fact so old it's stopped needing a reason.

I don't ask for one, and it doesn't even occur to me to ask.



BY EVENING Silas is in the courtyard with our people, and the court is watching from the upper windows.

He's chosen well, and not one of them has the look of a man who wants to be seen being brave.

He gives me my coat, and there's a weight in the left pocket that's been there since Tuesday, and my hand goes to it. I keep doing that.

My father's blade, keyed to his blood, useless against anyone but him, and he is already dead.

I carry it because I cannot put the fucking thing down. What else would I do with it?

"Route?" I say.

"Canal to the bayou. We go in by water, to the dock at Lafitte's." Silas doesn't look at a map because Silas has never looked at a map. "Straight through the settlement, south to the levee, and out the same way."

"The Marchand house?"

"Wide."

"Good. Any questions?"

None. I look at the six of them, young, most of them, young for our kind. They've spent their whole lives being told the truce mattered.

"Armed wolves," I tell them. "Nothing else: nobody in a house, nobody who puts their hands down."

One of them nods, and the others wait.

"If you can't tell," I say, "don't."

Nobody asks what happens to the ones who can.

We go.

INTERLUDE I

Cassian

I COULD TELL him tonight.

He is sitting where his father sat, in the chair his father never once turned toward the window, and he has finally asked the right question: who was in the room. He asked it plainly, as Aurelian asked things, and then he did what Aurelian never learned to do.

He waited.

He is very good at waiting, and I taught him that, in a manner of speaking, by being the only man in his life who never filled a silence for him.

The lamp is lit and the decanter is down a finger and the house has gone quiet around us, as it does after the household eats. A boy and his uncle in a warm room, and there is nothing in this evening that is not exactly what it appears to be, except for me.

I taught those hands to hold a blade. Aurelian was busy being a king, so it was me in the courtyard every evening, through all the years that takes, and nobody has ever thanked me for it and I have never asked.

He has his father's hands and none of his father's certainty. That is the whole difference between them, and it is the reason this city is going to survive what is coming.

"Who was in the room?" he says again.

He has asked it again, because he makes men repeat themselves. He has done it since he was small, because a man who hears himself say a thing has to live with having said it.

Why don't I hand him the whole of it now?

Across this desk, in this light, before he has spent a single life on the wrong answer.

How would it go?

I would say his father's name, and that the east door has been open to me since before this city had a name, and that a door standing open is not an accident when the same man walks through it for centuries. I would put the rest of it in his hands and let him do what the law requires, and the law requires a great deal, and he would do it. He is his father's son in precisely that one way.

It would take the length of a short conversation, and everything after would be different, and none of it would be mine.

He is waiting.

For what? For me to be the man he thinks I am.

"How is the Marchand woman?" I ask him.

He blinks, because it is not the question he was braced for.

"Ondine?"

"Her grandmother's chest was bad in the wet years, and I wondered whether it had come down to her."

"She's — well, I think." He is thrown, and being thrown makes him courteous, because courtesy is what he has instead of small talk. "Silas saw her last week. He didn't say otherwise."

"Ask him, when you think of it, not as the King but as yourself." I turn my glass on the wood. "She has held that house neutral through the bad decades and never asked either of us for anything. That is rarer than you know."

"I'll ask."

He will, and he will remember it before the week is out and send someone, and she will be surprised and a little moved, and it will cost him nothing and buy him something real.

I have given him good advice, and I want that to be true because it is true.

"Your father used to say the household was the last place he would look," I tell him, "and the first place he should."

He comes up off the back of the chair.

"He said that?"

"After the business with the Aldric cousin, he said it as a man says a thing he intends to act on and never does." I set the glass down. "He trusted this house, boy, and he built it to be trusted. That was not a weakness in him and I will not have it called one, but a house that cannot be searched is a house that cannot be cleared, and you are going to need it cleared."

"You think it was one of ours?"

"I think you are going to have to be able to say that it was not."

Every word of that is true. He will take it up in the morning and turn it into orders, and the orders will be thorough, and they will find nothing, because there is nothing to find at the end of that particular corridor.

He sits back, and his shoulders let go, a little, because I have given him a direction and the direction is a kindness.

"Thank you," he says.

"How is your mother's house in Toulouse?"

"Standing, but I haven't been."

"Go, when this is finished."

He nods, and he means it. He will not go.

I stand and gather my coat, and he stands because he was raised properly, and we say the things men say at the end of a warm evening in a room where nobody has lied.

Why wouldn't he? He trusts me, so he tells me when he will be at the council and what he intends to say there.

And the door closes without either of us touching it.



C H A P T E R

Four

S E L E N E

HE TAKES THE boat out alone on Thursdays.

I know this because a wolf at a bar in Tremé told me six months ago while trying to impress a woman who wasn't listening. He said it as men talk about other men's routines, as proof the man is predictable, and predictable means safe, and safe means not worth worrying about.

Pack doesn't split *routine* from *territory*. A man who does the same thing on the same day has marked the ground under it.

Rémy Thibodeaux goes out at dawn on his boat and comes back at noon with shrimp. The whole dock knows his schedule, and I have been carrying that sentence like a key for half a year.

Today is Thursday.



BARATARIA smells like itself and nothing else.

Mud. Salt. The low green rot of standing water in a place where water never finishes standing. And underneath it, everywhere, the smell I can al-

most catch and never hold, the one that makes the back of my skull sit up and go very still.

It's pack, and the whole ground is soaked in it. How did my mother ever leave it?

I came in by bus, because my car wouldn't survive the shell road, and I'm walking the last mile in city shoes, which was a stupid fucking mistake. My mother would have known what shoes to wear.



THE DOCK IS at the bottom of a shell road that goes from pavement to gravel to nothing before you've finished noticing. There's a fuel station with a tin roof and a dog sleeping under it, and beyond that, the water.

I find a sun-cracked bench near the fuel station where I can see the slips.

The knife is in my bag, where it's been since the house. I can feel the shape of it against my hip like a word on the tip of my tongue.



I SEE HIM at eleven.

He brings the boat in bow-first, which I've been told is wrong for the slip but is how he does it, every time, because — according to the drunk in Tremé — he doesn't like having his back to the water when he ties off.

Pack would call that manners: you don't put your soft side to the direction trouble could come from, which is the same reason they hold doors from the outside.

He's bigger than I expected. Why the hell does that matter?

I've known his height and build from a dozen descriptions in a dozen bars. Knowing and seeing are different languages, and the translation is never clean.

He steps off the boat and ties it off without looking at the rope. He's sunburned across the nose and down his forearms. His shirt is dark with sweat, and his right arm hangs wrong.

That arm. A vampire did that, the King, years back, when Rémy crossed a line on vampire ground. Every wolf in Barataria tells that story the same way, and in pack grammar they use the word for a lesson.

He hauls two crates off the stern and stacks them on the dock, and a man I don't know comes down the slope to help, and they talk.

I can't hear them, because I'm too far and the wind is wrong. What are they saying?

Then it shifts, for a second, and I catch a piece.

"—told her I'd fix the porch Sunday," Rémy says. "She's gonna kill me."

"She's gonna kill you anyway, podna."

"Hell, let her. I'd rather die on a porch than on this shit boat."

The wind turns back, and the rest goes out over the water.

But I can see his face, and his face is not the face of a man who killed my parents. What did I think it would look like?

It's the face of a man unloading shrimp on a Thursday, ordinary and easy in it. He says something and the other man laughs, and Rémy grins. His whole body changes shape when he grins — he gets smaller somehow, younger, the bigness of him pulls in.

I hate that I can see that, and I hate that I'm sitting on a busted bench cataloging how a man smiles.

What the fuck is wrong with me?

He doesn't drink, and the same drunk told me that, unprompted. *Rémy doesn't touch it. Not since the business with the Ward family.*

The knife in my bag is not any heavier than it was this morning.

So why the fuck does it feel heavier?



I COULD DO it now. Right fucking now.

The dock is empty.

The friend has gone back up the slope with one of the crates. Rémy is alone with the second one, and there's nobody between me and the end of the slip.

It would be fast, because I know where to put it. Fast, and then done, and then the bus back, and the rest of my life would start.

My hand goes to the bag.

And a voice says, "You look like you need water."



SHE'S YOUNG, my age and small for a wolf. She's holding out a bottle with condensation running down the side of it.

I didn't hear her come up, so either she moves without a sound or I was somewhere else, and both of those are bad.

"I'm fine," I say. "Hot as hell, but fine."

"You've been sitting in the sun for an hour." She puts the bottle on the bench between us. "The bus doesn't come again until two."

Shit. She knows I came by bus, and she knows how long I've been here. I don't know whether she's been watching me or whether everybody on this dock knows everything that happens on it, and both options are the same shape.

"Thank you," I say. "Do you always bring strangers water?"

"Only the ones about to pass out on our bench. You here for somebody?"

"Just the water. Is that allowed?"

"Nobody comes down here for the water, girl. Not even us." She says it as cheerfully as a weather report. "The water's nasty."

"Then I'm a very confused tourist, and shit happens."

That gets half a smile out of her.

"You're not from Barataria, are you?"

"What the hell gave it away?"

"The shoes. Look at them." She looks at them with real pity. "Those are gonna die on the shell road."

"They've had a good life, haven't they?"

She sits down on the other end of the bench, close enough to be friendly and far enough to make no point of it. She's wearing a jacket that's too big for her and her hair is pulled back. She has the kind of face that's going to be something in a few years and hasn't figured that out yet.

Then she breathes in, and her whole expression changes.

There's no flinch, no pull-back, no face like biting into something spoiled.

She tips her head and looks at me as if she's heard me somewhere, a song from a room she can't place.

"You smell like my aunt," she says.

The bench is very solid underneath me, and I need it to be, because my chest has just come apart at a seam I didn't know was there.

Nobody has ever said that to me, not one goddamn wolf.

I have been read as *wrong* my entire life, and not once as *familiar*.

"Your aunt?" I manage.

"She left." The girl shrugs, big, the shrug you use when what you're shrugging about is the size of a room. "A long time ago, when I was little."

In pack, *left* and *contaminated* share a root, and she's used the smaller one, the one that means a person walked out under her own feet.

Is she old enough to know there's a choice? Christ, she's a baby.

"I'm sorry," I say, and it's the wrong thing. In English it means sympathy, but in wolf it means you're accepting a portion of the loss, and I have no right to that.

She doesn't seem to mind, just picks at the label on the water bottle and looks out at the dock.

"Nobody at home talks about her," she says. "So I don't really know why she left, just that she did, and that we're not supposed to say her name."

"That sounds like every damn family I've ever poured a drink for."

"You're a bartender?"

"On Frenchmen. You know it?"

"Mama says Frenchmen's where good wolves go to get stupid."

"Your mama's not wrong. I've served a few."

"Huh." She looks at me again, longer. "She liked music. Mama slips, sometimes."

"What's your name?" she asks.

"Selene."

"I'm Delphine." She tears a strip of label off and lets it drop. "You shouldn't be down here, you know."

"I know. Why? What's the worst that happens?"

“My dad would — I mean, it’s not safe. For someone who—” She stops and recalibrates. “You should go before the boats come back in.”

“Why? What happens when the boats come back in?”

“My brother happens. And my brother’s friends, and their cousins, and everybody’s dogs.” She says it fondly, as if it’s a joke between us.

Her dad is Gaspard, which makes this girl Gaspard Thibodeaux’s daughter and Rémy’s sister. I am sitting on a bench a dock’s length from the man who murdered my parents, talking about water with his baby sister.

If she knew what I was here for, she’d be standing between me and the dock. Wolves stand between their family and a threat, and it’s the first thing they learn.

She’s sitting beside me instead, picking at a label, and that’s either trust or innocence, and I’m about to betray both.

“My aunt made tea,” she says. “The kind you have to get from Tremé, and she used to bring it when she visited.”

My mother’s tea, the tea I buy from a woman who has never asked me why.

I can’t speak, because there’s a sound in my throat that won’t go up or down. Delphine sits there long enough to see it happen, and she doesn’t ask about it.

Then she stands and brushes off her jeans.

“Get the two o’clock,” she says. “Okay? And buy some real shoes before you come back. I’m serious. The shell road eats city people.”

“Okay. Will you be here next time?”

“I’m always here. Where else would I be?”

She goes up the slope toward the houses, and I’m alone on the bench with a bottle of water and a knife in my bag and a sentence that has just rearranged a part of me I can’t put back.



RÉMY IS STILL on the dock.

He's hosing the boat down with his back to me, his bad arm doing most of the work and the good one holding the hose. He has the radio on in the wheelhouse, and I can hear it from here.

I could do it, because he's alone, and I'm close, and the girl is gone, and there's nobody.

My hand is on the bag.

My hand stays on the bag. Jesus Christ. What am I waiting for?



THE BUS COMES at two, and I'm on it. The knife is still in the bag where it started, and I cannot say why. Why didn't I?

I have lived inside a single intention for four years, and I had a clear path to it today. I left without doing it, and if you asked me in either language why, I would not have an answer.

A girl happened on that bench, and she said I smelled like her aunt.

Is that a reason? I know that isn't a fucking reason.

I'm taking the bus home anyway.

Next time I cross this water, I won't come on a bus. I'll come with something the wolves are afraid of.



CHAPTER

Five

LUCIAN

THE FIRST WOLF breaks before I reach him.

His nerve goes first: he comes out of a house on the levee side with a rifle. A rifle. It's so fucking human it almost earns him the time to use it, and then he sees me, and his whole stance changes.

I've seen it in men before, a decision unmaking itself in the middle of a body.

He drops the gun and shifts, and the shift takes him two heartbeats, and by the second one he's moving, going west, going fast, going away.

I let him go. Why wouldn't I? He put the gun down.

"Anything behind him?" I ask Silas.

"Nothing armed. You want him followed?"

"What for? He's running the right way. Leave the rifle where it lies."

Silas is at my left, and I set the pace and he reads the ground.

The settlement is small and badly lit: shell roads, tin roofs, dogs barking, a generator running somewhere on the far side. It's a place where people live, and I'm in it with my people and a rule that exists because I said it out loud.

Armed wolves only, and the night is about to test whether I mean it.



THE SECOND one is in the road.

He's shifted already, because he heard us coming, and he's fucking big, rust-colored and broad across the chest. His ears are flat and his head is low and he's not running.

He's between us and a house with a light on in the kitchen. Who's inside? Children, from the size of the shoes on the step.

In my language that's a man standing in a doorway. And in his?

I don't run at him, I walk, unhurried, because I've never once in my life needed to rush. Every line of him says *charge*, and every line of him stays where it is. A man who runs at you has lost control, and a man who walks toward you has already decided what's going to happen.

He doesn't charge.

He shifts, and the bones rearrange under his skin and he's a man, naked, breathing hard, with his back against the wall of the house with the kitchen light on.

I lay my palm on his chest, open, against his sternum, testing a door to see if it's locked.

I push. Gently.

He goes backward, and the wall goes first: the clapboard buckles and the studs give. He's standing in the gap of his own house with my palm on his chest and the kitchen light on his face.

"There are people in that house who are not armed," I say. "I am not going through that door."

I take my hand off his chest and step back.

He stays in the wall a long time after I've gone, and the kitchen light stays on.

"You could have killed him," Silas says, low.

"Could I?"

"Sire. You know you could."

"I know what I could have done, and so does he. That's the point."

"Is it a good one, sire?"

“It’s the only one I’ve got tonight, Silas. Keep walking.”

My people take that image home, the restraint more than the violence. Nobody in this city understands this about my father’s philosophy. The rules are the proof that there’s an animal here that needs a leash.



SILAS MOVES through the settlement like water through a drain, always downhill, always toward whatever hasn’t been checked.

At a line of four houses near the south end he checks three and skips the fourth without breaking stride. Why that one?

I notice, and I don’t ask. Silas’s answers are always true and never complete, and a man who gives you the truth in pieces has decided which pieces are yours.



THEY FIND US at the levee.

Three of them, shifted, coming out of the water where the land goes soft. They’re not strays — they’re organized, moving together, and the one in front is old enough to know what he’s looking at.

The young one doesn’t wait.

He comes out of the water fast, low, mud flying off his haunches. He gets one of mine by the leg, and I hear the cloth tear and the man scream.

Then I smell it: his blood, hot on the mud, and I haven’t fed since before the funeral. For one second the whole levee narrows to that smell. My gums ache, and I swallow, and my teeth want down.

I’m there before the scream finishes.

I take the wolf by the scruff, a soaked sack of fur and muscle heavier than any man, and lift him off my man as you’d lift a dog off a table. He twists in my grip, and his jaws snap at the air beside my throat, close enough that I feel the heat of his breath.

I throw him. He hits the levee slope a long way down and rolls, and by the time he gets his feet under him he’s looking at me from the ground with his ears flat and his belly in the mud.

He doesn’t come back.

The old one in front stops. He puts himself between me and the remaining wolf, and the set of his head is neither attack nor retreat.

He's reading me. What does he see?

I let him read me.

It takes him about as long as a held breath, and then he looks at the ground behind me — at the road, at the houses, at the lights that are still on in all of them — and his stance changes.

The wolves behind him are waiting for a signal, and he doesn't give one.

Instead he shifts back.

He's old, with a face that's been out in weather for all of it. He's got a scar down one arm that was stitched badly and healed worse.

He spits on the ground between us.

"King of teeth," he says.

Is that what they call us down here? I know what it means: a king who rules by appetite, with nothing in him but the bite.

I show him mine. The full set, the ones that come down when the feeding starts, the ones my father kept hidden for three centuries.

The old wolf takes a step back, involuntary, the first honest movement he's made since the water.

I hold it a breath. Then I close my mouth and the face goes back to being a face. The man in the mud is looking at me as if a room he thought he knew just lost a wall.

I've been called worse by people I loved. He can have the name. I'll keep the teeth.

"You can have the fucking levee," I tell him. "I'm done."

He goes back into the water, and the two behind him follow, and the bayou takes them completely.

King of teeth.

Fuck him. I put it somewhere I can find it later.



WE COME BACK through a settlement holding its breath, and who can blame it?

"One unaccounted for," Silas says.

"Where? Tell me it's not the water again."

"The dock, the south slip." He nods toward the water. "Young and armed. He was outside when we came in and he went into the shed."

"Still there?"

"Still there. You want him dead or talking?"

"Take him," I say. "Alive, damn it."

The man in the shed comes out alive.

He's forty-something, and scared enough to look younger. He's got his hands up and Silas has him by the collar, knuckles against his throat. The man's face is the face of somebody who has just found out what his night is going to be about.

"What's your name?" I say. "And don't lie to me, because I'll know, and then this night gets a hell of a lot longer for both of us."

"Thibault." He swallows. "I was on the dock. I wasn't armed. I wasn't fucking—"

"You were outside with a knife on your belt. Did you forget it was there?"

His mouth opens and closes.

"That's armed, you fucking idiot," I say. "In my house, that's armed. Is it different in yours?"

He doesn't answer.

"Thibault." I lean down. "You were in my father's chamber the night he died. You came in through the gallery with the rest of them."

His whole face goes slack, mouth open, eyes wide, his throat working, the kind of naked recognition that I can read without any language at all.

"I was there," he says. "Yes."

"Then you're coming with me."

"Where? To die somewhere drier?"

"To talk. Whether you die afterward is up to what you say."

Silas puts him in the boat without asking whether there's a reason, because Silas has never once needed a reason to be supplied out loud. He reads a decision like other men read weather.



WE'RE ON THE water heading back when one of my people, the youngest, says it.

"Clean."

He means the raid: no dead, no burned houses, no women pulled out of beds. He says it close to proud, and the others take it the same way.

"Clean?" I say.

"Nobody dead, sire. Isn't that the point?"

"Is that what you think that was?"

He doesn't know how to answer, so he doesn't, and one of the others mutters, "Hell of a night," and nobody disagrees.

Clean is the wrong word. The word is *chosen* — I chose what to leave standing, so I could have chosen otherwise, and every wolf in that settlement is awake right now knowing it.

My father did mercy. What I've done tonight is carpentry — a precise amount of violence applied to the joints.

The cost of the message is that the line was mine to draw.



THIBAULT SITS in the bow of the boat with his wrists tied, his knees drawn up and his head down, and he hasn't said a word since the dock.

I look at the back of his head and think about what's in it.

He was in the gallery when the windows came down. He was there when my father was still standing, and he was there after. What did he see? Who was standing where?

I could ask him now, but a question asked in the dark gets a dark answer. A man who talks because he's afraid of the water will say something else when the water is gone.

I want him under a roof with a lamp on, and time to think. What does the truth cost him, next to the alternative?

My father would have asked on the boat. He would have put a palm on the man's shoulder and spoken low, directly, warmly enough that the man forgot he was answering a king.

I don't have that, because whatever carried that gift went into the ground with him.

I have a lamp and a locked room and the patience to wait. Isn't that enough?

Silas brings the boat in and we tie off, and I don't say a word.

I take the prisoner by the arm and walk him up the dock, and behind us my people go home to whatever they have, and not one of them knows what I want from the man at the end of my hand.

They did their job. I'm about to do mine.



C H A P T E R

Six

S E L E N E

THE BAR IS full and nobody is drinking.

I know the tell, because I've worked enough Friday nights to know what a crowd that came for the music looks like, and this isn't it. These people came because they didn't want to be home.

Antoine has the news on behind the bar with the sound off. Nobody is watching it, and everybody is watching it.

The crawl at the bottom mentions a disturbance in Barataria, a gas leak, they're calling it: an evacuation of several homes on the south end, two injuries reported, no fatalities.

In English, that's a gas leak.

In the other language, the one nobody in this room speaks and everybody in this room feels in their joints, something came through Barataria last night and the city can feel the bruise.

The old locals don't have the words, but they have the grammar.

Don't take the second drink, and if a man at a bar doesn't blink for too long, sit somewhere else.

If the news says *gas leak* in Barataria, stay out of the Quarter for a week.

The woman at the end of my bar, sixty-something, with her purse in her lap all night, knows it without knowing why.

"Another?" I ask her.

"I'm fine, baby. Just don't want to go home to an empty house with the news on." She pats the bar. "Just sitting, you know?"

"Kitchen's closing in an hour. Antoine's been threatening to go home since eight, and tonight I think he means it. You want anything before the fryer dies?"

"No, baby. I just want the noise." She looks at the TV. "They say what started it?"

"Gas leak."

"Gas leak. You believe that?"

"I believe what they put on the television. Don't you?"

"Mm." She turns her glass on its napkin. "My grandmother used to say when the gas leaks in Jean Lafitte, you stay on this side of the canal."

"Smart woman, huh? Sounds like she knew her shit."

"She was a frightened woman, and that's different." She picks up her purse. "Same thing, though, in the end, isn't it?"

She puts a five on the bar for a three-dollar tonic and leaves. I put the five in the jar and wipe the bar and think about the difference between smart and frightened. Does a woman who can hear both languages have any right to be either?



AROUND TEN, two wolves from Tremé come in and sit where I can hear them.

I know them like you know regulars you'd rather not have: the heavy one is Luc. The one with the bad teeth is his cousin, and I've never needed his name. They drink Abita and tip in quarters and talk in front of me like I'm furniture that pours.

Tonight they don't even order, they just sit, and why come in at all?

"Nobody died," Luc says.

"I heard."

"Houses left lit. Old Fontenot's kitchen light was on the whole time, man, the whole time."

"I *heard*, Luc. Christ. The whole fucking bayou heard."

"So what's that?"

The cousin stares at his hands. "That's him saying he could have."

"Could have what? Say it, man."

"All of it." He finally looks up. "The son walked through the settlement like he was looking for his keys, put Arceneaux through his own wall with one hand, flat, like this." He lays his palm on the bar. "And then he *left*."

"That's so much fucking worse."

"That's what I'm saying. Hell of a thing to put in a man's head at night."

I set two Abitas down in front of them that nobody asked for.

Luc looks at me for the first time in a year of drinking here. "On the house? Since when does anything in this shithole come on the house?"

"You look like hell, and you need it. You want to tell me what happened, or you want to drink?"

"Drink."

"Smart man."

He doesn't thank me, because wolves don't thank people who smell like me. Fuck 'em. But he drinks it.



THE COUSIN'S right, and it's worse than he knows.

A raid that kills is simple: you bury your dead and you go to war, because war is the answer to dead. The grammar is old enough that nobody has to look it up.

A raid that leaves your lights on and your people breathing is a sentence the pack has no word for. They're going to spend the next week trying to translate it.

I've been translating it all goddamn day.

What the dead King's son said last night is: *I am not my father. I could have been worse.*

Most people will only hear one of those sentences. Which one will the pack hear?

And I keep thinking about the other thing: the man at my bar, turning a glass he didn't drink, reading my windows like a lease. He walked into Barataria and every wolf there got out of his way.

I said I needed somebody the wolves were afraid of, didn't I?



THE RUSH DOESN'T come, and Antoine cuts the kitchen early and bangs a stockpot against the sink with more force than the grease requires.

"You okay?" I ask through the window. "You're beating the shit out of that pot."

"My cousin's in Barataria."

"Jesus. Is she hurt? Did you call her?"

"She's fine. Everybody's fine. Scared shitless, but fine." He sets the pot down. "You know what scares the shit out of me? Somebody decided everybody gets to be fine, and that somebody gets to decide again tomorrow."

Pack has a word for that.

It means a debt you owe because somebody declined to collect it.

I close at midnight and sit on my crate in the alley with the map open on my phone, Barataria a green smear south of the canal. I went there and sat on a bench, and a girl told me I smelled like her aunt. I left without doing what I've been building toward since the funeral.



HERE'S WHAT I'm going to do instead.

When a city is afraid, people go where they feel safe: wolves go to Barataria and close the gate, and vampires go to the places they own.

There's a club on Perdido Street with no sign and windows painted black from the inside.

Everyone who works a bar on Frenchmen knows about it. Nobody goes, though the drinks are free if the right people like you. The people who go in come out tired in a way sleep won't fix, and the staff doesn't talk about the back hallways.

The dead King's son drinks there. Will he be there the night I go? No fucking idea.

Every wolf in Tremé knows it and hates knowing it.

A woman who walks into a room she doesn't belong in might get a few minutes before anyone notices. A few minutes is a conversation, and a conversation is the only way across the water I've got.



IT TAKES ME until Tuesday to talk myself into it. Then I trade away a shift, go home, and shower and stand in front of my closet. What does a person wear to walk into a room full of vampires?

Two years of bartender clothes, black shirts and dark jeans and shoes that don't slip on a wet floor. Nothing in here was chosen, only selected, and that's a whole different language.

At the back there's a dress.

It's the one nice thing I own that I didn't buy for somebody's funeral. Black, simple, and it does a thing to my shoulders that I've never liked and have been told twice is the point.

I put it on and look at myself in the mirror on the back of the bathroom door, the one with the crack in the corner I keep meaning to replace.

The woman in the mirror is small and dark-haired. She's about to walk into a club where the most dangerous things in this city go to drink, because the man she needs is across a body of water she can't cross alone.

God help her. Honestly.

Then the back of my neck goes cold. Shit.

It's below sound, a frequency in the skin, the kind the wolf-half registers before the rest of me gets the memo. My shoulders draw together and the fine hair on my forearms lifts, and for one breath the dress stops being fabric and becomes a membrane, and everything beyond it is paying attention.

I stand very still. Oh, fuck.

Is it him? It's the corner of my bar when he walked in, the air going out of it, except the bar is eleven blocks away and I'm in my bathroom.

It's older than wolf, lower, colder, and I swear to God I can smell it through a wall and a mile of city. Winter in a room with no windows. My body leans toward it as if it's a voice I can almost hear, and the voice isn't fading.

The reaching stretches farther than it's ever gone, and my pulse picks up and my skin goes tight. I can feel the shape of whatever's out there as you feel fingers a breath before they touch you. The heat of it. The weight. The gap about to close.

It doesn't close, it passes. Whatever it was moves on, and the reaching comes back empty, same as always. I'm standing in my bathroom in a black dress with my palm flat on the mirror and my breath fogging the glass.

But it was closer than it has ever been.

My hands are shaking. Holy shit, my hands are shaking.

It isn't fear, because I know what fear does to me, and this is the other thing. This is heat, low and stupid and getting worse. Oh, for fuck's sake.

I'm wet. From *that*. From a frequency. Is this a medical condition? Should I be seeing someone?

"Get it together," I tell the mirror, and the mirror doesn't have notes.

The knife is on the counter, and I look at it. Do I take it?

I leave it there.

Tonight I'm not carrying a blade, only a face and a voice and the ability to hear both sides of any sentence in any room.

That's the inheritance: my father taught me to listen, and my mother gave me something to listen with.

I put my keys in the small bag, the one with no room for anything else, and lock the apartment behind me, and walk out into a city that's afraid of itself tonight.

I'm not afraid. I should be. That's probably important.

I park where the staff park, down the block from Perdido in a lot that floods, and walk the rest in shoes that aren't built for it, in a dress I've worn once, toward a room full of things that drink.

I'm going where they go.



C H A P T E R

Seven

L U C I A N

THE WOLF HAS been waiting to be killed for two days, and he's stopped expecting it.

I watch it happen in his body: the shoulders drop first, then the jaw, and then the eyes start looking at things in the room instead of at the room.

He's looking at the lamp, and he's been looking at it for a while.

The east basement is a door, a chair and nothing else, except the lamp Silas brought down on the first night, which I didn't order removed. A man who can see the room he's in knows he's being held by someone who thought of his eyes.



HIS NAME IS Thibault, a dock worker, and one of the wolves who came through the gallery windows the night my father died.

I've left him alone to think about the difference between being killed and being kept.

I come in and shut the door behind me.

He looks up.

"I thought you forgot about me," he says. "Did you?"

"No."

"That's worse, probably."

"Probably. Are you disappointed?"

"Hell, I don't know anymore."

I take the second chair from the corner and sit across from him at a distance that says *conversation*, not *interrogation*. He notices, because stupid wolves don't survive to forty-seven in a pack that shares a city with us.

"You've been here a while," I say. "You've been fed, and you have a light."

"I noticed."

"Do you know why?"

"Because you want something from me that hitting wouldn't get. I'm not a genius, but I'm not a fucking fool either."

There it is. Not stupid at all.

I pick up the lamp, cast iron at the base, heavy, old, the kind of thing a man would need both arms to carry.

I close one hand around it and squeeze, and the iron deforms under my fingers. It folds inward with the sound of a can being crushed, and when I set it back down, the base has the shape of my grip pressed into it.

The lamp stays on, and the light doesn't even flicker. Did he think it would?

Thibault looks at the lamp, and then at my hand, the hand that just reshaped iron like clay.

"That's not a threat," I say. "That's a fact about the room you're in. The threat is outside the room, and it wears a council's face, and it has been asking me to give you to it since the boat came in."

He swallows.

"Tell me about the chamber," I say. "Start from the windows."



HE TELLS IT, and stops now and then to check what he saw against what he was told he saw.

"We came through fast, because the whole point was speed: get in, get to the platform, do the damage, get out."

"Who gave the order?"

"Gaspard. Who the hell else?" No hesitation. "The Alpha. The idea was chaos, enough of us at once that nobody could organize." His jaw sets. "For about a minute. Then your father stood up."

He says it like *then the weather changed*.

"He was at the table when we came in, sitting. I saw him from the gallery rail, and he had a glass in front of him and his hand was on the arm of the chair, and he didn't move."

"He didn't move?"

"Then he stood up, and it was over."

"What do you mean, over?"

"I mean the ones who were close to him stopped being close to him." A pause. "The ones who were closest stopped being anything."

I've read Marguerite's account and Cassian's and three Elders', and none of them told it like this. Why not?

"He was beautiful," Thibault says.

It goes into the room and sits down.

"I'm a wolf. I'm supposed to say he was a monster, or that I was frightened, and I was frightened, but frightened isn't the right name for it." He looks at me. "A man that old, moving like that. I'd never seen anything like it. None of us had."

"Keep going. Don't you dare stop there."

"The boys in front were done, and the rest of us went for the windows. Your father was still standing. He'd taken bites, both arms, one at the hip, and I watched a wound on his forearm close up in the time it took me to reach the rail."

"Then what the hell killed him?"

Thibault stops.

This is the part, and I've been waiting for it. He's been waiting to be asked, and we've both known it was coming since the dock.

"He was still standing when we quit," Thibault says. "He was standing, and he was healing, and the last of our people were going back through the windows. It was over."

"And?"

"And he turned."

"Which direction?"

"Away from us." The wolf's voice has gone careful. "Toward the east side of the chamber, toward someone behind him."

"Someone?"

"I couldn't see — I was on the gallery rail, going out. But I saw his face."

"What was in it?"

"Surprise," Thibault says, and his eyes are steady. "He looked at somebody behind him like you look at a man who's come through a door he's allowed to come through, and then he looked *down*, and I went through the window."

The room has no sound in it but the hum of the lamp.

"You saw him turn toward someone," I say. "Behind him, on the east side?"

"Yes."

"Not a wolf?"

"Our people were done, and we were out or we were dead. There was nobody behind him in a wolf's body." He stops. "And the smell."

"What smell?"

"I can't be sure, because there was blood everywhere and it was hard to sort. But I've been in rooms with your kind before, and there's a specific thing. Old ones have more of it."

"And you caught that?"

"At the turn, when he turned." Thibault rubs his jaw. "It was close to him, not across the room. Right there."



I SIT WITH that for a while. What else can I do with it?

The fight was over. My father turned toward someone he wasn't afraid of, someone he expected to be there, and that someone put him down.

The scent was wrong for a wolf.

One of ours.

I've been asking *who was in the room* since Tuesday, and I've been asking it about the wrong door.



"You're wondering whether to kill me," he says.

"Yes."

"Figured. Hell, I'd wonder too." He doesn't look away. "I'd like to make a case for not."

"Go ahead. Make it a good one."

"Nobody in your court was looking at your father when it happened, because they were looking at us. And the wolves who got close enough to see are dead." He holds my eyes. "If you kill me, it goes away. If you don't, you have a witness with no stake in the answer."

I could kill him, and nobody would question it.

But a dead wolf tells one story, and a live wolf tells the one I choose.

"We didn't kill your father," Thibault says.

The sentence goes through me as clean as a blade drawn across a nerve.

It's the *we*. A wolf in a vampire's basement, using a word that means *my people* in his language and *the enemy* in mine.

"We didn't kill your father," he says again. "He was still standing when we quit, and he was winning. Whatever happened after that, whatever put him down, it wasn't us."

I look at this man for a long time. What do I owe him for that?

Then I stand up, and I pick up the second chair, and I put it back in the corner.

"Silas will bring you food," I say.

"Am I staying?"

"You're staying. Is that a problem?"

"Beats the fuck out of the alternative."

"For how long?"

I don't answer that. I go to the door and open it, and the hallway is cold and empty and stretches in both directions, and somewhere at the top of

this house there's a room with a desk in it and a question I've been asking wrong.

I don't kill him.

Upstairs, in my father's desk, is the list Silas brought me the night I came home. Every name that was inside that room.

I've been reading it for the wolves.

Tonight I read it for everyone else.



CHAPTER

Eight

LUCIAN

I'M HUNGRY, and I've decided it's somebody's fucking fault.

Nine days, and I could have eaten on any of them, so why didn't I? Instead I sat in my father's chair and read wolf reports until the words went flat, and now my jaw aches, and the ache has opinions.

Hunger doesn't make me weak, whatever the young tell each other. It makes me unreliable.

Perdido has two doors — one on the street for anyone, and one off the service alley for the people my father chose.

I use the alley and he used the street, and that's the whole argument between us, standing up in a building.

Inside it's loud like money is loud: low ceiling, brass fittings, a bar down the length of the room. Tourists at the front, locals who know better toward the back, and the court drinking behind all of them.

They see me and they stand.

"Sit," I tell them. "For Christ's sake, sit."

They sit, but Bastien doesn't, because Bastien has never had a thought he didn't immediately share.

"Your Majesty—"

"No."

"Sorry, sire." He grins at me. "Sorry. Marguerite's been saying it all week, and now it sticks in your mouth."

"Then why put it there?"

"Because it's going to be true by the weekend, sire, and I like to practice."

He pulls a chair out for me anyway and I take it, because he's the only one at this table I'd let stand behind me.

Somebody sets a glass down at my elbow, and I don't look up at the hand that brought it.

Bastien has started on the raid, because he was on the water side and he needs me to know he was on the water side. There's a story about a wolf who went into the canal rather than come at him. He tells it twice, and the second telling has more canal in it.

"They'll come back," he says. "I'd bet my whole allowance on it, sire, and Marguerite gives me a very small allowance. They have to come back."

"Why do they have to? Think, Bastien. Use the head you were given."

"Because—" He stops, because he genuinely hasn't thought about it. "Because we went in."

"Isn't that a reason to be careful?"

"That's not how they are. Is it?"

"It's exactly how they are, Bastien. Don't be a fool about wolves." I turn the glass on the wood without drinking from it. "They're farmers with teeth, and careful is the whole of them."

He's young and he worships me, and neither of those is his fault. He's working toward the real question, whether there'll be a war and whether he'll be seen in it. I let him get most of the way there.

Then I stop listening, because somebody in this room is looking at me.



NOBODY LOOKS at me.

That isn't vanity: humans have an instinct that fires underneath thought. It tells them to find something else to look at. They glance and

slide off, and I stopped noticing it a long time ago, as you stop noticing a floor.

She's at the bar with her back against it, and she turned around to do this.

Dark hair down, and a dress that was chosen instead of bought expensive, which costs more attention than money does. She's holding a drink she hasn't touched, and she's looking at me as if I'm a door she's deciding about.

I get up, and Bastien says my name and I don't hear it.

The room does what rooms do. It opens.

Two men move out of my way without registering they did it. A woman with a tray changes her whole course to avoid crossing in front of me, and neither of them will remember any of it.

She watches me come the entire way. Who does that?

She doesn't straighten when I reach her, doesn't do the small apology thing with the shoulders that people do when I arrive somewhere. She tips her head back to find my face, and she waits.

The waiting is so unhurried that I think she's drunk, but she isn't, or I'd smell it.

I smell her, and I can't place it: lemon rind and cold skin and underneath it a green note, like crushed stems. Why can't I place it? I have placed everything for a very long time.

"You're staring," I tell her.

"So are you."

"I'm allowed. Aren't I?"

"Because of the suit, or because of the table?"

Her voice is low and a little rough, a bar voice, so she works in one.

"Both," I say. "Does it matter?"

"Hell, no. I just like to know what I'm talking to."

"Mm." She sets the glass down behind her without looking where it goes. "You came in through the alley."

That stops me.

Anyone could see which direction I came from, but she noticed which *door*, and decided the door was the interesting part of me.

"Most people don't know there's an alley," I say.

"Most people don't watch you walk into rooms."

"And you do?"

"You walked into mine last week, on Frenchmen." She glances at the drink she isn't drinking. "You tipped fifty on a bourbon you didn't touch."

I remember the bar: the man in the good suit and his all-night alibi, the windows, the kitchen door propped with a bucket, the exit behind the stage.

I don't remember a bartender, and that's new too.

"I don't remember you," I tell her.

"I know," she says. "Nobody does."

She says it like the weather, and then she tips her glass at the room. "Tonight I'm on the wrong side of the bar."

Somebody laughs too loud behind us, and she doesn't flinch.

My people are watching this, and I find I don't care what they make of it.

"What's your name?"

"Selene."

"Selene." I let it sit in the air. "Do you know what this place is?"

"A club where the drinks are free if the right table likes you. Isn't it?"

"That's one answer. You want the other one?"

"Is it worse?"

"It's a damn sight worse."

"It's the one I've got. You want to give me a better one, or you want to keep staring?"

"I haven't decided."

"Well, hell. Take your time."

She says it straight up into my face with no tremor under it. Her pulse is fast, and it's been fast since before I crossed the room. It isn't the rhythm of somebody looking for an exit. I know the difference — I've listened to both for longer than this country has had a name.

I look at her mouth while she waits, and at the line of her throat under her jaw, where the skin goes thin and blue.

The ache in my jaw stops being an opinion and becomes an instruction.

Nine days is too long, and I've been stupid about it, and stupid has a price: the decision is already made, and I'm only watching myself arrive at it.

"Come with me," I say.

She comes.



THE HALLWAY behind the bar is narrow and badly lit, and it smells like ice and cut lemons. A door at the far end lets into the courtyard, and crates are stacked along one wall for a delivery that comes at dawn.

Nobody uses this corridor in between, and I've fed in here before, not often. The room isn't the point. The point is that the room has no eyes.

She stops where I put her, back to the wall between two crates, and looks up at me.

There is nothing in her face I recognize.

They're frightened, usually, and people get that wrong, because even the ones who came looking are frightened when it stops being a story and becomes a corridor.

This one is waiting for me to get on with it.

"Are you frightened?" I ask her.

"Should I be? Tell me honestly."

Nobody has ever asked me that back.

Fine.

"Look at me," I tell her.

She does.

Here's what it is, said plainly, because the young lie to each other about this and I'd rather be honest with myself in a service hallway.

I take the alarm out, and that's all it is.

I hold the eye and I press, and the part of the brain that ought to be screaming lies down instead. Afterward I can go back into the last little while and smooth it as flat as a bedsheet.

It edits and it soothes, and it'll hold a body still if I want it still.

It cannot make anyone want anything.

Not *harder to do*. Not *lessened*. Cannot.

I could stand in this corridor until the walls sweated and not put one drop of want into a body that didn't walk in carrying it.

Whatever they feel while I'm at their throat, they brought it with them.

That's the law's entire excuse, and it's bullshit and I know it, but it's a good one. I've used it since before there was a law.

So I press.

She goes slack against the wall, loose in the shoulders, head tipped back, eyes still on mine.

"Good," I say.

I put my hand on her throat and close my fingers around it and feel her pulse kick against my palm, a thick double beat that doesn't settle. I'm cold, I'm always cold, and her skin is so warm it registers as a temperature I'd forgotten existed.

She doesn't flinch, and she tips her chin up to give me more of it.

Her pulse comes up hard under my thumb and keeps climbing, which is ordinary, because bodies know what's coming even with the alarm asleep.

Then she makes a sound, small, from the back of a breath.

And the smell of her changes.

I've had my mouth on more throats than this city has windows. I know every version of what a body does under it.

Fear has a smell, and adrenaline has a smell, thin and bright, like a struck match.

This is neither, and I know exactly what it is, and it should not be here. So why is it?

The scent of her arousal comes up through the lemon and the ice like a body rising through water. Wet, animal, unmistakable. Her pussy is soaked under that dress — I can taste it in the back of my throat before I've put my mouth anywhere near her.

Her thighs have gone tight under the dress, and her palms are flat on the wall behind her, pressing back into it.

Not away.

I drag the points of my teeth down the side of her neck without breaking skin. She shudders so hard her shoulder blades come off the wall.

Then I bite.

She whines.

A high thin sound, up in her nose, that goes down my spine and lands behind my teeth and in my cock.

My teeth are already through her skin.

The first pull is always the worst of me.

Her blood comes into my mouth and it's *wrong*, not spoiled, not sick, but wrong the way a word is wrong in a language you speak well.

Human on top, and underneath it, dirt and animal.

How long since blood told me anything I didn't already know? Three hundred and six years.

One taste, and that's done.

Whatever I was before I put my mouth on this woman is not what I'm going to be after.

My hand goes into her hair to hold her still.

She isn't fighting. She's arching.

Her tits come up against my chest and her hips come off the wall. My thigh is between hers and I don't remember putting it there.

She finds it, her clit grinding against the muscle of my thigh, and then she grinds down on it, hard, and again, and then without stopping.

She's riding my leg in a service corridor with my teeth in her throat, making that sound into my shoulder over and over, small and broken, every one shaped like a word she can't get to.

Should I stop? I should.

I don't stop, I fist her hair to hold her where she is and let her use me.

She soaks through the dress against my thigh, and the heat of her cunt comes through the wool. I can smell every part of it, the salt, the slick, the animal underneath. Her pussy against my leg. Through a dress. In a service corridor.

"Please— oh God, please—"

First word out of her. Not *don't*.

"Quiet, ghost," I tell her.

That's what they are, after: *ghosts* of an evening, and not one of them remembers the man who walked through it.

She won't either.

She gets louder.

Her heel comes off the floor and hooks behind my knee to drag herself closer. The whole long line of her is shaking against me.

She has not once tried to get my mouth off her neck. Why not?

I take my teeth out of her, and my saliva and her blood run together down the column of her throat, pink and thin. I need to see her face when it happens.

Her eyes are blown out black and her mouth is open and wet. Her blood is running down my chin where she can see it, and she's looking straight at it.

My fingers are still on her throat, and I can feel her swallow against my palm.

So I put my mouth to her ear.

I say what I only ever say against a wall or in a bed.

"Good girl."

She comes.

It goes through her like a floor giving way, and her whole body seizes. Her hands come off the wall and take fistfuls of my shirt.

She cries out into my coat, wet, wrecked, no shame anywhere in it.

She rides it out on my thigh in hard little jerks, then a smaller one, then another.

I'm hard enough that standing still is a fucking discipline problem. My cock is pressed against her hip through the wool and she can feel it — I know because her hand drops from my shirt and finds it and *squeezes*, once, like a woman confirming something she already knew.

I do nothing about it.

Would she let me? She would. That's the ugly part.

She'd let me put her on the crates and bury myself in her and she'd be loud about it, and in a quarter of an hour she wouldn't know it happened. I'd go back to my table and finish my wine.

But I came here to eat, didn't I?

I tighten my hand on her throat — one pulse of pressure, enough to feel her breath catch — and put my mouth back on the wound. The last of it leaves her in small stunned pulses against my leg while I swallow.

When I pull back, my spit is still on her skin, mixed with the blood. She looks ruined in a way that has nothing to do with damage.

“Ghost,” I say.

She doesn’t answer, because her legs aren’t working yet.

When I leave her in this corridor, I’ll leave with the taste of her in my mouth — blood on top, and underneath it the other thing, the dirt and the animal and the heat of a cunt I didn’t touch and will still fucking smell on my hands.



I CLOSE THE wound with my tongue, and it takes a moment, and then there’s nothing: no mark, no blood, a clean neck and a woman breathing like she ran here from the river.

I let go of her hair and straighten her dress for her, and that isn’t kindness, it’s housekeeping.

Then I take her jaw again and tip her face up, because the last part is the part that makes all of it lawful.

The smoothing: the evening goes soft at the edges, and what’s left is a woman who had two drinks and doesn’t remember a hallway.

Tomorrow she’ll be tired, sore high on the inside of her thighs. She won’t ask why, because I’m about to take the question away with everything else.

Is that mercy? My father would have said so, and he’d have meant it, too. He’d have been the only man in the room who did.

“You had a drink,” I tell her. “One drink. You talked to a man at the bar, and he wasn’t interesting.”

Her eyes stay on mine.

“You’re going home to sleep. You’re tired, aren’t you?”

Her eyes stay on mine.

“Selene.”

Her face doesn’t change, and she doesn’t even fucking blink.

It takes a beat sometimes, doesn’t it, with drunks and the very young and the ones already bleeding?

So I press harder, and push it out of me like I've pushed it into every throat I ever opened.

It lands on her like weather on a window.

Nothing.

It isn't resistance, which I would feel, because it has a shape and pushes back, and I've broken it in men twice her size.

This isn't a wall, it's a room I'm leaning on that isn't there.

I have never once failed at this.

Not fucking once, not on a drunk, not on a soldier with his hand already on his gun, not on a woman who'd watched me do it to her sister an hour before. Centuries of clean mouths, every one of them closed behind me.

So what is she?

Strength I'd have felt going in, and a witch's work I'd know by the taste of the air around it.

Fuck.

What walks into a room in this city and leaves no door on the inside of itself?

My fingers are still on her jaw, and I notice them as if they belong to someone else.

I let go.

"Step back," I say.

My voice comes out wrong, and I hear it come out wrong.

She steps back.

There's a rule about this, and the rule has one answer in it: a human who can't be smoothed doesn't walk out of the building.

My father wrote that line himself and he hated it. He kept it anyway, because the alternative is a city that finds out. Bastard loved his rules even when they cost him.

I know the rule, and I've enforced it, more than once, on people who'd done less than stand in a hallway and remember me. So why not her?

I turn and go up the corridor toward the noise instead. What the hell am I doing?

There's a version of the rest of tonight where I never think about this again. I'm already most of the way into pretending I live in it.

"Hey. Hey, you."

I stop.

I don't want to turn around. Standing in a hallway that smells like lemons, I understand that turning around is a door, and that I'd be the one opening it.

I do it anyway.

She has one hand flat on the wall for balance and her chin up, her dress straight and her throat clean.

She isn't dazed, and she hasn't been dazed once tonight.

"You've got blood on your teeth," she says.

I don't move.

"Are you a vampire?"



CHAPTER

Nine

SELENE

I REMEMBER EVERY second of it. Is something wrong with me? Something is seriously fucked up.

He asked whether I knew what this place was and I gave him the wrong answer on purpose. He told me to look at him and I did.

Then he put his mouth on my throat in a corridor that smells like cut lemons. My body went somewhere without asking me first, the traitorous bitch, and I let it.

And the reaching underneath, the part of me that goes for wolves and gets refused, the part that's been doing it since I could stand in a room with one, reached for him.

It didn't fall short.

For the first time in my life, the reaching found something older than pack, with teeth where the warmth should be, and the teeth didn't flinch, they bit down.

My body said *finally*, as a word you've been trying to remember for years arrives whole in your mouth: recognition.

He's not wolf, he's the other thing, the predator, the mouth, the four-hundred-year-old appetite in a good suit. And whatever's under my

skin, the part every wolf has ever flinched from, reached for him, and he *took it in*.

I'm still standing in the corridor, and my legs have opinions about whether they work.

The teeth I can live with, but what I keep going back over is that he tried to take it out of me afterward, and I felt him try.

It landed on me like somebody knocking on a wall in another building.

You had a drink. You talked to a man at the bar.

He said it twice, and he said my name as if it was supposed to work.

Then I asked him what he was, because I've never been able to leave a sentence alone.

He didn't answer me, just stood in the middle of a service hallway with my blood in his mouth and looked at me like I was a word he'd never seen before, and then he walked back out toward the music.



HERE'S WHAT I know about my own memory: it's the only thing I've ever been able to sell.

My father taught me that a conversation happens twice: there's what a person says, and then there's what those same words would mean carried across into the other language.

The second one is where people keep the truth.

He did contracts for a living, shipping mostly, and some court work he never described to me.

So I remember what people say, all of it.

It's less a gift than a habit that went too far, and tonight it means I'll be able to reconstruct every filthy thing that man said to me for as long as I live.

God.

Good girl.

Quiet, ghost.

He called me that twice, once with his teeth in my throat and once with my blood on his mouth.

I know what it means in his language: *you won't remember this*.

Won't I?

In mine, a *ghost* is the girl nobody sees, and he doesn't know how right he is.

I brace my palm on the wall and breathe until that stops doing what it's doing to me.

It doesn't fucking stop.

My thighs are still pressed together, and my pussy is still throbbing. The dress is still damp where I ground myself against his leg like an animal in heat. I can feel the shape of it, the muscle, the wool, the heat of him through the fabric. My hips shift against nothing and I hate myself for it.

Not for the corridor, for *now*: for standing alone in a hallway replaying a man's mouth on my throat and getting wet from the memory of getting wet. The original sin was bad enough, and the instant replay is obscene. Who gets wet from the memory of getting wet? Me, apparently.

The wolf-half is still reaching, and that's the part I can't make stop. God, I can't make it stop. It's spent my whole life grabbing for wolves and coming back empty. It found him in that corridor and now it won't let go. It's humming at a frequency I don't have a name for, low and steady, like a wire someone struck and walked away from.

He walked away from it, and I'm the one still vibrating. How is that fair?

I press my forehead to the wall, and the plaster is cool and it doesn't help.

In wolf there's a word for hunger that outlasts the meal. My mother's people use it for the season after a long winter, when the elk come back but your body hasn't learned to stop starving yet. You eat and eat and the hunger stays, because the hunger was never about the food.

I am not going to stand in a service corridor and translate my own arousal into a nature documentary.

I push off the wall.

Because there's a useful part, and I want the useful part more than I want to think about the fact that I can still feel his thigh between mine, and how wet I was against it, like a phantom limb I never owned.

He couldn't erase me.

Why not? What am I, that it slides right off?

He tried, and it failed, and his voice came out wrong when he told me to step back. I heard it: a man who has never once been surprised, being surprised, and having no idea how to do it.

So I have leverage. Worth what? No fucking idea.

I know the strongest thing in this city just found a hole in the world, and he walked away instead of closing it. Why?



I GO BACK out into the room, because the alternative is standing in a hallway until somebody finds me in it.

The club has gotten louder, as it does around midnight: the tourists thin out, the people who came here on purpose get comfortable, and the music moves down into the floor.

I'm not on shift, and I'm not even in my own bar, and I keep having to remember that. My fingers keep starting for the well, for a rail, for a rag, and there's nothing in them.

He's back at his table with a glass in front of him and he isn't looking at me. Is he pretending not to? He is. The young one beside him is talking with his whole upper body.

Everyone at that table sits like the chairs are theirs.



HERE'S WHAT I saw earlier, before the corridor, and didn't understand.

A man at the far curve of the bar bought a glass of wine and didn't drink it.

I noticed because I've worked bars long enough to know that doesn't happen: you buy a drink for yourself, or you buy it for somebody whose name you say out loud.

This man ordered the house red and put money down and held it a while, then set it back on the bar and said something to the server, a kid with a buzzcut and a tray.

And the kid carried it to the back.

Servers don't take drinks off patrons, and it's the first thing anybody teaches you, because shit like that gets you fired in any bar in this city.

The kid should know, but does he? Maybe a man who looks like money told him it was a gift for the table and he believed it.

He took it and walked it to the King's elbow, set it down, and got out of the way.

I watched a glass cross a room and I thought: *that's rude*.

In wolf, there's a word for a gift you can't refuse with a room watching. It's the opening move of something, dressed as a kindness, and both parties know it, and the whole point is the audience.

There's no word for that in English, so English makes it a drink.



THE LEVEL IN that glass is down, and I can see it from here. How much did he drink?

He puts a hand flat on the table.

It's a small thing, a man steadying himself on a table in a bar, which happens all night, every night, in this city.

Except he hasn't moved like a person all evening. He's been still in a way that made my back teeth ache. Creepy as hell.

Now his palm is on the table and his shoulders have come forward. The young one beside him has stopped talking mid-sentence.

Then he tries to stand up and doesn't manage it on the first attempt.

Does anybody else see it? The room hasn't noticed. That table has noticed, and one of them has gone the color of a dropped napkin.

I'm already moving, and it isn't mercy. What is it, then?

He's the only way across the water I have.

All this time trying to get near a man who won't come north of the water. Tonight I found the man with the keys to the whole city.

And now? Now he's about to die in a nightclub in front of me.



THERE'S A MAN by the stairs.

I clock him on my way across the floor, and my skin knows before I can explain why.

He's dressed for here, in a good shirt and no jacket, with a drink he's been nursing since I came out of the hallway, the right age and the right amount of bored.

And he is watching that table with his whole body while pretending to watch the band.

It's the stillness that gives him away.

Wolves go still like that before they move, and it's nothing like a vampire's stillness. A vampire is still because nothing in the room is urgent, and a wolf goes still because a thing is about to happen.

I grew up with one of them in my house. I've spent every year since close enough to the rest to be hated at, so I know that shape.

I catch a smell off him when I pass: bayou water, and underneath it the smell I have no word for and would know anywhere.

I don't trust my own nose, because it works sometimes and it has never worked when it mattered. Enough wolves have told me what I smell like, and whatever my mother gave me came through badly.

So I don't trust it, and I don't need it either.

He's got his weight on the balls of his feet in a room where nobody else does. Who's he waiting on? The same man I am.



I GET TO the table.

The whole table comes around, and one of them puts a hand out toward my chest without touching it, the politest way I have ever been told I'm about to be moved.

"He's fucking poisoned," I say.

That isn't what I meant to lead with. Where did the clever thing go?

The young one's head comes up. "What?"

"The wine. A man at the bar bought it and handed it to your server, and the kid walked it over." I'm talking too fast. "He didn't drink any of it himself, and servers don't take drinks off patrons. Ask anybody who works a bar."

"Who the hell are you?"

"The bartender. Who else? Holy shit, focus."

"You're not *our*— what the fuck is a bartender doing at this table?"

"Frenchmen Street," I say. "Keep the fuck up."

"Who was he?"

"I've never seen him before. Have you?"

"How the fuck would we know? We were watching the King."

"Then who was watching the bar?"

"What did he look like?" the other one says, already half out of his chair.

"Gray suit, paid cash, drank nothing, the son of a bitch. He never once looked at the band, and everybody looks at the band."

And Lucian looks up at me.

His eyes are not right, his throat working, with a looseness behind them. He's holding his jaw as if he's keeping a mouthful down.

And he knows exactly what's happening to him, doesn't he?

"There's a wolf by the stairs," I tell him.

"Yes," he says. "Did he see you see him?"

"I don't know. Does it matter?"

"It will."

Not *are you sure*, not *how would you know*, just yes, like I told him the time.

Then he stands up, and he does it properly, and I can see what it costs around the edges.

"Sire—" the young one starts.

"Get the car, both of you." His voice is perfectly level. "Out the front, and be visible about it."

"But you—"

"Now. Do you want me to say it twice?"



HERE'S HOW it goes, and it takes less time than saying it.

They go out the front, loudly, like he told them to.

The man by the stairs turns to follow them with his eyes, and for the length of a held breath, nobody in this room is looking at the King except me.

I get under his arm.

He's heavier than a building, and whatever I expected, it wasn't that. I get his arm over my shoulders and take a step and nearly go down with him on top of me.

He weighs like stone wrapped in wool, his hip jammed against mine, his thigh dragging. Every step pushes his cold throat against my cheek.

"Hallway," I say. "Left. There's a fucking door."

"I know where the fucking doors are."

"Then walk, goddamn it. And if you throw up on me, I'm leaving you in the coat check."

"I don't throw up."

"Everybody throws up, Jesus. I've seen senators throw up. I've seen a bishop throw up in a planter."

"Not in four hundred years. It would be undignified."

"Undignified? You're being dragged through a nightclub by a bartender in a dress. Dignity left, honey. It's in a cab."

"Then don't fucking start tonight."

He walks. Barely.

I keep us against the wall so the crowd does some of the work. I talk the whole way, because a woman holding up a drunk is invisible in this city.

A woman holding up anything else is not.

"You said you were fine to drive an hour ago," I tell him, loud.

Goddamn bartender instincts: I sound like I've done this a hundred times, because I have.

Somebody laughs. Somebody always laughs.

His head comes around and his mouth ends up near my ear. "You lie very well."

"Save it."

"Why? It's true."

"Chère."

"I said save it, for Christ's sake."



AT THE DOOR I look back.

I don't plan it, but my hand is on the push-bar and the night is right there. I turn my head, because I need to know whether the man by the stairs has worked it out.

He has.

He's off the wall and coming through the crowd at an angle, unhurried, going around people instead of through them. That's how you cross a room you don't want to be remembered crossing.

Our eyes meet and hold.

He has my face now. I'd like it back.

Then I put my shoulder into the bar and get us out into the alley, and the door swings shut on the music.

It's so still out here I can hear us both breathing.



MY CAR IS a decade past anything, still sitting in the staff lot where I left it.

We make it about halfway before his legs stop cooperating in a way I can't argue with. He goes down on one knee on the pavement. I go down with him, because I am not letting him put his head into a curb.

"Up," I say. "Hey. Up, goddamn it."

He says something in French that isn't for me.

Then, in English: "Leave me."

"No. Are you out of your mind?"

"That's an order."

"I don't work for you. I don't even work *here*, for fuck's sake."

"Why are you doing this?"

"Because I need you alive more than you need to be dignified. Is that good enough for you?"

"Selene," he says, as if the name is something to hold onto.

"Great, you remember my name. Get your ass up anyway. Shit, you're heavy."

His hand comes up and takes hold of my wrist without squeezing, his knees on the wet asphalt. He just holds it, and I think about what that hand was doing to me an hour ago, fisted in my hair while I rode his thigh and came, and I make myself stop thinking about it.

"Listen to me, you stubborn son of a bitch." I get my face in front of his. "You're going to get up. If you die in a parking lot I've wasted my entire night and I'll be extremely annoyed about it."

Something moves at the corner of his mouth.

He gets up.



I PUT THE King of New Orleans in the passenger seat of a car with a cracked windshield and a phone charger held together with tape.

He goes in like freight being loaded, and I have to fold him, a palm on top of his head so he doesn't take the frame with his skull, then his knee pushed in after him.

It's undignified, but there's nobody to see it and I've stopped caring.

Then I shut the door and stand in the lot with my hands shaking. What the fuck am I doing?

Behind me, down the block, a door opens onto the alley and somebody steps out into it.

I don't turn around, just get in and put the key in, and the engine thinks about it first.

Beside me he's gone still, his head against the window and his eyes open and not tracking.

"Hey." I get a hand on his jaw and turn his face toward me. "Stay with me. Where do I take you?"

Nothing.

"Lucian? Can you hear me? Where the hell is your house?"

Nothing at all, and the engine catches.

The man from the alley is walking up the middle of the lot toward us, his hands loose and empty and the streetlight behind him.

He's in no fucking hurry.

So I don't take him to a single door in this city that belongs to him.

I take him home to my apartment.

INTERLUDE II

Cassian

THE ATTEMPT failed, and the boy walked out on his own feet.

I have it from men who were never in the same room, which is the only way I take information now. He went in through the alley and fed, and he was standing when the trouble started.

He was not standing long after it.

Then he was gone, and what was meant to happen in that room did not happen.

He was never going to die in a club. How could he?

I would like that understood by nobody, because it is not the sort of thing a man says aloud. But there is a boy alive tonight who has been the strongest creature in this city since the week his father stopped being it, and a wolf with a knife was never the end of him.

I knew that when I paid for the bottle.

What was supposed to happen is that he would be shown teeth.

His father spent his whole long life explaining to him that the animals at our border are neighbors. Then the animals came through a window and took the man apart, and the boy went into a room and told his council which houses they were not to touch.

And the lesson he took?

He drew a line on a map and he made it narrow, on purpose, with his father barely in the ground.

And is he careful? He is being careful.

He is being his father, and he cannot hear himself doing it.

A man leaves his son a city and a philosophy, and the city can be defended. The other thing has to be taken out of him by hand.

I am the only one left who loves him enough to do it.

So: teeth, in a bright room, in front of witnesses. That is all it was ever meant to be.

Instead there is a woman. Who is she?



HERE IS WHAT the wolf saw, and the wolf is a fool. Fools see the useful part, because they do not know which part is useful.

She got him out.

Not carried but steered: she had him upright with his arm across her shoulder and she talked to him the whole way to the street.

At the door she stopped and looked back into the room before she took him through it.

She looked back to see whether anyone was following.

Why would a woman look back? I have turned that over all evening and it will not come apart in my hands.

A woman he has fed from does not look back. She walks to a cab with the evening gone soft behind her, and in the morning she is tired, and she does not remember a hallway.

That is the whole architecture of this city, and that is what the law is *for*.

And this one? This one was awake.

She was awake in the room and awake at the door, and she put the King of New Orleans in a car and drove him somewhere I do not have.

The boy does not make mistakes with his mouth, and he never has. He was fastidious about it before he was old enough to be dangerous.

He learned that from me.

So she is something. What? I do not know, and I find I do not enjoy the question.



THERE IS A version of tonight in which I stop.

Aurelian is dead, and the war will come or it will not, and the boy will grow into whatever he is going to be.

I could take a house on the coast and be an old man who lost his friend. Who alive would ever put a hand on my shoulder and ask?

I have thought about the coast more often than I would have expected.

What is owed to me?

Nothing. That is the trouble. A man does not get a debt entered against the world for a daughter, nor against a friend who did what the statute told him to do, in a courtyard, with the court watching, while I stood in the grass and said his name.

He held my arm afterward, and he was gentle about it.

He kept his hand there and told me it was the law and not the man, and he meant it. Then he went on being the man for the rest of his life, and every year of it was a year he did not think about it.

He would have gone on not thinking about it until the world ended.

So there is no debt, only what I intend to leave behind.

A species that does not apologize, and a king with his father's hands and none of his father's fence around them.

Who is she? I am going to find out.

Then I am going to see the boy in the morning and ask after the health of a witch he has never met.

And I will be the last warm room he has.



C H A P T E R

Ten

S E L E N E

THERE'S A VAMPIRE on my kitchen floor and he's healing wrong.

I know it as you know a sound in your own house is wrong, even though I have nothing to compare it to, because I have never seen one of them hurt. Holy shit.

But his forearm is open where he took it into my doorframe coming through. It was open an hour ago, and it is open now.

He bled on the linoleum and the blood is drying, and that should be impossible. Everything I have ever been told about them says he should have closed before he hit the ground. So why hasn't he?

He's on his side with one arm under him and his eyes shut, breathing, but not on any schedule a person breathes on.

I got him up the stairs by putting his arm over my shoulders and lying to a neighbor about a wedding.

"Big night?" Mrs. Guidry said from her doorway, in her robe.

"Cousin's wedding," I said. "He found the open bar."

"On a Tuesday?"

"They're Catholic. What can you do?"

"Mm. He's very pale, baby. Is he going to be sick on my landing?"

"Not if he knows what's good for him."

God knows what I looked like.



NOBODY CAME up behind us. Why not?

I sat in the car at the bottom of my own street with the engine running and watched the mirror until my fingers stopped shaking. Nothing turned in after me, no headlights, no man walking.

That doesn't mean anything good, because a wolf who wanted to follow me wouldn't need to do it tonight.

He has my face. How long before he uses it? He got a long look at it across a room. I gave it to him for free, because I stopped at a door to be sure of what I was already sure of.

Pack separates being seen from being caught. What he did was *place* me, put me somewhere on the map in his head, so that later, when there's a reason, he knows which way to walk.



HERE'S WHAT I keep coming back around to.

He gave the order to his own people and he sent them out the front, loudly, to be looked at.

I've been turning it over since the parking lot. He was going down, he knew it, and the last clean decision he made was to move every set of eyes in that room onto two young men going out through the front door.

Then he went into a service corridor with a bartender. Why a bartender?

A king holds onto his guards and gets carried out through the middle of the floor.

Unless he'd worked out that the problem was inside the building, and that his people were the wrong thing to be standing next to.

I don't like how fast he got there, when I had all night to get there and he had about as long as it takes to put a palm on a table. Who thinks like that while they're dying?



I GET THE first aid box out from under the sink, and then I stand there holding it and feel like a fucking idiot.

There is nothing in this box for a man like that: adhesive bandages, a tube of burn cream, a roll of gauze I bought when I was twenty-two and cut my thumb on a bottle opener.

Well, shit. I take the gauze out anyway, and I fold a towel under his head and put the water where he can reach it if he wakes up and can't sit up.

Then I sit down against the cabinets with my knees up and look at him, a fucking vampire.

"You'd better not die in here," I tell him. "My shitty lease has a clause. Do you hear me?"

He doesn't answer. Why would he?

"It says no pets," I tell him anyway. "I figure you count. Don't you?"

And I go and get the knife.



IT'S MY FATHER'S, out of a drawer of his things. It's nothing special: a short blade with a wood handle and a nick out of the bolster where somebody dropped it.

I've had it in the top of my bag for years and sharpened it more times than I've used it, and that's a sentence about a person.

It was always for Rémy Thibodeaux.

I sit on my kitchen floor with it in my hand and look at the King of New Orleans laid out like a delivery.

Under the ribs: that's what I know from the funeral talk and the club talk and every drunk at my bar with a theory. That's where they say you have to put it, and you have to mean it, and you have to be able to hold it there.

He can't stop me, and that's not a guess. He couldn't get himself into a car without me folding him into it.

And here's the honest version, because I'm the only one in this room awake enough to say it.

I could put this in him right now and be the person who killed a vampire king.

The wolves would sing about it, and some of them would sing about me and not know they were doing it, because they'd never believe a woman who smells wrong did anything that mattered.

His court would take the city apart to find out who, and they'd be god-damn thorough about it. It would take them a while, and it would not take them forever.

That's a reason, but it isn't the reason, not even close.



THE REASON is that he's the only way across I have. I'm not going to pretend to be better than that.

Four years of knowing exactly where a man lives and never once being able to cross the water to get to him. Four years of learning a pack's whole grammar from the outside, so I'd have the right thing to say to whichever one of them let me in.

Nobody let me in. Not fucking once.

Then tonight the man who owns this entire city put his mouth on my throat and *couldn't take it back out of me*, and now he's on my floor and he needs me.

That's not luck, and I don't believe in it and I wouldn't want it.

It's a boat at the dock with the engine running. I've been standing on the shore long enough to know you get in the one that comes.

So: I don't kill him because I need him. Is that the whole of it?

That's what I'd say if somebody asked, and it's true: clean and ugly and the kind of true you can say out loud at your own kitchen table.



HERE'S THE part I wouldn't say.

He looked at me.

Wolves look at me fast, then decide to be somewhere else, because whatever I am reads to them as spoiled.

Humans don't even do that much, because humans look right through the middle of me. They always have, and I'm so tired of it I've stopped noticing I'm tired.

A week ago he sat at my bar and didn't see me either.

Tonight he came across a room to find out what I was. What am I, to him? A problem. A meal that talked back.

And when he couldn't put me back the way he found me, he didn't call anybody or have me taken. He stood in a hallway with my blood on his teeth and looked at me like I'd gone off in his hand.

Then I asked him whether he was a vampire.

He didn't answer, but he turned around to be asked. He had to decide to do that, and I watched him decide it.

To a wolf, turning to face the one who called you is the whole of it: you don't have to answer, because turning *is* the answer. It means *I acknowledge you have standing to ask me something*.

Nobody has ever given me standing, not once, in either language.

Jesus. Not once.

And I am sitting on my own floor with a knife in my hand, deciding not to use it, because a four-hundred-year-old predator turned around in a hallway. How pathetic is that?

That's not a good reason, and I know exactly what it is.

I put the knife on the counter behind me, out of reach of the floor. Sense or cowardice? I'm not sorting that out tonight.

His dick is hard against his hip, and I can see the shape of it through the wool even with him half-dead on my floor.

I make myself stop looking at it, and then I look at it again, and then I look at the ceiling and ask God what exactly He was going for with me. Was this a joke?



HE WAKES UP a little before the sky does.

I hear it as a change in the breathing, and then his fingers move on the linoleum, flat, testing the surface.

I go very still against the cabinets. Oh, shit.

His eyes open and they're not right — there's a slowness behind them. It takes him too long to find me, and when he does he doesn't move his head.

He looks at the room first, his eyes going to the front door and then to the window over the sink and then to the one at the end of the hall.

Then to my bedroom door, standing open, the way it always is.

He looks at that one longer than he looked at the windows. Why that door?

Only after all of that does he look at me.

And then he moves.

I don't see the middle part: he's on the floor and then his hand is on my throat against the cabinet and his face is close enough that I can see what's behind his eyes, and it isn't a person.

He doesn't squeeze, his palm sitting over my pulse like he's reading a page he found open.

One second, maybe less, and his nostrils flare and I understand: he smells the wolf in me. His body got there before his mind did, and his body's answer to *wolf* is this, a hand on the nearest throat and the question afterward.

He lets go.

He steps back, or tries to, and barely makes it clear of me before his arm gives and he catches himself on the counter edge. The effort it costs him to stand there and not fall is worse to look at than the hand was.

He doesn't say anything about it, just moves his jaw once and sets it, and whatever he was going to say goes behind his teeth.

I should be on my feet, across the room with the knife in my hand and the deadbolt between us, because a predator older than this country just put his hand on my throat on instinct, and you can't negotiate with instinct.

I don't move. Why don't I move?

Because underneath the cold, underneath the adrenaline, underneath the part of me that is correctly, accurately afraid — my body answered him. The reaching that goes for wolves, that went for Rémy on the dock, that has spent my whole life going for anything that might recognize it, went for *him*.

It met the predator in his grip and didn't pull away.

Every nerve I own said *yes*, and I am sitting on this floor being both things at once, which is all I've ever been.

He slides down the counter and sits on the linoleum across from me, breathing wrong and not looking at his hand.

I'm not looking at it either, only at his face, and what's behind his eyes is a person again. The person is ashamed, and I don't want him to be.

I can't explain it, and I don't mean the hand. I mean that I don't want him sorry for it. Jesus. What kind of woman wants that?



"Your window's painted shut," he says.

His voice is wrecked, and it's the first thing he's said since the parking lot, and that's what it is.

"The one in the front's fine," I tell him. "That's the one I'd use. You planning on leaving through it?"

"I'm planning on standing first." Something happens at the corner of his mouth. "The front one. Why that one?"

"Because it's the one nobody expects you to know about."

He tries to sit up and gets about a third of the way and then braces a palm on the floor and stops. I watch him decide not to try again, and I watch him be entirely calm about it.

His arm is still open, and he looks at it for a while. I understand that he is finding out about it at the same moment I'm watching him find out.

"How long?" he asks.

"Most of the goddamn night. You snore, by the way."

"I do not."

"You do now. Hell of a thing to find out on a kitchen floor."

"And this is your apartment?"

"Yes. Where else would I take you?"

"Not a friend's?"

"I don't have that kind of fucking friend. I barely have the regular shitty kind."

He takes that in, and his eyes come up to my face and stay there. I feel how much of a room he is, even flat on the floor, even like this.

"Where's the knife?" he says.

My whole spine goes cold. Fuck.

"On the counter. Do you want it?"

"Mm." He shuts his eyes for a second. "You had it in your hand?"

"For a while. Does that bother you?"

"How long a while?"

"Long enough, Christ. What do you want, a timestamp?"

"Say it again."

"I said long enough."

And he laughs, barely anything, an exhale with a shape to it. It clearly costs him, and it's the single most frightening thing that's happened to me tonight.

Then he opens his eyes and there's nothing loose behind them anymore.

"There's a rule about people like you," he says. "I said it to myself in that hallway and I meant it. Someone who can't be smoothed doesn't walk out of the building."

"You walked me out of the building, didn't you? Well, I walked you out, technically, but you were upright for some of it, and I'm giving you credit. Somebody should."

"I did." A pause. "I've been thinking about that for most of the night, and I was unconscious for a good deal of it, which tells you something."

"Tells me what, exactly? That you sleep like hell on linoleum?"

"That I hadn't finished." He watches me. "You drove me here and put a towel under my head. You had a blade in your hand and you set it down on a counter I can't reach."

"That's right. So what does that make me?"

"Why are you still alive, ghost?"

“Honestly? I was hoping you’d tell me.”



CHAPTER

Eleven

LUCIAN

HER BLOOD IS the first new thing I have tasted in three centuries. I have been lying on this woman's floor thinking about it since the light came up.

I can't stand yet, and the situation, stated honestly, is fucked.

Whatever was in the wine is still in me. My strength comes and goes, a lamp on a bad circuit. There's a cut along my forearm from her kitchen doorframe that should have closed before I hit the ground and it is still, hours later, a cut.

I could kill her even like this, slower than I'd like, and she'd have time to know about it. Would she fight?

I've been in this apartment long enough to see there's no lock on the bedroom door and no chain on the front. There's a window painted shut and a second one that opens. That's the one she'd use.

She sleeps with the bedroom door open, a woman who lives like she might need to leave through a window and won't shut the one door in the place that shuts. Why?

She comes in with a glass of water and sits down on the floor across from me, out of reach, with her back against the wall.

Every time, out of reach, and nobody taught her that. Or did someone?

"You're healing wrong," she says.

"I'm aware. Did you think I hadn't noticed?"

"Your arm's still open."

"Yes."

"How long does that usually take?"

"It doesn't usually take."

She sets the water down within my reach and takes her hand back. "There's a wolf who watched you go down last night. He's going to tell people."

"Then people will know. What would you have me do about it from your kitchen floor?"

"That's it? The whole plan?"

"The situation. A plan is a different thing." I get myself up against the cabinet so I'm at least sitting. "Why am I alive?"

"I'm *working* on that, for fuck's sake." She pushes her hair off her face, not steady and not hiding it. "You fed on me in a hallway."

"I did."

"You don't sound sorry. Are you?"

"Would it help if I lied?"

"Hell, no."

"I'm not, because it was lawful." I watch her take that. "It's still lawful this morning, and if you want me to perform contrition to make the next part easier, we'll both waste the afternoon."

She laughs without any humor anywhere in it.

"I don't want you sorry." She looks up. "I want a favor."



SO HERE IT is, the thing I've been waiting for since I woke on her floor.

Everyone wants something, and that's not cynicism, it's the arrangement. I'm the largest door in this city, and people come to me like people come to doors.

"Go on," I say. "Ask. Everyone does, sooner or later, and you've already fed me once, so you've earned the question."

"There's a wolf I need to get to. He's the Alpha's son and he doesn't come north of the water anymore, and I can't get inside Barataria on my own."

"You want me to hand you a Thibodeaux?"

"I want you to make it possible."

"Why? What did he do to you?"

"He killed my parents."

She says it without decoration.

That's the first moment I understand I'm not going to get out of this apartment unchanged.

"And in exchange?" I say.

"You come here." She holds my eyes. "You feed, not in a hallway and not hypnotized. I'll know I'm doing it and I'll remember it in the morning."

The room goes very still.

She has no idea what she's offering, and that's clear immediately: she's offering me a meal as you'd offer a man a spare room, because she thinks the currency is blood.

"You don't know what the hell you're proposing," I tell her.

"Then tell me. What the hell am I proposing?"

"There are registers to this." I keep my voice level. "What happened in the hallway is the ordinary one. It's clean and it's forgettable and it's what your whole city is built on and nobody remembers a minute of it."

"And the others?"

"Taken by force from someone awake is a crime, a real one, with a real punishment, and I've enforced it myself."

"And the third one?"

"Given." I have to stop for a second. "Freely, knowingly, remembered after. It's rare because of what it does."

"Which is what?"

"It goes both ways."

She frowns. "Meaning?"

"Meaning I don't just get blood." I look at her across her own kitchen floor. "I get what you're feeling while you give it to me. All of it. I can't choose which parts and I can't put it down afterward."

She sits with that.

I watch her understand it — not the mechanics, she gets those instantly, she's quick in a way I have not accounted for. What takes her the extra second is the exposure.

"You'd be in my head," she says.

"Your state, not your thoughts, and that's worse."

"Why the hell is it worse?"

"Because a thought can be a lie, ghost."



SHE SAYS NOTHING for a long time, and I let her be.

I'm not going to talk her into this. I want it badly enough to feel my own pulse in the roof of my mouth.

I still won't do it.

I'm not good, but hypnosis is the only tool I have for making a person compliant. It has never once been able to make a person *want*.

And I've spent a night on this woman's floor learning it doesn't reach her at all.

Which means everything she does from here is hers.

Nobody has ever been able to give me that.

"What are you?" I say.

Her head comes up.

"Your blood is wrong, human on top and wild underneath it, and my hypnosis doesn't reach you." I stop. "You should know that I don't say 'I don't know' out loud very often."

"My mother was a wolf," she says. "My father was human."

Nothing in the room changes and everything in it changes.

There is no such thing, and there are no such people: pack custom kills the relationship long before it produces a child. Everyone at my court would tell you the biology is impossible.

Both halves of that are wrong in the same direction.

"You can't shift," I say.

"No."

"Ever?"

“Ever.” Flat. “So don’t ask me twice.”

“Do they know, the pack?”

“They know I smell wrong.” Her mouth goes bitter. “That’s as far as anybody’s ever gotten.”

And there it is — the whole of her, in one sentence, and she doesn’t hear herself say it.

Wolves smell something wrong on her, and humans notice nothing at all, and that’s worse.

I have been the most dangerous thing in every room I ever walked into. I have never once been in a room I wasn’t at home in.

“Come here,” I say.



SHE TAKES ME to the bedroom because the floor is a stupid place to do this and she says so out loud.

I get there on my own, and it costs me and she lets it cost me. She doesn’t put a hand under my arm, and I’d have hated her for it.

I sit on the edge of her bed: cheap frame, good sheets, the one thing in the apartment somebody spent money on.

“How do you want to do it?” she asks.

“You’re the one giving. You decide.”

That lands somewhere, and I watch it land.

She puts a knee up on the bed beside me and takes my face in both hands, and then she stops, because she’s arrived at the part she hadn’t planned.

“You’ve done this before,” she says.

“Given? God, no.”

“No?”

“No.” I can feel her thumbs at my jaw. “I’ve been offered. I’ve never taken it.”

“Why not?”

“Because I’d have to know what they felt about it.” I hold her eyes. “I’ve never wanted to.”

Her breath goes out of her, and she doesn’t let go of my face.

"You called me ghost," she says. "In the hallway, twice."

"I did."

"Why? What does it mean?"

"It's what they are, after." I don't dress it up. "The ones I feed from walk out of the evening and it closes behind them, and nobody remembers a thing."

"I remember everything."

"I know."

"So what does that make me?"

Her thumbs have stopped moving, and she's waiting for the answer like it might be a verdict.

"The ghost that stayed," I tell her.

She kisses me before I've finished saying it.



SHE KISSES like she talks, with no preamble, no apology, nothing that resembles asking.

My hands go to her hips and I get about half the grip I want. The poison of it is that I don't hate it.

I can't move her. First time in four fucking centuries I've had a body in my grip I couldn't put where I wanted it.

So she does it: she gets my shirt open, impatient with the buttons, and then she stands up off the bed and pulls the dress over her head and drops it on the floor like it insulted her.

And I look.

I'm too weak to do anything else, which turns out to be a mercy, because I'd have skipped this, and this is the part I'm going to keep.

She's small, and she's hard where a bartender gets hard: shoulders, forearms, the long muscle down the front of her thighs from standing a double. There's a scar on her hip, old and white, and a bruise on her shin she doesn't know she has. Her tits are small and high and her nipples have gone tight in the cold of the room, or in the cold of me.

Her underwear is black and plain and it's soaked through at the front, and I can see it from the bed.

I could smell it from the kitchen.

"You're staring," she says.

"Yes. Do you want me to stop?"

"You said that last night."

"I meant it last night." I don't take my eyes off her. "Come closer. I want to see what I'm getting."

"You're not *getting* anything. I'm *giving*—"

"Then give it closer."

She makes a sound that's half a laugh and half an insult, and does.

She stands between my knees, and I put my mouth on her stomach, just under the ribs, because it's where I can reach, and her skin jumps. I drag my open mouth down to the edge of her underwear. She puts her hand in my hair, and she doesn't push and she doesn't pull.

"Who's had you like this?" I ask against her skin.

She goes still.

"Nobody's *had* me."

"Who's touched you, then?" My voice is doing a thing I didn't tell it to. "Standing in your bedroom. Letting them look."

"Is that any of your goddamn business?"

"Tonight it is."

"Two boyfriends. One bad, one boring, and both of them shit at it." She tugs my hair, hard, until I have to tip my head back and look up at her. "Neither of them's in this room, Your Majesty, so you can put your teeth away."

My teeth are out, and I hadn't noticed.

I put them away.

"Good," she says, like she's been training dogs her whole life, and climbs into my lap.



SHE STRADDLES me with her knees either side of my thighs and takes my hand and puts it on her tit, because I'm too slow about it.

"Lucian."

My name, with no title in front of it, and nobody does that.

"Say it again," I tell her.

"Lucian—"

"Again."

"*Lucian*." She bites it. "Are you going to do something, or are you going to make me say your name all night?"

I laugh, and it comes out of me before I can look at it.

Then I get my hand into her underwear and she stops being able to talk.

She's soaked. Her pussy is slick against my fingers before I've done a thing to earn it. She's hot there, hot enough that my cold fingers make her flinch and then press down harder.

I get two fingers into her, and she drops her forehead onto my shoulder and makes a small punched sound into my collarbone.

"Oh, *fuck*."

"Good girl."

Her cunt tightens on my fingers the second I say it.

I'll be using that for as long as she lets me.

She rides my fingers because she can't help it, and my thumb finds her clit and she bucks. Her hips roll, and roll, and her breath goes short and wet against my neck.

"Tell me," I say.

"Tell you what— Christ, what do you want me to tell you?"

"What you want."

"You know what I want. You can *smell* what I want."

"I want to hear it."

"God, you're—" She grinds down on my fingers and her voice climbs. "Your cock. Okay? I want your cock. Happy?"

"Almost. Say it again."

"Go to hell. Your cock."

Then she gets impatient with her own body, reaches down and gets my cock out. There's a moment where she just holds it and looks at it.

"Oh, that's—" She stops. "That's going to be a problem."

"It won't be. Do you trust me?"

"Hell, no."

"It's *thick*."

"You'll take it."

"Is that a fact?" She strokes me once, root to head, slow and mean, and watches my face while she does it. "Say please."

"No. Why would I say please for a thing you want this badly?"

She sinks down on me anyway.



IT'S NOT SMOOTH, and she has to work for it.

The head of my cock stretches her open and she hisses through her teeth. She gets it in and stops, both palms braced on my chest, breathing through her nose, her eyes wet.

"Fuck. *Fuck*. Okay. That hurts."

"I know."

"Don't say *I know* like you're *proud*—"

"I'm not proud." I am. "Breathe."

"I *am* breathing."

"Slower."

A little further down she has to stop again, with her forehead against mine, breathing like a wounded animal.

"Don't move," she says.

"I can't. Remember?"

"Right." A wet laugh. "Right, that's actually handy."

She takes the rest of it in a slow grind that has both of us swearing, her thighs shaking, her nails digging into my shoulders hard enough to break skin, and the skin doesn't close, and I don't care.

When she's all the way down she just sits there.

Full. Stretched. Her whole body trembling around me and her mouth open.

"Jesus Christ," she says to my collarbone.

"Wrong name."

"Shut up. Oh my God, shut *up*. Don't you dare be smug about this."

"I'm not smug."

"You're so fucking smug."

Then she starts to move.

I can't drive it, can't flip her, can't pin her, can't set the pace. She has all of it, and three strokes in she works out that she has all of it.

Her whole face changes when she realizes.

"You can't do anything," she says.

"No."

"You can't—" She rolls her hips hard, and I make a sound I haven't made in a very long time. "Oh, I like that. I like that a lot."

"I know you do. I can smell it."

She fucks me like she's angry at me, deep, greedy, all the way down every time. She lifts almost off me and drops, and lifts, and drops, and the wet sound of it fills the room. Her tits bounce against my chest, and her nails are in my shoulders. The whole of her is working me like I owe her money.

There's a twist at the bottom of the stroke. She finds it by accident and then does it on purpose, grinding her clit down against me every time she lands.

My hands are on her hips and they're useless there, along for it.

"Bite me," she says.

"Not yet."

"Why not— why the fuck not—"

"Because when I do, it's finished." I get a fist in her hair and pull her head back so she has to look at me. "You'll go up like dry paper, ghost. You won't get another hour out of me after that."

Her eyes go wide and black.

"Then make it count," she says.



SHE COMES FIRST, before I've touched her throat.

She's riding me with my thumb on her clit and her mouth open against my cheek, and it goes through her hard. Her back arches, and her cunt clamps down on my cock in long rhythmic pulls. She cries out, high and broken, and doesn't stop.

She doesn't stop moving either, rides it out and keeps going straight through the other side of it, still shaking, chasing another one.

“Now,” she says. “Now, now—”

I take her by the back of the neck and put my mouth on her throat, and she gives it to me.

That’s the difference, and nothing prepared me for it.

In the hallway I took it, and now she *hands* it to me. My teeth go in and her blood comes up into my mouth, and it brings her with it.

All of her. At once.

Terror, straight off the top, old, worn thin, the kind you stop noticing you’re carrying. Under it, grief with no floor to it, and a want so raw and unprotected that I have to hold onto her ribs to stay upright.

And loneliness.

God. The loneliness.

It doesn’t even register as sad, and that’s what takes my legs out from under me. It’s *ordinary* to her. It’s the temperature of the room she’s always lived in, and she doesn’t think about it. She’d have to be told she was lonely before she’d know it applied.

She has never once been at home in a room. How does a person live like that?

She doesn’t know that about herself. I know it about her before she does, and I’m going to have to carry that now.

And there’s one more feeling, at the bottom, and it’s aimed straight at me.

Please don’t be another thing that leaves.



SHE COMES AGAIN with my teeth in her.

Harder. Her whole body locks up and she sobs into my hair. Her cunt spasms on my cock in wave after wave. I feel her come twice. Once in my lap and once in my mouth, the pleasure arriving in her blood a heartbeat behind her body, like thunder after the flash.

It drags me over with her.

I come inside her while I’m still drinking, and I can’t tell which of us is making that noise.

It goes on, and my balls draw up tight and it keeps going. She keeps clenching around me in long greedy pulls that drag it out of me. I'm feeling her feel it, and there's no floor under any of this.

She's saying words into my hair I can't make out.

Then we're just two bodies on a cheap bed frame, her shaking and me holding her together with arms I can barely operate.

I close the wound with my tongue.

"Don't," she says.

"It's already done."

"I wanted—" Her voice cracks. "I wanted to keep it for a bit."

That's the sentence that finishes me: she wanted to keep the mark.

"Next time," I say.

She laughs into my neck, wet and wrecked. "Is that a threat?"

"It's a schedule."

"Oh my God. You're so annoying." She doesn't lift her head. "Do you ever just *say* things?"

"I just did. What else do you want?"

"Hm."

I can feel her smile against my skin.



SHE FALLS ASLEEP on me, just goes, mid-sentence, with her face in my neck.

I sit there with a woman on my lap, in a room with no lock on the door, and do what I haven't done since my father died.

Nothing at all.

The poison is still in me and my arm is still open. Somewhere across the river a wolf is telling people he saw the King of New Orleans go down in a club.

I should be at work, shouldn't I? What the hell kind of king sits on a bartender's bed while his city waits?

Here's what I've agreed to, and I want to be precise about it, because precision is the last thing I've got.

I'm going to give her a Thibodeaux, Gaspard's son, the heir. The one thing that tips a bad situation into a war.

The pack will call it an execution and my court will call it a favor for a bartender, and both of them will be right.

And she's going to open her throat for me on purpose until the day she doesn't.

The arrangement is bad, but I've read worse into a ledger and approved it.

What's actually wrong is this: she thinks she's fucking paying me.

She thinks she handed over blood. She handed me every unprotected thing in her and she doesn't know she did it.

I'm not going to tell her, because the moment she knows, she'll start being careful.

And I need her not to be careful. That's the truth of it.

Her hand is open on my chest, and the bedroom door is open behind her.

A lifetime of getting out of rooms before anything closed.

Now I'm sitting in one with a hybrid asleep on me, working out how to keep her.

I don't move her.

That's how I know.

On her counter, my phone lights up: Cassian, asking where I am.

I let it ring out. When have I ever let him ring out? Never, not once in my life.



C H A P T E R

Twelve

S E L E N E

THE HOUSE HAS a word for me and it isn't my name.

I hear it like I hear everything in here, said near me, never to me, in a register that assumes I can't tell the difference. A woman on the second-floor landing tells another woman I'm *the arrangement*, and the other woman says *which one*, and they both laugh.

Pack uses *arrangement* for a temporary structure, a lean-to: you build it because you need it and tear it down when you don't.

And in this house? It means the same thing.



LUCIAN PUT me in the west wing, and he said it without preamble, *there's a room, it's yours, don't go east*, and then he went to the study and shut the door. I stood in a hallway with a bag over my shoulder and no idea which direction west was.

A boy named Bastien found me, young by their calendar, which isn't mine. He talks as a retriever runs, at everything, all the time.

"This way." He took the bag off my shoulder before I could stop him. "It's not far, and there's a bath."

"I don't need — who are you?"

"Everybody needs a bath after a night like that." He grinned at me over his shoulder. "You drove the King home in your car, and the kid with the tray told Silas, and Silas told me."

"Silas told you? Who the hell is Silas?"

"Silas tells me everything he doesn't want to say out loud. I'm like a — what's the word? A drain."

"A conduit."

"That's nicer, and I'll use the fuck out of that. Don't tell Silas I said drain."

"Why?"

"Because he'll look at me. You don't want Silas to look at you, trust me."

He walked me through a hall that smelled like wood polish and money and old paper. Every person we passed looked at me and then away. It wasn't the human look-through but a sort, a quick decision that I'm not worth adjusting for.

Except one.

A man came out of a doorway at the end of the hall, tall, silver at the temples, with a face that makes you think of somebody's favorite uncle. He stopped when he saw me, and his eyes went over my face like a letter he wasn't expecting.

Then he smiled at Bastien.

"Making friends?" he said. "Good. God knows this house could use a few new faces that aren't three hundred years old and furious about the silverware."

"She's the — she's Lucian's —" Bastien caught himself. "She's staying in the west wing."

"How lovely." The man looked at me. "How is the room? Does it have enough light? The west wing always had terrible light, even when it was mine."

"I haven't seen the goddamn thing yet."

"You'll find it comfortable. There's a window that sticks — pull up before you pull out." He adjusted his cuffs. "I'm Cassian. You must be the woman from the club."

He said it warmly, and the warmth landed on me like heat off a radiator, steady, and coming from a thing you don't touch.

"Selene," I said.

"Selene, a beautiful name. Is it your mother's?"

"My father's side. Why do you ask?"

"Because I collect names, my dear. Old men do." He nodded, as if I'd handed him something to keep. "How is your family?"

That sentence had a shape I didn't like. The words were fine, but they arrived pre-assembled, like asking after a person's family was a habit, like other people tie shoes.

"Dead," I said. "Both of them. Four years ago. Anything else you'd like to ask, or should I just hand you a fucking file?"

He blinked, the first genuine movement I'd seen on his face.

"I'm sorry to hear it," he said, and he meant it. I could hear that he meant it, and it went into me badly, as true things do when you're not braced.

Then he went down the hall and Bastien took me to the room, and the room was fine, and the window sticks.



THE HOUSE IS old and the house is a court.

I've never been inside one, though I've worked at the edges of it, poured drinks for the men who come from it, learned the names they drop and the order they drop them in. But being inside it is standing in the water instead of looking at it.

Everything here runs on rank: money's in every surface, but rank is the engine. Who gets to enter which room, which hallway, which conversation? I can feel it like I feel the second language in any room I've ever stood in.

There's a morning room where the council takes coffee, and I am not in it.

There's a library on the second floor where the Elders read newspapers that are printed in French, and I am not in it.

There's a kitchen where the human staff — the ones who know, the ones in the arrangement — eat together at a long table. They looked up when I came in and could not decide what to put me in.

Too human for the morning room, and not human enough for the long table.

So where does that leave me? At the counter, eating a piece of toast standing up, and then back to the west wing.



THE COURT NOTICES me as a body notices a splinter. Fuck them.

Slowly, over the first day, I can feel the attention gathering: small looks, held a beat too long, and the silence that drops into a room when I walk into it.

It's not hatred, because I'd smell hatred.

This is a house full of very old things trying to decide whether I'm furniture or a guest. The distinction matters, because furniture gets moved and a guest gets fucking fed.



ON THE SECOND morning, one of them decides to check.

He's old even by their calendar, an Aldric cousin, with a jaw set in a century that didn't ask women things. He finds me in the corridor outside the library and stands too close. I can smell what he's going to do before he does it.

"So you're the arrangement," he says.

I don't step back, because stepping back is a whole sentence, and I'm not giving him one.

He reaches for my face, two fingers under my chin, and tilts it as you'd turn a horse's head to check its teeth, slowly, in front of four people who don't look up.

I let him touch me. Why? Because I'm busy, already building the sentence that will take him apart. I can hear both layers of him, entitlement on

the surface and terror underneath. He's terrified that a half-breed with the King's attention will cost his family standing in a succession they've been positioning for since before I was born. The hand on my chin is a man checking whether the bomb is real.

I open my mouth to give him the translation — his own fear, named, in court register, in front of everyone, dressed as courtesy so he can't even flinch without confirming it —

And the hallway goes cold.

Pond-water cold, the kind where the temperature drops through some line and the whole character of it changes. The glass in a woman's hand fogs over, and she sets it down without looking at it.

Lucian is in the doorway at the end of the hall.

He doesn't come in or speak. He looks at the hand on my face, and that's all he does. I watch a man who has been alive for three centuries slowly remove his own fingers from my jaw as though he's just discovered they're touching something that will cost him the hand.

He leaves the corridor, and then the house, and Bastien tells me the next morning he left the city.

Nobody in that hallway says a word about it. A woman picks up her glass and finds it cold, and frowns, and drinks it anyway. Hell of a party trick.



I AM FUCKING furious.

At Lucian, because the man barely counts. At the back of him, already gone from the doorway, already somewhere in the east wing doing whatever a king does when he's finished making a point.

I was winning, with the sentence built. I had both registers loaded and the safety off and I was going to take that man's standing apart with six words and a smile. Every person in that corridor would have known that the woman in the west wing has teeth, and the teeth are *hers*.

Instead they know the King walked in. Who asked him to?

They know I'm protected, and in both languages that word means *doesn't need to protect herself*.

I go back to the west wing and sit in the chair and think about it until the thinking has a temperature, and the temperature is not going down.



A WOMAN FROM House Aldric — I catch the name from Bastien, who narrates this house as if he's calling a game — comes to the west wing door around noon.

She doesn't knock, just stands in the frame and looks at me sitting in the window with a cup of coffee I made myself in a kitchen that doesn't belong to me.

"You're the girl," she says.

In pack, *girl* is a position, and in this house it's a size.

"I'm Selene. And you are?"

"I know what your name is." She leans on the frame. "Marguerite wants you out."

"I'll talk to Lucian. Hell."

"Marguerite doesn't go through Lucian, dear, she goes around him. She's been going around kings since before your species had a written language."

My species? She doesn't know what my species is. She's looking at a bartender in the west wing and putting me under *human*, the smallest fucking drawer in her cabinet.

"I'll talk to Lucian, for fuck's sake," I say again.

"You won't need to." She straightens up. "You'll be out by the weekend. These things sort themselves."

She leaves, and I drink my coffee.



LUCIAN COMES to the room in the evening.

He doesn't knock either, which should bother me and doesn't. He stands in the doorway like he stands in every doorway, reading the room before he enters it. Then he comes in and shuts the door, and he has to pass me to get to the bed. He doesn't give me an inch of room to let him.

His hip brushes my shoulder, and his coat smells like rain and cold stone and, faintly, like my sheets.

That's not even a little bit fucking fair.

"You haven't eaten, ghost," he says. It's not a question.

"Toast. Is that a crime here?"

"That's not eating, is it?"

"It's what there was. Your kitchen's a fucking museum."

His eyes narrow while he works out who in his house let a woman go hungry, and somebody's about to have a very bad conversation.

"The Aldric bitch came to see me," I say.

"Which one?"

"Tall, opinions, a lot of both. Jesus. She talked to me like I was something on her shoe."

"She talks to me like that too."

"Shit. Really?"

"Every Christmas." He sits on the edge of the bed, the only place to sit that isn't the chair I'm in. "Tall with opinions is three of them. What did she say?"

"That Marguerite wants me out by the weekend."

"Marguerite wants many things by the weekend. She's been wanting things by the weekend for eight hundred years. She'll keep wanting them."

"And the cousin?" I say.

He goes still, and the air around him stops moving.

"He put his hand on you," he says.

"And I was about to take it off. I had the bastard, Lucian."

"I saw what he —"

"You saw what he did, but you didn't see what I was about to do." I lean forward. "I had it, Lucian, both registers: his fear underneath his face, and a sentence ready that would have cost him his standing in that corridor for a decade. With an audience. With a smile."

He watches me.

"And you walked in," I say. "And the room went cold, and he ran, and now every person in this house knows that the woman in the west wing is

protected. You know what that means in wolf? It means can't hunt for herself. You don't get to be my teeth, Lucian. I have my own fucking teeth."

The silence goes on long enough that I can hear the house settling.

"You had both registers?" he says.

"Loaded."

"And the sentence?"

"Built."

His jaw loosens, and his eyes go over my face again, the look he gave me in the hallway with blood on his mouth, when he tried to smooth me and it didn't take.

"Next time," he says, "I'll wait."

"Next time you'll wait in the hall until I'm finished."

The almost-smile, the real one, not the court one.

"Yes," he says. "I will."

The silence stretches while he looks at his hands like tools he's deciding whether to put away.

"If he'd gone further," he says, "I would have taken the hand off at the wrist. In the corridor. In front of the four people who didn't look up, so they could watch me do it and learn what not looking up costs. Then I would have gone to the Aldric house in Lyon and explained to his family, in person, with the hand on the table between us, that their name is welcome in this city for exactly as long as every member of it understands that the woman in my house is not a thing they get to touch. Not her face. Not her arm. Not the air around her."

He says it with no heat, like a sequence he's already rehearsed to the end.

"That isn't what I did," he says. "Because you told me you had it."

He looks at me.

"But I want you to know what the other version was."



"This is your aunt," I say, after a while.

"My father's sister. Did she frighten you?"

"Nothing in this house frightens me. It annoys the shit out of me. And she doesn't want me here."

"She doesn't want anything here that she didn't put here herself." He looks at me. "It's not personal."

"Then why does it feel like it's about me?"

"It isn't. Would I lie to you about my aunt?"

I want to argue, and to translate what the Aldric woman said to me and show him what it looked like in the other language, the one he doesn't hear because he's never had to.

But he's sitting on my bed in a room he gave me. He looks tired in a way that isn't about sleep. I don't have the right vocabulary for a fight I'd win.

"The pact," I say instead.

"What about it?"

"How does it work, in here? Am I a guest?"

"You're mine."

He says it simply, putting me in his house as you'd put a key on a ring. This is where you are, this is what you're attached to, this is who has to be moved to get to you.

"That word is going to cause so many fucking problems," I say.

"It's going to solve them."

"In your language?"

"In the only one that matters in this building."

He's wrong about that, because there are at least three languages in this house, and he speaks one of them. The one he doesn't speak is the one that's going to decide whether I wake up here tomorrow.

But he's also right: his name is the only protection that works in this building. I've been unprotected long enough to know what it costs.

I've taken worse deals for less, haven't I?

"Fine," I say. "Shit. Fine."

"Fine."

"But I'm going to need to leave the west wing."

"You can go where you like."

"The morning room?"

The space a smile would go, if smiles were permitted.

"The morning room," he says. "Yes."

"And the kitchen?"

"Obviously. It's a kitchen, for fuck's sake."

"And wherever the hell you keep the information about Rémy Thibodeaux."

The almost-smile goes away.

"That," he says, "is a different conversation."

"I know."

"Have it tomorrow." He stands.

He doesn't go. He puts two fingers under my chin, exactly where the cousin's were, and tips my face up.

It isn't the same touch: his fingers are cold and slow. His thumb comes up and drags across my lower lip until my mouth opens under it. My pulse jumps in my throat where he can see it. My thighs press together in the chair, and he watches that too.

"Anybody else puts a hand here," he says, "you take it off. I'll wait in the hall."

"And you?"

"I'm not anybody else."

I bite his thumb, not gently.

He doesn't pull it back, just lets me hold it in my teeth while his eyes go black at the edges, and then he slides it free, wet from my mouth, and wipes it slowly down the side of my throat.

"Eat something that isn't toast, ghost."

He goes, and the door doesn't close all the way behind him, because nothing in this house closes all the way. I sit in the window and look at the crack of light in the frame and think about the word *mine* and what it costs in both translations.

Someone moves to have me removed before the week is out.

"Let them try," I tell the crack of light in the door. "I'll be right fucking here."



C H A P T E R

Thirteen

L U C I A N

FOUR CENTURIES of records and someone has already pulled them.

That's what I find when I go down to the archive room, and absence would be obvious and stupid. This is *order*. Somebody has been through the household ledgers, the personnel files, the correspondence bound by year and sealed with my father's stamp.

They didn't take anything. They organized it. Who does that?

The folders are indexed, and every gap in the record has a tab in it, a slip of paper, unsigned, no handwriting I recognize, that says only what's missing and from which year.

Whoever did this wanted me to see what wasn't here. Why?



SILAS DOESN'T know who did it, or says he doesn't, which with Silas is a distinction I've learned to leave alone.

"The archive's been open since the funeral," he says. "Staff had access, council had access, and Marguerite was down here the second day."

"Marguerite doesn't index. Does she?"

"No. She reads and remembers and tells you what you missed, and then she tells you twice, God help you." He looks at the shelves. "This is someone who works with their hands."

I pull a folder at random, household accounts sixteen years old. Every entry is present, every page numbered, and at the back there's a tab.

Missing: receipts for the east door commission, spring of this year. Three pages.

The handwriting on the tab is small and precise, a hand taught in a schoolroom by someone who believed in consistency.

"Find out who did this," I say. "And find out tonight, before they tidy anything else."

"I'll ask. Who do you want me to start with?"

"Don't ask. Look. Whoever it was didn't want to be asked. They wanted it to be here when I came looking."

Silas nods and goes up the stairs without touching the rail, hands free, weight forward, ready for whatever's at the top.



I START WORKING.

The investigation has to wait, because it requires knowing what I'm looking at, and I don't. I've spent four centuries leaving the records to the men my father paid to keep them, and those men are either dead or frightened.

So I go back to the beginning, to the household rolls. Who was on the staff the year my father died, and the year before that, and the ten years before that?

I'm not good at it, because I'm good at rooms, at reading who's in them, who has a key, who walked past what to stand where they're standing. Paper is a different animal.

But the paper has doors in it too, if you know where to push.



SHE FINDS ME in the archive around noon. How does she always find me?

I don't hear her come in, and it's becoming a pattern. She stands in the doorway for a count I'll never know the length of, and then she says, "You're reading those wrong."

I look up, and she's in the clothes she arrived in, and there's coffee on her thumb. She's looking at the ledger I'm holding as Silas looks at a trail.

"These are household accounts," I say. "What else would they be?"

"Those are household accounts with annotations in wolf trade pidgin." She crosses and takes the ledger from me, and her fingers brush mine, and neither of us mentions it. "Here, this column. You're reading it as French shorthand."

"It isn't? Then what is it?"

"It's a trade cipher that wolf families use for cross-territory business: dock work, shipping, labor contracts. It shifts between French and a Barataria register that nobody outside the bayou writes down."

She turns the page, her nail tracking a line of annotation I'd been reading as a clerk's abbreviation for three hours.

"This says the east door commission was subcontracted," she says. "It's not missing, it *moved*. Somebody in this house was sending work to wolf contractors through a translation layer."

I've been staring at this ledger since morning, and she's been in the room for less than a minute.

"You read this? All of it?"

"I read everything, and that's the whole problem." She sits in the chair across from me and pulls another folder toward her. "My father was a translator. I grew up in a house full of documents in three languages, and he taught me to see the seams."

We work.

It's slow, and it's close: she reads the wolf layer and I read the political one. Where they overlap, where the same transaction appears in two registers and the registers don't agree, we find the gaps.

She reads rooms I didn't know had walls.

I watch her decode a funding annotation that I would have taken to Silas. Silas would have taken to the Marchand woman, and the Marchand woman would have sent me back with a question. She does it with a coffee

cup in one hand and her father's silence in the other. She doesn't look up, and I can hear her heartbeat from where I'm sitting, and it's steady.

She turns a page and stops. What has she found?

"Lucian."

Her voice has changed, and I look at the page. In the margin, in the wolf cipher, in handwriting she clearly recognizes: Aurelian's name. My father's name, written in a language he didn't speak, in his own household records, by someone who was communicating in both directions.

My hand closes over hers on the page.

I don't decide to do it. It happens like the hand on her throat happened, the body arriving before the mind. The body's answer to my father's name in a place it shouldn't be is *hold what you're holding and don't let go*.

Her fingers go still under mine, and she looks up.

My eyes are wrong, and I can feel it, because behind them is a version of me that doesn't sit in rooms and wait. It lasts a second, maybe two.

I let go.

"Sorry," I say. "Christ. I'm sorry."

"Don't be." She looks at me steadily. "That's the first honest thing your hands have done since I got here."

She doesn't take her hand back.

I lift it, and turn her wrist over on the ledger and bring it up to my mouth, and I don't bite. I breathe over the pulse and feel it jump against my lips. Her knees shift under the table and her thighs press together. I can smell exactly what that does to her.

"Not here," she says, her voice gone low and rough.

"Where, then? Name the room."

"Somewhere with a lock."

"Nothing in this fucking house locks."

"Then you'd better be quick about it, Your Majesty."

"I'm never quick."

"Oh, for fuck's sake. I know."

I put her wrist down on my father's accounts, very carefully, as if it might go off. Then I pick up the ledger again, because one of us has to, and I read the same line four times.



THE HOUSEHOLD is larger than I thought, page after page of names: the humans who don't know what they work for, the vampires who've been here longer than I've been paying attention, and the handful brought in since the truce, by Marguerite or by Cassian or by my father himself.

I pull the record for each of the handful, and most are straightforward: young vampires from good houses, sent here as a courtesy, and Marguerite's people, placed with her usual precision.

One doesn't have a record. Why not?

It was never created: a name on the payroll with no entry behind it, no hiring record, no note in anyone's writing. He's been on the household roll for years and nobody has ever written down where he came from.

The name is Tobias Vale.

I don't know him. Has he ever been in a room I was in? Or was he, and I didn't look?

Vale, Cassian's name. A cousin, probably, because the Vales are a large house, and most of them are administrative, the kind of vampires who keep courts running and never sit at the table.

I write the name down and move on, because a man with no record is either an oversight or a person somebody decided not to document, and both of those are worth knowing and neither is worth stopping for.



THE CORRESPONDENCE takes longer.

My father kept everything. Letters from Houses on the continent, from the Conclave — the continental authority that ratifies kings and has never once bothered to exercise it, as far as I know — from Gaspard Thibodeaux in the years after the truce, written in a hand that suggests the wolf learned to write late and never enjoyed it.

And from Cassian.

They wrote to each other, and I hadn't known that. They lived in the same city, saw each other most days, and still they wrote — short notes,

mostly, about small things. A bottle of something, a book one of them had read, a restaurant recommendation.

The notes are warm.

I stop reading them after the third one because my chest is tightening and I don't have the time for it.

What I'm looking for isn't warmth but the household's private correspondence seal, the mark my father used on internal messages, the informal ones that didn't carry the House stamp. A little hooked figure, like a fishhook or a question mark, that he drew by hand on anything he sent inside the walls.

I find it on letter after letter in the past year alone, all of them internal, all of them addressed to members of the household or to people with regular access.

I don't find what I'm looking for, but I know the shape of it now: a mark that somebody outside the house might have seen, might have copied down, might have kept in a ledger without knowing what it meant.

I'll need her father's book for that, the one she hasn't opened.



IT'S LATE WHEN I come up.

The house has settled for the night: lamps on in the halls, the smell of onions from the kitchen, and the particular absence of noise that means everyone who matters has gone to a room with a door on it.

Cassian is in the front hall.

He's putting on his coat, going home. He came by this evening when I wasn't there, as he often does. He comes most evenings and sits in the study and drinks a glass and leaves without being asked to stay.

"Boy."

"Going? Already?"

"It's late." He buttons the coat. "You were in the archive?"

"How did you know?"

"You have dust on your collar." He reaches out and brushes it off, like he did when I was a boy. "Find anything?"

"Paperwork. Mountains of it."

"Your father loved paperwork. God knows why."

"My father loved the idea of paperwork, and left the actual work to other people."

"True." Cassian smiles. "He always said the archive would be the last place he'd look and the first place he should."

I stop.

The second time he's said that: the same sentence, the same rhythm, handed to me like a coat in bad weather. Why twice?

"He said that?"

"After the business with the Aldric cousin, years ago. He meant it, and then he didn't do it, because that was Aurelian, a man with perfect instincts and no follow-through on the domestic end."

"You think I should search the household? My own staff?"

"I think your father's records will tell you what his rooms won't." He adjusts his cuffs. "How is the Marchand woman? Ondine. Silas was there this week."

The change of subject is so smooth I feel it happen and don't mind it, because Cassian's warmth is a climate, and you live in it.

"She's well, I think. Silas would know better. He's been out there more than he admits."

"Has he? Good for Silas. God knows he needs somewhere to go that isn't a doorway. Her grandmother's chest was bad, and I used to worry." He opens the front door. "You should order the body examined, if you haven't."

"The body? Now?"

"Your father's," he says gently. "Ambroise has been waiting, and he won't do it without your word, and the longer he waits, the less he'll find."

He's right, about this and about the archive and about Ondine Marchand. Every piece of advice he gives me is true and useful and arrives in the exact shape of innocence.

"I'll go down tomorrow," I say.

"Take him upstairs first and give him a drink." He's in the doorway now, backlit. "He does better when someone remembers he's a person before he's a physician."

"Thank you."

"For what? For being old and interfering?" He smiles. "How is your mother's house in Toulouse?"

"Standing, I assume. Why does everyone keep asking me about houses?"

"Go, when this is finished."

He goes, and the door stays open behind him, because it always does. The night air comes into the hall smelling like the Quarter after rain: wet stone, old wood, jasmine from the courtyard.

I stand there for a while like a fucking fool.

He's told me to examine the body and to search the records. He's pointed me at two things that will lead me straight to the truth. He's done it in the voice of a man who wants me to find it.

Why would anyone point me at the truth and then go home to bed? I don't understand that.

I go back to the archive and I pull my father's body order — the one that tells Ambroise what he's permitted to do and when — and I sign it, and I leave it on the desk for morning.

Then I go upstairs and stand outside the room in the west wing where a woman is sleeping with the door open. I don't go in, and I don't close it.

She's asleep with every door in her life standing open. Who taught her to sleep like that?

"Goodnight, ghost," I tell the dark, too low to wake her.

I ordered my father's body examined.

The first honest act of the office.

Somebody in this house is counting on it.



CHAPTER

Fourteen

LUCIAN

THE WOLF WOUNDS were survivable.

Ambroise has been a physician since before the truce and he says it like he'd say a room was cold. He has my father laid out on a table in the cold room under the house and he has been at this for two days. He does not look at me when he talks.

"Four bites," he says. "Left forearm, both shoulders, one at the hip that took a piece out, heavy damage, all of it closing."

"Closing? All of them?"

"He was healing while they did it, and he'd have been on his feet inside an hour." He turns the arm over. "This is a man who was winning."

"Then show me the one that did it. Where is it?"

He shows me.

It's under the ribs on the left, angled upward. It is not a bite but a clean entry the width of a blade. The edges of it are dry and slightly parted and they look like they gave up trying.

Every other wound on my father's body is a closed line, and this one is a hole.

Fuck.

"How long?" I ask.

"For a wound like this? On him?" Ambroise shakes his head. "It doesn't happen. I've put my fist inside an Ancient's chest and felt it close on my wrist. This did not close and it was never going to, and he'd have known that the moment it went in."

"How long was he alive?"

The old man finally looks up at me.

"Minutes," he says. "Awake for them. I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry. Be fucking certain."

"I'm certain, sire."



I STAND THERE for a while. What is there to say?

The room has one door, and I came through it, Ambroise came through it, and two of his people came through it with the table.

Nobody comes into this room who wasn't let in. The man on the table is here because somebody got close enough to put a blade under his ribs and have the hand not be checked.

"Wolves don't carry this," I say.

"No."

"Say it again. Say it plainly."

"Wolves don't carry steel keyed to a man's blood, sire." He wipes his fingers on a cloth. "They wouldn't know how to ask for it, or who to ask."

There it is, then. Who stands that close to a king?

Somebody stood next to my father in a room with wolves coming through the windows. My father did not put a hand up, because the thought of needing to was not a thought available to him.

Any wound says traitor.

This one says he wasn't afraid.



I GO UP into the house and I say nothing to anybody, and this is the part that will cost me.

Because I cannot bring this to the council. Why not?

I've run it a dozen ways in my head and every one of them ends in the same room. Marguerite hears *insider*, and in about a minute she has the household on a list, and in an hour she has the list narrowed to whoever most inconveniences her, and by morning there are three Houses accusing each other with real knives out.

And the war goes ahead anyway, *faster*, because a court that suspects itself needs an outside enemy more than it needs air.

So what do I do with the most important fact I have? I sit on it.

I've been King in everything but the crown for weeks and the first genuine act of the office is going to be a lie of omission to the people I'm supposed to be governing.

My father would have gone into that chamber and said it out loud.

He'd have stood up in front of all of them and said *one of you was in the room*, and he'd have taken whatever came, and half of them would have called it weakness.

I'd have called it weakness, and I did call it weakness, to his face across a desk with a bottle between us.

I have his blade in my coat, and it came out of the chamber floor that night and nobody has asked me for it since.

Why do I keep carrying it? It's been in my coat every day.



SILAS IS WAITING in the study, and he's been waiting long enough to have gone through the decanter and not touched it.

"The wine," he says.

"Go. What have you got?"

"Supplier's a house on Decatur, small, legitimate. The bottle came in a case of six and the other five went to three different buyers, all of them clean." He doesn't use paper, and he never has. "Route's the Gulf and then a warehouse in the Bywater, with two hands on it there. I have both names and neither of them knew what they were carrying."

"And the brewer? Who made the stuff?"

Silas looks at the window.

It's a small thing: he's a man who looks at whatever he's talking about. He always has been, and right now he is looking at a window.

"Still confirming," he says.

"You have a name? Any name?"

"I have a direction. Isn't that something?"

"Silas."

"I'd rather bring you a name than a direction, sire." He says it evenly. "Give me a week, because if I'm wrong and I've said it out loud, somebody gets taken apart in this house for nothing. I've seen that happen, and so have you."

Which is true, every word of it, and it is put together so well that I don't hear the shape of it.

Here is what I notice: that he's careful, and that's what he's for.

Here is what I don't notice: Silas Roche has never in two hundred years asked me for a week.

"One week," I say. "Not a day longer, do you hear me?"

"Thank you."

And he goes out, and the door closes, and I sit in my father's chair thinking about the wound and not about the only lie anybody has told me today.



SHE COMES IN without knocking, which nobody in this house does.

"Your physician's crying in the kitchen," Selene says. "Into the soup. The cook's too scared to tell him to stop, and I don't blame her."

"He's old. What do you want from me?"

"He's not crying because he's old, you ass." She shuts the door behind her. "What did he find?"

Should I tell her to get out? I've told better-born men than her to get out of this room this week.

Instead I hear myself say it.

"Somebody in my father's house put a knife in him while he was busy staying alive."

She doesn't gasp or reach for me. Why doesn't she?

She sits down on the arm of the chair across from the desk and thinks about it. I watch her turn it over and come out the other side with what nobody at my council would have gotten to in a week.

"Then you can't tell them, can you?" she says.

"No."

"Because it becomes a list."

"Yes. Does that surprise you?"

"And a list becomes—" She stops and starts again, and I can see her pull the word out of one language and hand it to me in the other. "In pack, when nobody knows who did a thing, the smallest family pays for it. Every time. It's not even cruelty by then. It's housekeeping."

"It's the same here. Did you think we'd be better?"

"I know it is. That's why I said it. Hell, it's why I'm still in the room."

I look at her across my father's desk, the only person in this city I can say this to.

Is she trustworthy? I don't know, and I'm not sentimental enough to assume it.

She has nothing to gain from any version of the answer. She doesn't want a House raised or a rival named.

She wants one wolf on a shrimp boat.

Everyone else who walks through that door wants a piece of what I decide.

She's said so out loud, and there's a horrible restfulness in it.

"Come here," I say.

"That's not— what the hell are you—"

"Come here."

She comes.



I GET HER by the hips and put her face-down over the desk.

I'm not gentle about it. I pick her up like she's nothing, because to these hands she is. She makes a sound when she lands, half a laugh and half the breath knocked out of her. Her hands go flat on the blotter to brace and I don't let her keep them there.

I put them where I want them, palms down, spread, on the papers.

His papers: the letters he was answering the week he died, the household accounts, a list in his own handwriting of people to be paid, all of it under her palms.

I know exactly what I'm doing and I don't look at it. Why would I?

I take the back of her neck, and my fingers are cold. She hisses when they touch her skin, and then she pushes into them. The heat of her throat against my palm is obscene.

"Don't move these," I tell her.

"Lucian—"

"Say you won't move them."

"I won't move them." Her voice has gone low and thick. "Jesus. *Okay.*"

I get her skirt up over her hips and her underwear down and out of the way, and then I stop for a second because I want to look at her like this: bent over, holding still, her fingers pressing white on a dead man's correspondence. Her shirt has ridden up and I push it the rest of the way, her tits against the blotter, her spine a line I could trace with my teeth.

She's already wet, wet since *come here*, and I can smell it, the sharp, salt-sweet smell of her pussy, wanting since she walked through the door and not knowing how to ask for it.

"Look at you," I say. "Four words across a room, and this happens?"

"Are you pleased with yourself? You smug bastard."

"I'm not pleased." I get two fingers into her and she goes up on her toes. Her cunt grips me like an answer. "I'm taking an inventory."

"Oh, *fuck*—"

"You're sopping. Didn't you walk in here to ask me about a corpse?"

"So did you— you absolute bastard—"

I drag my teeth down her spine, not biting, the points of them, from the nape of her neck to the small of her back, a slow line that leaves no mark and promises everything. She goes rigid under it, and then she melts.

I take a fistful of her hair and pull. She arches into it and gets louder, and clever is done for both of us.



I LINE MY cock up against her and push in, and the sound she makes is not a word.

She's tight, tight and wet and scalding hot, and I'm cold. The contrast makes her gasp and clench and try to pull away and push back at the same time.

I don't let her go anywhere: a fist in her hair, my other palm on her hip. I feed myself into her until there's nowhere left to go.

"Oh god — oh *fuck* — you're—"

"Take it."

She takes it and pushes back into it.

I fuck her hard enough to move the desk, a heavy piece of furniture built in a century that expected furniture to stay where it was put. It goes across the boards a finger at a time while I use her.

Every time I think I've gone past what she'll allow, she shoves her hips back to drag me in.

"Harder—"

"Be quiet. Do you want the whole house in here?"

"*Harder*, you—"

I slide my hand from her hip to her throat. I pull her up off the desk by it — her back arching against my chest, my cold fingers wrapped around her windpipe, my dick pressed so deep I can feel her heartbeat around it. She groans, and her cunt tightens on me so hard I lose a stroke.

"There," I say against her ear. "Isn't that what you wanted? All you had to do was hold still and let me have it."

"Say something else."

"Would you like that? Would you, ghost?"

"Say something *filthy*." Her voice is wrecked. "Please. I don't want to think for a minute, I just want—"

So I do.

I bend her back down over the desk and hold her there by the throat. I tell her what she looks like with her skirt around her waist and my cock stretching her open. I tell her what she sounds like. I tell her she's my good

girl and my filthy little whore, and that she walked into this room to be used. She didn't, she came in because a physician was crying. She takes it anyway because tonight it's the same as true.

"Yes — *yes* — don't stop—"

I call her *ghost*. I call her *mine*. I tell her I can feel her cunt getting tighter every time I say something that should make her push me off. She isn't pushing, she's *pulling*, and that tells me everything about what she needs and everything about what I'm going to give her.

Her orgasm starts somewhere in the middle of that and builds without her permission.

"Don't stop talking—"

I don't stop.

She comes with her forehead down on the blotter and one hand crushing my father's handwriting into a shape it will not come back from, loud and completely unguarded, a sound with no audience in it at all.

I keep going through it, and her cunt pulses around me. I fuck her through every pulse until she's sobbing into the wood.

Then she breaks the rule: her hands come off the papers and reach back for me, blind, grabbing at my coat.

I stop dead.

"What did I tell you?"

"I don't—" She's panting. "I don't care, I want to touch you—"

"I know you do. Do you think I don't?"

I pull out of her, and she makes a sound of pure outrage. I turn her onto her back on the desk. She lands on the letters, and they slide and fan out under her shoulders.

There's a bundle by the lamp, tied with the red tape my father's clerks have used for longer than I've been alive. I pull the tape loose, and the letters spill across the blotter.

She watches me do it with her mouth open.

"Wrists," I say.

"Lucian."

"Give me your wrists. Or tell me no." I hold her eyes. "Plain words, ghost. You say no, I stop. You say stop, I stop. Any time. Do you understand me?"

Her chest is heaving, her thighs open on either side of me. She's wet all the way down to the wood.

She holds her wrists up.

"I understand," she says.

It's the shortest sentence she has ever said to me, and it hits me low enough to hurt.

I wrap the tape around her wrists twice, snug, not tight, and slide a finger under the ribbon to be sure of it. Then I lift her arms over her head and pin the knot to the desk.

She pulls against it once, testing, and it holds, because I'm holding it.

Her whole body goes loose.

"Oh," she says, barely a breath. "Oh, that's— *oh*."

"Yes."

I push back into her, slow this time, all the way, watching her face while she takes it. Her eyes go unfocused and her mouth falls open and her tied wrists twist under my palm.

"Look at you," I say. "Tied up in my father's red tape on my father's desk, taking my cock like you were built for it."

"*Fuck* you—"

"You are."

She laughs, actually laughs, breathless and cracked, and her cunt clenches around me while she does it, and I nearly lose it.

I work her clit with my thumb and fuck her in long hard strokes that shove her up the desk and drag her back down. Paper crumples under her, and a pen rolls off the edge and hits the floor. She drums her heels against the drawer front and begs. The words are gone, and there's only my name, broken into pieces.

"Come for me," I tell her. "Right now. Let me feel it."

She does, going off with her back arching up off the wood and her bound wrists straining under mine. She clamps down on my cock so hard I see white.

I pull out of her and come on her stomach.

It takes the top of my head off, and my come streaks the soft skin under her navel. She arches up into it like even that's something she wants to keep.

She's panting under me, and I watch a drop of it run down toward her hip. The part of me that has been keeping its distance for a very long time takes one step closer.

I untie her wrists first, and the ribbon has left a faint pink print on the inside of each one, and I put my thumb on it.

Then I put my mouth on her throat, with no teeth, to feel her pulse with my lips, and it's hammering.

"Ghost," I say into her skin.

"Don't call me that."

"Ghost."

"I hate it."

She doesn't hate it, because her pulse just jumped under my mouth. She knows I felt it, and neither of us says a word about that.

And for about the length of the silence, I am not thinking about a wound under a rib cage.

Is that a coincidence? I'm certain it isn't.



AFTERWARD she lies there on the desk getting her breath, with her arm over her eyes.

I put myself back together, and then I look at the papers under her.

His handwriting is on the top sheet: a list of names with sums beside them, the letters small and upright. The corner of it is wet and one of the names has come away into a smear.

I stand there and look at what I did to it. How do you apologize to a piece of paper?

Selene takes her arm off her eyes and follows where I'm looking, and she sees the sheet.

She doesn't say anything for a moment, and then she sits up and gets her skirt down. She picks the paper up carefully by the dry corner, and she smooths it out on her knee.

"It's his," she says. It isn't a question.

"Yes."

"Do you want me to—"

"Leave it. For God's sake, leave it."

She sets it back down on the desk and squares it up with the edge, like you'd straighten something on a mantel. She does not look at my face while she does it. It's the kindest thing anybody has done for me since the funeral.

Then she says: "You could have taken me literally anywhere in this house."

"I'm aware of that. Did you have a preference?"

"Are you? Because you picked the one room with his handwriting in it."

"Get out," I tell her, and she does, and she takes her time about it, and at the door she stops.

"He was winning," she says. "Wasn't he? That's what your physician found."

"Yes."

"Then whoever did it knew they couldn't, not straight." Her fingers are on the frame. "That's not a soldier, Lucian, that's somebody who loved him."

The door shuts behind her.

I sit down in my father's chair, in a room that smells like her and like him, and I take an account of what I know.

A blade keyed to his blood, a room nobody enters uninvited, a wound that says he never put his hand up.

Somebody who could get close.

And the list of people who could get that close to Aurelian Croix without being stopped is a list I could say out loud right now, from memory, in about the time it takes to draw breath. It's short. It's shorter than my own name is long.

Cassian is on it.

That is not a suspicion but a fact about a door. He had a key, so he's on the list of people who had keys, and putting him on it means nothing at all.

He'll be here in the morning, as he is most mornings. What will I tell him?

He'll ask about Ambroise's findings, because he's been asking every day, because he loved my father more than anyone alive except me.

And I am going to tell him the wounds were wolf bites.

I decide that sitting in the chair. It takes no time at all and costs me nothing. I do not examine it, and if anyone asked I would say I'm keeping the number of people who know at one until Silas brings me a name.

That's even true.

It isn't the reason.



C H A P T E R

Fifteen

S E L E N E

THE PACT HAS terms and I'm already outside them.

The deal was simple: his help reaching Rémy, my blood freely given, two clean exchanges, one for the other, the kind of arrangement that makes sense in a room with a lamp on.

It doesn't make a lick of sense out here.

Out here is the Bywater, midmorning, with a list of addresses Silas gave me and a face that gets me into conversations I have no right to be in. Lucian's name gets me through front doors, not because anybody loves him, but because they've heard what happens to people who don't open up.

I've been working Rémy's edges for a week, never the man himself, only the space around him: the people who sell him fuel, the woman who stocks his bait, the bar where his crew drinks on the nights they come north of the canal.

Each one of them is a sentence in a language I've been learning for four years, and each one of them gives me a little more of the grammar.

Rémy Thibodeaux doesn't drink, and Rémy Thibodeaux goes to church, which makes no sense for a wolf until you know that in pack, a

public ritual is a claim. You put yourself in a building on a schedule so everyone who sees you knows you have a schedule and a building.

Rémy Thibodeaux has a sister who brings him lunch on Thursdays.

That one costs me, and I sit in my car outside a bait shop on the Lafitte highway and think about Delphine, who told me I smelled like her aunt and gave me water, and who brings her brother lunch on the day he takes the boat out.

She's not part of this, and I need that clean in my own head, and it won't stay clean. Why won't it?



THE WOLF AT the bait shop knows things.

He doesn't know he knows them, and that's the best kind of source there is. He's old, wide, and he talks about the pack like old men talk about the weather, a permanent condition he's stopped trying to change.

"Thibodeauxs been on that water since before there was a dock," he says. "You want the head on or off?"

"Off. Shit, off."

"Everybody says off." He keeps cutting. He's cutting bait behind the counter, his knife practiced and absent. "Before the city, before all of it."

"Why do they stay?" I ask.

It's an innocent question, making conversation, buying shrimp. Isn't it?

He stops cutting.

Just a hitch, as if a muscle in his back reminded him it's there, and then he goes on.

"Thibodeauxs have always been here," he says.

I wait for the rest of the sentence, and the rest of the sentence doesn't come.

"Right," I say. "But the flooding alone — the hurricanes —"

"This water's ours." He sets the knife down. "You don't leave water that's yours. That's — that's just how it is."

Flat certainty with nothing behind it, no stubbornness and no pride, a law of physics nobody wrote down.

I've heard this before, in the house, two nights ago, on the back stairs: one vampire telling another that the court doesn't relocate, not for a season, not for a war, not ever. And the other one saying *of course not*, and neither of them asking why.

Different words, different species, same empty socket where the *why* should be.

Two species planted in this city like teeth in a jaw, both certain they can't leave, and neither one with a reason they can carry to the end of a sentence. Why?

Then I let it go, because I'm here about a man on a shrimp boat. I can only carry one thing at a time.



DELPHINE IS at the gas station on the corner of the highway.

I see her before she sees me, or before she lets me see her seeing me. She's at the pump, filling a truck that's too old to be worth the gas. She's watching me like she watched me at the bench, paying attention.

Should I drive past? I should. I should keep my eyes on the road and my foot on the pedal and add her to the list of things I know and keep going.

I pull in.

She watches me park and get out, and she doesn't move from the pump.

"You smell like him," she says.

"Like who, for Christ's sake?"

"Like the house, like all of it." She pulls the nozzle out and hangs it up. "You've been sleeping there."

I don't answer, because the answer is in my skin and she already has it.

It's in more than my skin. There's a faint pink print on the inside of each wrist where his father's red tape held me. I'm sore high between my thighs every time I shift my weight, and yesterday he came across my stomach on a dead king's desk. Can she smell that too? Christ, I hope not. I hope so.

"I could smell it at the bench." She looks at me as if she hasn't decided about me yet. "I thought maybe you'd been inside once. But it's on you now, in the skin."

"What the hell does it smell like?"

"Old, cold, like a room that's been closed too long." She screws the gas cap on. "And underneath that, iron, like something that feeds."

The word *feeds* sits between us on the concrete.

"If I can smell it," she says, "everybody on that dock can smell it: the old man at the bait shop, Gaspard's people, everybody."

"What the fuck are you telling me?"

"I'm telling you that you walk through this territory smelling like whatever raided us three weeks ago, and the only reason nobody's said anything is because they can also smell that you're not one of them." She looks at me. "You're something else. I don't know what. But you walk through here like you belong here and you smell like you belong there, and that's a thing that gets a person noticed."

"I've been noticed? By who?"

"By us, by the dock." She pauses. "Not by him, not yet."

Rémy. She means Rémy.

"His nose isn't what it used to be," she says. "Too many years on the water, and salt kills it." She gets into the truck. "But it won't matter if you keep coming back, because somebody will tell him."

"Are you going to tell him? Delphine, are you?"

She starts the engine and looks at me through the window for a long time.

"I bring him lunch on Thursdays," she says. "It's Wednesday."

She pulls out, and I stand at the gas station and watch her go. The sentence she left me is the clearest thing anyone in this city has said to me since I arrived.

She's giving me one day. Why would she do that?



THE ADDRESSES Silas gave me are careful.

Careful, which isn't the same as safe: safe means nobody's watching, and careful means the person who put the list together thought about who might be, and routed me around them.

I can feel Silas in the list, because the order of the addresses makes a circuit that avoids the main roads through wolf territory, stays in the human zones between pack and court, and doesn't cross any line that would put me in someone's jurisdiction.

He reads the city like I read a conversation. Does he read me the same way?

What does he think of me? I've seen him twice — once at the house, when Lucian told him I was staying. Silas looked at me as if I were a delivery he wasn't expecting and can't return. Once in the hall, where he handed me the list without a word and went up the stairs.

He doesn't like this arrangement, me in the house, me in the car, me between his king and whatever Silas thinks is coming.

He'll work with it anyway, because Lucian told him to. Silas does what Lucian tells him to with the same precision he applies to everything — completely, silently, and with a set of opinions he keeps in a room nobody else has access to.



THE LAST ADDRESS on the list is a bar in Tremé, neutral ground, more or less, the kind of place where wolves and the edges of the vampire world overlap without anyone acknowledging it.

I've been here before and I know the bartender. He's human, and he doesn't know what his clientele is, and he makes a good Old Fashioned, and he talks.

"Rémy? Sure." He wipes a glass. "He was in here last week, Tuesday, I think. He doesn't order, just sits."

"By himself? Always?"

"Sometimes, and sometimes with the big one, Gaspard's man. The one with the ear. Half of it's missing, you can't miss him. Tips like a saint and drinks like a drain, and never once started trouble in here."

"Does the son of a bitch meet anybody?"

The bartender gives me the look people give when they've been asked a question that sounds casual and isn't.

"He met a woman once," he says. "Don't ask me her name, I don't ask names. That's how you stay open in this town without somebody burning the place down. Month ago, maybe. She was — not his type, too put-together. Nice coat."

"Not his type how? What was she like?"

"Rich," he says. "I figured she was a lawyer. Who else wears a coat like that in August?"

A woman in a nice coat who met Rémy in a bar in Tremé a month ago. Who?

Shit. I put it away in the other language, where sentences sit until I know which conversation they belong to.



I'M IN THE car on Esplanade when I notice the truck.

It's been behind me since the bait shop, dark, no markings. It keeps the same distance through three turns, which is one more than coincidence and one fewer than proof.

I take a fourth turn, down Dauphine, which goes the wrong direction for home and the right direction for the Quarter.

The truck takes the turn.

My hands are steady on the wheel, and that's a fact I'm going to hold onto.

I know how to be followed, and I've known since I was twenty-two, when a wolf in a pickup trailed me from my apartment to the bus stop for three mornings in a row and then stopped. I never found out why he stopped. I never found out why he started.

This isn't a wolf.

How the hell do I know that? I can't explain it: the truck is too far back and the windows are tinted and I can't smell anything through the car. But it moves patient, unhurried, and it knows it doesn't have to close the distance.

Wolves close the distance, because it's in their bodies, and a wolf who's tracking you leans forward even in a car.

This is leaning back.

I take another turn, then another, into the Quarter now, narrow streets, one-ways, and the truck has to commit or lose me.

It commits. Of course it commits.

I pull over on Royal Street, in front of a shop that's closed. I sit in the car with the engine running and watch the mirror.

The truck passes without slowing down, turns left on St. Philip, and disappears.

I sit there for a while and say *fuck* out loud to nobody, twice.

Then I drive home, and I lock the door, and I push the dresser in front of it. I haven't done that since the first year.

The pact came with terms, shitty ones, and I didn't ask about the fine print.



IN THE APARTMENT I sit on the floor with my back against the dresser and think about the list of things I know and the list of things I don't.

I know Rémy is on the water and he doesn't drink and his sister brings him lunch. I know an old wolf can't finish a sentence about why the pack stays in Barataria. I know a woman in a nice coat met Rémy in a bar a month before the King died.

I know someone followed me in a truck that moved the way vampires move.

I don't know who killed the King. I don't know why the house-mark in Lucian's private correspondence is lodged in my head where I can feel it but can't reach it. I don't know why Lucian looks at me like a question he's decided to keep.

He calls me *ghost*, and I told him I hate it. Liar. I don't hate it at all.

What am I going to do when I finally get close enough to Rémy Thibodeaux to use the knife? I don't know.

Four years ago the answer was simple. Now Delphine brings him lunch on Thursdays, and a wolf smelled iron on my skin. I'm starting to wonder what's underneath the intention I've been standing on.

The phone buzzes: Lucian.

Tomorrow. My father's study. Bring the ledger.

I stare at the text. He means my father's ledger, the one I've had since the funeral, the one with the handwriting I'm not ready for.

I text back: *Which ledger?*

I know which ledger. I ask because asking is the only control I have left tonight. The hell of it is he probably knows that too.

His reply is immediate, and of course it is.

The one you haven't opened.

And there it is: he knows I have it, and he knows I haven't opened it. He's been paying the kind of attention that doesn't require words.

I type one more.

Someone followed me today. Dark truck. Yours?

This time it takes him longer.

No.

Then, a second later: *Stay inside.*

I put the phone down and look at the dresser against the door.

Then I press my thumb to the pink line on my wrist, where the tape held me. My whole body answers it like he's in the room. Two words from him on a screen and I'm wet on my own floor with a dresser against the door. What the fuck has he done to me?

Someone is following me, and it isn't his.



C H A P T E R

Sixteen

L U C I A N

“**W**OLF BITES,” I tell the empty study. “Heavy damage, the worst at the hip.”

I have decided to lie to the only person I trust. I am sitting in my father’s chair rehearsing it.

The words are simple, and any of those sentences could be true. Most of them were true, once, before Ambroise turned the body over and showed me what was underneath.

What I’m rehearsing is the rest of me, the hands and the eyes, the part of a body that people read when they’ve stopped listening to the mouth.

Cassian has been reading me since before I could read myself. He taught me to sit still, and he taught me that silence was a room you could put someone in and see what they brought to it.

He’s going to walk in here and sit down and ask what Ambroise found, because he’s asked every few days since the funeral, because he loved my father more than anyone alive except me.

And I’m going to lie to him, and tell him the wolves did it. It’s going to come out of my mouth as plain as a fact, and if I do it right he’ll carry it home with him. Can I do it right?



HE COMES AT the usual hour.

There's no knock, because there has never been a knock. The door is open, as it's been since Tuesday. He comes through it like he comes through every door in this house, as if it was left open for him.

Wasn't it? It always had been.

"Boy."

"Come in."

He takes the chair across the desk, the one by the window, my father's guest chair, the one that faces the desk instead of the courtyard. He sat in this chair every evening for longer than I've been alive, and his body knows it like a bed.

Selene is on the window seat, where she's been since I asked her. The ledger is closed on her knee, her hand flat on the cover like it might open on its own. Her body is angled away from the desk as though she's part of the furniture.

She's not part of the furniture, and she's the only person in this room who can hear both layers of what's about to happen.

Cassian glances at her, and the glance is warm. I can read it now: he's deciding what she changes about the room.

He settles without rushing. He has a glass he poured himself on the way in, from the decanter on the shelf. The fact that he's comfortable enough to do that is the whole history of his place in this house.

"Ambroise?" he says.

"I went down yesterday."

"And? What did the old man find?"

"Wolf bites." I keep my hands on the desk. "Four of them, heavy damage, the worst at the hip, where one took a piece out."

He nods, and his face settles, as it always does when we talk about the death, water finding the bottom of a well, and it isn't performed.

"And the chest?"

"Ambroise thinks one of the bites went deep enough to catch an artery underneath. The healing would have prioritized the artery over the surface wound, which is why it looked—"

"Like he was still standing."

"Like he was still standing, and he was, while the internal damage was catching up."

Cassian turns his glass on his knee, a slow half-turn, as he turns everything, a man who has outlived the need to hurry.

"So he was fighting," he says. "And winning?"

"And winning, and bleeding underneath it."

"And nobody saw the moment?"

"Nobody in the room was watching him at the end, because they were watching the wolves."

"Yes." He takes a sip. "Nobody looks at anything else, in a room with wolves in it."

He's said that before, the same sentence in the same cadence, and why didn't I notice the first time?

I notice now, and the noticing goes into a room in my head where I'm keeping the things I notice about Cassian, and the room is getting furnished.

"How is Ambroise?" he asks.

"Tired. I took him upstairs and made him eat. He cursed me in three languages."

"Only three? He's slowing down." Cassian smiles, and it reaches his eyes, because with him it always does. "Did he tell you about the wife?"

"He mentioned her. Why?"

"Lovely woman, and she died young, young for a human, I mean, which is any reasonable schedule." He shakes his head. "He keeps her portrait in the cold room, between the instruments. I've always found that either very sweet or very troubling."

"Both. It's always both with Ambroise."

"Both, yes." He drinks. "You're being careful with this, aren't you?"

"With what? With Ambroise? With the council? With the weather?"

"The information, Ambroise's findings." His eyes come up to mine. "You haven't brought it to the council?"

"Not yet."

"Why not?"

This is the moment, when the lie has to live in my answer. The answer has to sound like a man being cautious rather than a man being dishonest.

"Because the council will turn wolf bites into a war inside an afternoon," I say, "and I'm not ready for a war."

He holds it like a glass he's going to taste before he commits.

"Your father would have told them on the first night," he says.

"My father would have told them everything, and the council would have drafted a declaration before the wine was finished."

"That's true." A pause. "Isn't that the cost of honesty in a room full of people with agendas?"

"I'd rather have the facts before I give them the feeling."

His chin lifts, a movement smaller than approval.

"You're growing into this," he says.

"Don't. For Christ's sake, don't."

"I'm not flattering you, I'm observing." He sets the glass down on the desk. "Your father was a great king and a poor politician. You are going to be the opposite, and the city will be better for it."

I don't answer that, because the answer would be something about the desk I'm sitting at and the man who sat at it before me. The words for that are in a language I speak badly.

"How is your mother's house in Toulouse?" he asks.

"Standing."

"Go, when this is finished."

"You always say that. Do you know that?"

"Because you never go." He stands and gathers his coat off the back of the chair, where he draped it when he came in, and he does up the buttons with the same patient attention he gives to everything. "Lucian."

"Mm."

"You're going to need people you can tell the truth to." His hand is on the doorframe. "Choose them carefully, and choose them soon."

He goes.



I SPREAD MY hand on the desk where my father's papers were and push down.

The wood creaks, and my fingers are white against the grain.

"He didn't ask," I say. "He didn't even ask."

Selene is still on the window seat, the ledger closed on her knee. She's been watching the door Cassian went through with both registers running. Her face has the expression I'm learning to recognize, the one that means she heard a second sentence under the one everybody else heard.

"I know," she says. "That's worse. Don't you see it?"

"He should have asked about the blade wound, or whether the bites were survivable. He should have—"

"He should have questioned it." She looks at me. "A man who doesn't question a lie is either trusting or has already seen the body. I know which one you're thinking. I know which one is true."

"Aren't they the same?"

"They're not." She stands. "You're thinking he trusts you, that he took the lie because he loves you and has no reason to doubt you. That's the version on top."

"And underneath? What's underneath?"

"Underneath, a man who already knows what Ambroise found doesn't need to ask about it. He sits in a chair and turns his glass and nods because the performance requires a nod, and the nod is as honest as anything else he's ever done in this room."

The desk creaks again, and I realize I'm still pushing.

I lift my palm off the wood, and there's a mark in the finish, a white crescent from the pressure of my palm.

"He told me to choose people I can tell the truth to," I say. "He said it while standing in the door of a room where I'd just lied to his face."

Fuck.

Selene looks at the mark on the desk, and then at my hand.

"Your hands do that," she says. "When the rest of you is still."

"Do what?"

"Tell the truth. Didn't anyone ever tell you that?"



I SIT WITH it. What else is there to do?

The lie is in the room now, and the room is the same as it was before. Cassian is walking down my father's hallway with his coat buttoned. He's going home to a house I've never been inside. The glass he left on my desk is still warm from his hand.

He didn't question it.

I keep arriving at it: he asked what Ambroise found. I told him a version, and he turned it over, and he set it down.

He didn't ask about the blade wound, or the entry point, or whether Ambroise had found anything that didn't fit the story of a king savaged by wolves. Why not?

And I'm sitting here trying to decide whether a man who doesn't question a lie is a man who trusts you, or a man who doesn't need to question it because he already knows what the truth is.

Which is it? I can't decide. I can't.

I pick up his glass and I put it on the shelf with the decanter. I wipe the ring it left on the desk. I go to the window and look out at the courtyard where he taught me to hold a blade.

Every evening, for years, while my father was busy being a king, Cassian was in the courtyard with a boy and a piece of steel. The boy is sitting at the king's desk now, and the steel is in his coat.

Choose them carefully, he said, from the doorway.

The bastard.

I stand at the window until the courtyard goes dark.

Then I go down to the archive and I pull every letter Cassian has written to this house in the past year. I look at the mark at the bottom of each one.

My father's hook, the little fishhook figure from the household notes. Cassian signs with it too, and he always has. Which of them drew it first? I've seen it a thousand times and never once asked.

I look at it for a long time.

Then I put the letters back, and I go and find the woman in the west wing.

"Ghost."

She looks up from the bed, where she's been waiting.

"Open it," I tell her. "The ledger."

Her hand goes flat on the cover. "Tomorrow."

"Tomorrow. Swear it?"

"I swear it. Damn you, I swear it."

She holds out her other wrist, palm up, across the sheet, without a word.

"You haven't fed since the desk," she says. "Don't tell me you have. I can hear it in your voice."

"Ghost—"

"Take it. And then go and sit in your father's chair and be sick about whatever you found downstairs. In that order."

I kneel on the floor by the bed and put my mouth on her wrist, over the pink line the tape left, and bite.

She sighs, a long, low, shaking sound, and her head goes back against the pillow and her thighs part under the sheet without her permission. I drink slowly. Her pulse beats against my tongue and her other palm comes down on the back of my head and holds me there. I can smell her getting wet with every swallow.

I stop before she wants me to, and I seal the bite with my tongue, and she makes a small furious noise.

"That's it? That's all you're taking?"

"That's it."

"You're a bastard, Your Majesty."

"I'm a bastard with work to do."

"You're a bastard, full stop. Go on. Go be sick about it."

That mark is in my head now.

It sits next to a face I've loved my whole life.

She doesn't ask whose.

I don't tell her.



C H A P T E R

Seventeen

S E L E N E

MY FATHER'S handwriting hasn't changed.

I've been carrying this ledger since the funeral, and I've had four years to prepare for whatever was inside it, and what was inside it is his hand — small and upright, every letter touching the line the same way, with the particular neatness of a man who was taught in a schoolroom and never stopped hearing the teacher.

I'm sitting at Lucian's desk with the book open to the first page, and the first page is a list of clients.

Names, services, fees, shipping translation mostly, contract work for the port authority: small jobs, the kind that keep a house warm and a daughter fed.

It goes on like that for about forty pages, and every page is ordinary, and I almost close it. What was I so afraid of? What did I think he'd left in here?



THE MARK APPEARS on page fifty-three.

It's small, a little hooked figure drawn in the margin beside a client entry, like a fishhook or a bent question mark. There's no name next to it and no company, just the mark, and a fee that's three times anything else in the ledger.

Who pays three times the rate and leaves no name? My father did a job for someone who didn't want a name, which isn't unusual. He told me once that the court work paid better because the court didn't like paperwork, and a man who'd do the work without the paperwork was worth the premium.

But the mark. Jesus Christ, the mark.

Where have I seen it before?

Where? Somewhere in this house, on the letters in the archive room, the private notes signed with a hook instead of a name.

Lucian showed me the archive two days ago, pulled a letter, pointed at the mark and said, *my father's private seal*.

An hour later I was reading a stack of notes from Cassian to the King: restaurants, a bottle of something, every one of them signed with the same hook.

So whose is it? His father's? Or both of theirs, and one of them drew it first, and it's a sweet old habit between friends?

Except the King is dead, and the other man who signs with a fishhook isn't.

Either way, the same pen that signed letters to this house is in my father's work ledger, beside jobs that paid too much and came with no name.

My father did private work for somebody in the vampire court. Holy shit. My *father*.

The wolves told me he was informing, that he was carrying pack movements to the King's people.

And the mark in the margin says my father was being paid by someone who signs the way Cassian signs.

What does this mean? I don't know. I know what it looks like, and my hands are shaking.



LUCIAN IS IN the study.

I go in without knocking, because I've learned that knocking in this house is a declaration of rank and my rank is *none*. So every door is either open or it isn't, and this one is.

He's reading a report, and he looks up.

"You opened it," he says. "When?"

"An hour ago. Does it matter?"

I put the ledger on the desk. "Page fifty-three."

He finds it and looks at the mark for a while. I watch him look at it, and I see the moment he recognizes it.

His whole face goes still.

"Where else have you seen this?" I ask.

"My father's letters. Where else would I have seen it?"

"Look again. Look harder, for fuck's sake."

He looks at me instead of the mark, deciding how much to tell me. I can feel it behind his eyes like heat through a wall.

"Cassian," he says.

The word comes out of him flat and heavy.

"The same mark," I say. "In your archive, on his correspondence."

"It's a common seal — for Christ's sake, Selene, half the old houses —"

"It's not common. I've been in your archive, and nobody else in this house uses it." I slap my palm down on the ledger. "My father was paid by somebody who signs the way Cassian signs, for work that has no name on it, at three times the going rate."

The room is very still, and the lamp on the desk hums.

"That doesn't mean —"

"It doesn't mean anything yet." I hold his eyes. "It means my father worked for someone in your court who didn't want to be named, and that someone uses a mark that your uncle uses. I'm not saying more than that."

He sits back.

I watch him wrestle with it, the space between a mark in a margin and a man with silver at his temples who asks about your family.

"I lied to him," Lucian says.

"I know. I was sitting right there, holy shit, three feet from you."

"I told him wolf bites. To his face, in this room." He says it looking at the desk. "Do you know why I did it?"

"Tell me. Why?"

"Because I didn't want him to know about the blade wound. Because —" He stops. "Because something told me not to."

I know that feeling, because I've been building a life on it.

"We need to —"

The window breaks.



THE SHUTTER first: it comes off the frame with the crack of a boot on a board, and then the glass behind it cracks in a single line. I'm on the floor before I've decided to be.

Lucian is already moving, from the chair to the window without a middle to it. He was sitting, and then he's at the wall gripping the frame, and the glass is still falling.

"Stay down," he says.

"What — what the hell—"

"Stay *down*."

A body hits the courtyard below, a wet arrival, a bag of sand dropped from a height.

Then running, multiple sets of feet, heavy, moving fast.

Lucian goes through the broken window.



I DON'T STAY down. Fuck that.

I go to the window and I look out. The courtyard has two men in it, in human clothes, no shift. They're moving toward the east gate, the one that opens onto the street, and one of them is carrying a bundle under his arm.

Lucian drops into the courtyard from the second floor and it doesn't slow him.

He hits the ground and keeps going without a break in his stride. The distance between him and the first man is simply *removed*.

He catches the first one at the gate. I see it this time — his hand goes around the man's throat and lifts, and the man's feet leave the ground. There's a sound like a branch snapping, and then the body goes down and Lucian is already turning for the second one.

But the second man is through the gate and running.

I'm already going for the stairs.

What am I doing? I'm running down a staircase in a vampire's house toward a broken window and a courtyard with a body in it. The only thing I'm holding is a ledger that belongs to a dead man.

The front hall, the door, the street.

Lucian is at the gate with blood to the wrist and a man on the ground who isn't moving, and the second man is gone.

Silas appears from somewhere. He looks at the body, looks at Lucian, looks at me standing in the doorway with a book under my arm and bare feet on cold stone.

"Sire," he says.

"Find the other one. Can you?"

"Already moving." He looks at me. "Get her off the street."

"I can get myself —"

"Off the street," Lucian says. His voice is the one I haven't heard before — low, level, and with a tone underneath it that makes the hair on my arms stand up. "Now."

The way he says it, I almost go.



THE CAR IS Silas's, left running at the curb. He was already coming when it started, and I don't think about what that means.

Lucian puts me in the passenger seat and gets in the driver's side and pulls away from the house before my door is shut.

"Who were they?" I say. "Lucian, who the fuck were they?"

"I don't know. I don't know."

"They weren't fucking wolves."

"No. Wolves don't hire out, and they don't wear shoes that cost that much."

"How the fuck do you know?"

"I had one of them by the throat." He takes a turn without slowing. "He smelled like a person."

"Humans?"

"Humans. Does that surprise you?"

"Hired? By who, for fuck's sake?"

He doesn't answer, his hands on the wheel and his eyes on the mirror, and his jaw is working. I've seen it do that once before, in the hallway at Perdido, when I asked him if he was a vampire.

He's afraid. For *me*?

"Lucian."

"Be quiet." He takes another turn. "I'm thinking."

"About what? About who?"

"About who knew you were in that room."



HE DRIVES FOR a long time with no destination, just moving, which in his language means the same thing it means in wolf: you move when the ground under you isn't safe.

I'm in the passenger seat in the dress I slept in. I look like hell, with my feet dirty from the courtyard and the ledger in my lap.

I've stopped shaking. Shit. That happened about ten minutes ago, and the stopping is worse than the shaking, because the stopping means I've decided this is what tonight is, and tonight is a thing that's happening to me, and I'm in it.

"Someone tried to fucking kill me," I say.

"Someone tried to get into the study." He checks the mirror again. "You were in it."

"Isn't that a distinction you're making for yourself?"

"It's a distinction that matters. Doesn't it?"

"Not to me. Not right fucking now."

He looks at me for the first time since the car. His face is still doing the held thing, and under it there's heat, close to the surface, that has nothing to do with the men in the courtyard.

"You were in the room," he says. "With the ledger, with the mark."

"And? So what?"

"And somebody didn't want you to be."

The car goes silent: the engine and the road and us.

Then he takes one palm off the wheel and cups the back of my neck.

He doesn't grab, just holds on as if he's confirming I'm where he left me, a check, *still here*.

His thumb finds the place under my jaw where my pulse is going hard, and he holds it there.

"You're all right," he says.

"I know."

"Say it."

"I'm all right."

He nods and doesn't let go.

And something in me, what's been at full tension since the window broke, the spring and wire of it, four years of being ready and tonight being the night when *ready* stopped being a theoretical state — something in that releases.

It comes out sideways.

I take his hand off my neck and put it between my thighs.



HE SAYS NOTHING.

His fingers are between my thighs and the car is still moving and he doesn't say a word. His fingers tighten on me through the dress, and I hear his breath change. The car drifts a little before he corrects it.

"Pull the fuck over," I say.

"Selene —"

"Pull over."

He pulls over on some block I can't name, dark, no lights, residential and empty, thank God.

The engine runs.

I get my seatbelt off and I get over the console and into his lap, and it isn't graceful and I don't care. My knee hits the steering wheel and the horn goes off for half a second and I don't care about that either. The car smells like leather, and blood from his knuckles. The ozone of a night that almost rained and didn't.

He grabs my hips.

"This is —" he starts. "Selene, is this—"

"Shut up."

"Ghost —"

"*Shut up.*" I get his belt open and his dick out. He's hard and thick and cold in my fist, cold the way all of him is cold, and my palm is so hot against him that I feel the contrast like a current.

I pull my underwear aside and I get him in, and it's too fast. The stretch of it makes me gasp — the cold and the size and the fullness, all at once, like being filled with a thing that doesn't belong in a body and my body taking it anyway.

God.

He makes a sound, low and broken, up in his throat.

I grab his shoulders and ride him.

Badly, with no thought in it, hard and fast and graceless, and the car rocks with it. The steering wheel is in my back and his mouth is on my throat, not biting, just there, breathing into the skin.

I'm so wet I can hear it, Jesus fucking Christ, the sound of my pussy taking him in, over and over. I should be embarrassed and I'm not, because shame left the building when I climbed into this man's lap with dirty feet and a dead man's book.

His fingers come up and wrap around my throat, holding, like in the hallway at Perdido, cold fingers, steady pressure, my pulse kicking against his palm.

"Don't you fucking bite me," I say.

"I won't."

"Don't you dare."

"I won't." His hand tightens on my throat — not enough to choke, enough to feel. His other palm digs into my hip hard enough to bruise. "I won't, I won't —"

I fuck him in a car on a dark street because someone tried to kill me and I'm still here and he's still here and this is the only language I have for that.

His cock hits a place deep inside me on every downstroke and I can feel him in my stomach. The cold of him is warming now, warming from me. The intimacy of it wrecks me — his body taking my heat. My clit grinds against the base of him every time I push down. My pussy clenches on him and he swears under his breath. The sound of it — the surprise in it, like I've caught him off guard with my own body — makes me want to do it again.

It's joyless, for about a minute, mechanical, desperate, two bodies processing some fucked-up night the mouth can't say.

Then he laughs.

It comes out of him like it did on my kitchen floor, involuntary, surprised by itself.

"What?" I say.

"Nothing."

"What?"

"You hit the horn." He's grinning, and I can feel it against my neck. "You hit the horn with your knee."

"That's funny to you? That's what's funny?"

"It's —" He laughs again. "Yes."

And I laugh. It comes out of me without permission, wet and ugly and too loud for the car, and then we're both laughing and I'm still moving on him and the laughing and the moving somehow become the same thing.

The joylessness goes out of it and laughter comes in instead, lighter, rougher, real.

He gets a hand in my hair and pulls my head back and kisses me while he drives up into me, hard. I can feel the strength he's holding back, the in-human part of him, the part that could put me through the windshield. The holding back is what makes me come apart.

"Good girl," he says against my mouth. "My ghost."

I come, and it rips through me, a bolt knocked loose. I cry out into the car, and my cunt clenches on him so hard he swears. His whole body goes rigid under me, and his forehead drops to my shoulder with a sound that's half groan and half surrender.

I think that's it, and I'm shaking, and I'm done.

"No," he says into my neck. "Not yet."

"What do you mean *not yet*, I just—"

He lifts me off him.

Just lifts me, like I weigh what the ledger weighs. There's a second where I'm in the air in a dark car with my dress around my waist. Then I'm in the passenger seat, and he reaches past me and pulls the lever and the seat drops back flat. I go with it, and I'm staring at the roof.

"Lucian—"

He's in the footwell, and I don't know how. The car is not built for a man his size to be in the footwell and he's there anyway, on his knees, with his shoulders between my thighs and his hands spreading them.

He looks at me first, just looks, in the dashboard light: at my face, at my pussy, wet and swollen and open for him, at the mess he's already made of me.

"I've wanted this since your kitchen floor," he says.

"You couldn't *stand* on my kitchen floor. You could barely hold your shit together."

"I didn't need to stand."

Then his mouth is on me.

His tongue is cold, and that's the first thing. It's almost too much: one cold flat stroke from the bottom of my pussy all the way up to my clit, slow, like he's reading a line he wants to remember. I buck so hard my head hits the window.

"Ow. *Fuck*. Don't stop."

He doesn't stop.

He eats me like he's starving and he's decided to take his time about it anyway, long strokes, then his tongue circling my clit, cold, then warmer as my heat gets into him. Then his lips close around it and *suck*, and my thighs clamp down on his head and he pins them open and keeps going.

I can't keep it in, and I don't try. I'm swearing at the roof of Silas's car in a voice I've never heard come out of me.

"Right there. Right *there*. Oh my God, don't you dare move—"

He pushes two fingers into me and curls them, and I sob.

It builds fast because I'm already raw. My hips come up off the seat and grind against his face and he growls into me. The vibration of it goes straight through my clit.

"I'm gonna—"

He looks up at me over the line of my stomach, his eyes black, his mouth on me.

He doesn't say anything, and he doesn't have to.

I come on his tongue with my fist in his hair and my foot braced on the dashboard, my back arching off the seat, and the sound I make fogs the windshield.

He doesn't stop until I shove his head away, laughing and crying at the same time, too sensitive to stand it.

Then he climbs back up over me, careful of the gearshift, still hard. I reach for him and he shakes his head.

"Let me," I say.

"You'll get your turn."

"When?"

"When you can walk."

I laugh so hard I nearly slide off the seat.

He strokes himself, kneeling over me in the dark, and it only takes a few strokes. He comes on my thigh with his forehead pressed to mine and his breath wrecked, the cold pulse of it and then the warmth as my body takes the heat back.



AFTER, in the dark, in a car that smells like sex and sweat and the iron of the blood still on his knuckles from the courtyard.

His forehead is on my shoulder and his breath is slowing down.

"Someone just tried to kill me," I say.

"Yes."

"And I just —"

"Yes."

"In a *car*, Jesus Christ."

"In Silas's car." A pause. "You think he won't know?"

"How? How could he possibly know?"

"He knows everything about this car." Another pause. "He's going to be very unhappy."

I laugh again, smaller this time, and tireder, and when it's done I put my face in his hair and breathe.

"I need to go back," I say. "My things, my shoes, my goddamn toothbrush."

"Not tonight."

"My things are —"

"Not tonight." His arms tighten. "Whoever sent those men knows where you are. You're not going back tonight."

"Where am I going, then? Where the hell do I go?"

"Where I go."

In wolf, that sentence is a claim, and in English, it's an answer to a question.

I sit in his lap in a dark car and I don't translate it.

For once, I don't need both versions.

INTERLUDE III

Cassian

IT SHOULD HAVE been finished tonight.

It is not finished, and the men I sent for her are not coming back.

They were competent and paid properly, and they understood what they were being asked to do. Now there is a car in a canal off Chef Menteur, and a woman asleep in my friend's house.

I have spent the evening with that, in a room with the lamps off.

Do I enjoy this? I do not.

There is nobody to say that to, so it can be said here and go no further. She has done nothing to me: she poured drinks in a club and went home afterward and got a man out of a room.

For that I have now put hands on her, and not for the first time, and if it continues I will put more.

When did I stop needing to be angry at a person first?



IS THE BOY in love with her? He is.

He has not said so, and he will not say so for months, and he may never manage it in a sentence with a verb in it.

But he has moved her into his father's house, and she walks the west hall without an escort. Last week an Aldric cousin put two fingers under her chin, and Lucian looked at the man until he left the city.

I have seen him do that before, for a dog he had as a boy.

And does she look back at him? She does.

That is the part I could not have planned for: she is not frightened of him, and she is not impressed by him. Nothing of that description has ever stood in front of that boy in his life.

He is going to tell her things. How many has he told her already?

So she has to go. I have tried, and the trying has cost me good men and a quantity of goodwill I cannot replace.



AND THE EVENING in this house?

I came home and the girl who keeps the front rooms had put flowers on the hall table. She does it because she believes I like them.

She is right, and I stood in the doorway with my coat still on and looked at them for a while.

There are portraits at the turn of the stair, and I go up past them most nights without seeing them. A man can learn to do that in his own house.

Isabeau's is on the left, done in the year she stopped coming here.

Why don't I go up and stand in front of the other one? I could, on any night I chose.

There is a small chair on the landing, and no visitor would ever work out what it is for. It has been there since the year of the courtyard.

I have sat in it about as often as I have taken ships.

I am not going up tonight.



THERE IS A simpler road, and I keep finding myself at the mouth of it.

What if I went to him in the morning and told him?

He would sit very still, and then he would ask me to say it again, because that is what he does. I would say it again.

Then he would put me in a chair and send for the council, and do what the Code requires of a man who has confessed to what I would be confessing to.

It would take the rest of the night.

And at the end of it he would be a king who had executed his father's murderer inside the month, under the law, properly, with witnesses.

His father's law, and his father's ending.

Everything I have done would become a story about a grieving old man who went strange, and was dealt with correctly by a young king keeping faith with a dead philosophy.

The truce would hold, and the wolves would be handed another long stretch of years to sit on our border and breed.

And nothing in this city would be examined again inside his lifetime or mine.

And they would be kind about me. Can a man be buried under kindness? He can.

That is the part I cannot carry. Marguerite would say *tragic*, and she would mean it, and the whole of what I am would come to rest inside that word.

The question my friend never asked himself would go into the ground behind me and stay there.

I was right about him, and I have been right about him since before that boy was born.

And if I stop now? Then I was never right.

I was only sad.



SO, no.

In the morning I will go to the house and ask after Marguerite's chest, and she will tell me about the damp. Lucian will come downstairs and find me being kind to his aunt in a hallway.

I will ask him whether the woman is eating.

He will be surprised that I asked, and grateful, and he will tell me more than he intends to.

And I will begin looking for someone who can get close to her without being seen to be mine.



CHAPTER

Eighteen

LUCIAN

THIBAULT HAS stopped looking at the lamp and started looking at the door.

That means he's decided, because a man who watches a light source is a man waiting, and a man who watches an exit is a man who's made a plan for what comes next, and the plan includes leaving.

I've kept him ten days, fed, watered, allowed to stand and walk the room. Silas brings his meals, and nobody else comes down here.

He's more useful than I expected, a man who saw the last minutes of my father's life from the gallery rail, who has no stake in any version of the answer, and who tells it the same way every time I ask.

I've asked three times and the story hasn't moved. That's either a man with a good memory or a man with a better lie, and I'm betting on the first.

Today I'm asking a different question.



"Tell me about Gaspard," I say.

He looks up from the chair, and his face does a small recalculation, because he's been waiting for the next round of questions about the chamber, and this isn't that.

"The Alpha? Hell of a question to start with."

"Your Alpha. Tell me about him."

"What do you want to know? He's an old bastard, like any other."

"Everything you'd tell a man who's never met him. Start with whether he sleeps."

"He doesn't. Not since his wife got sick."

Thibault rubs his jaw, a habit he has when he's sorting through what he knows, trying to decide which piece goes on top.

"He's old," he says. "Not old the way you're old. Old the way a man is old who's done one thing for forty years and the thing has worn a groove in him."

"What's the thing?"

"Keeping us alive," he says simply. "That's the whole job. The pack is — you have to understand, from outside it looks like an army, but it's a town. People with kids and boats and mortgages, and Gaspard's job since his father died is making sure the town stays standing."

"Against us? Only us?"

"Against everything: the water, the city, the humans, you." He counts them on his fingers. "In that order. You're not the biggest thing trying to kill us, and you're not even second."

I sit with that, because it isn't what the court would say. The court would say the wolves are a military force at our border, organized around aggression, bred for it.

Thibault is telling me they're a fishing village with teeth. Is he wrong?

"Why did he send you into the chamber?"

"Because somebody told him there was an opening."

"Who? Who told him?"

"I don't know, it was above my head." He shifts in the chair. "The order came down through the captains. We were told the gallery would be open, the windows unlatched, and that the council would be seated, and we were told to go fast and go hard and get out."

"And the target? My father?"

"Chaos, not a kill." He looks at me steadily. "I know what you think: that we came for your father. We didn't. We came for the room."

"And my father was in the room?"

"Your father was the room." His voice shifts down, into a register that sounds like remembering. "You have to understand what he was to us."

"A predator? A monster?"

"A king." Thibault leans forward. "A king with teeth who never once used them on us."

The sentence goes into the room and the room holds it.

King of teeth.

The old wolf on the levee said it as an insult: a man who is nothing but the bite, appetite crowned and called a king.

Thibault is saying the opposite with the same words.

A king who had teeth — the worst teeth, the oldest, the ones that could have taken the whole pack and the water it sits on — and who never once put them in a wolf.

"Say that again," I tell him.

"A king with teeth who never used them." Thibault's hands are on his knees. "Forty years of truce. Forty years where the Alpha woke up every morning knowing the man across the water could end it before lunch. And every morning that man got up and went to his table and didn't."

"Isn't that restraint?"

"That's more than restraint. That's a decision, every day."

He looks at me as the old wolf on the levee did, measuring and unafraid, a man trying to understand.

"The wolves at the levee called me that," I say. "King of teeth. They meant the other thing, didn't they?"

"They meant the first thing. The young ones always mean the first thing." Thibault shakes his head. "The old ones know. Your father was the king of teeth because he had them and he kept them in his mouth. That's harder than using them. Anybody can bite."

He's right, damn him.

I've been carrying that phrase since the raid, in my pocket. I liked the weight of it: the insult, the sharp edges, the name for a thing that is nothing but appetite.

I didn't know there were two of them, one that means *monster* and one that means *the man who chose not to be*, and the difference between them is what I've been arguing with my father about since I was old enough to argue.

I told him mercy was weakness.

A wolf in my basement is telling me my father's restraint was the most frightening thing about him. Was it?



"He was winning," I say.

"He was winning."

"And the wolves knew it. Your captains, your Alpha, everybody who put men through those windows knew they were sending them at a man who would tear them apart?"

"Yes."

"So why go?"

"Because somebody told Gaspard there was an opening." Thibault's voice goes careful again. "Not a chance to win but an opening: a window that was unlatched and a room that was full. The idea wasn't to kill your father but to make it look like we tried."

The lamp flickers.

"Make it look like you tried?" I say.

"So that afterward, when the council voted, the vote would already be made." He meets my eyes. "Wolves in the gallery. Wolves at the windows. A whole court watching the glass come down. That's a war vote, Your Majesty. That's the vote already cast."

I've been asking who killed my father, and asking it about a blade and a wound and a man with a key.

Thibault is telling me a larger story. He's telling me that the wolves were brought into that chamber not to kill a king but to provide a reason

— a spectacle, a narrative, a room full of witnesses who would agree that the wolves had declared war.

And the person who arranged the opening — the person who unlatched the gallery windows — would have needed to be inside the chamber.

On our side.



“The man who told Gaspard,” I say. “Did he have a name?”

“If he did, Gaspard never said it to me. Do you think I’d hold it back now?”

“What did Gaspard say about him?”

“That he’d been reliable, that the information had been good before, and that the cost was reasonable.” Thibault pauses. “And that the man asked about his wife.”

The room goes cold.

Both my hands press down on the arms of the chair, and the wood creaks. I can feel the grain finding the line where it would split if I let it.

I don’t let it.

He asked about his wife.

Cassian asks about wives, about mothers and houses and the health of a grandmother’s chest. He does it like other men breathe, constantly, and with a warmth that is entirely real.

“Describe him,” I say.

“I never met him. I told you, this was above me.”

“Gaspard described him?”

“Gaspard said old, older than he looked. Silver. Good coat.” Thibault shifts. “He said the man was sad.”

I close my eyes. Christ.

He was sad.

I could have a hundred men who fit that, because this city is full of old men in good coats who carry grief like dock workers carry rope, so long that the weight has become the posture.

But it sits on only one of them like that, and I know it.



WHY DON'T I say his name?

Because a name said in front of a witness stays said. I'm not ready for what comes after it.

What I do is stand up, and push the chair back, and walk to the door with my hands steady.

"Am I done?" Thibault asks.

"Almost. Is that a problem?"

"Almost means a lot of things in a room with a locked door."

"It means I have something to check." I turn. "You'll be fed tonight, and Silas will come."

"And tomorrow?"

"Tomorrow I'll either let you go or I won't. Can you live with that?"

"Hell, I've lived with worse."

He nods, because he's been useful, and he knows useful has a shelf life.

"Your Majesty," he says.

I stop. "What now?"

"Your father earned that name. He earned it by having it in him and not using it." Thibault leans back in the chair. "What you do with it is your business. But remember a wolf said it to you and meant the second one."

I go up the stairs.



THE ARCHIVE room, late that night, after Silas and whatever couldn't wait, and six letters, all signed with the hook.

I spread them beside the ledger and look at the marks side by side, and they are the same writing. Selene told me that, and I didn't hear her because the hearing would have cost me more than I was ready to pay.

Five of the letters are routine — archive instructions, wine for the council, Ambroise's schedule.

The sixth is about a payment to a translator in the Bywater.

My father didn't write it, because the writing is neater than his, more deliberate, with a particular way of crossing a *t* that I have seen on every note Cassian has left on this desk since I was a child.

Cassian. God damn it. Cassian.

I let the name into the room. It sits where it sits, and the room doesn't change. Nothing in the house breaks, and the lamp goes on humming.

Somewhere above me, in my bed, a woman is asleep with the door open. I can hear her from here, if I stop breathing and let the house go quiet: her pulse, slow and heavy, and the small catch in it when she turns over. I had her against these shelves this afternoon for less than a minute before Silas knocked, and before that I hadn't touched her in three days. I've counted. I think about the car, and her thighs locked around my head in the footwell, and the salt-sweet taste of her, and my cock stirs against my thigh in a room full of my dead father's letters. I let it, because it's the only thing in this building tonight that isn't lying to me.

Tomorrow I sit across from my uncle and ask him about a translator in the Bywater, the way he taught me to ask: around the edges, with warmth, with the question about somebody's family that sounds like care and is.

His own instrument.

Let's see if it still cuts.



C H A P T E R

Nineteen

S E L E N E

THE PACT HAD a shape and the shape is gone.

The deal was his help for my blood, and that was the sentence. The sentence was clean, and I could hold it and know what I was holding.

How did I get here? I'm in his bed at four in the morning because someone broke a window and he drove me through the city and I fucked him in a car and he brought me here.



HE'S IN THE shower, and I can hear the water through the door. He went in a long time ago and he hasn't come out, standing under running water because the water is the only thing in the house that doesn't require a decision.

His bedroom is not what I expected. I expected antiques, furniture from another century, heavy curtains, the kind of room a man who's lived centuries would accumulate.

It's nearly empty, sparse enough for a monk.

A bed, a chair, a wardrobe with the doors closed, and a window with the curtain pulled, letting in a stripe of streetlight that crosses the floor and stops at the foot of the bed.

No photographs, no books, no personal things of any kind, except a coat draped over the chair with a weight in the pocket.

The blade, his father's blade, which he carries as I carry the knife, always there, never discussed.

Should I touch it? I don't.



HERE'S WHAT I'm not saying out loud.

The ledger has Cassian's mark in it, and my father did private work for someone in Lucian's court who signs the way Cassian signs. Lucian knows this, and he's been lying to Cassian about the autopsy findings, and tonight someone sent men with human hands to break a window in the study where I was sitting with the proof.

That's a sentence that wants to be a paragraph, and the paragraph wants to be an accusation. I can feel it building in me like a translation builds.

Can I give it to Lucian? No. Would he even want it from me?

He's already got it, because I watched him look at the mark in my father's ledger and say the name. I watched the knowledge go into him and settle. I saw what it cost, a small closing, right between his eyes.

He's carrying it alone, because centuries of being the strongest thing in every room teaches you that asking someone to help is an admission the weight exists.

Could I help him carry it? That's the one that scares me. What happens to a pact when one side starts carrying the other's weight?



BECAUSE THE pact was never about carrying. It was an exchange, his access for my blood, with clear terms and a clear end, and when I have Rémy, the pact is done.

I've gone to Barataria and sat on a bench, where a girl told me I smelled like her aunt, and a man unloaded shrimp while I held a knife I couldn't use.

And I still haven't killed Rémy Thibodeaux.

I could have gotten to him, because Lucian has given me enough access to get to him three times over: maps, schedules, routes, and Silas's careful list of addresses, which carried me around the edges of the pack with the precision of a man drawing a circle around a target.

Why haven't I done it? What the hell am I waiting for? Because something is wrong with the intention.

The intention is the same: I want Rémy dead, like I want air. I want the son of a bitch *dead*.

But underneath it, where the floor used to be, there's a question.

Why the fuck did a vampire send a wolf to kill my father?

My father translated contracts, and that's all he did. He sat at a kitchen table with two versions of a document and a pencil he never sharpened. He taught me to hear the second sentence underneath the first.

Somebody paid him to do other work, and the mark in the ledger says so. The mark is the same as the mark on Cassian's letters.

If Cassian paid my father for work, and then Cassian sent a wolf to kill my father, that's a cleaning, a man removing the person who can connect him to the work.

And the work is somewhere in that ledger, on a page I haven't reached. Which page? What did he see that got him killed?

The intention is the same, but the target has changed: I came to this city to kill the hand, and I'm starting to understand there was a head.



THE WATER STOPS, and Lucian comes out with a towel around his waist and his hair wet and the cut on his forearm still open from last week, healing slower than it should, because whatever the poison left behind is still in him, making his body heal in an order he didn't choose.

He sees me awake and stops in the doorway with water still running off his shoulders.

"Why aren't you asleep?" he says.

"Why aren't you?"

"I don't sleep." He crosses to the wardrobe. "Not the way you mean."

"What do you do?"

"I wait for morning." He says it like he takes his coffee black. "And then I do the morning."

"Every morning? For four hundred years?"

"Give or take a few I'd rather not discuss."

I sit up, and the sheet comes with me and I let it, because whatever modesty exists between us at this point is a fiction both of us have stopped performing.

"The mark," I say.

"Not tonight."

"Lucian—"

"Not tonight, ghost. For God's sake, not tonight." He pulls on a shirt with his back to me, and I watch the muscles in his back move. Four centuries of a body built for one purpose, and it shows. "This week I'm going to the Marchand house. Neutral ground. There's a woman there who makes things that the court would prefer she didn't, and I need to ask her about a poison."

"The poison that put you on my floor? The shit that nearly killed you in front of a hundred people?"

"Yes."

"I'll come."

"Hell, no."

"I'll come," I say again. "She'll talk to me. Women like her — women who keep their houses neutral — they talk to people who aren't carrying flags."

He turns, and there's a pause on his face, as if he's been counting on one version of me and just found another.

"You don't know her, do you?" he says.

"I don't know anyone, and that's why people talk to me."

"That's a sad fucking sentence, ghost."

"It's a true one, and there's a goddamn difference. Shit, somebody in this house has to say true things."

He looks at me for a while, and I hold the look, because I learned to hold looks before I learned that most people don't.

"Fine," he says. "Bring the ledger."

"When have I ever not brought the ledger?"

"I know." He almost smiles. "You hold it the way I hold the blade."

That lands somewhere I wasn't expecting, and I look at him standing in his empty room in a shirt he just pulled on. I think about the two of us carrying the things our fathers left us.

His father left him a philosophy and a city. My father left me a pencil and a habit and a book full of work he did for a man who killed him for it.

We're both carrying the wrong goddamn inheritance.



HE DOESN'T get into the bed, he goes to the door.

"I'll be in the archive," he says. "I don't sleep."

"Didn't you say that already?"

"I'll be downstairs, and the door to this room locks from the inside."

"I know how doors work, Lucian. Christ."

He almost smiles again, and then he goes, and the room is his empty room with me in it, and the stripe of streetlight is on my legs.



I LIE THERE a while, not going to sleep, my body still running the program it started in the car, the one where everything is lit up and the quiet makes it louder, not softer.

My phone buzzes on the nightstand. I pick it up, and the number is the one I saved as *L* because saving a vampire king's number under his full name seemed a good way to get killed.

You left your shoes in the car.

I type back with one thumb, before I can think better of it.

It's four in the fucking morning. Do you know that?

I don't sleep. You left your shoes in the car, and Silas will find them.

Let him.

He's going to be unhappy.

Isn't he always unhappy?

A pause, then:

You're awake.

You're texting me from the archive before dawn. I think we're both awake.

Another pause, longer.

I can hear your heartbeat from down here.

I stare at the screen and read it twice, and then a third time, because the third time is the one where I believe it.

How is that fucking possible? I type.

Your pulse went up when you read that. I heard it.

My pulse is hammering, and he's right, and he's two floors below me and he can hear my heart beating from the archive, and that, the distance and the intimacy of it, the fact that he's sitting with dead men's letters and listening to my blood, makes me press my thighs together.

What else can you hear?

The pause is different this time, longer and deliberate.

Your breathing changed, and it just went shallow.

Stop listening, Jesus.

No.

I press my phone against my chest and stare at the ceiling. Is this insane? This is a conversation about acoustics and it's making me wet. I know he knows that, because the man can smell a mood change through a floor.

I pick the phone back up, because of course I do.

What would you do if you were up here?

His answer comes fast, as though he'd been waiting for me to ask.

I'd put my hand on your throat. You've figured out by now that I like it there.

Yes.

I'd hold you by the throat and I'd put my mouth on you, not your neck. Lower.

I'd start at your stomach and go down.

I'm reading this one-handed, the other on my stomach under his sheet, my thighs already restless, tracing the path he's describing, and my fingers are shaking.

Holy shit, my fingers are actually shaking. Oh, fuck.

And then?

Then I'd put my tongue in you and find out exactly what that sound is — the one you make when you stop being a person with opinions and start being a body that wants something.

Lucian.

I'd taste you until you couldn't keep your thighs still, until the whole bed knew about it, until you said my name the way you said it in the car, like a word you were trying to hold in your mouth and couldn't.

My fingers are between my legs, and I'm not going to lie about it, not here, not to myself. Fuck it. I'm in the King of New Orleans's bed with my hand in my underwear reading his messages. The sound I'm making is exactly the one he described.

The last time I did this thinking about him, he didn't know my face. Now he's sending me instructions from two floors down.

My pussy is soaked. My clit is so swollen I can feel my own pulse in it. Every stroke of my fingers sends a jolt up my spine that makes my thighs clamp together. I'm thinking about his dick in the archive, about the shape of him through wool.

Two fingers, he sends. Inside you, slow.

I do it, of course I do it. I push two fingers into my pussy and my hips come up off his mattress to meet them, and my knees fall open on his sheets.

Now your thumb on your clit. The way I do it.

"Good God," I say to his empty room, and I do that too.

I'm—

I can't finish the text, though I try twice, and my thumb just slides off the glass.

I know, he sends. I can smell you from here.

Come upstairs. Right fucking now.

Not yet. Finish what you're doing.

Lucian—

I want to hear it from down here. I want to sit in this archive with my father's letters and listen to you come in my bed.

I drop the phone on the pillow and close my eyes. My fingers find the place they know, and the rhythm is his, the one he sets on the desk and in the car. His rhythm, in my hand, in his bed, with his name in my mouth.

I come with the phone beside my head and his name in the dark and two floors between us.

It isn't soft, and I don't try to make it soft. God.



THE DOOR OPENS almost immediately, before my breathing has come back down.

He's in the doorway, his eyes dark and his jaw set. There's a tension in his body that I recognize from the hallway at Perdido, a man who has been still for too long and has decided to stop.

"That was fast as hell," I say. "Were you running?"

"I was already on the stairs."

"Since when?"

"Since *what would you do if you were up here.*"

He crosses the room and takes the phone from me and puts it on the table.

"You listened?" I say.

"I listened." He gets on the bed. "I heard every sound you made. I heard your heartbeat go up and I heard it break, and I stood outside that door with my fingers on the handle and I didn't come in."

"Why the fuck not?"

"Because you told me to come upstairs, and I told you to finish, and I wanted to know if you'd listen to me from two floors away the same way you listen to me when I'm inside you."

"And?"

"You do." He puts his hand on my throat — cold fingers, warm skin, the grip I know. "You're the most obedient disobedient woman I have ever met."

"Don't call me obedient."

"Ghost."

"Don't call me that either."

He kisses me, and I can taste archive dust on his mouth and, underneath it, what might be want, and his hand is on my throat. I'm already wet again, and this is how it's going to be. I know it, and I'm done pretending I don't.



HE GETS INTO the bed and takes the left side, the one nearer the door, and I notice and don't say.

The room is dark except for the stripe of streetlight.

"Someone tried to kill me today," I say. "Did you notice, or were you busy?"

"I know."

"Not you. *Me*. Specifically me: the ledger, the mark."

"I know."

"Then you know what that means?"

"It means someone in this city wants the connection between the ledger and the house to stay quiet." His voice is calm about it, as it's always calm about the things that should terrify a person, and it's infuriating as hell. "It means you're worth killing."

"That's a shitty thing to say to someone lying in your bed."

"It's the most important thing anyone's said to you since the club."

He's right, and I hate that he's right, because being worth killing is not the same as being worth keeping, and I'm starting to want both.

"Go to sleep, ghost," he says.

"Are you going to?"

"You know I'm not."

"I don't sleep for shit in other people's beds."

"This isn't other people's."

"Then whose the hell is it?"

"Go to sleep and I'll tell you in the morning."

I don't answer that. I lie in the dark in the King of New Orleans's bed and listen to him not sleep, and somewhere in the house a clock ticks, and somewhere outside the house a city is afraid of itself.

And the pact has no shape.

And I'm staying anyway.



THREE DAYS later he goes down to see the wolf again.

I know because Silas tells me, in a sentence with the verb missing, as Silas tells anyone anything. "The prisoner. He's with the prisoner." Then he goes up the stairs.

I take the ledger to the archive: my father's handwriting and the wolf cipher and the columns of figures I'm learning to read in two registers, like I read everything.

I'm in the chair with my feet under me when Lucian comes back up from the basement.

I hear him before I see him, his footfall on the stair heavier than it was a week ago, a man carrying new weight.

He appears in the doorway, his jaw set like it sets after he's been sitting across from Thibault. His eyes are working the room, and when they find me they stop.

"The wolf used the title," he says. "*King of teeth*. About my father."

"Isn't that the insult?"

"It wasn't." He crosses toward the desk. "He meant something else by it: a king with teeth who never once used them on them. He was being — what's the word?"

"Respectful."

"Yes." He stops at the desk and leans on it. "My father was the king of teeth and he never bit, and the wolves knew it, and I'm standing here with a dead man's title and a set of jaws and no idea which version of it I'm supposed to be."

He's been getting closer without crossing the room. How does a man move toward you without his feet changing position? It's in his attention, a physical thing, and right now it's on me like his hand was on my throat.

He hasn't touched me since his bed. I know he's been counting because I've been counting, and neither of us has said so, and the not-saying is its own kind of pressure.

"Lucian."

He looks at me, and I look at him, and whatever we've been doing with the investigation and the ledger and the marks and the wolf in the basement, whatever this has been pretending to be, stops pretending.

He moves.

My back hits the shelving. Books fall — two of them, heavy, one catching my shoulder on the way down — and his mouth is on my throat and his hand is in my hair and I'm pulling at his shirt with both hands because it has been *days* and I am *done*. His hips pin mine to the shelving, and I grind against him without deciding to.

"Days," he says against my neck, like an accusation, like I'm the one who made time pass, like the distance between the car and this moment is a personal offense I committed against him specifically.

"I know."

"You were in my bed. I listened to you—" His teeth graze my collarbone. "I stood on the other side of a door and *listened*, and I didn't come in, and I haven't thought about anything else since."

"Stop talking. Jesus Christ, would you stop talking?"

"No." His fingers find the hem of my shirt, and then my stomach. "Say it again."

"Stop talking and—"

Two knocks, soft ones, on the archive door, and then Silas's voice through the wood, flat as a floorboard. "Sire. It can't wait."

Oh, you have got to be *fucking* kidding me. We both stop: his palm on my ribs, his thigh wedged between my thighs, my shirt halfway up, a book on the floor between our feet and another hanging off the shelf by its spine.

Two knocks: Silas.

Silas never knocks, because Silas opens doors and stands in them and waits. Silas knocks when the house is on fire, or when whatever he's bringing can't wait for a man to finish what he's doing.

Lucian steps back, and the distance between us opens like a wound. His palm leaves my skin and the air where it was turns cold. I'm standing against the shelving with my shirt pushed up and my pulse in my ears and a gap between us that feels like someone reached in and *pulled*.

His hands are shaking, and I can see it.

"I will finish this," he says, low, to me, his eyes on mine and nothing in them that belongs to a court or a code or a crown.

"You'd better."

He walks out. What the fuck could Silas be bringing? Whatever fire or finding or failure has earned two knocks on a closed door in the middle of the afternoon.

I stay against the shelving. My back hurts where the books caught me, and my shirt is still pushed up. My mouth tastes like him and the archive smells like old paper and I am shaking and I am *furious* and this is the cruelest thing that has happened to me since Tuesday.

Why can I still feel his palm on my ribs?

I pick up the book that fell, a household record from a year I don't recognize.

I put it back on the shelf with fingers that don't work right. I go upstairs, and I don't look at the door he went through.

The pact has no shape.

What shape is it trying to be? It keeps getting interrupted.

He said *I will finish this*

He'd goddamn better.



CHAPTER

Twenty

LUCIAN

THE MARCHAND woman told us what was in the poison. I've spent the drive home thinking about everything except what was in the poison.

Ondine Marchand keeps a house on neutral ground between the canal and the bayou. The house smells like things growing that shouldn't be growing indoors. She sat across from us at a kitchen table covered in jars and spoke about the brew like a doctor speaks about a patient, clinical, with no apology and a precision that made Selene's eyes go bright.

There was a woman at Ondine's table, quiet, dark-haired, with the posture of someone who'd been raised in a court and decided to stop attending. Ondine introduced her as a friend — no name, no house, no last initial. She sat in the corner with a cup of something that wasn't tea and didn't say a word for the entire conversation.

But she watched Selene, and why would a stranger do that?

The court watches her to decide which drawer she belongs in. This woman watched her as I've seen Selene watch rooms, from the inside, with both registers.

Selene stopped at the door on the way out, one hand on the frame.

"Who is she?" she asked Ondine.

"Isabeau." Ondine didn't offer a last name. "She comes for the tea."

"Just the tea?" Selene said.

"Is anything ever just the tea, cher?"

A look passed between the two of them on a frequency I don't have, and we left.



IN THE HALLWAY at home, I almost walk past her. She's standing between the study and the west wing, in the part of the hall where the lamplight doesn't reach. She stops me and puts her hand on my chest.

She doesn't push, just rests her palm flat over the place where a heart-beat would be urgent if I were human.

"Lucian."

"Mm."

"The woman at Ondine's. Isabeau."

"What about her?"

"She has it." Selene's eyes are searching my face. "The same thing I have, the two registers. She hears both layers."

"How do you know?"

"Because she was listening to Cassian's name like I listen to Cassian's name, from underneath. Didn't you see her face?"

Her palm is still on my chest, and my pulse is under it, slow and steady, the clock that never hurries. But it's not steady now, damn it. Her fingers are warm through my shirt and the warmth is going into me like her blood does. I am standing in a dark hallway with her palm over my heart and my forehead is tilting toward hers and the distance between us is the width of a held breath.

Her forehead touches mine, and we stand there, breathing each other's air. Her eyes are open and mine are open and the distance between our mouths is nothing — a word, a lean, the smallest possible decision.

I don't kiss her, and she doesn't kiss me. Why the hell not?

We stand in the hallway with our foreheads together and the ache between us is a physical thing, a third body in the dark, and neither of us

closes the distance because closing it would mean admitting that the distance is what we've been protecting.

I haven't been inside her since the car, and I can smell her from here: her skin, her sweat, and under the borrowed dress the wet heat of her pussy, wanting. Her nipples are tight against the thin cotton, and her thighs shift. Mine don't, but my cock does, hard enough to be a goddamn problem. The withholding has become a pressure that lives in every room we share, and this hallway is the smallest room yet.

"Shower," she says, and her voice is not right. "I smell like witch. Can't you smell it?"

"You smell like yourself."

"Shower," she says again, and steps back, and the distance returns, and the ache stays, and I follow her down the hall because following her is the only vocabulary I have left.



THIS AFTERNOON, at Ondine's table, she laid it out like a physician: the brew stops a vampire's body closing. Strength goes, then speed, then coordination, and half a glass puts a man on the floor for half a day.

"Does it kill?" I asked. "Straight out. Don't dress it up for me."

"No. It opens a window. Whatever happens inside the window is somebody else's doing."

"And after the window closes?"

"The worst of it passes in half a day, and the rest settles into the blood and sleeps." She turned a jar a quarter-turn. "Cuts heal slow for a month or so, and if you lose enough blood at once, it wakes up again. Don't get opened, Your Majesty, not badly, not for a while."

"And if I do?"

"Then you'd better have somebody willing to bleed for you." She looked at Selene and away again. "Do you?"

She said it looking at the cut on my forearm, still open, still healing at the rate of a human scratch. She knew what had been done to me because she'd made what did it.

She did not apologize, and why should she?

Selene asked the question I couldn't, in a voice so level it could have been reading a menu.

"Who did you make the fucking stuff for?"

"A man I've never met, through a broker I have." Ondine picked up a jar and turned it. "I don't ask who the client is. That's the arrangement."

"The broker? Does he have a name, or just a bill?"

"Has a name, and I'll give it to you, because I've been sitting on it for a month and it's starting to smell." She set the jar down. "Absalom Cray."

A name, a real one, the first link in the chain between a bottle of wine and my father's floor.

Selene wrote it down in the margin of her father's ledger, beside the hooked mark. I watched her do it, and the room settled.



NOW IT'S EVENING, and there's a woman standing in my bathroom looking at the shower.

"It works," I tell her.

"I'm not looking at whether the goddamn thing works." She's looking at the tile. "There's no curtain."

"Why would I need a curtain?"

"You don't need a curtain because nobody sees you shower. Jesus, Lucian."

"Nobody sees me do anything." Centuries of that.

"Doesn't that get lonely?"

"I wouldn't know. I never had anything to compare it to."

She turns, still in the dress from the Marchand house — a thing she borrowed from the staff, because her clothes are in an apartment she can't go back to.

"I smell like jars and kitchen grease and whatever that herb was she put in the tea."

"Lemongrass. Did she tell you it was for your nerves?"

"How do you know what lemongrass smells like?"

"I've been alive for four centuries. At some point you learn the herbs."

She laughs, a small one, almost nothing, and it costs her less than the ones in the car, because she's loosened since this afternoon.

"Turn around," she says.

"No."

"I'm getting in the shower."

"I know."

"Lucian."

"Selene."

She holds my eyes for a long breath, and then she pulls the dress over her head.



SHE'S THIN in a way that isn't about food, a body held ready for so long that the readiness has become the shape of her, with the muscles held and the shoulders set.

She gets in the shower and turns the water on without testing it first, reckless or a statement. She stands under it with her head back and her eyes closed and the water running down the whole length of her.

Her tits are small and her nipples go hard the second the water hits them. I watch from the doorway and I don't pretend I'm not watching.

I've been watching her since the club, not for threat, and not for access. I watch her like a door I've already decided about.

The pact ends when she has Rémy. She said that, and I agreed to it: one clean exchange for another, and when it's done she goes back to whatever she was before.

And I've spent a week understanding that the pact ending changes nothing.

She's going to leave, because that's the arrangement. She'll take what she came for and she'll walk out of this house and she'll go on being a woman in a city that doesn't see her.

Am I going to let her? I am, and then I'm going to find her anyway.

The pact is paper. What's underneath it I've been carrying since I lay on her kitchen floor and she sat against the cabinets with a knife she didn't use.

What is it? She hasn't named it, and neither have I. In four centuries I've never needed a name for it, because the name implies a condition I've never been in.

The water hits the tile and the steam fills the room, and I take my shirt off.



SHE HEARS ME and doesn't turn around, just tips her head a fraction toward the sound.

"Don't," she says.

"Don't what?"

"Don't be gentle about it."

I get in behind her, and the water is too hot — she's set it to a temperature that would scald a human. It hits my chest and runs, and my body doesn't care.

I slap my palm flat on the tile beside her head.

She goes still, her translating stillness, listening for the second version of a sentence, the one underneath the words.

"The pact ends when I have Rémy," she says.

"Yes."

"And then I leave."

"Yes."

"And then what?"

I put my mouth to her ear. The water runs between us and her hair is flat against her shoulders and her back is a line of tension that I could break. She smells like lemongrass and steam and underneath both of those, herself: warm skin, clean sweat. The salt of blood moving fast under the surface.

"And then nothing fucking changes," I say.

She turns her head just enough to catch my eye. The water runs over her cheek and her mouth is open and she's looking at me like she did in the hallway at Perdido, like a woman who has found a hole in the world and decided to stand in it.

"Say that again."

“Nothing changes.” I get my hand in her wet hair and pull her head back. “You can leave, and go back to your apartment and your bar and your bus to Barataria, and it won’t change a damn thing about what’s happening in this shower.”

“What’s happening in this shower?”

“I’m going to fuck you until you can’t stand, ghost.” I tighten my grip. “And tomorrow you’re going to sit at my table and look at me across the room and know exactly what I did to you in here, and the day after that, and the day after that.”

Her breath goes out of her and she braces on the tile.

“That’s not the pact,” she says.

“No. It isn’t.”

“Then what is it?”

I turn her around to face the wall, and she goes. She plants her palms and arches her back, and the water runs down her spine and pools in the curve above her ass.

“It’s the thing that comes after,” I say. “When the arrangement is done and the terms are met and there’s nothing left between us except what we decide to put there.”

“And what are you putting there?”

“Everything.”

She drops her forehead to the tile.

I run my fingers down her spine, slowly. My fingers are cold enough that the water between us steams where I touch her, and she shivers with each inch. I follow the line past the small of her back, past the curve, and let my thumb drag between her cheeks — one slow, deliberate stroke.

She goes rigid.

“Every part of you,” I say against her ear. “Eventually.”

“Lucian—”

“Not tonight.” I press my thumb there once — just pressure, a promise — and then move on. “Tonight I’m going to ruin you standing up.”

She pushes back against my hand anyway.

“Good girl,” I say.



I TAKE HER from behind, standing, with one hand on the tile beside her head and the other around her throat.

I don't start slow, because she told me not to be gentle and I take her at her word. The first stroke goes in hard enough that she slides on the wet tile. I have to hold her by the throat to keep her where I want her.

She chokes on a gasp, and her cunt clenches around me like a fist.

I stop, buried in her, still.

"Listen to me." I say it into her ear, low, under the water. "My fingers stay where they are. It's going to get tighter. I know exactly how long a body like yours can go without air, and I have never once been wrong about it."

Her breath shudders against my palm.

"You'll have no voice. So if you want me to stop, you tap my wrist. Twice. Like this." I take her hand off the tile and put two of her fingers against my forearm and press them. Once. Twice. "Two taps, and I let go. No matter what. No matter when. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"Show me."

She taps my wrist, twice.

My fingers open, and air goes into her in a ragged pull.

"Good," I tell her. "Again."

She taps it again, then puts her palm back on the tile, flat, and pushes her ass back against me.

"Now stop *talking*," she says.

I close my fingers.

She makes a sound that bounces off every surface in the room, and then she can't make any sound at all.

I count her heartbeats. I fuck her through a slow run of them with her throat shut in my hand. Her pulse climbs and hammers against my fingers, and her cunt goes tighter and tighter until I can barely move in her.

Her palm stays flat on the tile.

Then I let go.

The air goes into her in a whoop, and she's shaking. Her knees give, and I hold her up on my cock.

"Louder," I tell her.

"Lucian—"

"Louder. I want the whole wing to hear you."

"They'll—"

"They'll know." I pull back and drive in again and she cries out, sharp and broken. "They'll know exactly what's happening in here and they'll know it's me, and tomorrow when you sit at my table they'll know it was me then too."

"You're—" She can't get the sentence together. Her nails are scraping the tile. "You're filthy, you know that?"

"Yes."

"Christ. Say something else."

"You're soaked. You've been soaked since the car, haven't you? Since the Marchand house."

"No—"

"Don't fucking lie to me." I get my hand around to the front of her and find her clit, and she goes up on her toes. "You sat across from a witch and talked about poison and you were thinking about this."

"I was not—"

"Your pulse was up the whole drive home. I had the window down because I could smell you." I work her clit with two fingers and her pussy is so wet it's dripping down her thighs, mixing with the water. "I could smell this cunt from the driver's seat, ghost. Don't tell me you weren't thinking about it."

She makes a sound that isn't a word. I work her clit and fuck her at the same time. The rhythm is mine, only mine, and she takes it.

She takes all of it and pushes back into every stroke, because her body has stopped arguing with itself.

"This is mine," I tell her. "This cunt, this sound you make, the way you come apart when I'm inside you. All of it."

"Lucian—"

"Say it."

"I can't—"

"Say it."

"It's yours." Her voice cracks. "*Fuck*, it's yours, I—"

I stop.

Dead stop, buried in her, my grip on her throat, my fingers still on her clit, everything motionless.

"No—" She tries to push back, and I hold her still. "Don't stop, don't you dare—"

"Count to three."

"What?"

"Count." I tighten my grip on her throat, just enough that she has to fight for the air to do it. "Slowly."

"One—" Her voice is shaking. "Two— *please*— thr—"

I close my grip before she finishes, and drive into her. She comes with no air in her at all.

It hits her in waves, and I feel each one: the rhythmic clench of her around me, her whole body going rigid and then liquid, her pulse slamming against my palm. She comes in total silence, mouth open against the tile, and it's the loudest thing I've ever felt.

I let go, and she drags in air and it comes out of her as a sob.

I don't stop. She's still coming when I pull her off the wall and turn her and put her back against the tile, face to face, and her legs go around me and she's shaking.

"Again," I tell her.

"I can't—"

"Can't you? Again."

The second one takes longer and goes harder. I hold her against the tile with both hands under her thighs and fuck her through it while she holds onto my shoulders with her nails in my skin. The scratches won't heal for hours.

I watch her face while it happens, and her eyes are open. She's looking right at me while she falls apart, and there is nothing guarded in her.

She's handing me all of it, like she handed me her blood in the bedroom, freely, knowingly, with no smoothing afterward to take it away. Has anyone ever given me that? Not once, not in four hundred goddamn years.

I follow her over, and the sound I make is one I haven't made in a very long time, and I don't care where it goes.



AFTER.

The water's gone cold, and neither of us has moved to fix it.

She's standing against the tile with her arms around my neck and her face in the place where my neck meets my shoulder, and her breath is warm and unsteady.

"The pact ends when I have Rémy," she says, into my skin.

"Yes."

"And nothing changes."

"Nothing changes."

She pulls back enough to look at me. Her eyes are dark and wet from the shower and she's searching my face for a lie, maybe, the small print she's been waiting to find since the first night.

Does she find it? She doesn't.

Then her thumb finds my wrist and taps it, once, twice.

I'm not holding anything, so what is she doing? Checking the signal still works.

"Still works," I say. "Did you think it wouldn't?"

"Good." Her voice is wrecked. "Remember it."

"I don't have a word for this," she says.

"In which language?"

"Either."

I turn the water off, and the silence that comes in behind it is enormous.

"Then don't translate it, ghost," I tell her.

She looks at me for a long time, the water dripping off both of us and the tile ticking as it cools.

Then she nods, once, and she puts her forehead back against my shoulder, and she stays there.

The pact is the same, and the fucking terms are the same, but everything underneath it has changed. I'm standing in my own shower holding a woman who can hear two versions of every sentence I say.

I let her hear the third one.

Then I tell her, very low, what happens the next time she doesn't tap. She stops shaking for an entirely different reason.



CHAPTER

Twenty-One

LUCIAN

“**T**HE CONTINENT has noticed.”

Two people want two different wars from me, and I’m running out of ways to say no.

Marguerite has me cornered in the morning room with three Elders, because Marguerite never brings one person to a conversation that requires three.

“I’ve had a letter from the Aldric cousins in Lyon. A *letter*, Lucian. Do you know when they write letters? When they want the postmark in the record.”

“Let them send whatever the hell they like. What are they going to do, write again?”

“And the Conclave has inquired. Did you know that? Of course you didn’t, because you’ve been living in the archive with the bartender like a monk.”

That lands differently, because the Conclave doesn’t inquire. The Conclave ratifies, at a distance, with the disinterest of an institution that con-

siders the colonies a hobby. If they're asking, someone has been talking, and the talking has a purpose behind it.

"Who wrote to the Conclave?" I say.

Marguerite's mouth thins. "I'm looking into it."

"How long have you been looking?"

"Long enough to be annoyed about it."

"Look faster. I don't have a century."

The Elders shift, and one of them — Roche, old line, no ambition past his chair — clears his throat.

"There's a feeling in the council," he says, "that we're waiting for something that may not come."

"It's coming."

"You've been saying that for weeks. Have you any idea how that sounds from this side of the table?"

"I'll keep saying it."



CASSIAN ARRIVES after the Elders leave, because he always knows when.

He's warm, always warm, and the warmth has been the same temperature since I was a boy, whether from consistency or practice. I used to know which, didn't I?

"The council is restless," he says, and sits in the chair across from the fireplace, the one my father used to offer guests.

"The council is always restless."

"This is different. They want the war, Lucian, as a feeling, not a policy. They want to *do something*, and a crowned king is a king who can authorize them to do it."

"I'm aware. Did you think I'd missed it?"

"You're stalling, aren't you, boy?"

"I'm investigating."

He gives me the old look, warm eyes and a patient mouth, a man who has never once been in a hurry to tell you you're wrong.

"Your father once told me," he says, "that the difference between patience and hesitation is that patience has an end in mind. Does yours?"

The sentence fits, sliding into the conversation like every piece of advice he gives: true, useful, arriving in the exact shape of a clean conscience.

But I've heard that sentence before, the construction if not the words: the same rhythm, the same pivot on *your father*, the same warmth in the handing-over. He's said something shaped like this to me at least three times since Tuesday, and each time it's pointed me somewhere true.

Is the pointing the point? I'm not sure anymore.

"I have an end in mind," I say, and he doesn't need to know which.

"Good." He stands. "How is the Marchand woman? Silas was there again, wasn't he?"

"She's well. Why?"

"No reason. I worry about houses on the water." He adjusts his cuffs. "Houses should stand."

He goes, and the warmth goes with him, and I sit with the shape of it, the concern, the pivot to somebody's wellbeing. How does he make it feel like love every time?



I GO OUT in the evening, which I haven't done since the funeral.

I go as a man with a coat and a thirst and no desire to be recognized, to a bar on Magazine, a place my father liked because nobody in it knew what he was and the bartender called him Aury.

It's still here, and the bartender has changed and the drinks haven't.

The booth in the back corner is empty. My father used to sit there, never in the center, always against the wall, with his back to the wood and his coat folded on the bench beside him. He held his glass by the base and turned it twice before he drank, and I never asked why, and now I can't.

He ordered rye, neat, and he'd give the bartender a bill that was too large and say *keep it*, and the bartender would nod. Nothing else would pass between them: no name, no title, no history. Just a man with a glass of rye in a bar on Magazine Street, turning the glass twice because the turning was the ritual, and the ritual was the rest.

The booth smells like wood and old varnish and the warmth of a seat sat in by strangers who never knew the man beside them had been alive since before the city was named.

I sit at the end of the bar with a glass of red and I look at the room and I don't know why my father chose this city. Why here?

That thought catches me, because it's been sitting at the back of my mouth like a taste I can't place. Why New Orleans? He had a whole continent, houses in Toulouse and a standing in Lyon and a name the Conclave treated with near-warmth.

He came here, and he stayed.

I try to finish the sentence — *he came here because* — and I don't have the end of it.

Commerce, the port, the old families, the infrastructure a species accumulates over centuries: those are the words everybody uses and none of them are the reason.

He came here because — because what?

I change the subject in my own head, a coward's move, and I know it.



A MAN SITS down next to me, two stools closer than the empty bar requires.

He's vampire, and I know that like I know weather: established, comfortable, the kind of person who has been in this city long enough to have habits and not long enough to have history.

He orders a glass of a brandy I've seen at the Aldric house and slides a second one down the bar.

"For the gentleman," he says, to the bartender, not to me.

I don't touch it. I watch the bartender bring it to my end of the bar and set it in front of me without making eye contact.

"Terrible business," the man says, looking at his own glass. "About the King."

"Yes."

"I didn't know him well. Met him once, at a thing at the Marchand house, big man, warm." He drinks. "The condolences of a grateful city."

The formula is wrong, and who gets it wrong in this city?

I know the condolence forms of this city. *The condolences of a grateful city* is what you say to a widow, not to a son, one register off — the register of distance rather than proximity.

A man who knew the forms would have said *the condolences of a grieving house*. A man who was coached would have said *our sympathies to the Crown*.

This man said neither. Who coaches a man that badly?

He finishes his drink and puts money on the bar, more than the drink costs: another form, and it's the right one.

"A good man," he says. "Hard to replace, isn't he?"

He leaves, and I sit with the drink I didn't touch and the wrong word, and I don't let go of either.



I COME HOME to Selene in the study, in the chair across from the desk, the one Cassian usually takes. The ledger is open in front of her, and she's been reading.

"You went out," she says.

"I did."

"You smell like a bar. Did you drink anything?"

"I ordered something. I didn't drink it."

"You smell like old varnish and somebody else's brandy."

She looks at me like she looks at everything, both versions running at once.

"We need to talk about the word," she says.

"Which word?"

"The one you used in the west wing. The one you said to me the first week." She closes the ledger. "*Mine*."

I sit at the desk, because this conversation has a shape I haven't agreed to, and she's already inside it.

"It's a position," I say. "In this house—"

"In this house it means claimed. In your court it means property with a flag on it. And in wolf—" She stops herself, and starts again. "In wolf, *mine* is what an Alpha says about a kill, not a person, a thing he's going to eat."

"You're not a goddamn kill—"

"I hear all three, Lucian. Every time you say it, I hear the version that means *this belongs to me* and the version that means *this is attached to me* and the version that means *this is something I'm consuming*. And none of them say what I need them to say."

The room goes still, and even the lamp seems to wait.

"What do you need them to say?"

"That I'm choosing. That I'm here because I walked in, not because you put me here." She leans forward. "I'm not yours. If I stay it's because I choose to stay, every morning, and the choosing is mine. Not the being."

I look at her across the desk, my father's desk, the desk where a king sits and gives words to things.

She's right, and she's right in a way that goes past *mine* and into what I've been building around her without asking whether she wanted walls.

"Then teach me, ghost," I say. "The word for what you are. Because *mine* is the only language I've had for four hundred years, and I'll learn yours tonight if you'll stay long enough to teach me."

Her mouth changes, an arrival, as if a sentence she's been waiting for has finally shown up.

"I'll stay," she says. "Not because you asked. Because you offered to learn."

She comes around the desk and sits on the edge of it, between my knees, and takes my hands and puts them on her thighs, under her skirt.

"First lesson," she says. "In wolf, you don't take. You wait to be given. Can you do that?"

So I wait, and it's the hardest goddamn thing I've done in a century.

Her skin is warm under my palms, and I don't move them. She watches me not move them, and her breathing changes, and then her thighs part, slowly, an inch, then another, until my thumbs are resting on the soft skin at the very top and I can feel the heat of her through the cotton and smell how wet she's gotten from nothing but my stillness.

"Good," she says, very quietly. "You're a fast learner, Your Majesty."

She leans down and bites my lower lip, hard enough to sting.

"Second part of the lesson," she says against my mouth. "You don't move. Not a finger, unless I move it."

"And if I do? What happens then?"

"Then you've failed, Your Majesty, and I go to bed."

She takes my right hand by the wrist and slides it up the last inch. She pushes her underwear aside with her other hand and lays my fingers against her. She's soaked, hot and slick and swollen, and my whole body wants to curl those fingers into her, and I don't. I keep my hand exactly where she put it.

She rocks against it, slowly at first, her palms flat on my father's desk behind her, her thighs spread over my knees. She drags herself along my fingers, back and forth, until her clit is sliding over my knuckles and her breath has gone ragged. Then she takes my wrist again and pushes two of my fingers inside her, deep, and holds them there, and grinds down.

"Don't," she says, when my thumb twitches toward her clit. "Did I say you could?"

"No."

"Then don't."

I don't. I sit in my father's chair with my hand inside her and every muscle in my arm locked, and I let her use me. She fucks herself on my fingers with her head tipped back and her mouth open. The wet sound of it is the loudest thing in the room. Her cunt tightens around my fingers in small pulses that get closer together. The desk creaks behind her, and a pen rolls off the blotter.

"Look at you," she says, and her voice is wrecked. "All these centuries and you've never once held still for anybody."

"No."

"Holding still for me?"

"Yes."

That's what does it. She comes on my fingers with her thighs clamped around my wrist and a low, shaking sound in her throat, and I feel every pull of it. I don't move, not even when it's over, not when she lifts herself off my hand and my fingers come away wet and she looks at them, and then at me, and smiles.

Then she takes my wrist, and taps it with two fingers, once, twice.

Why tap, when I haven't moved since she sat down? She's showing me she can stop this any time she likes, and that she only stops when she's finished.

She picks up the ledger and goes to the west wing, and the door doesn't close behind her. I sit in the study with the word *mine* on the desk between us like a coin she's turned over to show me the other side.

I have spoken one language in every room I've ever been in, and a woman who hears two has just told me the first one isn't enough.

That was the first lesson.

She left the door open for the second.



CHAPTER

Twenty-Two

LUCIAN

I LET THE WOLF go on a Tuesday.

That's a choice I make without explaining it, and the people who want an explanation will have to do without one. Thibault walks out of my house at midmorning with the clothes he came in and a cut on his wrist from the ties and nothing else.

He stops at the gate, because of course he stops.

"Your Majesty."

"Go home, Thibault, before I change my mind. Do you need someone to walk you to the road?"

"I know the way. I came in through it with a bag on my head." He looks at the house behind me — at the windows, the courtyard, the door that's been open since his arrival. "You know what I told you about the chamber?"

"I know."

"It's going to come apart. Whatever's holding this thing together — the story, the arrangement, the version everybody's been telling — it's going

to come apart." He puts his hands in his pockets. "When it does, I'd like to be somewhere useful."

"You've been useful. You know that? More than half my court."

"I'd like to stay useful," he says plainly. "A wolf who can say what he saw, in front of whoever you put him in front of. Isn't that worth something?"

"It's worth getting you killed."

"It's worth getting me killed by the right people." He shrugs. "Better than the wrong ones, isn't it?"

I watch him go, down the street with the gait of a man who's been sitting for ten days, the morning sun on his back, and he doesn't look around.

He's going back to Baratara to tell Gaspard whatever he chooses to tell Gaspard. I'm going to have to live with whatever that is.

It's the right thing to do, and my father would have done it on the first day, sat him down with a meal and sent him home with a bottle.

Was that cruel? I let him sit for ten days in a room with a lamp. I'm not sorry about it, and I'd do it again.



SILAS HAS CRAY, more or less.

He isn't in custody, only in sight. Silas has been sitting on the Bywater address for three days. The man hasn't run, which Silas reads as confidence and I read as instruction. Somebody told Cray to stay, and staying is what he's doing.

"He has a routine," Silas says, standing, because we're in the study and Silas doesn't sit in the study. "Coffee at eight, a walk at ten, the house from noon until evening, and one visitor per day, late afternoon."

"And the visitor? Who is it?"

"Different each time. I've logged four." Silas doesn't use paper. He keeps it in his head, organized by a system I've never been able to replicate. "Two are human. One is a wolf I don't know. One is a vampire."

"Which vampire? And don't say you don't know, Silas. You always know."

"Young, established, not Elder. She wore a coat I've seen at the Aldric house."

"Aldric? You're certain?"

"The house, not the cousin you sent away." A pause. "The cousin's people, though. Same tailor."

I let that sit. The Aldrics are a large house, and their domestic arrangements are complicated like very old families are complicated — layers of obligation, of favor, of money that moves between accounts nobody examines.

"The money going into Cray's account," I say. "Have you traced it?"

"I've traced it to a holding, managed by a firm in the Bywater, and the firm has one other client."

"Who?"

"Daniel Ward."

The room changes, somewhere under the air and the light.

"Her father," I say.

"Her father's estate, what's left of it." Silas looks at the window. "The same firm that holds whatever Ward left behind also manages the account that's paying Cray to stay in his house."

"That's a connection, isn't it?"

"It's a pipe, sire. Money goes in one end and comes out the other, and somebody put the plumbing in before Ward died." He turns back to me. "Cray was paid through the same channel that Ward was paid through. Different accounts, same firm, same holding."

"And the holding? Whose is it?"

"Has a signatory I don't recognize, a name that isn't a person — it's a device, a legal fiction."

"Can you open it?"

"I can try. I'll need Ondine."

"The Marchand woman?"

"She holds names. That's what witches do." His jaw works, the same tightening I've seen before. "A name held by a witch can be traced, and a name held by a lawyer can be hidden."

"Then go to her."

"I'd rather she came here."

"Why the hell not?"

"Because I don't want to be in her house when I ask for this," he says evenly. "She's done enough. If I'm going to ask for more, I'd like it on ground where she can say no without it costing her."

That stops me, because Silas is being decent about it, in a way that makes the rest of what we're doing look like exactly what it is.

In weeks of investigation, of asking and pushing and turning people over, Silas has never once expressed a preference about where a conversation happens. He goes where the information is and reads the ground, and he's never wrong about it.

So what's this about? Not the ground. This is about a woman in a house on neutral ground, and the particular care a man takes when the person he's asking something of is the person he's most careful about.

"Bring her here," I say, "and make it comfortable."

"Thank you."

"For what? It's my house she's coming to."

"For asking what would make her comfortable, sire. Nobody asks."

He goes, and I sit at the desk with the ledger open and the chain laid out in my head link by link, and it's all one chain.

Cassian's mark in the ledger, and Ward's payments held in trust. Cray brokered the poison, and Cray is funded through the same pipe as Ward. The pipe has a name that isn't a person.

And somewhere at the other end of it, someone asked about Gaspard's wife.



CASSIAN COMES in the afternoon. I haven't seen him in three days, the longest gap since the funeral. He's been at his house — the one I've never visited, the one on a street I've walked past without knowing it was his.

He looks tired. Vampires don't look old as humans do, but there's a settling in him, like a building when the foundation shifts.

"Boy."

"Come in. Where have you been?"

"At home, being old. Did you miss me?"

He takes his chair and doesn't pour — that's the first difference — and sits down with his coat still on and his hands on his knees.

"You let the wolf go," he says.

"This morning."

"And?"

"And he'll go home and tell his Alpha what he saw, and I'll deal with whatever that produces."

"What did he see?"

I look at Cassian across the desk. The man has been sitting in this chair for decades. The wood knows the weight of him, and so do I.

The question is ordinary. He's been asking me about the investigation most days — what I've found, what I've ruled out, what I need. Every answer I've given him has been true, and every true answer has been a selection from a larger truth, and the selection is the lie.

"He saw my father fight," I say. "He saw wolves die. He saw my father standing when they left."

"And after?"

"After was after. He was through the window."

Cassian nods, and his hands stay on his knees.

"You're closer," he says.

"Closer to what?"

"To whatever you're looking for." He says it without asking what it is. "I can see it in the way you sit in that chair. You've stopped leaning back."

He's right. I've stopped leaning back in my father's chair because leaning back is what a man does when he's thinking, and I've stopped thinking and started knowing.

"The poison came through a broker," I say. "A man named Cray, in the Bywater."

"And beyond Cray?"

"I'm working on it."

"Through what channel?"

“Through the financial records.” I keep my voice level. “Ward’s ledger — the translator. It has a mark in it that matches our internal correspondence seal.”

There it is: I’ve put the evidence in front of him, and only the evidence, the mark in the margin, the connection between the ledger and the house.

Cassian looks at me, and his mouth tightens — a small closing I have to be very careful about reading, because I can’t unread it if I read it wrong.

What I see is recognition, as if he expected it before I said it, a man who’s been waiting for a sentence and has just heard the first word of it.

“The house seal,” he says.

“Yes.”

“Your father’s?”

“My father used it. So did other people.”

A pause, a long one, filled with the sound of a house in the afternoon — a clock somewhere, a footstep above us.

“So did I,” he says.

The words go into the room and sit there.

“I used that mark before your father did,” he says. “He took it from me. Or I gave it to him — I’ve forgotten which, and it was a long time ago, and we were both younger.”

He says it openly, without defense, without explanation, as though it were a fact about the architecture of the house rather than a confession.

“You signed Ward’s payments,” I say.

“I signed a great many things over the years with that mark.” He leans back. “If you’re asking whether I knew Daniel Ward, the answer is yes. I commissioned translations from him, legal work, mostly, the same kind of work any Elder commissions when they’d rather not put their name on a filing.”

“That’s not what the payments look like.”

“What do the payments look like?”

“Large, regular, held in trust.”

“Then they look like exactly what they are, for God’s sake.” He meets my eyes. “Private commissions, paid at a premium, held by a careful man who understood that discretion has a price.”

It's perfect. Every word of it is plausible, and every word of it fits, and a man who didn't know what I know would take it and go on.

But I know what a blade wound looks like. I know it was under the ribs, angled upward, and it didn't close.

"Thank you," I say.

"Is that all? No more questions for the old man?"

"For now."

He stands and gathers his coat — it was already on, so the gathering is a gesture rather than a function, a man leaving a room in the posture of leaving.

"Lucian."

"Mm."

"When you find what you're looking for," he says, "come to me first, not the council, not Marguerite." His hand is on the doorframe, where it always is when he says the last thing. "Come to me, and I'll help you carry it."

He goes, and I sit in the study with his offer in the room, and his honesty about the mark, and his perfect, reasonable explanation.

And I don't believe him.

Not one piece of it: not the private commissions, not the premiums, not the careful translator who held payments in trust.

I don't believe him because I watched his face when I said the word *mark*, and what I saw wasn't surprise.

It was relief, God damn him.

He'd been waiting for me to ask, with the answer ready, and a ready answer is a built one.

The truth doesn't come with furniture.

I go to the window and look down at the courtyard. I remember his hands on my hands, when I was a boy, showing me where to put the weight.

I take the blade out of my coat and I put it on the desk, keyed to my father's blood, useless against anyone else. Against Cassian, what is it? An ordinary knife.

He made sure of that: one vial, one blade, one king.

I put the blade back in my coat and I go to find Selene, because she's the only person in this house who can hear the second version of a sentence.

Ghost. I've said it so often it's stopped being a name.

It's a location.

I go there now, up the west stair two at a time.

She's in the west wing bath with the door open, up to her chin in water gone cloudy with soap, and she doesn't cover herself when I come in.

"You look like you've seen a ghost," she says.

"I'm looking at one."

I kneel by the tub and put my mouth on her wet shoulder, then her throat. She tips her head for me without being asked. I don't bite. I drag my tongue up the line of her pulse and taste soap and salt and her, and under the water her knees come apart. Her hand finds mine and pulls it down between her thighs.

She's slick even under the water. I stroke her slowly with two fingers while she grips the rim of the tub. Her hips lift into my palm, and the water slops over the edge onto the tile. When she comes it's quiet, with her teeth in her lip and her fingers locked around my wrist and her eyes on mine the whole time.

She reaches up out of the water and pulls me down by the collar, and kisses me with her wet hand on the back of my neck. My shirt soaks through where it touches the rim.

"Get in," she says.

"There isn't room."

"There's room if you're under me."

There is. She climbs on top of me in water that sloshes over the edge and floods the tile, and sinks down on my cock with a sigh I feel in my teeth, and rides me slowly with her palms on my chest and her hair dripping on my face. I can feel how tight she is around my cock, how wet, even with the water around us, and her thighs grip my hips. Her clit grinds against me every time she sinks down. Every time she does it she gasps, and she does it again. Neither of us says much, and her nipples drag against my skin every time she leans forward. I hold her hips and let her set the

pace, and when she comes the second time she bites my shoulder to keep the sound in. I follow her with my face in her wet throat.

She doesn't ask what happened downstairs, and I don't tell her what I saw on his face when I said *mark*.

I'm not ready to hear her translate it.



CHAPTER

Twenty-Three

SELENE

ONDINE MARCHAND'S guest room has a door that locks from the inside. I stand there looking at the lock for a while. When did a lock last mean anything to me?

It's a simple thing, a bolt, old brass, the kind you find in houses that were built before anyone in them needed to worry about what came through a window.

Does it work? I tested it twice, like an idiot.

We're here because Ondine wouldn't come to us. Jars don't travel, she told Silas, and neither does she. So we came to neutral ground instead, and the conversation ran late. She offered the room without ceremony, clean sheets already on the bed, like she'd known we were staying before we did.

Did she know?

She probably did, because witches know things, mostly by paying attention. That's how you keep a house standing between two powers for as long as she has.

The room is small: a bed, a chair, a window that looks out on a garden going wild in the dark. It smells like dried herbs and old wood and a third thing underneath both that I can't name and don't try to.

Lucian is downstairs, and he's been in Ondine's kitchen for an hour, talking to her about the name behind the holding. I left because the conversation had moved past the part I could help with and into the part that's just two old things with long memories comparing notes.

On my way up I passed through the kitchen for water, and Silas was at the table. He wasn't part of the conversation — he was at the far end, reading papers Ondine had spread out for him, and Ondine was at the stove with her back to the room.

She poured a cup from the pot without turning around and set it at his end of the table. Did she ask how he takes it? She didn't need to.

He drank it without looking at her. When she reached past him for the salt, her wrist passed an inch from his mouth, and he stopped reading and didn't move. She took the salt back to the stove, and he read the same line three times.

Holy shit, those two.

Neither of them said a word, and I recognized the shape of the silence: two people who have done this so many times that the doing has become the language. In wolf there's a word for it, and the word has *kitchen* in it, and *years*.

I took my water and went upstairs. And Lucian, at the other end of that kitchen, didn't look old.

He's older than this city and he moves as if he's thirty-five, and when he sat at Ondine's table tonight with a cup of whatever she'd brewed, he looked like a person in a room. For the first time since I've known him, he wasn't the whole fucking room himself.



I SIT ON the bed and take out the ledger. I've been carrying it since the funeral: years in my bag, then a week on the desk, then everywhere I go, because the ledger is the only thing I have left of my father that's still working.

His handwriting, his clients, his careful columns, the hooked mark in the margins.

And the held payments — twenty-three of them, money he kept for someone who killed him for it.

I open to the last page he wrote on, dated a Thursday, three days before he died. Goddamn it, Dad.

The entry is simple: a fee, a mark, and beside it, in his writing, smaller than the rest:

For S. When she asks.

I've read that line a hundred times. I read it the first night I opened the ledger past the first page. I sat at Lucian's desk and didn't make a sound.

He knew. Did he know exactly what was coming? I don't believe so. But he knew the ledger would matter, and he knew I would find it. He left me a line that says he was thinking about me on a Thursday three days before a man came to the house.

For S. When she asks.

I'm asking now.



LUCIAN DOESN'T knock. He tries the handle, finds the bolt, and waits, and I get up and open it.

He looks at my face and he doesn't ask what's wrong. He comes in and shuts the door behind him and stands there with his coat on. I realize he's been carrying the blade in his pocket the whole time we've been in this house.

"Ondine?" I say.

"She's going to trace the name. It'll take a few days."

"A few days? How many is a few, to a witch?"

"As many as it takes. She was very clear about that."

"And us?"

"We're here for the night, because she insisted."

"Hell of a host. Does she always insist?"

"Only when she's worried. And we're safer here than in my house tonight." He takes the coat off and drapes it over the chair, and the weight in the pocket pulls it sideways. "What are you reading?"

I look down at the ledger in my lap and don't answer right away.

Should I close it? I could put it on the bed and say *nothing* and he would let me, because he has never once pushed me past the edge of what I'm willing to give. Not once, this whole shit month.

Instead I hold it out to him.

"Last page," I say. "Will you read it?"

He takes it and reads it, standing, with the lamp behind him.

His face doesn't change, because when a thing lands hard enough, his face goes still instead of moving.

"*For S,*" he reads. "*When she asks.*"

"He wrote it three days before."

"Before Rémy?"

"Before everything." I sit back down on the bed. "He was thinking about me, on a Thursday, doing his books."

Lucian looks at the page for a long time, then closes the ledger and sets it on the chair on top of his coat, and sits down on the bed beside me, close enough to say *I'm here*, not close enough to take anything.

"He left it for you?" he says.

"He left all of it for me, God damn him." My voice cracks without my permission. "The ledger, the held payments, the mark. He left me the whole trail, because he knew — he *knew* — that the man who paid him was going to close the account."

"You don't know that. How could you?"

"I do." I look at him. "A man who writes *for S, when she asks* on the last page of his ledger is a man who knows someone is coming, not who, not when. But he knew the work was dangerous, and he kept the record anyway, and he left it where his daughter would find it."

The room is still. Ondine's house at night is a different thing than Ondine's house in the day — the herbs smell stronger, the wood creaks with its own temperature, and somewhere in the garden a frog is saying one thing over and over.

"I've been carrying this since the funeral," I say. "I didn't open it because I wasn't ready for his handwriting."

"And now? What changed?"

"Now I've been reading it every day for two weeks and his handwriting is the only thing in this city I trust."

Something moves in Lucian's face, coming up through the stillness like water through cracked ground.

"You trust me," he says.

He's not asking. He's reading the sentence I just said and hearing the second version underneath it.

"I trust the ledger," I say. "The ledger led me to you."

"That's not the same thing, is it?"

"It's what I have, and it's all I've fucking got."

He looks at me for a while. The lamp on the table beside the bed is the only light in the room. It turns his face into a thing I have to be careful about looking at, because looking at it too long makes me want to say things I don't have translations for.

"Can I see the rest, ghost?" he asks. "Will you let me?"

I nod, and he picks the ledger back up, opens it to the first page, and starts reading.

And I let him, God help me.



HE READS IT slowly, page by page, running his finger down the columns, the way I imagine my father's finger did, checking his own work.

I watch his fingers turn each page from the corner, as you turn the pages of something that matters.

I sit on the bed beside him and I watch him read my father, and a wire I've been holding taut for four years goes slack by a degree.



HE FINISHES and closes it, and puts it on his knee and keeps his palm on it.

"Your father was thorough," he says.

"He was a translator. Thorough is what translators are, for God's sake. We're insufferable."

"I've noticed."

"Shut up."

"He left you everything, didn't he?" He looks at me. "Every client, every payment, every mark, a trail that runs from a kitchen table in the Bywater straight to the heart of my house."

"He didn't know it ran to your goddamn house."

"He knew it ran somewhere." His palm presses flat on the cover. "He held twenty-three payments in trust for a man he suspected would come for him, and he put your initial on the last page."

"Yes."

"He trusted you with it?"

"He trusted me to ask."

Lucian sets the ledger on the bedside table, then turns to me and takes my face in both hands.

It isn't for a kiss. He holds my face and looks at me, thumbs at my jaw, like he's seeing me for the first time.

"You are the most careful person I have ever met," he says.

I don't speak, because my throat is full of something that doesn't have a word. Shit. Am I going to cry?

"You've been carrying this for years. You learned a language to use it. You came to my city and got into my house and sat across from me with a dead man's book in your lap, and you waited until you were sure before you opened it." His thumbs move on my jaw. "You are meticulous and you are patient and you terrify me."

"I terrify you? Me? The bartender?"

"You terrify me," he says simply. "Nothing in four centuries has done what you did in a hallway that smelled like lemons."

Jesus, that sentence.



I KISS HIM softly, nothing like the car, or my bed, or the shower. I put my mouth on his and I hold it there, and the kiss stays gentle.

He makes a sound, low, almost nothing, a held breath that comes out shaped like my name.

Then we're lying down, and how does it happen? I don't know — the mechanics of two people going from sitting to lying on a bed in a bor-

rowed room. One moment his hands are on my face and the next I'm on my side with my back against the mattress and he's on his side facing me.

We're looking at each other, with a hand's width of air between us. His hand is on my hip, over the dress, and mine is on his chest, and neither of us is moving.

"This is the part I don't know how to fucking do," I say. "Shit. I'm serious."

"Which part? The part where we don't fight?"

"The quiet part." I look at his collar instead of his eyes. "I know how to do the other thing, the hard thing, the wall thing, the car thing."

"The shower thing."

"The shower thing, holy shit." I almost smile. "God. I don't know how to do this."

"Neither do I. Isn't that a hell of a thing?"

"Haven't you been alive longer than this country?"

"Not like this." His hand moves on my hip and stays. "Never like this."

Do I believe him? I do, because his voice has gone to a place I haven't heard it go. The place is low and unsteady and has nothing underneath it.

He's as far out as I am, isn't he?



HE TAKES HIS time undressing me, a thing he has never been with me.

One button, then the next, then the zipper at my side, eased down with the attention of a man defusing a bomb.

His fingers are cold, as they always are, and I know that now as well as I know the sound of his footsteps. But tonight the cold on my skin feels less like a shock and more like an announcement: *This is me. This is what I am.*

He's not taking the dress off. He's *reading* it. His fingers find the seams and follow them, learning the garment as if it were a sentence, structure first, then meaning. Each cold fingertip leaves a trail of heat behind it as my body warms whatever it touches.

When it's off he looks at me for a while, and I let him, because the looking is the point.

I take his shirt off, and it's slower than I expected, because my hands are shaking, and God help me, the shaking isn't fear or adrenaline or any of the things I know how to handle.

It's the other thing, the one I don't translate.

He gets his trousers off, and this time I'm the one who looks.

I've never really looked at him. There's always been a hallway or a car or a desk, and my eyes have always been busy. Now he's lying on his side on a witch's clean sheets in lamplight, and I take my time.

He's broad through the shoulders and narrow at the hip, pale everywhere. There's an old scar on his ribs, silver, the only mark on him, and who managed that? I want to know, and I don't ask. The scratches I left in the shower are still on his back, still red. His cock is hard and heavy against his thigh. I look at that too, for long enough that it twitches.

"You're staring," he says. "Are you going to tell me what you see?"

"You said that to me once."

"I meant it as a compliment."

"So do I. Shit, I'm bad at this."

His mouth goes soft in a way I've never seen, almost shy.

"Nobody's ever looked at me like that," he says.

"Like what? Like a fucking crime?"

"Like I'm something they want to keep."

I don't have an answer for that, so I lay my palm over the scar instead, and he lets me.

We're both bare and on our sides, face to face. His dick is hard against my thigh and neither of us acknowledges it, because acknowledging it would mean rushing, and tonight is not for rushing.

A hand's width of air, his hand on my hip, cold palm, warm hip, and mine on his chest.

I move my hand up, inch by inch, along his collarbone and up the side of his neck, and I put my palm on his throat.

He goes very still, and oh, God, it's the stillness of a man who's been touched somewhere nobody touches him.

I can feel his pulse under my palm, slow, ancient, a clock that's been keeping time since before my country had a name.

"Nobody does that," he says.

"I'm doing it. Is that all right?"

"I know." His voice is barely there. "Don't stop."

I hold his throat, and he holds my hip, and the space between us hums.

"Come here," he says.

I close the space, and he kisses me for a long time before he does anything else.

Then he moves down my body without hurrying, and I let him. I don't know what to do with my hands, so I put them in his hair.

He kisses my collarbone, and the top of each breast. He takes my nipple into his mouth and sucks it slowly, his tongue flat and cold and then not cold. My back comes up off the witch's clean sheets. He does the other one, and he takes his time. Every pull goes down through my belly and lands between my legs. I'm wet before he's anywhere near there, and he knows it, because I watch his nostrils flare.

"You don't have to—" I start. "God, Lucian, you don't have to do anything."

"I know I don't."

He kisses the soft skin under my navel, then each hipbone, then the inside of one thigh and the other. He spreads my knees with his palms and looks at me, lamplight on my pussy, wet and open for him. He doesn't say a word, just looks, like he looked at my father's ledger.

Then he puts his mouth on me.

Unhurried, in a way he has never once been with me, his tongue moves through me in one long stroke and circles my clit and stays there, soft, patient, until my thighs are trembling on either side of his head. He doesn't push his fingers into me, and he doesn't suck. He just keeps his mouth on me, warm now from my own heat, and lets it build, and lets it build, until I'm lifting my hips off the bed into his face and gripping his hair and saying his name to the ceiling in a voice I don't recognize.

"Lucian. Please. I'm—"

"I know," he says against me. "Let it come."

It comes slowly, the way everything tonight comes, rolling up from somewhere under my ribs and breaking without a sound. I shake through

the whole length of it with his palms spread on my thighs and his tongue moving through me gently, until it's too much and I push at his forehead and he stops.

He kisses the inside of my knee.

Then he comes back up the bed and lies down facing me again, a hand's width away. His mouth is wet with me, and he doesn't wipe it.

"There," he says. "Now you know how to do the quiet part, don't you?"

I laugh, and it comes out broken.

"Come here," I tell him, and this time I pull him the rest of the way.



IT'S SLOW. He enters me on our sides, face to face, with my leg over his hip and his hand in my hair. The angle isn't deep — it can't be, like this — and neither of us tries to make it something it isn't.

He moves in me so slowly I can count it, out until only the head of him is inside me, then back, an inch at a time, until his hips are flush with mine. His palm slides up from my hip to my breast and cups it. His thumb circles my nipple until it's tight and aching. Every circle goes straight down to where he's buried in me.

"Is this all right?" he says against my mouth, the first time he's ever asked.

"Don't you dare stop. Do you hear me? Don't you fucking dare."

I reach down between us and touch myself, slow circles on my clit in time with him, and he watches my face while I do it. His cock jerks inside me, and he makes a sound like I've hurt him. His fingers tighten in my hair, and he doesn't speed up. He goes slower.

He's cold inside me, cold and then warm, like his fingers were, my body taking him in and changing him, a translation that loses nothing. My pussy aches around him, deep and full, and the ache is not pain. God, it isn't pain.

It's so still, and I keep coming back to that. The room is still, and so are we, and the only sound is breath and the small sound of two bodies moving together without urgency.

He doesn't talk: no filthy words, no commands, no *good girl*. His mouth is on mine, and then on my cheek, and then on the place below my ear where the pulse is, and he stays there.

I feel his fangs against my skin, resting there, barely touching, two cold points against the vein, a promise he's choosing not to keep.

How is restraint more intimate than anything he's ever done to me? It is.

I hold onto his shoulders, and my fingers find the scratches I left in the shower — still there, still not healed — and I trace them while he moves in me.

His cock shifts inside me and I feel every inch of the drag. I tighten around him, and his breath catches against my throat. My pussy clenches and I feel it in my spine.

"Lucian."

"Mm."

"Stay. Shit, Lucian. Stay."

That's it, one word, and it comes out of me in one language, and it doesn't need translating.

He pulls back enough to look at me, his eyes dark and open, and there is nothing held back in them.

"Say it again," he says.

"Stay."

"Ghost," he whispers, with none of the tease in it, none of the ownership, like a prayer, like a word he's only now learning the meaning of.

He puts his mouth back on the place below my ear and he stays there. His hips move in a rhythm that's about staying, not finishing.

I come quietly. It rises through me in a long slow wave that has none of the violence of the car or the shower or the desk, just warmth, spreading outward. I hold onto him while it happens and I don't make a sound.

He comes after me, inside me, with his forehead against mine and his eyes closed for the first time, and the sound he makes is my name.



AFTER.

The lamp is still on, and the frog in the garden has stopped.

He's on his back and I'm on his chest. His hand is moving in my hair without pattern, without purpose, just moving.

"My father left me a ledger," I say. "Your father left you a philosophy."

"And a city."

"And a city. Did he ever ask if you wanted it?"

"He never asked me anything. He told me."

I trace the line of his collarbone. "But the philosophy is the one you carry."

"The philosophy is the one I argued with."

"You argued with it because it was worth arguing with." I look up at him. "A man who restrains himself when he could do anything is a man who's chosen something harder than power."

"My father would have liked you. Do you know that?"

"Your father would have erased my ass. Don't lie."

"Yes." Something moves at the corner of his mouth. "And then he would have liked you."

I put my face back on his chest. His heartbeat is slow, slower than a human's, steadier, keeping time like it has since before any of this.

"I gave you the ledger," I say.

"You did."

"That's not part of the fucking pact, is it?"

"No."

"I gave it to you because I wanted you to hold it." My voice is small in the room. "Because you turn pages from the corner. And because my father wrote *for S, when she asks* on the last page, and I've been asking ever since, and you're the first person who's heard the question."

His hand stops in my hair, and then it starts again.

"I'm going to keep it safe, ghost," he says.

"I know."

"When this is over—"

"Don't." I cover his mouth. "Don't say *when this is over*. Just say what's true right now."

He takes my hand off his mouth and holds it.

"You're in a borrowed room in a witch's house," he says. "Your father's ledger is on the table beside us. There's a frog in the garden and you smell like lemongrass and I am not going to sleep tonight."

"Why not?"

"Because sleeping means not looking at you."

"That's the most ridiculous goddamn thing anyone's ever said to me."

"Is it wrong?"

"No."

I close my eyes, and something in me, the last quarter-turn of whatever's been holding at full tension, lets go.

It doesn't have a word, not in wolf, not in English, not in whatever language I've been inventing between the two of them since the night in the hallway.

He's still looking at me, because he said he would, and I let him.

I don't tell him what I think the ledger is saying. Not tonight. One more night of him looking at me like this first.



CHAPTER

Twenty-Four

SELENE

I 'VE BEEN READING the ledger in two registers and he's only been reading it in one.

That's the sentence I've been carrying since the archive. He sees the mark and he sees his friend's name underneath it and the weight of that is enough to keep him staring at the same page for an hour.

I see the mark and the name and a third thing: what the mark is doing in my father's handwriting. It's a frequency, more than a signature, because the jobs with the mark get more regular as the years go on. The fees climb, and the climbing tells me what the mark by itself doesn't.

Whoever this client was, my father became more valuable to him over time, not less, not steady, *more*. The payments rise as a salary rises when the employee starts carrying a secret the employer can't afford to lose.

My father was holding something for Cassian Vale, something worth more every year, something worth killing to keep buried.

I've known it a day longer, because I read the second register while he was still reading the first.

So why didn't I tell him? Was it cruelty? Was it the translator in me, waiting for the whole sentence?

I wasn't protecting Cassian, and I wasn't being kind. I wanted to see Lucian's face when the name arrived on its own. I wanted to know whether the knowledge would break him or sharpen him. The answer is: it sharpened him, and the sharpening cut me, and I don't regret the waiting.



THERE'S A GATHERING in the east wing, though vampires this old don't throw parties. They hold receptions. The court assembles in a long room with good light and indifferent music and glasses of a red that isn't wine. They stand in clusters and talk about the things they talk about, which are power and money and who has too much of each.

I'm here because Lucian asked me to come, in the voice he uses now, with no *mine* and no command, a question with a shape: *Would you come to this? I'd like you beside me.*

Is he learning? He is.

I wear a dress I found in the west wing closet. Someone put it there — Bastien, probably, or one of the staff who's decided I'm staying. It's black and simple, the kind of thing that says *I belong here* in one language and *I dare you to tell me I don't* in the other.



CASSIAN IS across the room, talking to two Elders and a woman I don't know — warm, attentive, asking about somebody's mother. His voice carries like warm things carry, and the people around him lean in like plants.

He says something fond about Aurelian — a memory about a table at a restaurant, a waiter who called the King by a name nobody else used. The room nods, and the room *agrees*. Three centuries of a dead man. The bastard who killed him is telling the best stories about him.

I watch a woman at the back of the cluster look at the floor.

She's tall and dark-haired and court-raised, and I know her: the woman from Ondine's kitchen, the one in the corner with a cup of something that wasn't tea. Isabeau. She's been in this room all evening and she hasn't spoken once.

When Cassian says Aurelian's name, everyone looks at Cassian, and she looks at the floor.

I catch her eye, and she looks back at me steadily, without blinking, without looking away, without the small adjustment that everyone else in this room makes when they see me.

She doesn't say a word. Hell, I invented that look. I've been wearing it my whole life — the look of a person who can see what's happening in a room and has chosen not to speak.



THE ALDRIC brother finds me by the staircase.

He's not the cousin who left for Lyon — that one is still there, sitting in a room he chose not to leave. This is the brother, louder and taller, the kind of man who takes up space like a building does because nobody's ever told him to stop.

He's had three glasses of whatever they're drinking, and the third one has loosened the hinge on his big stupid mouth.

"The arrangement," he says, loud enough for six people to hear. "Still here?"

"Still here. Is that a problem for you?"

"My brother left because of you." He steps closer. "He left this city — this *family's* city — because a half-breed bartender has the King's ear and the King's bed, and nobody in this fucking house has the spine to say what that costs."

Six people are listening and pretending not to: the court version of listening harder.

Pack teaches you this early: when a man shows you his fear, you have two choices. You can step back and let him keep it, or you can name it out loud and watch him discover he's naked.

I've been stepping back my whole life, and where has it gotten me?

"You're afraid," I say.

He blinks. "What the hell did you say?"

"You're afraid." I say it like I'd say *it's raining*, mild, an observation about the weather. "Of what I represent, not of me. A woman who isn't vampire

and isn't wolf and isn't human, standing next to the King. Because if I can stand there, then the ladder you've spent three centuries climbing is just a suggestion, isn't it?"

His face changes, the look of a man who's just been undressed in public by someone he assumed couldn't read.

"Your family has been positioning for this succession since before I was born," I say. "Your brother came to this house to test whether the King's attention had a weakness, and he found one — me. And when Lucian removed him, your family lost its closest line to the Crown, and you've been sitting in this room all evening working up the courage to find out if the weakness is real."

Silence, and six people who were pretending not to listen have stopped pretending.

"It isn't," I say. "I'm not his weakness. I'm the only person in this house who can hear what you're actually saying when you open your mouth. And what you're actually saying is: *please let the hierarchy be real, because if it isn't, I've wasted three hundred years.*"

His face goes white.

He wasn't prepared for this. Who is? Nobody is prepared for a woman who hears what's under the words and says the underneath part out loud, to a room, in a sentence that sounds like courtesy and cuts like a blade under the ribs.

He opens his mouth, closes it, and opens it again.

"You—"

"Me? What about me?" I wait, and he has nothing. "I'm done," I say. "Enjoy the goddamn reception. The shrimp's shit, by the way."

I take my glass and I walk away from him, and the six people part for me. I can feel their attention on my back as plainly as a palm.



LUCIAN WATCHED. He's across the room, and he saw all of it, from the approach to the white face and the silence.

He's looking at me like he looks at Thibault, like he's seen a weapon. Is that what I am to him now?

I hold his eyes across the room, and I don't smile. I let him see exactly what I am: a woman who has spent her whole life hiding her teeth, because you only get to use them once before people learn to close their mouths around you.

I used them tonight, and the whole goddamn room heard.

He crosses to me without hurrying, and the room gets out of his way without being asked. He stops behind me, close, and his hand settles on the small of my back, low, lower than a king's hand should be in a room full of Elders.

His fingers are cold through the dress, and my whole spine lights up.

"Remind me," he says against my ear, "never to argue with you in public, ghost."

"You argue with me in private all the goddamn time. You argued with me about toast this morning."

"The toast was a disgrace. And in private I win."

"In private," I tell him, "I *let* you win."

His hand slides lower, an inch, where the room can't see it, and spreads over the top of my ass.

"Tonight," he says, so low it's only breath against my ear, "you're going to show me exactly how you let me win. On your knees, ghost, and slowly."

My thighs press together under the dress. I'm wet, soaked through my underwear, standing in a reception full of Elders with a glass in my hand and my nipples tight against the silk. He knows it, because I watch his nostrils flare as he catches it.

"Who says I'll be on my knees?" I say. "You think you get to decide that?"

"Your pulse did. Want me to repeat what else it said?"

His hand presses once, hard enough to feel it in my hips, and then it's gone, and so is he, back across the room like nothing happened, and six people are staring at the place where his hand was.



THE WOMAN WHO was looking at the floor is by the piano.

I go to her because she's the only person at this reception who didn't flinch when I named the Aldric brother's fear. Everyone else adjusted — a step back, a look away, a room deciding how afraid to be.

She didn't move an inch.

"That was well done," she says, in a voice that's formal, over-formal, the kind of courtesy with a blade in it. "We weren't properly introduced at Ondine's. If you'd be so kind?"

"Selene. And you?"

"Isabeau." She looks at Cassian across the room, still talking, still warm, still asking about someone's mother, and something goes hard in her jaw that I'd call hate in any language. "You hear things, don't you?"

"Everyone hears things. Hell, the plants hear things. Don't they? There's a fern in the west wing that knows more about this court than I do."

"Not the way you do." She turns back to me. "You hear the second version, the one underneath."

My chest goes still. Who the fuck is she? Lucian sees a beautiful problem, but this woman sees me as I see rooms, underneath the surface of them.

Her hands are at her sides, and I watch the right one without meaning to. She wears a ring on her middle finger, silver, thin, old enough that the engraving has gone smooth. She turns it deliberately, like turning a dial down.

I've seen that gesture before, in myself: the small physical ritual of a woman deciding not to say what she heard. I used to press my thumbnail into my index finger under the bar at Antoine's when a customer said something that had two meanings and I chose to serve the drink instead of the translation.

She's been doing it longer, and I can see the years of it in her shoulders, which hold a permanent quarter-turn away from whatever room she's in. She's declining the room, not hiding from it, a woman who found the exit a long time ago and stands near it out of habit.

Her mouth is set in a line that looks like tension and is actually practice.

Give me a century of never opening my mouth, and I'd be her.

"You could do it too, couldn't you?" I say.

"I can." She sets her glass down. "I choose not to."

"Why? Why the hell would you choose that?"

She looks at me for a long time, and in her eyes there's a look I recognize — the heaviness of a person who knows what a room is doing and has decided that knowing is enough.

"Because I've seen what happens when you name it out loud," she says. "Haven't you? And I've decided the naming isn't worth what it costs."

She walks away, and the piano lid is closed, and when the fuck did she close it?



I GO BACK to the west wing and shut the door and say *fuck* into a pillow. Then I say it again, louder, because once wasn't nearly enough.

Then I sit on the bed with the ledger in my lap and I look at my hands.

They're steady, and they're always steady — that's the problem. I just took a man apart in front of six witnesses and my hands are as calm as they were when I was pouring drinks on Frenchmen Street.

Why doesn't that scare me more than it does? What kind of woman takes a man apart and doesn't shake?

To a wolf, showing your teeth is a permanent decision, because once the pack has seen them, they know. No fucking take-backs. They adjust, and they close their mouths.

I showed mine tonight, holy shit, I showed them.

The room will be different tomorrow. The woman in the west wing has teeth, and the teeth are hers. Nobody in that corridor needs Lucian to walk in for her.

Did I want this? I wanted this: the sentence I was building in the corridor outside the library, when he walked in and took it from me.

I have it now, and it's mine.

And the woman by the piano — Isabeau — chose differently. She can hear the same thing I hear, and she keeps it behind her teeth. I think she's been doing it for a very long time.

I think about Cassian telling stories about a dead man he killed. How does a man do that? The fucking gall of it. I think about the room agreeing,

and about a woman looking at the floor because the floor is the only honest surface in the whole goddamn room.

His voice is still in my ear, telling me where I'll be kneeling tonight, and how slowly.

I lie back on the bed and put my hand between my legs, over the dress, and press. I'm soaked through my underwear from a sentence he said at a party. I rub myself through the cotton in slow circles until my hips are rocking and my breath is coming short. I stop right at the edge, and I take my hand away, and I lie there aching.

Not tonight. He said tonight, so it won't be tonight. It'll be when he isn't expecting it, somewhere he can't do a thing about it.

Tomorrow the council meets in the chamber behind the antechamber door.

I open the ledger to the pages I know by heart.

The name is Cassian's. The mark is Cassian's. The money is Cassian's.

Will it sound different out loud? I say it once to the empty room, to hear how it sounds before I say it to him.

"Cassian."



CHAPTER

Twenty-Five

SELENE

THE ANTECHAMBER smells like old paper and someone's cologne from a century that doesn't exist anymore.

I've been in this goddamn room three times: once on my way to Lucian's study with a question about the ledger, once because Bastien led me the wrong direction and then apologized in languages I didn't know he had, and once because Lucian was behind the door and I stood here counting my own heartbeats before I decided to knock.

I didn't knock, I walked in, and he looked up from his desk as if I'd always been there.

Today the council is meeting, and I can hear the room filling through the wall — chairs moving, the low vibration of voices that have been talking in rooms like this for longer than the city has been standing. Marguerite's voice carries. She's going on about the eastern boundary, and the way she says *boundary* has a blade in it.

Lucian is in here with me, and he's not ready yet. He's standing at the narrow table by the door with his back to me, going through the papers Bastien laid out — the agenda, the motions, whatever else a king reviews before he walks into a room full of people who want something from him.

He's in the coat, the dark one, the one that fits his shoulders like water fits a glass.

His hair is tied back, and he's moving through the papers with the unhurried precision of a man who knows nobody starts without him.

I know something he doesn't know I know.

It isn't Cassian's name. He has the name now, and it's been sitting between us like a body neither of us has buried. He knows I figured it out before he did, and he knows I waited.

What he doesn't know is what I'm about to do with it. Does he suspect? Has he looked at me this morning and seen any of what's coming?



"The Aldric motion is third on the agenda," he says without turning around. "Marguerite wants it moved to first."

"Let her have it. Who gives a shit?"

"If I let her have it, she'll read compliance as endorsement, and by sundown she'll be telling three Houses I've backed her position."

"So why not tell her no yourself?"

"I intend to." He turns a page. "I'm telling you because you'll be in the room, and when she looks at you—"

"I'll give her fuck all. What else would I give her?"

He pauses for just a beat, a sentence finding a wall it wasn't expecting.

"You've been doing that," he says.

"Doing what?"

"Finishing my sentences before I've built them." He still hasn't turned around. "You did it with the mark, with Cassian's name, and you're doing it now."

"Maybe you build them too slow. Shit, Lucian. It's like watching a cathedral go up."

Now he turns, and he's got the face from the reception: a man who has been the sharpest thing in every room for centuries, and has just noticed someone sharpening a blade in the corner.

"You're in a mood, aren't you?" he says.

"I'm in a fucking mood."

"What kind? The kind that locks doors?"

I don't answer. I walk to the door — the one that leads to the council chamber — and I turn the lock.

The sound is small, because the lock is old, heavy, a mechanism made before mechanisms were made to be discreet. It clicks, and the click fills the antechamber, and Lucian watches me do it.

"Selene."

"The council can wait."

"The council is— Selene, what the hell are you doing?"

"The council can wait." I turn away from the door and face him. "Marguerite can wait. The Aldric motion can wait. The eastern boundary, the river, whatever Bastien has in his stack of folders — all of it can wait."

He's still holding the fucking papers and he hasn't moved.

I walk toward him deliberately, like he walks, each step a sentence. His eyes track me like they track a room.

"You've been running this city for weeks," I say. "Have you stopped once? You haven't slept through a night since the poison, and your hands go still when you're holding too much, and they've been still all morning."

"I'm fine. Why does everyone keep asking?"

"You're a goddamn liar." I stop in front of him, close enough to smell the cold that lives in his skin, and God, he smells good. "Beautiful, functioning, extremely convincing. And I can hear the second register, and it says you're wound so tight that if I flicked your collarbone you'd shatter."

Pack has a word for the sound a man makes when he's carrying something too heavy to put down and too sharp to hold. English doesn't have it. English just calls it *fine*.

His jaw moves, the muscle that fires when he's deciding whether to let a thing land.

"What are you doing, ghost?" he says.

"Giving you what you need, you stubborn bastard. Somebody in this house has to." I plant my hand on his chest and push him back against the door. "Before you run this city, you're going to let me take something off you."



HE LETS ME push him, and that's what gets me. The strongest creature in the building lets a woman with warm palms push him back against a locked door. His spine meets the wood, and the papers slide out of his grip, and he lets it happen.

He's tired in a way that tired doesn't cover.

Because the name in the ledger is Cassian's and the evidence is mounting and the man who raised him is going to die in a room with good light. Lucian has been carrying that toward a council chamber every morning for a week.

I can smell it on him, colder than fear: a man who has made a decision and is living in the space before the doing of it.

I go to my knees, and his breath changes, because what he expected later is happening now.

"Selene—"

"Don't." I look up at him from the floor. "Don't say my name like that, not with a sentence about timing coming after it."

"Marguerite is right through that wall. Do you understand that?"

"And she's going to hear every sound you make." I set my hands on his thighs. "Every single one. Can you stand that?"

His pupils blow, and I watch it happen — the black eating the gold, the oldest tell in the world. A predator with a city in his grip and centuries behind his teeth. His eyes just told me everything his mouth won't.

"You think you figured out Cassian's name first?" I say. "I let you think you were catching up."

His jaw sets hard.

"I had it before you did." I slide my palms up his thighs. "I sat in the archive and read the second register of every payment and watched the pattern form. Holy shit, did it form. I had his name in my mouth before you'd even opened the third ledger."

"You—"

"I waited." My fingers find his belt. "I watched you sit with the mark, the fees, and I waited because I wanted to see your face."

“And?”

“And it sharpened you.” I open the belt. “And the sharpening cut me, and I don’t regret the waiting.”

The belt comes free, and the buckle makes a sound against the door.

“You walked into that reception thinking you were the most dangerous person in the room,” I say. “You weren’t.”



I TAKE HIM out. His cock is hard against my palm — cold the way all of him is cold, thick, heavy — and I hold it like I held the ledger the first time, with the attention of a woman who has spent her whole life reading things.

He’s watching me, his hands hanging open, not gripping the door, not reaching for my hair. They go like that when the control is costing him.

“She’s right through that wall,” I say. “The whole court’s right through that wall.”

I lick the underside of his cock from root to head, slow, flat tongue, full contact. I take my time about it because time is what I’m stealing from his schedule and I want him to feel every second of it.

His hips shift against the door, a twitch, suppressed.

“The King of New Orleans,” I say. “The strongest thing in the city, the man who makes rooms rearrange themselves when he walks into them.”

I take the head in my mouth, suck once hard, then pull off.

“On a locked door, with a bartender on her knees.”

“You’re not a bartender. You haven’t been since the club, have you?”

“I’m whatever I want to be right now.” I take him in again — deeper, past the head, my jaw opening to accommodate the width of him. His taste is salt and cold, like snowmelt off a tin roof, and I work my tongue along the vein on the underside while my fist grips the base.

He makes a sound, low, through his teeth, a man trained by centuries of rooms to never make a sound when someone might hear it.

“Louder,” I say, pulling off to say it, and my spit bridges between my lip and his cock. “The council’s waiting. Shouldn’t they hear their king?”

“You’re—” His voice is rough. “You’re enjoying this, aren’t you?”

"I'm enjoying this." I grin up at him, my fist working him while I talk, slow, twisting, slick. "I'm on my knees with nothing between your cock and Marguerite's agenda but a wall. I've never enjoyed anything more."

"That's a problem."

"For who? For you."

I take him back in, all of him, as deep as I can manage. His cock hits the back of my throat and I swallow around it. He finally moves: his hand goes to the door behind him, palm flat, fingers spread, bracing.

And I slide my own hand up under my dress.

I'm soaked, of course I am, and I've been soaked since I turned the lock. I get two fingers against my clit and I moan around his cock. He feels it, and his head knocks back against the door.

"Are you—" He looks down and sees where my fingers are. "*Selene*."

I pull off him long enough to answer. "Stay on the door."

"Let me— for God's sake, let me touch you—"

"No. You watch." I rub myself in slow circles and let him see every one. "You don't get to touch. You just get to know."

He makes a sound like I've cut him.



I DRIVE HIM slow, and that's the trick of it: the pace, more than the kneeling. He doesn't set it, and he doesn't get to set it. His hips try to push and I pull back. His hips go still, and I reward the stillness with my throat.

Every time he reaches for control, I take it away. Every time he surrenders, I make the surrender worth it. I am running the oldest negotiation in the world from the floor of an antechamber, and the terms are mine.

"You kept something from me," he says, in a register I haven't heard before — low, stripped, the voice underneath the voice. "The name. How long?"

I pull off. "Does it matter?"

"How long, Selene? A day? A week?"

"You know how long. Does it make you feel stupid?"

"You let me work for it."

"I let you earn it, you stubborn bastard." My fist doesn't stop, slow strokes, root to tip, and I can feel him getting close — the tension in his thighs, the way his cock pulses against my palm. "Like your father earned the Code, like you earn a crown. Nobody hands you the answer, Lucian. You find it or you don't deserve it."

His face breaks, not the control but the wall behind the control, the wall between the king who runs a city and the man who is standing against a door with his trousers open.

"Good," I say. "Holy shit, there he is."

I take him deep, my mouth, my throat, my fist working what my mouth can't reach. I set a rhythm — fast now, hard, deliberate — and I listen to him like he listens to rooms. Every catch of breath tells me a secret, and every bitten-off sound is a sentence in a language he's never let anyone read.

I'm reading it now, every fucking word.

He comes off the door and grabs my hair, the grip, the pull he does without thinking.

I pull his fingers out of my hair and put them back on the door. I look up at him while his cock is in my mouth and I shake my head once.

He stays on the door.

"Good boy," I say around him, and his whole body jerks.



HE COMES LIKE a dam giving, all at once, the whole structure. The sound he makes is nowhere near soft and the council is right there through the wall and I don't care.

My own orgasm hits a heartbeat behind his, from nothing but my fingers and the sound he made. I shake with it on my knees with his cock still in my mouth.

I swallow. His come is cold in my throat, salt and snowmelt, and I take all of it. I keep my mouth on him through the aftershocks until his palm on the door is shaking and his breath is the only sound in the room.

I pull off and sit back on my heels and wipe my mouth with the back of my hand.

He's against the door with his coat untouched, because I didn't take his fucking coat off, and I did it on purpose.

The King of New Orleans, fully dressed, undone by a mouth and a locked door. Holy shit, I did that.

I stand up, and his eyes follow me, blown and dark, and for once there is nothing calculated in them.

No assessment, no architecture, just a man looking at a woman who just put him on the floor without putting him on the floor.

"Your hands," I say.

He looks at them, open at his sides, loose. The tension that's been living in them all morning is gone.

"Better?" I say. "Or do I need to do it again?"

I reach behind him and unlock the door. The mechanism clicks, and I can hear the council on the other side — chairs, voices, Marguerite saying *quorum*.

"Selene."

I stop with my hand still on the lock.

"The name," he says. "You could have told me."

"I could have."

"Why didn't you?"

I look at him: the coat, the jaw, the blown eyes and the barely-fastened belt and the door behind him that leads to a room full of people who have never seen him like this.

"Because you needed to get there yourself," I say. "And because I wanted you to know I was already there when you arrived."

I smooth the front of my dress and run my tongue over my lip.

"Go run your fucking city," I say. "Can you manage that now?"

I walk through the other door — the one that leads to the corridor, the one that doesn't put me in front of the council with his taste still in my mouth. My knees ache from the stone floor and I don't give a shit.

Through the wall, I hear the council door open, and I hear Marguerite say, "You're late."

And I hear Lucian say, "Begin," in a voice that has no trace of what just happened in the room behind him.

I put my mouth to the crack of the door, where only he will hear it.
“Good boy.”

INTERLUDE IV

Cassian

THE BOY HAS stopped bringing me things.

He does not know that he has done it, and he has not decided it in a sentence. He is not yet capable of deciding to distrust me, and on the day he becomes capable of it he will be finished and so will I.

But he used to come and find me, at any hour. He would arrive with a thing in his hands and set it down in front of me and wait while I looked at it, and he has done that since he was young enough to need lifting onto the desk to do it.

This week he has come to me, and each time I asked the first question.



HE LIED TO me in his father's study, weeks ago now, and he did it badly, and I let him.

I asked what Ambroise had found. I had asked every few days since the body came up out of the cold room, and every time he had told me a little and been glad to tell it, because a man carrying a thing like that wants hands underneath it.

That evening he said: wolf bites, heavy damage, and the worst of it at the hip.

Then he put both hands flat on the desk and kept them there, which he does not do.

Why is he such a poor liar? He has never had to practice. Aurelian raised him to be direct and I trained him to be still, and between us we made a man who cannot dress a falsehood.

His voice was perfect, and his hands were too perfect, pressed to the wood so they would have nowhere to go. The woman on the window seat never once looked at me, which is how I knew she was listening.

So he has seen the wound. How long has he known? Weeks, and I missed it.

He has sat in a room with me most mornings since and asked after my house. He has let me put my hand on the back of his neck, and said nothing.

That is my boy.

That is not Aurelian's boy. Aurelian would have stood up in a full chamber on the first evening and said *one of you was in this room*, and taken whatever came, and called it honesty.

The son kept it in his pocket and went hunting.

I have never been prouder of him in my life. That is not a figure of speech and I am not going to soften it into one.



WHAT DID IT cost me, in that room?

He said *wolf bites* and looked at me, and I felt my own face arrange itself.

I did it well, and that is the whole of the cost, and I did not know it was going to be the cost until it was already done.

My eyes went where they go, and my hands stayed where they were. And something came up in my chest that was almost entirely real, because he was telling me that his father had been savaged by animals, and I have been listening to that sentence in this city since the funeral and it has not stopped working on me yet.

Then I said the things a man says. I told him he was growing into it, which is true. I told him to choose the people he can tell the truth to, and choose them soon.

I meant it. I was standing in his doorway when I said it, the one man in the city he should not choose.

Every part of that was genuine, and every part of it was in the service of the lie.

There is no longer a seam between the two, and I have been doing this for a long time without ever having to feel it as a skill.



I COULD TELL him tomorrow.

The thought arrives with its own furniture now, as a habit does. It came to me first in that doorway, and it has come every night since.

He is closer than he knows. The woman is cleverer than he is about a certain kind of thing, and she has been quiet in a way I do not like. What is she sitting on?

What if I said it first? Set it down myself, in a warm room, and let him have the whole of it out of my own mouth instead of off a page?

He would remember that I told him. Whatever he becomes, there would be a version of it in which the old man did not make him dig.

I have thought about that for longer than I thought about the blade.



AT THE NEXT full council I will ask the court for its war. The boy has been standing in front of it with his arms out, and I will walk around him, gently, as I have walked around him since he could stand.

Is there permission for that? I looked for it, and it is not there.

A man who can no longer find the seam between the genuine and the lie does not get to ask whether he is permitted.

His father is dead.

I am what he has.



CHAPTER

Twenty-Six

LUCIAN

I'M GOING TO kill the man who raised me, and tonight I'm in a bed with the only woman who knows.

Marguerite suspects, Silas has the direction, God knows how, and the council has a week. But Selene knows the name and the evidence and what I've decided, because I told her, because she's the only person in my life who can hear a sentence and tell me what it means underneath.

She hasn't said anything about it. She came into the room and sat on the bed and took her boots off. The boots made a sound on the floor I've been listening to for weeks: a woman arriving somewhere and deciding to stay.

"You're thinking, aren't you?" she says.

"I'm always thinking. Isn't that the job?"

"Not like this, for fuck's sake." She's looking at me from the other side of the bed. "You're thinking about him. You've been thinking about him since dinner, and you haven't moved."

She's right, God damn her. I've been gripping my knees for minutes with the same grip, a man keeping himself assembled by the smallest available margin.

"Come here," I say.

"No."

I look at her, and I wait for the rest.

"No," she says again. "Hell, no. Not tonight. Tonight you don't get to say *come here* and have me come." She pulls her legs up under her. "Tonight I need you to ask."

Ask? The word lands on me with the whole weight of a brick.

When did I last ask anyone for anything? I don't ask, and that isn't a boast. I'm the strongest thing in every room I walk into. The rooms are built around that, and the people in them arrange themselves accordingly. I give instructions. I say *come here* and the room adjusts.

She's telling me to do the other thing, the thing I've never fucking done.

"Selene."

"Ask me. Is that so fucking hard?"

I look at her across the bed. She's in one of my shirts and her own underwear and her hair is down. She's looking at me with her chin lifted and her eyes steady and open in a way I haven't seen before.

Is she giving me permission to need something? She is.

"Will you come here, ghost," I say.



SHE COMES. She crosses the bed on her knees and takes my face, and holds it, and looks at me like she looked at her father's ledger, reading something that matters.

"You don't have to do this alone," she says.

"I'm not alone. Am I?"

"You're not alone in the room. But in the goddamn decision?" Her thumbs are at my jaw. "You decided three days ago. You've been carrying it since, and you haven't set it down once, and your hands are locked."

She pries my grip off my knees and opens my fingers one by one, a fist that's been clenched too long.

"There," she says. "Was that so hard?"

My hands are open on the bed between us. I look at them, the hands he taught to hold a blade.

"He's going to know," I say. "When I send for him. He'll walk in and he'll know before I say a word, because he's known me since I was an after-noon old."

"Yes."

"Will he fight?"

"No."

"He's going to sit down in that chair and wait for me to say it, and then he's going to say *yes*, and that's going to be worse than a fight."

"I know."

"I've never—" I stop, because the sentence has a wall in the middle of it, and the wall is the one thing I've never said out loud in four hundred years of saying things out loud. "I've never done anything without knowing he'd be there after."

Selene doesn't say anything. She holds my fingers open and lets the sentence sit in the room.

"Even when I argued with my father," I say, "even when I was wrong about the Code and he was right and the whole house could hear us, I'd go to Cassian after. I'd find him in the courtyard and he'd pour me a drink and he wouldn't say my father was right. He'd say *your father believes what he believes*, and then he'd change the subject to a woman whose chest was bad."

"And when you do this, there's no after?"

"There's no after."

She lifts my hands and puts them on her face, my palms on her cheeks, my fingers in her hair, and she holds them there.

"Then tonight there is," she says.



SHE UNDRESSES me, and I let her, and the sentence costs more than *let* usually costs.

She unbuttons my shirt like she unbuttons everything, reading the garment.

I'm shaking, and it isn't the poison, which has been quiet for days while my body closed every wound it owes me. This is a man who has been holding everything at full tension for weeks, shaking apart because ten warm fingers on his buttons just told him to stop.

"Let go," she says.

"Of what? Tell me what, and I'll try."

"Of whatever you're holding onto." She gets the shirt off my shoulders.

"You're a fist, Lucian, and you've been a fist since the funeral. Open."

How do you open? I don't know how, and the truth of it sits in me and I'd rather it fucking wasn't there. God.

"Lie down, Lucian. For God's sake, lie down."

"Selene—"

"Lie down. For once in your life, lie down and let somebody else hold it."

She pushes me back onto the bed, gently, but *she* pushes *me*, and my body goes, because the poison took the last of the pretense that I'm immovable.

I'm on my back and she's above me, her knees on either side of my hips and her palms on my chest, looking down at me.

"You said *come here* the first time," she says. "And I came, in the club, in the hallway, in the bedroom."

"Yes."

"And every time after that, you've been the one holding it." She pulls the shirt over her head, and her tits are bare underneath, and the sight of them above me does a thing to my chest I can't name. "The pace, the position, the sounds I make, all of it yours."

"Yes."

"Not tonight." She presses down flat on my chest. "Tonight it's mine."

I can smell her arousal. Her pussy is wet against my hip where she straddles me. The heat of it against my cold skin says everything.



SHE TAKES HER time, and nothing prepares me for that. In every bed we've shared she's been fast — hungry, immediate, a woman who fucks like she's working through a problem — and I liked it. I understood it, because speed is the language of a body that doesn't trust the ground under it.

Tonight she goes slow, and it's going to kill me.

She puts her mouth on my chest and follows the line of my sternum down, and she takes a long time about it. I can feel her breath on my skin, and her mouth is warm, and her fingers are on my ribs.

"Don't move," she says.

"I'm not— for Christ's sake, I'm not moving—"

"You're about to. I can feel it." She pins my hip. "Don't."

I don't move, and it costs me a currency I didn't know I had.

"Good," she says. "See? You can learn."

She gets my trousers off, then my underwear, and looks at me for a while.

"What are you looking at?" I ask. "Is it that interesting?"

"You. Holy shit, you. No court, no council, just a man in a bed, hard for me."

"I'm not wearing a crown. Do you see a crown?"

"You're always wearing it," she says. "Take it off for me." I look at her to own her, and she looks at me as if I'm a sentence she's going to have to say in front of people.

My cock is hard against my stomach. She wraps her fingers around it and holds it — just holds it, feeling the weight, the thickness, the cold of me in her warm palm — and her fingers don't close all the way.

"You're cold here too," she says.

"Everywhere. Is that a problem?"

"Everywhere?" She strokes once, root to tip, and watches what it does to my face. "I'm going to warm you up."

She strokes me again, slower, and bends and kisses my stomach just above where her fist is working, and her hair falls across my hips.



I'VE BEEN ALIVE for four centuries, and I have had every variation of this that a body can have, and none of them were this.

She's in no hurry to make me come. She wants me to *feel* it, her fingers, and her mouth on my stomach, my ribs, the inside of my wrist, unhurried, a woman reading something twice to be sure.

Then her mouth goes lower. She licks me once from root to tip, with the flat of her tongue, and looks up at me while she does it. Her lips close over the head of my cock, warm, so warm it hurts. She sucks, gently, and lets me slide out of her mouth wet, and then she does it again, deeper, her fist working what her mouth doesn't reach.

"Selene."

"I've wanted to do this slowly since the antechamber," she says, and licks the head of me. "You were so loud in there. Can you be louder here? There's no council behind this door."

"Selene—"

"Mm." She doesn't stop. She takes me into her throat and holds me there, swallowing around me, and my hips come up off the bed on their own.

She lets me go with a wet sound and pins my hip flat again.

"I said don't move."

"You're— Christ, you're—"

"I know what I'm doing." She licks the head of my cock in slow circles, watching my face. "You're going to lie there and let me."

I reach for her hair out of habit: the fist, the grip, the habit.

She takes my fingers out of her hair and puts them on the pillow beside my head.

Then she climbs up my body and straddles my hips. Her pussy slides wet along the underside of my cock, root to tip and back. She grinds on me like that without letting me in, her clit dragging along me, her breath going ragged, slick enough that I can hear it.

"Feel that?" she says.

"Yes."

"That's you, every time you walk into a room." She rolls her hips. "Even tonight, even with all of this."

"Let me in," I say.

"Not yet. You don't get in until I say."

"Selene."

"Say it nicer. Can you do nicer, Your Majesty?"

"Let me in, ghost. Please don't make me beg for it."

"That's not begging," she says. "You'll know when you're begging."

She reaches down between us and takes my cock and fits the head of it against her, wet and hot, and she doesn't sink down.

She holds there, just the tip of me inside her, her thighs trembling with the effort of not moving.

Then she reaches up with her free hand and puts it on my throat.

Her warm fingers around my throat, where mine go around hers, and the room inverts.

"Stay," she says.

What she said in the Marchand house, and it has one version.

She sinks down an inch and stops. Her cunt is tight and slick around the head of my cock and the rest of me is aching in the cold air, and she's watching my face.

I put my hand on the pillow and I stay.

She takes me so slowly I lose track of anything else: an inch, and a breath, another inch, and her eyes closing. By the time she's seated all the way down on me I'm gripping the pillowcase hard enough to tear it, and she hasn't moved her hips once.

"Look at you," she says, soft, wrecked. "You're shaking."

"Yes."

"Say it."

"I'm shaking."

Her fingers tighten on my throat, gently. "Good."

"Do you know what you look like right now?" she says.

"Tell me. What do I look like?"

"Like nobody's ever once taken their time with you."

"Nobody has."

"All those women, and not one of them took her time?"

"I never let them."

"You're letting me."

"I'm letting you."

"Then let me hear you," she says. "Every sound. I want all of them."

Then she moves, and it builds without hurry, none of the sharp climb, the peak, the drop, just a warmth that starts in the base of my spine and spreads outward, taking its fucking time with every nerve it passes through.

She rides me in long slow rolls that take me all the way in and almost all the way out. Every time I think she's going to lose me she sinks back down. Every time she sinks back down she clenches, and every clench goes straight up my spine into the back of my skull.

Her tits sway above me with every roll, her nipples tight and dark. I want them in my mouth so badly my jaw aches. I keep my head on the pillow because she told me to. She watches me want it. She leans down until one nipple grazes my lips, and pulls back the instant I open my mouth.

"You want them?" she says.

"Yes."

"Then you'll wait." She rolls her hips. "Tell me how it feels."

"Cold, then not."

"More words, Your Majesty."

"Tight, wet, you're—" My voice breaks on it. "You're burning me alive."

"Good. Say you're mine."

"I'm yours."

"Like you mean it."

"I'm yours, Selene. I've been yours since you asked me if I was a vampire."

My cock jerks inside her, and she feels it and laughs, low, and clenches around me in answer.

Her other hand goes between her thighs, and she rubs her clit in small tight circles while she rides me, her fingers wet, her knuckles brushing my stomach on every downstroke. I watch her fuck herself on me. I watch her

pussy take my cock and give it back, slick and swollen and stretched around me. It's the most obscene thing I've ever seen, and the most tender.

She comes the first time like that, quietly, her thighs shaking around my hips, her cunt fluttering on me, her fingers still moving. She doesn't stop riding. She rides me through it and keeps going.

"That's one," she says, breathless. "You don't come until I've had two."

"Is that a rule? Since when the fuck do you make the rules?"

"My bed tonight. My rules."

I make sounds I don't recognize, low ones, broken ones. She grinds down and circles her hips with my cock buried in her, and the sounds get worse. She responds to each one by changing her rhythm, the angle, the depth, the drag of her body on mine. I understand that she's listening to me like she listens to everything.

She's translating me, isn't she?

She's hearing what my body says and finding the version underneath, the one I don't know how to say with my mouth, and she's answering it.

Her pussy tightens on every downstroke, and her thighs are wet where they grip my hips. The wet runs down onto my balls, and every slide of her is slicker than the last.

Her hand tightens on my throat, to hold, not to choke, the way I hold hers: pressure and presence, and fingers around the place where a body is most itself.

"Selene."

She leans down over me, and her hair falls around both our faces. Her eyes are dark and her mouth is wet and she's looking at me with an expression I need a new word for.

"Tell me what you want," she says. "Out loud. Can you use that mouth for something besides orders?"

"I want to come. God damn it, Selene, I want to come."

"Where?"

"In you, inside you. Selene—"

"Ask me," she says.

"Please."

It comes out of me like a thing pulled loose, a word I haven't said in a bed in four hundred years, a word I haven't said to anyone, for anything, since I was young enough to need something and admit it.

She grinds down on me hard and holds there, all of me inside her, and I come. My hips jerk up off the bed and I come so deep in her that she gasps at the cold of it.

It doesn't have a peak. It has a duration, a long slow thing that moves through me like water through a held cloth. I shake through the whole of it with my hand on the pillow where she put it and her hand on my throat where she chose to put it.

She comes again, with me, and I feel it before I hear it: her cunt pulling at me in long helpless waves, her thighs clamping my hips, her forehead dropping onto my chest. The sound she makes is small and cracked and it's my name.

She keeps me inside her until the last of it is gone, and then longer.

The sensation of being held like that, taken in and kept, is the closest I've come in four centuries to understanding what it feels like to be fed on.



AFTER, she lies on me and kisses me, slow, and I hold her with arms that are not shaking anymore.

"Good boy," she says.

She said it in the antechamber too, with the council through the wall. It lands worse now, because there's no council to hide it from. I feel it in my spine and in the back of my skull and in a place I didn't know was a place until she found it.

I laugh, and it comes out wet and stupid and completely without fucking dignity.

"Don't you dare," I say.

"Too late." She's grinning. I can feel it against my neck. "I've got two now, and I'm keeping them."

"You can't— Christ, you can't—"

"I'm keeping it. I'm going to use it at council, in front of Marguerite."

"You would not. Would you?"

"I absolutely would."

I hold her, and she lets me hold her. The room is dark and the window is cracked and the night air smells like the Quarter after rain, and soon I'm going to sit across from my uncle and say his name.

"I'm afraid," I say.

She doesn't react, doesn't stiffen or pull back or try to comfort me. She stays exactly where she is and she listens.

"Not of the act. I can do the act." I look at the ceiling. "I'm afraid of what comes after it: a house without him in it, a chair nobody sits in, a courtyard where nobody teaches anyone anything."

"Your father was afraid too, you idiot."

"How do you know?"

"Because he kept the Code." She traces my collarbone. "A man who writes a law that binds his own hands is a man who's afraid of what the hands would do without it. He didn't make the Code because he was good. He made it because he was frightened, and the fright made something better than good."

That's the sentence, the one I've been trying to find since my father died, the answer to the argument we had across a desk with a bottle between us.

The Code isn't a leash. It's a fear written down and turned into a promise.

My father was afraid of what he was. He spent his whole life being afraid of it, and the fear became a philosophy. The philosophy kept a city alive for three hundred years.

I've been afraid of the same thing, and the levee told me so: a wall giving under my hand in Barataria, and how much I fucking liked it.

The Code is the thing that says *stop*, not because stopping is natural, but because not stopping is.

"Thank you," I say.

"For what?"

"For the sentence. Do you know which one?"

She doesn't ask which one, because she knows.

We lie in the dark, and I'm not shaking. My fingers are open, and soon I'm going to close them one more time around a thing I love.

And after that I'm going to open them again, because a woman in a hallway that smelled like lemons taught me that opening is harder than holding.

She falls asleep on my chest, still slick against my hip, one thigh thrown over mine, and I don't sleep. I watch the ceiling and I count the hours and I let the night be an *after*.

She mumbles something against my chest, already mostly asleep, and it sounds a great deal like *good boy*.

Am I ever going to live this down? I am never going to live this down.



CHAPTER

Twenty-Seven

SELENE

“THREE DAYS,” Lucian said last night. “Gaspard hands him over on neutral ground. No blood.”

Three days? I’ve had four years.

That sentence is still in my head when I wake up, and it doesn’t leave.

I said yes. I looked him in the eye and I said *I’ll wait* and I meant it when I said it, and that’s the worst part, because a lie you mean when you tell it is the kind you can’t take back.

I’m already dressed, boots and jacket and the bag with the knife in it — my father’s knife, the one that was always for Rémy Thibodeaux.

A controlled handoff: diplomatic language and neutral ground and the careful machinery of two species agreeing to hand a man across a line.

To a wolf, that’s a season, plenty of time for a man to run. Rémy hasn’t run since the funeral, but that was before a vampire king started asking about him by name.

Can I wait? I can’t, and I’ve known it since he said it.



I TAKE THE car, mine, not Lucian's, the one I drove him in the first night, the one with his blood still in the upholstery because I haven't cleaned it and I'm not going to. It starts on the second try, like it always does.

I don't tell Lucian or Silas, and I don't leave a note or send a text or do any of the shit a person does when they're going somewhere they're supposed to go.

I drive south, over the bridge, into the West Bank. The city drops away behind me, a coat I took off. The Quarter is gas lamps and money and the particular silence of things that live forever, and Barataria is water and diesel and the sound of engines that have never stopped running.

My grip is different on the wheel this time, because last time the knife was in the bag like a verdict, final and certain.

The knife is in the bag again, but my grip is loose, as you hold a wheel when you're driving toward something you don't want to do.

Last time I went to Barataria to take a life from Rémy Thibodeaux.

This time I'm going to take one from myself: the version of me that came for him, the wait Lucian asked for, the controlled handoff, the version of this that doesn't end with a dead wolf on a dock and a war in my name.

I'm going to stand in front of him, and I'm going to not kill him, and that is going to be worse than anything I've ever done.

I know where he'll be, because I've known his schedule by heart since I learned it: the dock, the boat, the routine of a man who gets up before dawn and works until the light is wrong. Silas's reports confirmed what I already knew. Thursday, last light, the boat comes in, and he unloads alone.

I park on the shell road above the dock and I wait.



HE COMES IN with the tide, right on time.

The boat is small — a shrimper, white hull gone gray, the kind of thing that lives in the water instead of on it. He ties off with one hand because

his right arm doesn't work right. It hangs at his side with the patience of a thing that's been broken and healed and never been the same.

Aurelian did that. He put a wound in this man's arm that it has carried for years. The arm still works, and the man still uses it, because wolves don't stop. They just get slower.

He's bigger up close, and sunburned, and he works the rope as if he's done it since he could hold one.

He doesn't see me. Two men are with him on the dock — wolves, both of them, I can smell it from the road — helping with the catch and talking about something that makes Rémy almost laugh.

He has a life. How does the man who killed my parents get a life with ropes and bad jokes and a boat that comes in with the tide? I knew this. I saw it from the bench. But knowing it from a distance and standing in it are different languages, and I speak both.



I GET OUT of the car, and the dock goes still when I step onto it.

Wolf-quiet, the silence of a pack that's scented something wrong. The two men stop moving, and their heads come up, and their nostrils flare.

I smell like the vampire house, like Lucian's sheets and Lucian's study and the particular cold that lives in a building full of things that don't age. I've been in House Croix for weeks and it's in my skin and my hair and my clothes, and to a wolf that scent is a flag.

"You're in the wrong fucking place," one of the men says.

"I know where the hell I am."

"Then you know you shouldn't be." He steps forward, measured, the step of a man who's been taught that you don't attack what smells wrong. You identify it. "You're from the house."

"I'm from a bar on Frenchmen Street. Got a problem, asshole? Or just a shitty nose?"

"You know you smell like a vampire's bed? You think we can't tell?"

"I smell like a lot of things. Go fuck yourself."

The second man is moving, flanking wide around the edge of the dock, positioning, because if I'm a provocation, they want to know what kind before they respond.

And then Rémy sees me.

He's at the bow of the boat with a line in his good hand and his face changes as a sky changes, across the whole of it, from the jaw to the eyes.

Does he know who I am? He knows.

He knows what I am, anyway: the daughter, the one who survived, the one who's been standing at the edge of this water for years. He's known it, and he's been waiting for it like a man on a dock waits for weather.

"Stop," he says, to his men, not to me.

"She's from the house—"

"I know where she's from." He ties the line off one-handed, without looking at it. "She's from a kitchen table where a man used to translate contracts, and she's Daniel Ward's daughter, and you're going to step away from her."

The men don't move a goddamn muscle.

"Step away from her," Rémy says. "Now."

They step, because his voice changed, and a wolf's voice changing is its own kind of command.

He looks at me across the dock: weathered wood and salt air and everything he did.

"You came alone?" he says.

"Yes."

"The king knows? Does he know where you are right now?"

"No."

His jaw sets, and he's weighing the same odds I should have weighed before I got in the car.

A woman from the vampire king's house, in Barataria, alone, at night, without permission. What the fuck was I thinking?

"Do you have any idea," he says, "what this looks like?"

"I know what the hell this looks like. Do you think I'm stupid?"

"It looks like a provocation. It looks like Lucian Croix sent a woman into Barataria to start something, and every wolf between here and the bridge is going to hear about it inside the hour."

"Lucian didn't send me. Nobody sent me, goddamn it."

"Then *you* are the provocation, and that's worse." He comes off the boat. His boots hit the dock and the sound of it is heavy and real and I can smell him now — wolf, salt, diesel, and underneath all of it a smell I know from my own skin: guilt. Guilt has a scent, and it smells like a house the morning after.

"You promised him you'd wait," Rémy says.

I go cold. "How do you know that?"

"Because Gaspard told me. He told me the king would send for me, and he told me the woman would wait." He's close now, close enough that I can see lines in his face that weren't there the night he came to our house. "I've been sitting on this dock knowing you'd come, because I've met one other person who carried something for that long, and she didn't wait either."

"Your mother?"

"Mine, yeah."

The silence on the dock is the kind you can hear blood in.



ONE OF THE wolves moves, the flanking one, the one who went wide. He's behind me now, between me and the road, and his posture has changed from identification to decision.

"She's a truce violation," he says. "The king's woman, in Barataria, unescorted. Doesn't the Alpha need to hear about this?"

"The Alpha is going to hear about it from me," Rémy says, "not from you, and not tonight."

"Rémy— are you fucking serious?"

"I said not tonight."

The man looks at Rémy, and Rémy looks at the man. Something passes between them that I can read in wolf but couldn't translate into English if I had an hour — the full weight of a man's son telling a man's soldier to stand down, and the soldier deciding whether the son has earned it.

The soldier stands down, and he hates it.

Rémy turns back to me. "Go home," he says.

"I'm not— who the fuck are you to send me home?"

"Go home, Selene."

He knows my name. When did he learn it, and from whom? The sound of it in his mouth makes my stomach turn over, because the last man who said my name with that particular weight was my father.

"You killed them," I say.

"Yes."

"You killed my mother and my father and you're standing on a dock telling me to go home? Are you out of your goddamn mind?"

"Yes." He doesn't move, doesn't step back. "And I'm standing between you and two wolves who want to take you to Gaspard as a truce violation, and if Gaspard gets you, the diplomatic version dies tonight, and the king starts a war to get you back, and Cassian gets what he's been building toward for decades."

The name, Cassian's name, in his mouth. Jesus Christ.

"You know?" I say.

"I know who told me to kill your father. I know why. I've known the whole time, and I've been carrying it like you've been carrying that knife."

My hand is on the bag, and I haven't opened it. The knife is inside, under the flap, and my fingers are on the zipper. I can feel the weight of it like a third person on this dock.

"Go home," he says again. "Come back with your king, and let this happen the way it's supposed to happen."

"The way it's supposed to happen is you dead on this dock."

"Maybe." He looks at the knife, through the bag, like the canvas isn't there. "But not tonight. Tonight you're in my territory, and my men have your scent, and the Alpha is going to know by morning. And if you kill me here, right now, it isn't revenge. It's murder. It's a woman from the king's house killing a wolf on wolf ground, and that's the war Cassian has been engineering since before you were born."

I can't fucking breathe.

He's right, and I can hear both versions of it. The English version is logic, and the wolf version is simpler: *You owe me now. I'm standing between you and a war, and you owe me for it, and you can't kill a man you owe.*

I came to Barataria to take something from him. He gave me my life instead, and I can't afford what that goddamn costs.



DELPHINE COMES out of the dark from behind the truck, where she's been, I think, since before I stepped onto the dock, watching, like she watched me at the gas station.

She doesn't interfere. She stands at the edge of the light with her arms crossed and her face steady. She looks at me like I looked at Isabeau, a woman who sees exactly what's happening and has decided not to speak.

Then she speaks. "He told you what he was told," she says, to me, not to Rémy. "Ask him who told him. Ask him that, and then go home."

Rémy's face goes still.

"Who told you?" I say.

"Don't you know who told me?"

"Say it. Say the name, damn you."

"Cassian Vale." He sets the name down like something heavy. "Cassian Vale told me your father was a vampire informant, that he had a report that would get Gaspard assassinated, and that the report had to be stopped before it reached the court." He looks at the water. "I was twenty-seven, and I believed him. I believed him because he knew things about the pack that no vampire should know, and he spoke to me like a man speaks to someone he respects, and he asked about my mother's house."

He asked about my mother's house.

The sentence goes straight through me. Cassian, the warmth, how he asks about your family because he means it, and the meaning is the weapon.

"I'm not asking for forgiveness," Rémy says. "I don't have the right. I killed your parents and I knew what I was doing and I was wrong, and there isn't a version of that sentence that makes it smaller."

I look at him, and at the dock and the boat and the water and the wolves and Delphine standing in the dark with her arms crossed.

I take my hand off the bag.

He saved my life on this dock tonight, and the man I came to kill is the man I owe. There is no word for that in either language.

I walk back to the car without running or looking at him. I put one foot on the shell road after the other and I get in and I start the engine and I drive north.

Behind me, in the mirror, Delphine walks Rémy to the edge of the dock. Is she the only one who knew I'd come? She's the only one who stayed.



I DRIVE HOME, and *home* is wrong. I drive to the house where a vampire king is waiting for me to come back from a place I promised not to go.

The bridge, the city, the Quarter, the gate.

Silas is at the door, and he looks at me and he knows, maybe not where I went, but that I went somewhere I shouldn't have. He reads it like he reads ground.

"He's in the study," Silas says.

I go to the study. Lucian is at the desk with the lamp on, and he looks up when I come in. His face does a thing I haven't seen before: recognition, a man who told a woman to wait and knew she wouldn't.

"You went, ghost," he says.

"I went."

"Alone?"

"Alone. Who else would I have taken?"

"To Barataria. Into pack territory. Without telling me, without telling Silas, and without the diplomatic cover that was days from being ready."

"Yes."

He stands and comes around the desk, moving as he does when the control is costing him, slowly, each step a decision instead of a habit.

"They have your scent now," he says. "Every wolf on that dock knows who you are, and that you came from this house, and that you came alone."

"I know."

"If Gaspard reads this as a provocation— do you understand what I'd have to do?"

"He won't." I swallow. "Rémy stopped it. He stood between me and his men and he sent me home."

Something happens in Lucian's face. The cold goes out of it and something worse comes in: the hurt of a man who trusted someone with a promise and watched them break it.

"You promised me," he says. "Didn't you?"

"I know."

"You looked me in the eye and you said *I'll wait*. Christ, Selene."

"I know."

"And you went anyway."

"Yes." I don't look away. "Because I've waited my whole adult life and three more days was too long and I was wrong. I was wrong and Rémy saved me from the consequences of being wrong, and my parents' killer just saved my life, and I don't know what the hell to do with any of it."

The desk is between us and the lamp makes his face half gold and half dark, and his hands are very still.

"Don't do it again, ghost," he says. "Do you hear me? Don't you ever fucking do that again."

"I won't. I swear to God I won't."

"You will." His mouth doesn't quite smile. "But not tonight."

The study is still, and the chair behind him is turned to face the desk — I only notice it now. He turned it. Who is he getting ready for?

I sit in the guest chair and I put the bag on the floor and I close my eyes.

The knife is still in the bag. The knife was always for Rémy Thibodeaux, and tonight I stood on a dock with my hand on the zipper and a man who killed my parents stepped between me and a war.

I don't have a word for what I owe him.

He comes around the desk and pulls me up out of the chair by the front of my jacket. The bag falls off my knee and the knife inside it thumps on the floor. He kisses me hard enough to split my lip on my own teeth. I taste blood, and so does he. He makes a sound against my mouth that I feel in

my knees. His hand closes on my throat, not squeezing, just there, just proving I'm still under it.

"I listened to your pulse from across a river tonight," he says against my mouth. "Don't you ever make me do that again."

My thighs are shaking, and I'm wet, and furious about it, and I don't let go of his shirt.

"You're angry," I say against his mouth.

"I'm fucking terrified, ghost. Angry is just the part you can see." His tongue drags over my split lip, tasting it, and his thigh pushes between mine, and I grind down on it without deciding to, soaked through my jeans. "Feel that? That's what an hour of not knowing does to me."

"Then stop not knowing."

"I intend to. All night."

"Bed," he says. "Before I decide the dock deserves a punishment."

I open one eye. "Is that a threat, Your Majesty?"

"It's a menu."



CHAPTER

Twenty-Eight

SELENE

ALL THIS TIME, and he's standing still.

Why did nobody warn me about this part? Nobody fucking warned me. I built everything out of him moving — out of a man I'd have to run down, corner, catch out. In the version I've been carrying since the funeral he is always going away from me and I am always nearly fast enough.

He's in the net shed at the end of his own dock with his back to the door, sorting line into a crate.

He's going nowhere. He's doing Tuesday.

What do you do with a man who isn't running?

I've been at the treeline long enough for the cold to come up through my shoes. The knife has been in my fist so long it's stopped being a decision.

The handoff never happened, because Gaspard called it off the morning after the dock. The King's woman had walked into his territory alone at night, and in pack that voids an arrangement made in good faith, and Lucian didn't argue with him. So there's no neutral ground and no three days, only this shed.

Five nights ago I stood on this dock with the knife zipped in my bag and this man stepped between me and a war. Two wolves had my scent and a flanking position and the diplomatic version of this was about to die in the salt air. Rémy Thibodeaux — the man I've been sharpening a blade for — put himself between me and the consequence.

I owe him my *life*, and the sentence sits in me like a bone crossways.

Could I have done it from behind? Easily, and nobody would ever have known I had the choice.

I walk in through the front of the shed instead, and I say his name.

"Rémy Thibodeaux."

He doesn't jump. He turns around slowly, as a big man turns in a small room. He looks at the knife first and my face second.

Then his face shifts into nothing I've ever seen on a man facing a knife: recognition, and not of me.

"You're Marisol's girl," he says.

Girl, the way he says it, means accounted for, inside a house, under somebody's arm. He has just put me in a family in front of my mother's name and he doesn't know he did it.

My throat closes so fast I have to breathe around it. Fuck you, I think, fuck you for saying her name like that.

"Don't," I tell him. "Don't say her name. Don't you dare."

"All right."

"Do you hear me? You don't get her fucking name."

"All right." He sets the line down on the crate, careful about it. "What do you want me to call you?"

"Selene."

"Selene." He nods once. "Okay. Is that what your father called you?"

"Don't you ask me about my father."

He isn't reaching for anything. His hands are open and down and he isn't putting the crate between us. He could, because the shed is full of things a man could put between himself and a knife.

He's making it easy to get to him, and that's what I'm looking at. Is he brave, or is he just finished?

"Lift your goddamn shirt," I say.

"I'm not armed. Would I be standing here like this if I was?"

"Lift the fucking shirt."

He lifts it, slowly, like a man who's been searched before.

Nothing at his waist, nothing at his back. Sunburn to the collarbone and a gut going soft and a long puckered seam up his right side that ends where his shoulder sits wrong.

What did that? A vampire, and not just any vampire.

The King did it, years back, when Rémy was young and went across a line he'd been told about more than once. Every wolf on this water tells that story the same way: *A scar he earned*.

In wolf, *earned* isn't praise. It's a receipt.

And the story always stops in the same place, before the part where the strongest thing in this city had the Alpha's son by the arm, armed, on vampire ground, and broke it, and sent him home walking.

He lets the shirt fall and waits.

"You know what I'm here for?" I say. "Do you?"

"Yeah."

"Say it, you son of a bitch."

"You're here for your mother and your father," he says flatly, and flat is different from gentle, and better. "And you're here for me."

"Say what you did. Say it, goddamn it. Can you even say it?"



HERE'S WHAT I had planned: I had him denying it. I've had answers for that, in both languages, for years.

I did not plan for this. Jesus Christ, I did not plan for this.

"I did it," he says.

The shed is very still, and outside, water moves under the dock like it does all night, whether anyone's listening or not.

"I came up to their house on a Thursday," he says. "Your mother was on the porch, and she said my name, my whole name, like she did with everybody. Then she looked at my hands."

"Stop."

"Didn't you tell me to say it?"

Did I? I did tell him that, didn't I?

"Go on," I say, and my voice comes out someone else's.

"I did her first because she was between me and the door." A pause, the only time he looks away. "Your father came out. He didn't run, and I've thought about that a lot. He could have gone through the back and he came out the front instead."

"Because she was there? Is that why?"

"Yeah."

"Say the rest. All of it. Every fucking piece."

"There isn't any rest, God help me. I did it with my hands and I did it fast and then I went home and I was sick in my own yard." He looks up. "That's all of it. There's no part you don't already know."

I have imagined this conversation, in my head in both languages, hundreds of times, and in every single version he lies to me.

What do you do with a man who doesn't?



"Cassian Vale," I say.

Rémy's face changes. He said the name on the dock and it came out of him heavy, a crate being set down.

"You told me on the dock," I say. "You said his name and I already had it. I've had it for weeks."

"Then you know? All of it?"

"I know he told you my father was informing. I know he said it like a kindness, and I know he asked about your mother before he handed you the debt." My grip is steady on the knife. "What I don't have is the rest, the part you haven't said out loud."

Rémy's jaw works while he weighs how much it costs to put it into sentences a second time.

"He knew things about the pack no vampire should have known," Rémy says. "Routes, names, which houses had young in them. He spoke to me the way a man speaks to someone he respects, and he was sad, and the sadness was real."

"I know the sadness is real. That's the hell of it."

"Yeah." He rubs his bad shoulder. "That's the worst part."

"He asked about your mother's chest?"

"The damp, whether it was getting into her chest." He shifts, tired and old. "He asked before he told me anything, as though the telling cost him, as though he was a man doing me a kindness he'd get in trouble for."

Pack has a word for a warning you owe somebody: the telling costs the teller, so the hearing costs the hearer, and you're bound the moment it's said.

English makes it a favor, and wolf makes it a chain.

And now I'm standing in his shed with a knife, carrying a debt of my own — the dock, the wolves, his body between me and a war — and the debts don't cancel. They just pile.

"He was an instrument," I say, to nobody. "Somebody else's."

"I was twenty-seven," he says, as a fact that stopped being an excuse a long time ago. "I believed him, and I killed your parents because I believed him."



"Go ahead," he says, and I've been standing here long enough that my arm aches.

"What?"

"Go ahead." He turns his front to me and lets his hands drop, just down. "I'm not going to fight you and I'm not going to ask you not to. My sister's up at the house. If you could do it in here, I'd take that as a kindness."

"Don't you fucking dare ask me for a kindness. Not you. Not in this shed."

"Okay."

"Don't you *dare*—"

"Okay," he says quietly. "I won't ask."

And he waits, and I can't get past that. He waits, with his hands down, on a Tuesday, in a shed that smells like tar and rope, and he isn't performing any of it. There's no shine on him. He isn't holy about it and he isn't begging and he hasn't once said he's sorry.

I notice it as I'd notice a word missing from a sentence. He hasn't apologized. He hasn't fucking apologized. Why not?

"You haven't said you're sorry," I say.

"No."

"Why the fuck not? Isn't that what people do?"

"Because it'd be for me." He looks straight at me when he says it. "It'd make it lighter for me and it wouldn't do one thing for you. You'd have to stand there and decide what to do with it. That's more work for you, and you've already come all this way."

A muscle behind my ribs unclenches that I didn't know was holding.

I hate him. I hate him with the only part of me that has ever been organized. I hate the son of a bitch.

But he weighed his own apology and worked out it was for him, and then he put it down.

There are people in that vampire's court who couldn't get there with a century to think about it.



THE DOOR BEHIND me moves, and Delphine is in the doorway with the dark behind her, in the same jacket, too big for her.

She stops and she looks at the knife and she looks at her brother standing there, unarmed. She understands the whole shed in about a second.

She's already said her piece. On the dock she told me to ask him who sent him. I asked, and he told me. The name is Cassian's and the name has been sitting in me since.

She doesn't speak. She stands in the doorway of the shed and she crosses her arms and she watches.

She's choosing. She chose between her brother and me on the dock. This time she's choosing to witness, to stand in a doorway and watch whatever this costs and not look away from the price.

Rémy sees her. "Del," he says. "Go up to the house. Please? This isn't yours to carry."

She shakes her head, once.

"Delphine—"

"I'm staying, Rémy." Her voice is steady and clear, and her eyes are on me, not him. "Finish it or don't. I'm not leaving."



I LOOK AT Rémy. He killed them. He's not sorry, and he'd do it again with the same information. The information was handed to him by somebody who asked about his mother's chest first.

Goddamn it, I came here for a *monster*.

What's standing in front of me? An instrument, somebody else's, used, and then put down, and left out in the weather to think about it.

If I open his throat right now, does the one who sent him ever get touched?

And the dock. Five nights ago this man stood between me and two wolves with pack authority and a truce violation in their teeth, and he sent me home alive. He did it without asking for anything, and he did it knowing I'd come back with the knife.

I can't kill a man I owe.

That's the oldest law in both languages — a debt unpaid makes the killing murder, not justice.

All this time I've been translating everybody else's sentences, and I never once checked the one I was living in.

"Look at me," I say.

He does, and he doesn't blink.

"You're not finished," I tell him. "Do you understand that? This isn't mercy and I haven't forgiven you and I'm never going to. You don't get to be at peace about this."

"Okay."

"I'm going to need you again, when the name is said and the court has to look at it: a wolf who can say he was sent."

He takes that in slowly, and then he nods. There's nothing like relief in his face, which is the only reason I don't change my mind.

"Yeah," he says. "All right."

I lower the knife, and my arm shakes on the way down.

Delphine is in the doorway, and she hasn't moved. She watched the whole thing and she didn't close her eyes and she didn't leave.

She looks at me, and I look at her: two women who have just watched a man be held accountable and have chosen, separately, to let him live.

I walk past her and she steps aside without flinching, making room.

At the treeline she's behind me, and I can feel her like I feel wolves when they're close enough to read.

"He'll testify," she says quietly. "I'll make sure."

I don't turn around. I get in the car and I drive north.



THE HOUSE IS still when I come in through the kitchen door.

It's the wrong quiet, the quiet of a house where the one person still awake has been awake for a long time.

Silas is in the hall. He looks at the bag over my shoulder — the knife is back inside it, the blade clean — and he doesn't ask.

"Study," he says. "He's been there since you left. Pacing."

"He knew I went? How the fuck did he know?"

"He knew before you turned the engine." A beat. "I told him."

Of course Silas told him, because Silas has been watching exits since before I moved in.

I go to the study. Lucian is at the window with his back to me, his hands hanging empty, and the moonlight puts his profile in silver. He's standing like he's been waiting for something and doesn't know which version of it is about to walk through his door.

"Alive," I say. "Both of us, God help me."

"I know." He doesn't turn. "Silas called. Did you think he wouldn't?"

"Did Silas tell you Rémy's alive too? Did he tell you I let him live?"

"I know that too."

I drop the bag on the desk, and the knife makes a sound against the wood — dull, final, the sound of a thing being set down that isn't going to be picked up again.

"He told me how he killed them," I say. "My mother was on the porch, and he did her first. My father came out the front."

Lucian turns, and his face is the face I've been learning for weeks — the controlled one, the composed one, the king's face. But underneath it, in the jaw, in the line beside his mouth, there's fear.

He's been sitting in this room knowing I was in a shed with a knife. The not-knowing ate him, and he let it eat him instead of following me. How long has he been standing there? Did he think I wouldn't come back?

"I couldn't do it," I say. "Not because I've forgiven him. Because I owe him."

"The dock?"

"The dock." I swallow. "He saved my life and I can't kill a man I owe. And the knife was in my hand and my parents were dead and the man who did it was standing there with his hands down saying *go ahead*, and I couldn't."

My voice breaks on the last word. How long have I been holding it together? Since the shed.

Through the treeline and the car and the bridge and the gate and the hallway, it held because I held it, and now I'm standing in a study with a man who has his own fractures and I can't hold it anymore.

"Can you make me stop thinking?" I say. "Can you? I need you to."

He looks at me, and waits for the rest.

"I don't want to talk about the shed. I don't want to talk about the dock or the knife or the debt. I don't want to translate anything." I'm shaking, and I can feel it in my fingers and my jaw and the back of my knees. "I need you to make it quiet."

He crosses the room fast, none of the measured steps of a king managing his own danger, a man who heard a request and understood it completely.

He takes my face. His palms are cold and the cold is the best thing I've felt all night.

"The window," I say.



HE PUTS ME against the glass.

My face turned to the city, his body behind me, the window cold against my forehead and my palms. The city is out there, lit up and indifferent, and I don't want to see it. I want to see nothing. I want the inside of my skull to go fucking dark.

He pulls my dress up from behind, no preamble, no negotiation.

"Tell me what you want," he says.

"Make it quiet. Make me stop thinking."

"Then stop, goddamn it. I'll do the thinking tonight."

He heard what I asked for and the asking was the consent, and his grip on my hips is not gentle. Good.

"Harder," I say. "Fuck. Harder." He hasn't even touched me yet. I'm asking for the intensity before the act because the act isn't the point. The silence is the point, the absence of my own head.

He reaches around and cups my throat, holding, the same pressure I put on his throat in his bed, handed back to me now, and something in my chest cracks.

"Stay," he says.

His word now, because I gave it to him, and it sounds the same in both languages.

"You say stop, it stops," he says against my ear. "Even tonight."

"I know. Don't make me talk."

He hooks my underwear aside and drags two fingers through me, back to front, slow, and they come away slick. I've been wet since the moment he crossed the room, because my body has been running on adrenaline for hours. The adrenaline has to go somewhere, and it's going here.

"Soaked," he says. "You walked in here soaked, ghost."

"Shut up."

"No." He spreads me open with those two fingers and holds me like that, bare to the cool air of the study, and doesn't touch my clit. "You asked me to take your head away. Then I'm taking all of it."

He drops to his knees behind me. I feel his breath first, cool on the backs of my thighs, then his palms on my ass, spreading me, and then his tongue, one long flat drag from my clit all the way up that makes my forehead knock against the glass.

“Oh, fuck. Lucian—”

“Palms on the glass. Hold still.”

He does it again, slower. He eats me from behind with the same total attention he gives everything he’s decided on, his mouth open on my pussy and his tongue pushing inside me, then sliding back down to circle my clit, his thumbs keeping me spread for it. My knees buckle, and he catches my hips and pins them to the window and keeps going.

“Tell me what you need,” he says against me.

“Don’t stop. Don’t talk. Don’t—”

“I’ll talk,” he says. “You’ll listen. You’re dripping down my chin, and I’m not getting up off my knees until you’ve come on my tongue. That’s the only thing happening in this city right now. Understand?”

“Yes. Fuck. Yes.”

I make a sound against the glass, lower than a moan, rougher, a body emptying itself of everything it’s been carrying. My breath fogs the window, and the city goes soft behind it.

He sucks my clit into his mouth and pushes two fingers into me, crooked, dragging against the front wall. The first orgasm comes up so fast I don’t get a warning. It punches out of me. My thighs clamp on his head and my palms squeak down the glass. I come on his tongue with my cheek against the window and his name in my mouth.

He doesn’t stop until I’m shaking. Then he stands, and his cock is out, and I never heard the belt.

“There,” he says, his mouth at my ear again. “That’s one. Now let it go. I want every sound you’ve got, and nobody in this house is listening but me.”

He lines up behind me and pushes in, one stroke, full, and the stretch makes my teeth lock. I’m swollen from his mouth and he’s thick and cold and there is so much of him, and the city blurs.

He doesn’t start slow. He starts at the pace I asked for — hard, even, each thrust a sentence that says the same thing: *stop thinking*. His grip tightens on my throat, and his hips pin me to the glass. My tits are crushed against it through my dress, my nipples dragging on the cold with every

stroke. The sound of him driving into me is wet and loud in the empty study.

"Tell me it's hard enough," he says.

"Harder. Fuck, harder."

"You know you'll be sore tomorrow?"

"Good. I want to feel it on the stairs."

I can see our reflection: his face above my shoulder, concentrated, stripped of everything except the act. My face turned half away, eyes shut, mouth open.

I don't look like a woman being fucked. I look like a woman being emptied. Is this what I asked for? Is this what I meant?

"Rémy's alive," I say, and I don't know why I say it. It falls out of me on a thrust, a fact escaping a body that can't hold its own contents.

"I know."

"My parents are dead."

"I know."

"The man who—" A thrust takes the rest of the sentence. I gasp against the glass. "The man who ordered it is in a house in the Quarter asking about someone's chest."

His rhythm doesn't change, and his grip at my throat doesn't tighten. He fucks me through the sentence as you'd hold someone through a fever, without stopping, without pretending the sickness isn't there.

"Keep talking," he says. "Say all of it. I'll fuck you through every word."

"I lowered the knife," I say.

"I know."

"Not because I'm good."

"I know." His lips at my ear. "You're not good. You're better than good."

The sound I make is not a word. My pussy clenches on him, hard, and he groans into my hair and fucks me through that too.



HE STOPS, buried in me, still. He lets go of my throat and takes my jaw, and he turns my face toward the glass.

"Open your eyes," he says.

"No."

"Open them."

"I don't want to *see*—"

"I know." His voice is low against my ear. "Look anyway, my witness. Look at who lowered the knife."

I open my eyes.

She's there in the glass, over the city: a woman with her dress rucked up to her waist and a vampire buried in her from behind, flushed, wrecked, wet-faced, alive.

She looks like somebody who did a hard thing today.

"There she is," he says.

"Her? She's a fucking mess. Look at her. She's a shitshow."

"She's magnificent. Look at her take me."

He reaches around and yanks the front of my dress down. My tits spill out over the neckline, and in the glass I watch his palm close over one of them. He rolls my nipple between two cold fingers until I'm grinding back onto his cock to make him move.

"Watch," he says. "Don't close them again."

"What if I can't?"

"Then I stop, and you don't want me to stop."

"No."

"Then watch."

Then he moves, slower now. He pulls almost all the way out and pushes back in, long and deep, and makes me watch it happen in the reflection, every stroke: my mouth falling open, my eyes going heavy, my thighs wet to the knees and shaking. His cock in the glass, slick with me every time he draws back, and I can't stop watching it disappear into me.

"This is mine," he says, and his fingers slide down my belly and settle on my clit. "Your pussy, your mouth, this face in the glass. Nobody else gets it, and nobody else has ever had it like this. Say it."

"Yours."

One word, and it goes off in me like a struck match.

"You lowered the knife," he says, rubbing slow circles on my clit in time with his cock. "And that was harder than using it."

My eyes are wet, and I don't look away from them.

He moves to my hair and holds me by it, not pulling, cradling, a man who has learned the difference. He fucks me slow against the window with the city behind the glass. His fingers work my clit, and I watch every second of it. I watch my own hips start to push back on him. I watch myself spread my feet wider on the floorboards to take him deeper. I watch my mouth say *please* without any sound coming out.

"Look at you taking me," he says. "Every inch. You're shaking, and you're still pushing back for more, aren't you?"

"Can I have more?"

"Ask me properly."

"Please. Lucian. *More*."

He gives me more, and then he asks.

"Is that enough? Or do you want more?"

"It's not. God. Don't stop."

"Not yet," he says, when I start to shake. "Not like this."

He pulls out of me, and I make a sound of pure protest, and he turns me around and lifts me.

He just lifts me, my back to the cold glass, his palms under my thighs. My legs go around his waist and my arms go around his neck. He fits the head of his cock back against me and lets me sink down onto him with my whole weight.

The angle is so much deeper I lose my breath. He's in me to the root and it aches, sore and full, and I want more of the ache.

"Feel that?" he says. "That's how deep you let me."

"Nobody's ever—"

"I know. Nobody ever will."

Now I can see his face instead of mine. He's looking at me as if I'm the only lit window in the city.

He fucks up into me, short, deep strokes, my back sliding on the fogged glass, his fingers digging into my ass to haul me down onto every thrust. My clit grinds against the base of him each time he bottoms out, and my tits bounce against his chest. I can't breathe right and I don't try. His

mouth finds my throat and he licks the pulse there. I feel the points of his teeth, and my hips jerk on his cock like he's already bitten.

"Lucian—"

"I've got you. Hold on to me. Whatever tonight cost you, you put it on me, because I can carry it."

"I'm close. I'm—"

"Come for me," he says, a mercy, more than a command.

I come, and it goes on and on, a long wave that takes the shed with it and the dock and the knife and the look on Rémy's face when he put his hands down. It takes all of it. My pussy clenches on his cock in hard pulls and I shake through the whole thing with my back on the glass and my legs locked around him and his mouth saying words I can't hear over my own blood.

He follows, three more strokes, hard enough to thump the window in its frame. He comes buried as deep as he can get. I feel him pulse inside me, cold and then not. His forehead drops to my shoulder and his breath comes hard against my skin.

We stay against the window, the glass fogged where my back has been, the city a smear of lights behind the fog.

He lets me down, slow, careful, and my legs don't work. He holds me up by the hips until they do.

His face is the face underneath the face — no control, no architecture. A man looking at a woman who just came apart and trusting her to see him without the machinery on.

"Better, ghost?" he says.

"Quiet," I say. "Holy shit. It's quiet. How did you do that?"

He puts his forehead against mine, and we stand there. The window holds my weight and he holds my hips and somewhere below the study a city is running on an engine that doesn't know what just happened in this room.

"Tomorrow," he says.

A heading, not a question, because everything else starts again when the sun comes up.

"Tomorrow," I say.

“Tonight you sleep in my bed,” he says. “Not the west wing. Mine.”
It isn’t a question, so I don’t answer it.
I just go.



CHAPTER

Twenty-Nine

LUCIAN

“FULL HOUSE,” Cassian says at my shoulder.

I have a name and no fucking proof and a court that wants blood.

The chamber is full for the first time since my father’s funeral. Every House with a seat has sent a body to sit in it, and some of them have sent bodies that haven’t been seen in this room in decades. Marguerite is counting heads, and I watch her do it and I watch the number please her.

War fills rooms. My father said that once and I didn’t write it down because I thought I’d remember the rest of the sentence, and I didn’t, and I remember only the fact.

Cassian is standing where he always stands — to my left, one step behind, close enough to speak without the room hearing it. He’s been there since I was a child, and the position was never assigned. He chose it.

“Marguerite’s doing,” I tell him. “Isn’t it? She’s been counting heads since she woke up. I could hear her counting from the stairs.”

“Marguerite’s doing would have been half this. The rest came on their own.” His voice is warm, as it always is. “They want to see you decide.”

They want to see me commit. There's a difference, and Cassian knows it, and the warmth in his voice is doing the work of making me forget he knows it.

I don't forget, not anymore.



THE MOTION is simple, and Cassian wrote it, and it reads like statute and sounds like a eulogy.

War against the Thibodeaux line, full mobilization of the Houses, territorial enforcement at the river, and reprisal authority delegated to House commanders, so Marguerite gets the leash she's been pulling against since the funeral.

It's clean and proportional and exactly what the court wants and exactly what a guilty man would build if he needed the court looking outward instead of inward.

I read it and I say nothing, because it's a masterpiece.

"The motion carries a sunset," Cassian says, "ninety days, renewable by vote."

"Generous, isn't it? Ninety days of war, renewable?"

"Practical, boy. A court that votes for war without a limit votes for something else entirely." He looks at me. "Your father taught me that."

Did he? Or did Cassian teach himself and put my father's name on it afterward?

"The council will hear speakers," I say.

Marguerite stands first. Her argument is brief and contains no sentence longer than the one before it, and she is very good at this.

Then Alençon, who runs the docks and wants them defended, and then Brodeur, who hasn't spoken in this chamber since the last succession and stands up to say one sentence about a nephew who died in the raid, and sits down.

Cassian watches each of them with the expression of a man witnessing a process he respects, and it's convincing. It was always fucking convincing.



SELENE IS AT the back of the room, and she's not supposed to be here. I told her the west wing. She heard me say it and she came here instead, because she has decided that she will be in whatever room I'm in when it matters. She is correct, and I don't have the time to be angry about it.

She's standing against the wall near the door, dressed for court in one good thing worn like a dare, with her arms at her sides and her chin up.

Nobody is looking at her, because everybody has already looked at her.

Laurent Desrosiers sees me notice.

Laurent is Marguerite's second cousin, and he has held a minor seat since before the last war and has never once said anything worth the air it displaced. He is standing near the third column, closest to the door. He has been watching Selene since she walked in.

He turns to the man beside him and says something.

I hear it. The room is loud and he pitched it under the noise and I hear it anyway, because I have my father's ears and the room is mine.

"The hybrid."

A description, and not an inaccurate one, and the man beside him laughs.

Did Marguerite send him? Or did Laurent convince himself this was his own idea, and arrive at it like small men arrive at courage, slowly, with someone else's hand on his back?



THE SPEAKERS continue, and I give them the room because the room is what the Code requires. Everyone speaks who wants to speak, and nobody is told to sit down, and if my jaw tightens for a reason that has nothing to do with hunger, the chamber doesn't need to know about it.

Then Laurent stands, and he's not on the speaker list. He rises from his seat without being recognized, a small breach, the kind Marguerite commits and gets away with because she's Marguerite, and which Laurent is committing because he has confused proximity to Marguerite with being her.

"The council should address the matter of the King's arrangements," he says.

The room shifts without a sound, every predator in it pointing at the same thing at once.

"Arrangements?" I say. "What arrangements?"

"The woman." He doesn't look at Selene. He looks at me. "The hybrid woman who has been in this house for a month, eating our food, using our name as cover, being seen with the acting King."

"She has a name. Would you like to use it?"

"She has a species, and it's neither of ours." He's been rehearsing this. I can hear the rehearsal in the rhythm, too even, too clean. Somebody told him this was a good idea. "The court's concern is simple. An unclassified creature in House Croix, with access to the household, during a time of war—"

"We are not at war. Or did I miss the vote?"

"—during a time of *imminent* war, presents a security risk that the council has a right to address."

He's looking at me with the expression of a man who believes he is being brave, and he isn't. He is standing in a room with me because the room is full of witnesses and the Code is in effect and he has mistaken those things for safety.

"Is that the whole of it?" I say.

"The council should vote on her removal."

"No."

"With respect, sire—"

"With respect? Is that what this is? I heard you, and the answer is no."

He doesn't sit down, and that's the second breach and the one that tells me he's been sent. Who would gain from this? Who wants the room looking at Selene instead of at the motion on the table?

"The Code provides for a challenge on matters of household security," he says. "Any seated member may—"

"I know what the Code provides." I stand up, and the chair doesn't make a sound because I don't let it. "I wrote the enforcement commentary on that clause when I was a hundred and twelve. It requires a named griev-

ance, a named respondent, and a named consequence, presented before the challenge is heard. Would you like to name them?"

The room holds its breath, and so does he.

"Go ahead," I say. "Name the grievance. What has she done to you?"

His mouth opens, and nothing comes out.

"Name the respondent. She's standing right there." I nod toward Selene. "And then name what you'd like done to her, Laurent, out loud, in this room, in front of everyone here. Because that's what the Code requires: not an implication, not a concern, but a sentence, spoken, with your name attached."

He's pale. Vampires don't go pale like humans do — the blood doesn't leave the face, the face leaves the expression — and what's underneath is older and flatter, and Laurent is wearing it now.

"I have no specific— I didn't—"

"Then sit the hell down." He doesn't sit down.



THIS IS THE part where a different man would let it go, because the point is made and the room heard it. Laurent is standing in front of a full council with his rehearsed speech in pieces on the floor, and any reasonable reading of the situation says I've won.

I'm not interested in winning. Winning is what happens when two people disagree and one of them is louder, and I'm interested in this never happening again.

I step down from the chair and take the stairs like my father took them, one at a time, without the rail, and the room tracks me like weather.

Laurent takes a step back. He catches himself and stops, but the step happened, and every person in this chamber saw it.

I walk to him and stop at arm's length, the distance a man keeps when he's being polite.

"You pointed at her, didn't you?" I say.

"I didn't—"

"You gestured toward the back of the room when you said *the hybrid woman*. Your left hand. I saw it." I hold his eyes. "I want to be precise about this because the Code requires precision."

The room is not breathing, and neither is Laurent.

"Article eleven," I say. "A guest of the House is under the protection of the House. A slight against a guest, in the presence of the host, is answered by the host. The answer is proportional."

"She's not a guest, she's a—"

"She is whatever I say she is in my house." I take the last step, and we are close enough now that he can feel the cold coming off me. "You pointed at a woman under my protection and asked a room full of people to remove her, in my father's chamber, while I was sitting in his chair."

His chin comes up, and it's the last brave thing he does.

"I'm going to break your hand," I tell him. "The left one, the one you used to point at her."

"You can't— you can't *do* this, it's—"

"I'm telling you before I do it. That's what the Code is for."



I TAKE HIS wrist. There is a way to do this that my father showed me when I was young, a physician's grip, not a combat one. You hold the wrist with both hands, thumbs on the back, fingers wrapped underneath, and you find the third and fourth metacarpals, which are the bones that run from the knuckle to the center of the hand, and you apply pressure at the midpoint.

It takes very little force, less than opening a fucking jar.

I've never done it. My father showed me and then said, *You will never need to, because you'll tell them first, and telling them first is usually enough.*

It is usually enough, but not today.

Laurent screams, a short sound, cut off when I let go, because I hold the break for a beat and then release. His hand is still attached to his arm, and the bones will set in a day.

It is precisely proportional to a pointed finger and a sentence spoken out of turn. Every person in this room knows it, because every person in

this room grew up under the same Code and knows the graduation by heart.

He staggers, but he doesn't fall, because I've left him enough to stand on, and because falling would cost him the rest of what he walked in here with.

"Sit down," I tell him, and he sits.

The room is so still I can hear the clock in the hallway through the door.



I GO BACK up at the same pace, in the same posture, one at a time, no rail.

I sit down and Cassian is looking at me with an expression I have never seen on his face, not horror and not admiration. He is watching me become my father.

"The motion for war is on the table," I say. "Are there further speakers?"

There are not, and I didn't expect any.

"Then we vote."

It passes, every seat. Marguerite's hand goes up first, which is expected, and Brodeur's goes up second, which is not — a man who hasn't spoken in this chamber since the last succession votes with the speed of someone who has seen enough.

Laurent votes with his right hand, and nobody laughs.

Cassian doesn't have a vote and never has. He stands to my left with his hands behind his back and watches the room commit to a war he built. He looks like he's gotten exactly what he wanted and isn't sure he should have.

Was that the point? Did I just give him what he's been angling for since the funeral?



AFTER, the chamber empties like water from a basin — fast at first, then slow, then the last few hanging on the rim.

Selene stays at the back wall, her arms still at her sides. Her face has not changed since I broke a man's hand in front of her.

That worries me, and it should, because a woman who watches that and doesn't flinch is either numb or dangerous, and she isn't numb.

I come down the stairs a third time, slower now.

"You were supposed to be in the west wing," I say. "Why aren't you?"

"You were supposed to not break a man's goddamn hand in front of me."

"I told him first."

"I heard you." She looks at my hands. "You told him which hand and why. You quoted the article number."

"That's the process. What would you have had me do?"

"That's not a process. I've watched processes. I've watched my landlord process an eviction and a priest process a funeral, and neither of them had to hold a man's wrist while he screamed." Her voice is steady and her eyes are not. "That's a man telling another man exactly what's about to happen to him and then doing it while a room watches. That's a warning label, not a law."

I look at her, and I don't have a defense ready.

"My father called it a fence," I say.

"I know what your father called it, you bastard." She pushes off the wall. "Your father built a fence. You just showed them what's on the other side of it."

She's shaking, her hands at her sides, her jaw set, and a fine tremor through her shoulders that she is not going to acknowledge and I am not going to name.

"Are you all right?" I ask. "Ghost?"

"Don't ask me that right now. For Christ's sake, don't."

"Selene—"

"I watched you break a man's hand because he pointed at me." Her voice is still steady, and the steadiness is costing her. "I need a minute to decide which part of that is the part I'm supposed to feel."

She turns and walks toward the door, and at the frame she stops.

"You told him first," she says, and it's not a question.

"Yes."

"Every time?"

"Every fucking time."

She nods once, and I smell it.

Under the fear there's something else on the air around her. I know it the way I know the smell of rain. Her pulse is up and her thighs are pressed together under that one good dress, and she's wet, and she hates it. She's going to hate it all the way to the west wing.

Then she's gone, and the door closes, and I'm standing in my father's chamber with the smell of Laurent's broken bone in the air and a war I voted for and a man to my left who arranged the whole of it.

"Well done," Cassian says.

Two words, warm, and I don't turn around.

"Get me the deployment terms by morning," I say. "And Cassian."

"Yes?"

"If anyone points at her again, I won't name it first."

Silence, a beat of it, the length of a held breath.

"Understood," he says. "Is there anything else, Lucian?"

"Not tonight."

The court voted for war, and the evidence hasn't caught up to the decision yet.

And the man who killed my father just told me *well done*.

It sounded like pride.



CHAPTER

Thirty

LUCIAN

“SO THE WINE came through a supplier on Decatur.”

Bastien talks too much, and I have stopped hearing most of it. He’s been on the poison money for a week. It’s the first real work anybody’s given him, and he’s taken it as a dog takes a bone.

He has papers. He’s brought papers into a hallway. “But the *money* doesn’t. The money goes out through a shipping account, then it goes sideways twice, and then there’s a broker.”

“A name? Tell me there’s a name.”

“Three names. I checked them all twice, sire, and once more at four in the morning when I couldn’t sleep, because I kept thinking I’d got a letter wrong and you’d have my head. One’s a company, and one’s a dead woman.” He turns a page. “And one’s Cray, the Marchand woman’s broker. He’s the only one who’s ever picked up a phone.”

“Give it to Silas.”

“I already did.” A pause. “Sorry. I should have said that first, shouldn’t I?”

“Yes.”

He grins anyway, as he always grins when I correct him. I've never understood that about him and I've decided not to examine it.

"There's more," he says. "You're going to love this part. Or hate it. Honestly, sire, I can never tell with you. The dead woman's account paid for something else last spring, and I can't read the ledger line, because it's in somebody's private shorthand."

"Whose? Can you guess?"

"I'm working on that bit." He's pleased with himself, and he's earned it, and I'm not going to tell him so. "Sire — can I ask you a thing?"

"You're going to. When have you ever not?"

"When it starts, the war." He gets the papers squared against his chest. "Will you put me where it's happening? Not the gate, not standing outside a door in the Quarter counting wolves."

"You want to be seen? Is that it?"

"I want to be *useful*."

He means both, and he's young enough to think those are the same sentence.

I look at him for a moment. He's ninety years old next spring and he came to this house because my father took him off a dock in a bad decade. He has spent every year since arranging his whole personality around being let into rooms.

Should I tell him he's not ready? It would be true. I could tell him he did good work on the money, also true. It would cost me nothing, and he would carry it around for a month like a coin.

"Later," I say.

"Later when, sire? Next week? Next war?"

"When I say so. Go on, get out of my hallway."

That's what I gave him: *later*.



THEY COME IN through the kitchen, not the gallery, not the courtyard, not the street doors, not any of the ways my father's house was built to be entered.

The kitchen has a door for deliveries, held by nobody, because the men who use it are human and they come before dawn with fish.

I'm in the west hall when the first one dies. I hear it — not the shout, the shout comes later, but the wet crack of a young vampire being opened by an animal that knows where to open him.

Then the house starts screaming.

Six of them, shifted already, inside the walls. Somebody walked them past two courtyards and a guard post, so who let them in?

Who the fuck opened the kitchen? I'm moving before I've finished the thought, and I'm aware of the thought like I'm aware of weather — *who has a key, who has a key* — and it's the question I've been asking for a month.

It's the wrong question, and it has always been the wrong question. I ask it the whole way down the hall.

Bastien is in the small dining room, and he shouldn't be. He should be behind me.

He's put himself in a doorway with his arms out, because there are two of the household staff behind him — a girl who does the linen, and a man whose name I have never learned, both human.

He's eighty-nine years old, and he has never been in a fight that mattered, and he holds the doorway.

He holds it about as long as it takes me to cross the hall, and when I get there he's on his back with his throat open to the spine.

His hands are still up.



HERE. This is where it goes.

The wolf over him turns and I take the front of its face off with my hand. I don't strike. I get my fingers into the skull under the jaw and pull.

It comes away wet, and I'm already past it.

The second one comes at my left, and I take the arm off at the shoulder.

Then I use it. I put the loose end through the animal's own chest and out the other side. It's still trying to bite me while I do it.

Noise in the room, somebody screaming in a human register.

The third goes into a wall, not thrown but pushed, with my weight behind it, until the wall stops being a wall. I don't remember choosing the wall.

Fourth. The fourth one is on the floor.

It's on the floor and it has gone back: human, a man, naked, young, with his hands flat on the boards and his head down and blood coming out of his nose in a thin string.

Shifting back is surrender. Everybody in this city knows it — you go human, you put your hands down, and the other side stops.

My father stopped, every time. He'd have the man taken and tried, and I sat in the room while he did it and told him it was a weakness.

"Wait," the man says. "Wait — I'm — please, I'm done, can't you see I'm done?"

Who has a key.

I stop asking. Not the killing — the killing is ordinary. What happens is that the question goes out of me as a light goes out. I stop asking who the fuck let them in.

What's underneath it has no question in it at all.

I take his lower jaw off first, because he's talking.

Then the rest of him. It takes a while, and he's conscious for a great deal of it, and I do not hurry.

The fifth is trying to get out through the kitchen, back the way they came, and I catch him in the passage.

I put him through the doorframe, and then I keep putting him through it after there's no reason to.

Sixth is the girl.

She's young, younger than Bastien, and her back is against the stove and she hasn't shifted at all. She never shifted. She came in a coat and a face, and she opened a door for her cousins.

She's crying. "Please," she says. "Please, please—"

I've heard that word tonight already. Somebody said it to me in a hallway a month ago and meant something else by it entirely.

I put my hand around the whole of her head.



AND THEN THERE'S nobody left.

That's the part nobody warns you about: there's no ending to it. You don't finish. You run out of material.

I'm standing in my father's small dining room with the raiding party in pieces around me, and I'm looking at the pantry door.

It's shut, and somebody is behind it. There's a heartbeat going in there like a bird in a box, and it's human. I know before I've taken a step that it's the linen girl, the one Bastien died standing in front of.

I'm walking toward the pantry door, and nothing stops me — not conscience, not the Code, not my father's voice, which I have heard in every other room of this house.

I get my hand on the door.

And Silas says, "Sire."

One word, from the hall, in the flattest voice a man ever used, and I turn around.

He's in the doorway with his hands loose at his sides and nothing in them, and he's looking at me like roadkill.

He's been there a while. He watched the last of it and he didn't come in.

"That's a person in there," he says. "Do you hear her?"

And it comes back all at once, like water finding the bottom of a well.

I'm myself again, standing in a room with my hand on a pantry door and a house full of bodies, and I take my hand off it.



AFTERWARD, I'm very calm, and the calm is worse. It arrives complete, a guest who was waiting in the next room for its turn.

I go and stand over Bastien. His hands are down now — somebody put them down, Silas probably. There's a decency in that man he has never once admitted to.

The girl comes out of the pantry. She looks at me and her face does the ordinary human thing, the instinct firing underneath thought: *find something else to look at*. She can't, because I'm all there is in the room.

"You were behind him?" I say. "The whole time?"

She nods.

"He didn't move out of the doorway?"

She nods again, shaking hard enough that she has to hold the frame.

"Then you'll tell people that." My voice is level, a courtesy voice, the one I use at council. "Not the rest of it, just that part."

She says something I don't take in.

Then I give the orders — the bodies, the kitchen entrance, the human staff paid for the month and sent out of the city until this is finished.

I do all of it in the tone of a man rescheduling a delivery, and Silas writes it down.

"The name Bastien traced," I say. "Where is he?"

"Cray, still in the Bywater. He hasn't moved."

"Keep him there. Not tonight." I look at the kitchen passage. "Tonight I want the house walked, every door, every way in."

"Yes."

"I want the list short. I want it honest if I'm on it. I mean that, Silas."

"Yes, sire. And you? Do you want the list to include you?"

"I said honest, didn't I?"

"You did, sire. I'll put you at the top. Where you'd want to be."

"Where the hell else would I be?"

He goes, and I stand in the middle of it and take an account of myself, because there's nobody left in my life who'll do it for me.

I am not sorry about the fourth one. He put his hands down and went back to being a man and said *wait*, and I opened him anyway.

I've looked for the part of me that objects and it isn't there. I'm not sorry about the girl at the stove either.

What I keep arriving at is the pantry door.

I had my hand on it. There was a woman behind it who has never done anything to anyone — she folds linen in a house she has no idea about. She was standing behind Bastien because he put her there.

And I was going to open the door, not in a rage. I'd like to be able to say it was rage.

It was quieter than that: I was going to open the door because it was the next door.

What do you call a man who does that? There's a word and I know it, and it is not one of the ones they use about my father.



MARGUERITE will hear about this before morning.

She'll want it called a defense of the house, which it was, for about the length of the hall, and then she'll want it called a message.

The court will want it called the night the King finally stopped apologizing.

They'll be pleased, and I can see it coming and can't head off the sentence. Some of them have been waiting four centuries for a Croix to do precisely this. They'll put it in a sentence with my father's name in it. The sentence will be about how the son is not the fucking father.

And they'll be right about that, and that's what I can't get around.

I told him mercy was a thing you could afford until the night you couldn't.

This was the night, and I was correct. Why does being correct feel like this?



HERE'S WHAT I won't be saying to Silas, or to Marguerite, or to my father, if he walked in right now and asked what I'd done to his dining room.

I keep going back to the moment Silas said my title.

What I feel about Silas standing in that doorway is that he interrupted me.

Do you know what I wanted? I wanted to keep fucking going.

INTERLUDE V

Cassian

HE KNOWS.

How much? Not all of it, but enough. He has stopped telling me where he is going, and a boy who stops telling you where he is going has already decided something.

He sent no word about the dining room. I heard it from Marguerite, who heard it from a physician. By the time I reached the house they had the doors off the small room, and men washing a wall.

The whole raiding party, and he did it with his hands.



THE HOUSEHOLD is frightened of him this morning, and it is not the ordinary fear. They have always been frightened of him as you are frightened of the weather in a place you have chosen to live.

Now they stop talking when he passes.

He walked one of them to the kitchen door himself, the linen girl. He put her in a car with a month's pay and told her to go to her sister in Lafayette, and he stood on the step until the car was through the gate.

He did that because he nearly killed her.

I have watched him since he was an afternoon old, and I know what that particular courtesy is made of.



WHAT IS HE, then?

He went through that room like a story from the old country, and then he stopped, and then he gave orders about paying the staff.

Both of those are him.

His father never believed it. I have known it since the boy was a child. He is not a good man wrestling an animal, and he is not an animal wearing a coat. He is both of them at once, all the way down — and the Code was written to make a creature like that spend his life apologizing for half of himself.

His father put the leash on him at the age when a boy will take anything from the man who says it kindly.

Last night the leash came off in a dining room, and this morning he is walking his own servants out to cars.

He is going to be the most complete king this species has had. Whatever happens in the week in front of us, I made that, in a courtyard, every evening, for as long as it took.

Aurelian gave him a philosophy.

I gave him his hands.



THERE IS A very easy way out of this, and I keep being surprised by how easy it is.

There is a house near Bruges that has been in my name since before this city was surveyed, and there are others, and there is a ship on Thursday.

I could walk out of the gate this evening and be gone before he has a name to put on a warrant. He would spend a lifetime looking, and he would not find me.

I have had that thought several times today and it does not stay. It cannot find anywhere to sit down.

A man who runs is a man who was only ever sad.

If I go to Bruges, then there is a king in this city who tells a story about an old man who went strange with grief and disappeared. The story ends with *poor Cassian*, and the question at the bottom of it is never asked by anybody again.

Why did I do it, then? Not to be forgiven, and not to get away. I did it to be answered.



SO I WILL be in the study when he sends for me.

Will he send for me? He will, soon — this week, I think, and in the evening, because he is his father's son about certain furniture. He will want the door closed, and he will want to hear me say it again.

I will say it again. I will not deny a word of it and I will not ask him for anything, and when it is done I will give him the rest, because there is a broker with a name and he is going to need it, and I would rather he had it from me.

I will not give him the other thing. The broker never quoted me a price. He told me it had already been paid, by someone who had been waiting a long time for a man like me to walk through his door, and by then I was too far along to ask who.

Who paid it? Let the boy find that one himself. He will need something to do with his hands.

Then he will do what the statute requires.

He will drain me first and take the head after, in front of witnesses, in a room with the door standing open, exactly as it is written, exactly as it was done in the courtyard, by his father, personally, because that man would not hand the ugly part to anybody else.

Will he notice whose hands he is about to do it with?

He will not notice, not for years.

That is my last gift to him. He will hate me for it when it finally arrives, and he will be a great king by then, and it will be too late for either of us to take it back.

I raised him better than his father did.

He'll do it properly.



C H A P T E R

Thirty-One

S E L E N E

THERE'S BLOOD on him that isn't his and he hasn't noticed.

He comes through the west wing door like weather comes through a window — no announcement, just the displacement of air and then the fact of him. His shirt is ruined, Jesus Christ, his shirt, one sleeve torn at the shoulder, the other soaked to the elbow in blood dark enough to be black under the hall light.

His hands. His knuckles are split open and the skin hasn't closed, and that's the first thing I see and the first thing that goes wrong in my chest, because Lucian's skin closes. I've watched it close. I've put my mouth on a wound and felt it seal under my tongue.

These aren't closing. His right is slicked from the second knuckle down. The left has a thing caught under the nail I don't look at twice.

He's standing in the doorway and he hasn't said a word. Where is Silas? Where is anyone?

His eyes are the problem.

I've seen his eyes in a hallway, in a bed, in a car with his hand between my thighs, across a desk with his father's papers under my palms: angry

and hungry and tired and once, just once, afraid. This is none of those. There is nothing behind his eyes that I have ever met.



HE WALKS IN and doesn't shut the door, and the smell hits me before he's across the room: salt and adrenaline and wolf-blood, which has a resin underneath it, pine sap and iron. There's so much of it that it coats the inside of my nose and sits.

Under all of it, his, thin and cold, a cut somewhere still going.

"Lucian?"

Nothing, not even a blink.

"Hey." I get off the bed. "Look at me. Can you hear me?"

His head turns, but the rest of him hasn't decided to be in the room yet.

"Who's dead?" I say.

"Bastien. God damn it. Bastien."

One word, the flattest voice I've ever heard from his mouth. I've heard him give orders that ended a man's standing in fewer syllables.

"How? What the hell happened?"

"He held a doorway, the stupid, brave little bastard." A breath. "He held it, and I was in the hall."

I understand the sentence. I understand the gap between the hall and the doorway. I understand that Lucian Croix can cross a hall faster than anything alive. I understand that he didn't, and the understanding sits in my teeth.

"Come here," I tell him.

He doesn't move, not an inch.

"Lucian. Come *here*. Do you hear me? Come here."



HE CROSSES the room like a dog with the leash just off.

He grabs the back of my neck and his mouth comes down on mine and there's nothing in it that resembles kissing. He's taking. His teeth catch my lower lip and the taste of iron comes up between us, his blood or mine. His

other fist gets into my hair and pulls. My back hits the wall beside the bed hard enough to rattle a frame.

I don't push him off. I get both hands into his ruined shirt and tear it the rest of the way open because the buttons are gone and the fabric is wet and I need my palms on his skin more than I need to be careful about anything.

His chest is cold, cold and hard and streaked with drying blood that flakes under my palms, and under the blood a long shallow gash across his ribs on the left side, open and wet and not healing.

He doesn't notice I've found it — he's past noticing.

He lets go of my hair and takes my throat and squeezes. It isn't the measured pressure he gives me when I ask, the pulse that means *I have you*. This is the other one, the one from the dining room, and his grip says *I could* and doesn't finish.

My pulse hammers against his palm, and I'm frightened. Holy shit, I'm frightened.

And the wetness between my thighs started the second he walked through the door, and those are the same fact wearing two faces, and I stopped apologizing for that weeks ago. What does it say about me that the version of him with no leash is the version my body answers fastest? Something fucked up, and I don't care tonight.

"Harder," I tell him. "Is that all you've got?"

His eyes find mine, and something in them flickers, and it's an animal watching food hold still on purpose. The man doesn't come back.

He shoves me down the wall to the floor.



THE CARPET burns under my shoulder blades and I don't care. He's on top of me with his full weight, which he has never once given me — always braced before, always a palm down, always holding the worst of himself just above me.

Not tonight. Tonight he drops every pound of it onto me and I take it and the air goes out of my lungs in one flat punch.

His thigh is between mine, his mouth on my throat, dragging teeth. The points scrape without breaking, a line from my jaw to my collarbone that leaves a white trail and then a red one as the blood rushes back.

I writhe under him, toward him.

My skirt is up around my hips, and his cock is hard against my thigh through his trousers, thick and heavy. My body has already started making room for it.

“Get them *off*,” I say. “Jesus Christ, can you get them off?”

He doesn’t hear me. His mouth is at my collarbone and he bites — a real bite, not a graze, his teeth breaking the skin in a small clean crescent that fills with blood before the pain arrives — and I buck.

“Lucian — your *pants* —”

He gets them open without taking them off, gets his cock out and lines up and pushes into me in one stroke that takes the breath I just got back.

My fingers find the floor and my heels find his calves. He’s thick and cold and the stretch of him after no warmup has my eyes stinging. Oh, fuck. Oh, *fuck*.

“Wait— fuck—”

He stills instantly, even like this.

“No.” I grab his hips and drag him deeper. “No, don’t wait. Don’t you *dare* wait.”

His hips snap forward and I take it. I take it because the sound he makes is not a sound I’ve heard from him — low, guttural, a groan dragged out through clenched teeth that has *Bastien* underneath it and *the pantry door* underneath that and *I wanted to keep going* underneath everything.

I get my hand into his hair and hold on.

He fucks me like a man fights, short, hard, graceless strokes that slam me into the carpet, his grip still on my throat, his other arm braced beside my head, the wounded one, and blood from his split knuckles drips onto the carpet next to my face.

I watch a drop land, then another.

Is he losing it? He lost himself in the dining room, and now he’s losing blood.



“Lucian. Stop. Stop, damn it.”

He stops.

Dead, mid-stroke. With nothing behind his eyes, with Bastien’s blood still on his hands, *stop* goes into him and he stops, every muscle locked, his cock buried, his breath ragged and wrong.

Whatever came back from that dining room, the leash still answers to me.

His eyes come back, not all the way.

“You’re bleeding, goddamn it,” I tell him.

“I know.”

“No, you — look at your hand. *Look*. Do you see it?”

He looks. The gash across his ribs has opened wider, blood running down his side, thin and dark, pooling in the crease of his hip, and his knuckles are still split.

None of it is closing, oh, fuck.

“The poison,” I say. “Jesus Christ. The poison.”

“It’s been weeks. Hasn’t it?”

“Shit, Lucian, it doesn’t matter how long.”

“Ondine said it sleeps in the blood, and if you lose enough, it wakes up.”

I press my palm to the gash, and his blood runs between my fingers, warm for a second and then cold. Shit. Shit. “How much have you bled tonight? Too much. It’s awake, and this isn’t stopping on its own.”

He closes his eyes, still inside me, still hard, his body shaking with the effort of holding still.

“I need to pull out.”

“No.”

His eyes open.

“Stay where you are,” I tell him. “I need to do something and I need you to let me.”

“Selene —”

“Trust me. For fuck’s sake, trust me. Have I ever steered you wrong?”



I REACH FOR a knife. The Barataria knife is in my bag, wrapped, and I'm done with it.

The paring knife from the kitchenette is on the bedside table because I left it there this morning. I'm a woman who leaves knives where she can reach them, and tonight that's not paranoia. Tonight it's providence.

I pick it up, and he sees it, and his whole body goes still, a predator watching something it doesn't understand come into the room.

"I need you on your knees," I say. "Now. Right the fuck now."

"What are you doing? Selene, what the hell are you doing?"

"I need you *off me* and on your *knees*."

He pulls out, and the drag of his cock leaving my body makes both of us swear. He kneels back on the carpet, his trousers open, his chest streaked, the gash weeping.

I sit up in front of him and hold the paring knife against the inside of my left wrist.

"Don't."

"Listen to me." I hold his eyes. "I've been feeding you for weeks, my blood in your mouth. You bite and I let you, and afterward you heal."

"That's not the same — how is that the same?"

"It's exactly the same, because the blood is the blood." I press the edge against my skin, and my own pulse knocks against the blade. "Except this time it's mine. I'm opening the vein and putting it in your mouth, and you're not taking. I'm giving."

His jaw works and the tendons in his neck stand out. His hands are fists on his thighs, blood dripping off the knuckles.

"Do you know what it'll do?" he says. "Do you have any idea?"

"I know what it'll do. Hell, I've been thinking about it for days."

"You don't —"

"I know that given blood goes both ways. You told me that on the floor of my apartment." I hold the blade steady. "You feel what I feel. Isn't that the deal?"

"It's never gone the other direction. What if it can't?"

"Then we fucking find out."



I CUT.

It's shallow, one clean line across the inside of my wrist, just shy of the vein. The blood comes up in a thin dark bead that stretches into a line before it starts to run.

The smell of it hits the room, and I watch Lucian's face when my blood reaches the air.

His nostrils flare, and his eyes go from bruised and empty to *black*, the pupil swallowing the iris in one pulse. His mouth opens and I can see his teeth.

He's shaking. "Take it," I tell him.

He doesn't move.

"Take it. What are you waiting for?"

He takes my wrist, and his grip is not gentle. His fingers wrap around my forearm and his thumbs find the pulse points on either side. He holds me like something he's been starving for, and his mouth comes down on the cut.

The first pull hits my nervous system, a wall of water.



I'VE BEEN BITTEN, and I know what his mouth on my throat does — the warmth, the drag, the orgasm that builds behind the surrender. I know the shape of it.

This isn't that, not even close.

His mouth is on my wrist, and I'm not lying under him. Holy shit, I'm not lying under him. I'm sitting up, and I opened the vein, and my blood is running into his mouth because I decided it would. The direction has reversed, and what comes back through the blood is not my feelings landing in his body.

It's his, in mine.

Four hundred years of it, arriving all at once.

The hunger hits first. It's worse than appetite, worse than the ache he carries at court, a headache he's learned to work through. It's the real thing, the one underneath all of it, a want so total that my vision goes white at the edges. I understand in one flooding second that he has been this hungry every day of his life and he has never once satisfied it, because to satisfy it he would have to stop choosing and he will not stop choosing and the effort of that choice is a thing I could not have imagined from the outside.

And inside the hunger, a number: three hundred and six years of feeding that tasted like nothing, years of mouths and throats and the same flat taste, meal after meal, century after century, until the act of eating became indistinguishable from the act of forgetting. Then me. One taste in a service corridor and the counter reset and he knew it was over — the nothing was over — and he's been terrified of that ever since, because a man who has tasted *anything* after three hundred and six years of nothing will do unspeakable things to keep it.

I gasp, and my thighs clamp together on the carpet and I grab his shoulder. How does he walk through a room? How does he sit across from me at a desk and talk about shipping routes with this living under his skin?

Under the hunger: the restraint. It's a living thing, muscular, constant, awake at all hours. He holds himself back like a man holding a door shut against weather, every minute, every throat he walks past, every heartbeat in every room. The discipline isn't the absence of desire. It's desire, and the decision to survive it, and the decision remade every single time.

That's what it costs him not to touch me.

The feeding is easy, and the fucking is easy. The not-touching is what costs: standing in a room with me and choosing not to put his mouth on my throat every second of every conversation we have ever had.

All of it, centuries of it, in my body at once.



I COME. I don't decide to, and it isn't built.

It detonates and my spine buckles and I hear myself cry out, high and wrecked. My cunt clenches on nothing because he's not inside me. I'm

coming from his hunger. From the weight of his restraint hitting my nervous system and my body reading it as the largest act of desire anyone has ever committed in my direction. Is this what he feels every time he feeds from me? Has he been carrying this and saying nothing?

“Lucian.” It comes out of me cracked. “This is you. This is what you carry around.”

He can’t answer with his mouth on my wrist. His grip tightens instead, and that’s the answer.

He’s still drinking, his mouth on my wrist, his eyes closed, his throat working.

And in the blood, under the hunger and the restraint: me, what I look like from inside his head.

I see myself through centuries of empty rooms: a door that opened, a woman who looked at his teeth and asked whether he was a vampire instead of screaming, a voice that heard both registers and never once held it against him, a body that arched into him when every other body in his life has either bowed or backed away.

The loneliness I felt in his blood on my apartment floor — the one I didn’t know was mine — I feel its mirror now: his, older, deeper, packed down so dense it doesn’t register as loneliness anymore. It registers as a room, and I’m in it.

The only warm thing in a room he’s been sitting in alone for longer than I’ve been alive, longer than my whole bloodline has been alive.

I come again, harder, with my thighs shaking and my pussy clenching around nothing. My whole body locks up and my fingers in his hair go to a fist and I pull, and he groans against my wrist. The vibration of that groan goes through the cut and into my blood and back into me like a circuit completing.

“Enough,” I say. “Enough — *stop* — Jesus, stop —”

He seals the wound with his tongue.



THE ROOM COMES back in pieces: carpet, wall, his breathing and mine at different speeds.

His mouth is off me, blood on his lips — mine, thin and bright. The gash across his ribs has closed, not fully — a pink line, raised, new skin pulled tight — and his knuckles are sealed.

He's on his knees on the carpet, and I'm sitting in front of him, my wrist in his grip. He's looking at the cut as if it's a word in a language he thought he knew.

"What did you feel?" he asks.

"Everything. Holy shit, everything. Do you want the list?"

"Selene."

"I felt what it costs you." I'm shaking so hard my teeth click. "Every day, every room, the not-touching."

His jaw tightens, and he looks away.

"Is that what I look like to you?" I say. "A door?"

"Don't."

"A warm room? Is that what I am?"

"*Don't.*"

"You are the only thing in four hundred years I have wanted more than I wanted to be good." I say it because it came through the blood and it's his sentence, not mine, and I'm handing it back to him like a translator hands back a borrowed word. "That's you. That's what you carry around."

He looks at me, and he has no answer for hearing his own interior said out loud by a woman with carpet burn and a cut on her wrist she put there herself, and I watch him not have an answer.

Then he leans forward and puts his forehead on my shoulder and his weight comes onto me. It is the first time in weeks he has put his full weight on me without it being a weapon.

"I almost opened a pantry door tonight," he says.

"I know."

"There was a woman behind it."

"Silas told me."

"And you're still here? After that?"

"I'm still here."

His arms go around me, his face in my neck, and his breathing starts to settle and then doesn't.



HE'S STILL hard. I feel it against my hip when he shifts, and I feel him notice. His whole body goes careful, and he starts to pull away.

"No," I say.

"Selene. You're bleeding, for God's sake."

"I was, and you fixed it." I hold up the wrist, the line sealed and pink. "Are you back?"

He looks at me for a long time, and his pupils have come down to something that belongs to a man.

"I'm here."

"Then come back and finish it."

The breath goes out of him, and he takes my face between his palms and searches it for the fear he put there an hour ago.

"Say stop," he says. "Once. I need to hear that it still works. Please, ghost. I need it."

"Stop."

He doesn't move a muscle, and he waits until I laugh.

"Okay," I say. "See? It works. Now don't."

He lays me back on the carpet, slow this time, one palm under my skull so it doesn't hit the floor. He gets my skirt off and doesn't bother with the rest, and when he pushes back into me it's nothing like the first time tonight. It's slow. All the way in and then still, his forehead on mine, his weight on his forearms, the whole of him shaking with the effort of being gentle.

"Look at me," he says.

I do, and I don't look away.

He moves in me like he's counting something, long and deep and unhurried. The carpet burns my shoulders and I don't care. I wrap my legs around him and pull him closer, and his mouth finds my throat, and his teeth stay behind his lips.

Somewhere under us there's a sheet over a boy who called me a conduit. I feel it arrive in him halfway through: the stroke falters, his breath catches wrong, and his face goes into my neck. I hold the back of his head

and keep him moving, because stopping is the one thing he can't afford tonight.

"Tell me whose you are," he says against my skin, and it isn't a command. It's a man asking what's still standing.

"Yours." I put my thumb on his wrist, where the signal lives, and I leave it still. "Yours. I'm here."

I come quietly, with his name in my mouth and my fingers in his hair. He follows a few strokes later, buried as deep as he can get, and the sound he makes isn't pleasure. It's the other thing, the one he didn't let out in the hall. I hold him through all of it.

After, he stays, his forehead on mine, and neither of us moves to change that.

"Next time," I say, "take your fucking pants all the way off. I'm serious as hell."

He laughs, wet and broken, against my mouth, the first sound he's made tonight that I recognize.

"Next time," he says, "everything comes off, yours and mine, and I take all night about it."

"Promise? Swear it?"

"Ghost. I've never broken one to you."



I HOLD HIM on the floor for a while, his blood drying on both of us. My wrist throbs. His ribs are tender — he flinches when I touch them and then presses into the pain, because he has never once turned away from what hurt.

There was one more thing in the blood, at the bottom, underneath the hunger and the restraint and the loneliness and me: a name.

Not mine, not his father's, not Bastien's. I already know it. I've known it since my father's ledger, since Rémy said it out loud on the dock, since Lucian told me in the dark what he'd decided. What I didn't know is what it weighs from in here. He's been turning it over for weeks like a stone in his palm, and the stone has a sharp edge, and every time he turns it the edge cuts him and he turns it anyway. Under the edge, still whole, is the love.

None of it has gone anywhere. Every morning Cassian walks into the study, and Lucian sits there with this name in his teeth and loves him anyway.

"Cassian," I say.

He goes still against me.

"You still love him," I say. "I felt it."

His arms tighten, and his breathing stops.

"Yes."

One word, the flattest one he's ever given me, and I've heard them all. What do you do with that kind of love? Where do you put the name of the man who raised you and killed your father when the man is still standing in your house?

I hold him, and I don't say anything else. There's no translation for loving the man who killed your father and deciding to kill him anyway, and I'm not going to pretend there is.

He finds my wrist. The cut is sealed but the line is there — a thin pink thread where I opened my own skin and put my blood in his mouth.

He runs his thumb over it, then puts his mouth on it, not to feed, not to heal, just to feel it there.

"You did that?" he says.

"Yes."

"You cut yourself open for me?"

"Yes."

He holds my wrist against his mouth for a long time, his lips on the scar, his breath on my skin.

"I'm still going to do it," he says, to the room, not to me.

"I know."

"Selene."

"I know." I push my hand into his hair. "And when you do, I'll be here. Same as now."

He lifts his head, and his eyes are his own again, most of the way.

"You saw all of it?" he says. "In the blood. What I am."

"Yes."

"And you're still sitting on this floor? Why?"

"Where the fuck else would I be?"

"Yes."

He puts his mouth back on the scar, and when he speaks it's against my skin, so low I feel it more than hear it.

"The ghost that stayed."

The door is open, and the hall is dark. Somewhere in this house a boy's body is under a sheet, and a king is on his knees on a carpet with his mouth on a woman's wrist. The king's wounds are closing with her blood and her wounds are open because she chose them.

Something came back to me through that cut. A low hum under my skin that points at him like a compass needle, and it hasn't stopped.

I don't tell him, because he has enough to carry tonight.

I stay exactly where I am.



C H A P T E R

Thirty-Two

S E L E N E

“**B**ASTIEN.”

That’s the first word he said when he came through my door last night, and I slept anyway. There’s something wrong in the house, and Lucian’s cold is still on my skin.

It’s an absence of sound, the silence a building makes when everyone in it has stopped what they were doing and started cleaning up.

I sit up to an empty bed, because he left without waking me. The frame beside the bed is still crooked on the wall where my back hit it. There are marks on my throat I can feel without a mirror, and a bite on my collarbone that’s gone dark. My thighs ache in a way I’m going to feel every time I sit down today.

For a breath the only thing in my head is the floor. God, the floor: his face with nothing behind it, my blood going back into him.

Then Bastien. How the fuck have I been asleep?



I SMELL IT before I reach the stairs: old blood, something animal underneath it, wet and resinous, the smell of bodies opened in a room that wasn't built for it.

I pull on the shirt I was wearing and walk barefoot down the corridor. The house is wrong, occupied in a new way: footsteps below, moving with purpose, a door closing that doesn't usually close.

The kitchen door is open — the delivery door, the one that faces the service alley — and there's a man standing in it I don't know.

He's one of Silas's people, and I know because he has the stance, loose and weighted forward, a man taught to stand in doorways by someone who believed doorways were the point.

He sees me and his mouth tightens. "Ma'am—"

"What the hell happened?"

"You should— ma'am, you shouldn't be down here— sire said nobody, and sire meant nobody, and I don't want to be the one who tells him I let you past."

"What the fuck *happened*? Who's hurt?"

He doesn't answer. He steps aside, which is an answer.

The kitchen is worse. The smell has weight in here — thick, iron-sweet, coating the back of my throat — and blood on tile holds its heat longer than blood on wood, and this floor is still warm with it.

There's blood on the floor, less a pool than a pattern. It goes from the kitchen door to the dining room in a line that tells a story about how a body moved through a space it was never meant to be moving through.



I FOLLOW IT. The small dining room is destroyed, and *destroyed* isn't enough.

The table is against the wall, thrown there, the legs snapped and the top split down the center. The chairs are pieces. There's a hole in the plaster where a body went through it and kept going. The shape of the hole tells me what made it.

Somebody went through that wall backwards, and the lath behind the plaster is splintered outward, and through the wall is a room I've never been in with a stain on the floor I'll never ask about.

The floor is a map, and I can read it like I read a conversation: what happened, and what's underneath. Four distinct blood patterns: one long drag from the door to the wall, two pooling marks where bodies fell and stayed, and one spray across the ceiling that arcs from the fireplace to the window — a carotid, opened at speed. The body was still turning when it bled out.

There are men in the room, Silas's people, moving without a sound, doing the work that comes after. One of them has a bucket, and the water in it is red. One of them is taking the pantry door off its hinges. It has claw marks gouged into it, deep furrows from a wolf that shifted mid-fight and tried to get through to whatever was on the other side.

A tooth on the floor, wolf, the root still attached, pulled out of the jaw it grew in.

And in the middle of all of it, on the floor, with his throat open to the spine, is Bastien.

Someone, Silas I think, has laid him straight and drawn a sheet over him, up to the chest.



I'M STANDING in a doorway looking at the only person in this house who ever grinned at me. He's on the floor with his throat gone, and I don't make a sound.

His hands are folded. Somebody arranged them, carefully, like you'd straighten a collar. His eyes are closed, and his face has the look of a thing that was still deciding what expression to make when the decision was taken away from it.

He was eighty-nine fucking years old, and he worshipped Lucian. He carried papers into rooms where nobody asked for them. He called me a conduit because I told him it was nicer than a drain.

He held a doorway. I can see it in the scuff marks on the floor, and in how the blood falls around a space where a body stood and didn't move. He

put himself between the wolves and whoever was behind him, and he held it.

I go to him and kneel on the floor beside him. The blood soaks into my jeans, and I don't care about the jeans.

"You held it," I say. "Didn't you?"

He doesn't hear me, because he's been gone for hours, and the room is cold. Goddamn it, Bastien.

"You held it, Bastien. Do you hear me? You held it."

One of Silas's men looks at me without saying anything and goes back to the bucket.



LUCIAN IS IN the study. I know because Silas told me. Silas appeared in the kitchen doorway with his hands in his coat and a face I've never seen on him, under grief, under anger, down where the machinery is.

"He's upstairs," Silas said. "Don't go in. For God's sake, don't."

"Is he hurt? Silas. Is he fucking hurt?"

"He's not hurt." A pause. "Don't go in."

"Why not?"

"Because I asked you not to. That has to count for something, doesn't it?"

I go in anyway. Fuck Silas.

The study door is open, as it always is. The lamp is on and the desk is clean, and there's a hole in the wall.

A fist-shaped depression in the plaster beside the window, clean, precise, with the knuckle marks still visible in the dust: one strike, none of the fury from the dining room, a single measured punch into a wall that gave like paper.

It's older than tonight, because the dust in it has settled. Some other day, after some piece of news I wasn't here for, he stood in this study and put his fist through the wall.

And then he pulled it out, and flexed the fingers, and walked to the next meeting.

I know this because there's no blood on the plaster, no rage in the mark, just the precise impression of a man who needed to go through a wall. The wall was closer than the man who deserved it.

Lucian is at the window with his back to me. There's blood on his hands, most of it not his. He's still wearing the ruined shirt I tore open last night.

He doesn't turn around. "Silas told you not to come in, ghost," he says.

"Silas tells me a lot of things. When have I ever listened?"

"This time he was right."

I cross the room and stand behind him, close enough to touch him, and I don't touch him.

"Bastien," I say.

"Yes."

"He held the doorway?"

"He held it." His voice is level. "He put two humans behind him and he held it, and he'd never been in a fight that mattered, and he held it until I got there."

"And after? What happened after?"

He doesn't answer. The blood on him is drying, and the gray morning through the window puts his face in a light I have to be careful about reading.

"Lucian."

"I killed them all," he says, like he took the garbage out. "Six wolves, and one of them had shifted back. He put his hands down."

"And?"

"And I took his jaw off." He turns, and he looks like he's looked at himself and found what he expected. "Because he was talking."

I hold his eyes, and I don't flinch, and I don't step back. I don't do any of the things a body does when it's standing in front of something that just told it what it's capable of.

"And the pantry," he says.

"Silas told me."

"Silas told you the door, not the rest." His fingers flex at his sides. "There was a woman in the pantry, the linen girl. She was behind Bastien when he held the door, and I went for the pantry."

"Did you open it? Lucian. Did you?"

"Silas stopped me."

The room goes still, and so do I.

"He said my name," Lucian says. "*Sire*, one word, from the hall. And I turned around, and there she was behind the door, and I had my fucking hand on it."

He looks at his hands, the blood dark on them, almost black in the lamplight.

"I wanted to keep going," he says. "Not that I did it — that I wanted more of it. The pantry door was the next door and I was going to open it."

I take his hands, and he lets me. They're cold and stiff and the blood on them is someone else's. I hold them like he held my father's ledger, from the edges, something that matters.

"You stopped," I say. "Don't you see that?"

"Silas stopped me."

"You turned around." I tighten my grip. "A man who can't be stopped doesn't turn around because someone says his name. You turned around because the name was enough."

"That's a generous fucking reading, ghost."

"That's the correct reading." I look up at him. "I'm a translator. Don't you trust the translation?"

His jaw loosens, and whatever's been holding since he walked into the dining room lets go, one fraction at a time.

"Bastien was eighty-nine," he says.

"I know."

"He called me *sire* every time I told him not to. Every single time. I told him once I'd have him flogged, and he laughed and said *yes, sire*."

"I know."

"He grinned when I corrected him. Like it was a gift. Like being told he was wrong meant somebody was paying attention."

"I know, Lucian."

He puts his forehead against mine, his eyes closed, his breath uneven, and his fingers in mine are shaking.

"They came through the kitchen," he says. "Somebody let them in."

"I know."

"The same hand, every time, the same hand on the same door."

I hold on, and the house holds still around us. Somewhere below, men are washing a wall and taking a door off its hinges.

"Tomorrow?" I say. "You're sure?"

"Tomorrow."

"He comes at the usual hour?"

"He comes at the usual hour."

I let go of him and go to the desk and I pick up the blade — the one that was his father's, the one that's keyed to one man's blood — and I put it in his coat, in the pocket where it lives.

"Go sleep," he says.

"You won't."

"No. Would you?"

I leave him in the study with the lamp on and the blood drying on his knuckles. The hallway is dark and the house smells like what happened in it tonight. I go to the west wing and I shut the door, all the way, for the first time since I moved in.

Then I open it again, as wide as it goes.

If anybody comes for him tomorrow, they walk past me first.



CHAPTER

Thirty-Three

SELENE

“YOU’LL WANT to be close enough to hear,” Marguerite says. “Not in the room, but close enough.”

She’s standing in the door of the west wing with her hands folded. It takes me a second to understand that she’s been standing there a while. She hasn’t come in. She’s never once come in.

“He told you,” I say.

“This morning, and I’d have given a great deal for it to be anyone else telling me.” She looks past me, at the window. “He came to my rooms before the sun was up and sat on the end of my bed like he did when he was a boy with a nightmare, and he told me.”

“All of it? Even the part about you?”

“Enough of it.” Her jaw sets. “Cassian’s name, the window, my brother.”

What do I say to her? I’ve spent weeks in this house translating what Marguerite means underneath what Marguerite says, and right now there’s nothing underneath. She’s just an old woman in a doorway.

“I’m sorry,” I say.

“Don’t be, for God’s sake.” She finally looks at me. “I’ve known Cassian Vale for longer than your country has had a flag. He stood beside me at my

brother's funeral and held my hand through the whole of it. He sat in my kitchen last week and asked about my chest."

"He asks everyone about their chest. Shit, he asked me about mine."

It comes out before I can stop it, and her mouth twitches into something that isn't quite a smile.

"Yes," she says. "He does."



SHE COMES INTO the room, just inside the door, for the first time.

"The court will be there," she says, "two of the Roches, and Silas. It has to be witnessed, and it has to be done correctly, and the boy will do it correctly because that's who my brother made him."

"Then why do you need me close enough to hear? What the hell am I supposed to do from a bench?"

"Because the court will be witnessing the law." She looks at me very steadily. "Somebody has to witness him."

The sentence goes into me and sits down. "Why me?"

"Because you're the only person in this house he didn't choose for his father's reasons." She turns back to the door. "Everyone else he keeps because Aurelian kept them. You, he found in a hallway."

"You wanted my ass out by the weekend. You told Aldric's cousin's wife I'd be gone by Saturday. I heard you on the stairs."

"I did." She doesn't apologize. "I was wrong about the weekend. I'm frequently wrong about weekends, aren't I?"

She goes, her heels on the hall floor, even and unhurried.

Then she stops, and without turning around she says, "He'll need to eat afterward. He won't want to, so make him."

"How? He doesn't eat when he's sad, and he's going to be the saddest man in Louisiana."

"You're a bartender, aren't you? Pour him something." Her voice drifts back up the hall. "Figure it out."



THE HOUSE EMPTIES out in the afternoon. The staff are sent home, and the linen girl is already in Lafayette. The kitchen is dark except for one lamp, and under the lamp Silas is sitting at the long table with a whetstone and a short plain blade.

He doesn't look up when I come in.

I get a glass of water I don't want and stand at the counter and watch him. The stone goes one way, then the other, and the sound is small and wet and steady, and it's the only sound in the whole house.

"That isn't his father's," I say.

"No."

"He asked you for it."

"This morning." The stone goes one way. "He said he wanted plain steel, nothing with anyone's blood in it."

"Did he say why? Or did he just ask?"

"He didn't have to." Silas tests the edge on his thumbnail, and it shaves a sliver of nail off clean, and he goes back to the stone anyway.

I've never had a conversation with Silas that lasted longer than a sentence. I've never seen the man sit, not once, in all this time.

"Can I ask you something?"

"You're going to."

"Did you know, before, about Cassian? I'm sorry, you don't have to—"

The stone stops. For a long moment he doesn't move at all, and then he starts again, slower.

"I knew he was the only door in this house I never checked," he says. "That's not the same thing."

"No."

"It's worse. Isn't it?"

He turns the blade over and does the other side.

"When it's done," he says, without looking at me, "he'll sit on the floor. He always sits on the floor, after. Since he was a boy." The stone goes one way. "Don't let him sit there too long."

"I won't. I swear to God."

“Good.” The stone goes the other way. “He listens to you.”

“He doesn’t listen to anyone. He’s a stubborn bastard.”

Silas looks up at me for the first time, and his face is completely flat, and his eyes aren’t.

“He listens to you,” he says again.

Then he goes back to the stone, and I understand I’ve been dismissed, and I go.



LUCIAN FINDS me in the west hall an hour before dark.

He’s dressed in the dark coat, the one that fits his shoulders, with his hair back. He looks like a king, which is to say like nobody I’d ever want to be in a room with.

He stops in front of me and doesn’t say anything, and then he puts his forehead against mine.

He’s cold, as he always is. His palms come up and hold my face on either side. He stands there in the hall with his forehead on mine and his eyes closed. I can feel him breathing, slow, deliberate, a man counting himself down.

“Ghost,” he says.

“I’m here.”

“Stay out of the room. Will you do that for me?”

“Marguerite already told me.”

“Marguerite told you to stay close enough to hear. Didn’t she?”

“She did.”

His thumbs move on my jaw.

“Then stay close enough to hear,” he says. “And stay out of the room.”

“Lucian—”

“Say it. Please, ghost. Say it.”

“I’ll stay out of the room.”

He kisses me, hard, once, with his hand on the back of my neck, and there’s no heat in it at all. It’s a man leaving his hand print on the one thing he wants back before he goes into a fire.

Then he goes down the hall to the study, and I watch the lamplight come on in the open doorway.



CASSIAN COMES at the usual hour.

I see him from the west hall window. He crosses the courtyard in the last of the light with his coat buttoned and his hands in his pockets, and halfway across he stops.

He stands in the middle of the courtyard, where the stone is worn in a patch, pale, smoother than the rest. I've walked across it a hundred times and never noticed. Why would I?

He looks down at it for a while, and then he looks up at the house, at the windows, at me.

He sees me. I know he does.

And he takes one hand out of his pocket and lifts it, a little wave, the kind you give somebody's granddaughter across a garden party.

I don't know what the fuck my body does, but my hand comes up and I wave back.

He smiles, and it reaches his eyes, because with him it always does.

In English that's a wave. Underneath, it's a man saying goodbye to a house.

He goes in through the east door, which has been open to him since before this city had a name.



I SIT ON the bench at the end of the west hall, past the turn, where the study door is out of sight and every sound from that room comes down the corridor like water down a gutter. I've sat here a dozen times without knowing what it was for, and now I know.

I hear the front hall, the coat coming off, maybe, or not, and footsteps on the boards, slightly heavier than they should be, because he's always walked like the floor was something he was doing a favor.

The footsteps stop outside the study.

And I wait for him to walk in, the way he has walked in every evening, and he doesn't.

I hear him knock, and it's the first wrong thing: three knocks, even, deliberate, from a man who's already decided what the knocking means.

He knows. He knows, goddamn it, and he knew in the courtyard. Maybe he knew when he buttoned his coat.

"Come in," Lucian says. Is his voice shaking? It isn't. God help me, it isn't.

The study door is always open, and it stays open.

I hold on to the edge of the bench and I listen.



CHAPTER

Thirty-Four

LUCIAN

THE DOOR TO my father's study is unlocked, the way it has been since Tuesday.

I could have changed that in an afternoon, with a new lock, a new key, one instruction to Silas. I've thought about it most days since and never once given the order, and tonight I understand why.

I left it open because he's allowed in here, which was always true, and some part of me is still working off the old list.

The trap is a different thing. I built it this afternoon, and it happens to use this room.

Selene is on the bench in the west hall. I haven't looked, and I haven't listened. I know it the way I know my own skin is cold — it's in the blood now, since her wrist, since the cut she put there herself: a low signal, steady as a wire, telling me where the warm thing is.

It's new, and I haven't told her about it.

He comes at the hour he always comes, and then he knocks, which he has never once had to do.

"Boy."

"Come in."

He looks tired, as he's looked since the funeral. Nobody would believe that part if I said it out loud.

He crosses to the chair by the window and stops, because I've turned it back around to face the desk.

"You moved it?" he says.

"It was facing the wrong way. It has been for a long time."

"Your father never sat facing the window."

"No. He didn't, God rest him."

Cassian sits down in it anyway, rests his palms on his knees and waits. The silence goes on long enough to be a question, and he doesn't fill it.

He's the only man alive who doesn't fill my silences. Why didn't that tell me something a long time ago?

"How is Marguerite's chest?" he asks. "She was rattling at the council."

"She's fine. Why do you always ask about her chest?"

"Because nobody else does. She works too hard, and she won't be told."

"Cassian."

"Mm? You've got something on your desk, boy. Are you going to show me?"

I put the ledger on the desk between us.

Selene's father kept it for years: every job, every client, every fee. One client never gave a name, only a mark, a little hooked figure Daniel Ward copied down again and again without ever understanding it.

It's at the bottom of every private letter Cassian has ever sent me.

He looks at it for a while, then reaches out and turns it a few degrees, square to the edge of the desk, because he's always straightened things.

"Where did you get this? No — don't tell me."

"Does it matter?"

"No." He sits back. "No, I suppose not."

"Say it again."

"It doesn't matter where you got it." He almost smiles. "You've always done that, since you were small: made a man say it twice so he has to hear himself."

"Did you kill my father?"

"Yes."

The word goes into the room and nothing happens to the fucking room.

I had plans for this, a sequence of questions, an order to take them in, a way to walk him into it — and he takes the whole structure apart with one syllable.

Then he sits there and looks at me, very nearly patient.

“Ask me the rest,” he says. “You’ve earned the rest.”

“The wolves? Was that you too?”

“I told a boy on a shrimp boat that a translator was informing on his father.” A pause. “It was easier than it should have been.”

“The windows? The latches?”

“Mine. Somebody had to leave them unlatched,” he says, without weight. “Who looks at the man who arrives afterward?”

So there it is.

Wolves came through the gallery, and this city built a war out of that. And the gallery had a latch, and the latch had fingers on it. They belonged to a man with a key to every room in this building.

I’ve spent a month asking who let them in, and I asked *him*, twice.

He helped me look. He sat in that chair and went through the household with me, name by name. He was thorough about it, and he never once steered me wrong.

He didn’t have to, because there was nothing at the end of that list.

“You helped me search?” I say.

“You needed to search. Would you have believed anything else?”

“You gave me Thibault’s men, and the gallery roster.”

“I gave you everything that was true,” he says, without defending himself. “You’d have found the hole in it eventually, and you found it.”

“I found it because a dead translator wrote a shape in a book, you bastard.”

Cassian looks at the ledger again, and his jaw loosens, and it isn’t fear.

“Daniel Ward,” he says. “He asked good questions. I remember thinking so at the time.”

“The poison?” I say. “Was that you?”

"I never met the witch. There's a broker between us." He glances up. "He has a name and I'd rather you heard it from somebody who isn't dying. Write it down tonight, because I won't be able to say it again."

"Why? Why, God damn you?"

And here it is.

He looks up at me and his face does what it has always done, the warmth coming up in it like milk on a stove. He's about to be honest with me for the first time in my life.

"Because your father took my daughter's head off in a courtyard while I asked him not to," he says. "Because he was right to. Under the law. And that law is a thing we wrote to make ourselves legible to our food. We are the oldest predator that has ever lived, and we drafted a statute that makes us apologize for our mouths. He put the leash on his own throat and called it philosophy. Then he held me to it. I loved him, and I want that understood, and he was the most dangerous idea anyone has ever had about what we are."

One paragraph, when he's had sixty years to write it, and he keeps it that short.

Is he wrong? He isn't, and I can't put that down.

I made this argument myself, at this desk, with more heat in it and worse phrasing. My father heard me out and passed me the wine. I have no answer to it that isn't borrowed from a dead man.

"She killed a woman for the pleasure of it, didn't she?" I say.

"She did. Do you think I didn't know?"

"You don't say her name, do you?"

He stops.

It's the only time tonight I get in front of him. His mouth opens and stays open, and he goes still, and for a moment there is nothing behind his face at all.

"No," he says. "I don't."

"Why not?"

"How is your mother's house in Toulouse?" He is looking at the window now. "Do you still keep it?"

"Cassian."

"I ask because she chose the stone herself, and your father wanted brick." A breath. "You should keep it."

He won't walk through that door. He's had sixty years to brick it up and I'm not the one who gets it open tonight.

I don't need it open. I need what's already on the desk.



"Stand up," I say. "God damn you, stand up."

He stands.

He knows what this is. He's known since he saw the chair turned around, and I'd put money on him knowing since Tuesday.

What he does is check his cuffs, one and then the other.

"Will you hear the charge?" I ask.

"Is there one? You'd give an old man a charge?"

"Under the Code: the killing of a king, the killing of a kinsman, a false witness used to start a war." My voice is steady, which surprises me. "You have no recognized justification. Grief isn't one, and being right isn't one either."

"No," he agrees. "It isn't."

"Then the judgment is mine."

"You're not crowned. Does that bother you?"

"No."

"Then doesn't the council hold it?"

"The council held it while I looked for you." I come around the desk. "And I found you."

He takes that in, and then he nods, once, like a man agreeing to a change in a schedule.

"Do you want to fight me," I say.

There's no question mark in my voice and I don't put one there.

"Would it help you? Tell me honestly."

"Nothing about tonight fucking helps me."

"No."

"Then no."

He unbuttons his jacket and folds it over the back of the chair. He does it neatly, because he has been neat his whole life.

"You'd have had me standing up, boy, without hurrying." He smooths the collar flat. "I've known that since you were young, and I never said it to you. I'd like you to hear it while it's still worth something."

He's older than me by lifetimes and it has never mattered, because age is the floor. It was never the ceiling.

He was never the threat. He was the threat because he was standing close.

"On your knees," I say.

He kneels.

Then I open the door.

Silas is outside it with two of the court. They come in and stand where I put them, and nobody says a word.

"One more," I say, and go out into the hall.

She's on the bench at the turn, where Marguerite put her, gripping the edge of it.

"Selene."

She looks up, and she's already standing.

"The statute wants witnesses," I tell her. "He killed your father too, and you have the right to be in the room. You don't have the duty."

She comes down the hall before I've finished the sentence and stops in the study doorway. Cassian turns his head where he kneels and sees her, and for the first time tonight something crosses his face that he didn't put there himself.

"Miss Ward," he says. "Have you come to watch?"

"Say his name."

He knows which name. "Daniel Ward."

"Again."

It's almost a laugh, if there were any air behind it. "You've been spending time with the boy."

"Again."

"Daniel Ward." He holds her eyes. "He asked good questions."

"He taught me to ask them." She doesn't come any closer, and she doesn't need to. "You asked everybody in this city about their mothers. You never once asked me about mine."

Cassian looks at her for a long moment, and then he lowers his eyes, the only thing I have ever seen him lower.

"Stay, my witness," I tell her.

"I'm not going anywhere."

There's a protocol and the protocol exists for a reason: drained first, then the head, in front of witnesses, so that no one can ever say a king was murdered in a room with the door shut. My father wrote that, and he hated it.

He used it on this man's daughter and he did it himself, because he wouldn't hand the ugly part to somebody else.

The Bloodsteel is in my coat, where it's been for weeks.

I take it out and put it on the desk where he can see it, and it stays there. It's keyed to my father's blood, and against Cassian it's a kitchen knife.

It was only ever going to kill one man, and he saw to that.

I take him by the hair and tip his head back until his throat is bare.

Nearly seven hundred years of pulse under that skin, and I can see it — the vein, the rhythm, the whole long history of a man who kept his collar open because he had nothing to fear from the air.

Then I put my mouth on his throat, and this is not feeding. It is the opposite of feeding. God help me, it is the opposite.

When I feed, the blood comes easily, the body giving it up, a gate opening, a held thing released.

This is a taking, and his body fights me. Every cell of him resists — the blood comes thick and slow, and I have to pull for it. The pulling is the worst thing I have ever done with my mouth. My tongue is flat against the wound, and my throat works around every mouthful.

His blood tastes like my childhood, and I was not fucking prepared for that. It tastes like the courtyard and the blade and the evening light on stone, like the man who taught me to hold a weapon and poured me wine when my father wouldn't, and it keeps coming. I swallow, and swallow again, and I don't stop.

I'm shaking.

"Good boy," he says.

"Don't. For Christ's sake, don't."

"Good boy." His voice is going thin, the warmth in it leaving from the edges, like a lamp going out. His hand finds my wrist — the grip from the courtyard, from the funeral, from every evening he sat in this room and steadied me with a touch that was never a lie.

His skin is changing under my mouth. The warmth goes out of it first — he goes cold, and then past cold, into a cold that isn't temperature anymore. His skin turns gray, not the gray of stone but the gray of paper left in the sun, thin, translucent. I can see the veins emptying under the surface, collapsing like tunnels with nothing left to hold them open.

I drink my uncle until he can't hold his own head up.



I SWALLOW AND swallow. It takes a long time, longer than it takes with anyone, because there is so much of him and none of it wants to leave.

His heartbeat slows under my tongue, the spaces between beats getting longer. Each beat pushes less, and each pull takes more.

A sound comes out of him, a rattle, a chest that has forgotten how to fill, pushing the last of its air through a throat that's already somewhere else.

By the end he's on his side on the floor and his eyes are still working.

Draining doesn't take the mind. My father knew that cruelty and used it anyway, on a girl he'd carried on his shoulders.

His face is a ruin of what it was, the skin pulled tight over the skull, the lips drawn back, the eyes sunken but alive. He looks like a saint's body found in a wall — a man who has been still for centuries and is only now being discovered.

I kneel down next to him, and my knees go into the wet, and I don't care.

"Was it only you?" I ask. "Cassian. Was it only you?"

His eyes come around to me, and it costs him something to do it.

"I meant it." His voice is nothing, a shape made out of air. "Every part of it. Don't let them tell you I was ill, or mad with grief, or led."

"Cassian—"

"I chose." His fingers move. "I want you certain of that."

"I'm certain. Christ, I'm certain."

"Good." His mouth softens, tenderness, maybe, or the last of it. "Good boy."

"Was it only you?"

The pause goes on so long I think he's gone.

Then his mouth works. "No."

"Who? Tell me who, you bastard."

His fingers come up off the floor and find my wrist.

It's the grip from the funeral, and from the courtyard before that, when I was a boy: a man steadying someone who stumbled into him.

"Verity," he says.

The truth.

He's telling me he's given me the truth of it. It's an old man's word for it, and it's the last one he has.

What's the rest of the sentence? I wait for it, and it doesn't come.

I sit on the floor of my father's study with my uncle's blood soaking through my knees, and his grip goes loose around my wrist.

I have been given an answer. What is it? I don't know, and I stand up.



MY KNEES ARE wet, and my mouth is wet. I can taste him: age, and dust, and underneath both, the taste of the courtyard, like the blade lessons, like a man saying *again* until my wrist stopped hurting.

The Bloodsteel is on the desk. It's been on the desk the whole time — my father's blade, keyed to my father's blood, useless for this.

I don't use it. I take the other blade from my coat, the short one, plain steel, that Silas sharpened this morning without asking why.

Cassian is on the floor with his eyes open, watching me.

The head comes off after the draining. That's the protocol, and I keep to it.

Silas is behind me, and the Roche brothers are at the wall. Selene is in the doorway, and she hasn't looked away once, and nobody speaks.

I kneel back down and put one hand on Cassian's shoulder — the same shoulder I gripped at the funeral, when I was trying to stay upright and he was the only solid thing in the room.

"Close your eyes," I say.

"No." His voice is nothing — air pushed through a throat that has no blood left to warm it. "I'd like to see you do it."

I hold the blade against his neck. The steel is cold, and his skin is colder. The blade shakes, once.

Then it doesn't.

The cut is clean, one stroke, through the muscle and the spine. The resistance is less than I expected — his body has so little left in it that the blade goes through almost gently.

His head comes away from his shoulders and his eyes are still open and they are still looking at me when it happens, and the last thing in them is not fear.

It's pride.

The body settles, and the blood that's left — not much, a thin dark seep — pools on the floor around my knees.

Silas steps forward and looks at the body, looks at the head, looks at me.

"The hour is nine-fourteen," he says, as he says everything. Then he takes out a cloth and lays it over Cassian's face, and the small decency of that nearly takes my legs out.

The word stays in the room after he's gone out of it.

I sit down on the fucking floor without deciding to.

After a while, Silas clears his throat, which he has never done, not once in two hundred years. The sound is so wrong coming out of that man that I look up.

He's holding a paper, folded once, with a line written on the front in his small square handwriting.

"When you're able, sire."

I hold out my hand, and he puts the paper in it. I don't unfold it, and I don't read it. I pick up Cassian's pen from the desk, still warm from the dead man's coat, and I sign across the fold.

Silas takes it back and puts it inside his coat, and steps back to the wall.

The doorway is empty, and I didn't see her go.

I'll read it tomorrow, though I know already. Silas Roche has asked me for one thing in two hundred years — a week — and whatever he's spending now, he's spending on the woman in the house on neutral ground.



I FIND ISABEAU in the front hall.

She's standing at the bottom of the stairs with a coat she hasn't put on and a face that knows everything and is choosing what to show me.

How do you tell a woman you've killed her father? Yourself: no messenger, no Silas, no note delivered to a house she keeps a few streets from here. I stand in the hall with her father's blood on my shirt and I say the sentence.

"Thank you," she says. "For telling me yourself."

It's courtesy, not grief. She said goodbye to her father years ago, when he stopped seeing her, which was long before he stopped seeing anyone else.

She puts on the coat and buttons it with fingers that don't shake.

"He loved you," she says. "I want you to know that. The love was real, and it was always real."

"I know."

"That's the worst part."

"Yes."

She goes out the front door without looking at the study. The coat she chose has a collar that covers the back of her neck. I think she chose it for exactly that reason.



SELENE IS IN the west wing, on the bed, not the floor, sitting upright, with the ledger closed on the table and her fingers laced in her lap, a woman who watched every second of it from a doorway and is deciding what to do with the seeing.

She sees me, and she doesn't flinch at the blood.

"Marguerite told me to make you eat," she says.

"I'm not hungry. How could I be?"

"I know. She said you'd say that."

"What do you need?" she says. "Tell me. Anything."

"I need you to not leave this room, ghost. For God's sake, don't leave."

"I'm not leaving. Where the hell would I go?"

I stand in the doorway. My father's study is behind me, down the hall, being cleaned by men who will never speak about tonight, and Cassian's body is being taken out through the east passage, wrapped in a sheet Silas chose, carried by people who don't know what they're carrying.

"I killed the man who raised me tonight," I say. "I did it correctly, under the law, in the room my father built. I drained him on the floor, and I took his head with a blade Silas sharpened this morning."

"I know."

"I did it under the Code, by the protocol, in front of witnesses, with the door open, the way my father did it to his daughter sixty years ago."

"Lucian—"

"And if he had touched you—" My voice changes. What was in the dining room comes into it, and the pantry door, and I can hear it and I cannot stop it. "If any part of this had pointed at you — if Cassian had sent a wolf to your apartment instead of to a translator's house — I would have done it in the fucking street with my hands and I would not have used the law and I would not have been sorry and God help anyone who got between me and the door."

The room is very still, and she doesn't move.

"That's the truth of me," I say. "The law and the animal. I used the law tonight because my father was right, but for you I would have been the thing the law was written to prevent."

She stands up and crosses the room and puts her palms flat on my face, like she held me on the floor two nights ago, and she looks at me with both registers running.

"I know," she says. "I've always known. That's why I'm here."



SHE DOESN'T take me to bed. She takes me to the washstand.

She fills the basin and wets a cloth and washes my hands, one and then the other, as you'd wash something you meant to keep. The water goes pink, then red, and she empties it and fills it again. She doesn't say anything, and she doesn't hurry, and she doesn't look away from what comes off my skin.

When my hands are clean she washes my mouth, the cloth at my lip, her thumb on my tongue, as if she can wipe the taste of him off it.

That's where it breaks, not in the study but here, with a warm cloth at the corner of my lip and her thumb holding my jaw still. It comes up out of me with no sound at all, and my shoulders go. She pulls my head down against her neck and holds it there while I shake.

"Stay here," she says, "with me."

"I'm here."

"So am I. I'm not going anywhere, you hear me? Not a fucking inch."

We end up on the floor with our backs against the bed, because neither of us makes it the last three feet. She keeps my hands in her lap, and my fingers are still shaking. She covers them with hers and holds them still.

She says something I don't catch. It comes out in one language — not wolf, not English, not the court register she's been working in since she walked through my door — just a word, hers.

I hold onto it, and I hold onto her, and it's the quietest hour this house has had since Tuesday.



AFTER.

Sometime before dawn we get into the bed, her on my chest and my palm on her back. The window is dark and the house is still and Silas is somewhere in the building writing things down in a script I'll never be able to read.

"Your father's Code," she says.

"What about it? Tonight of all nights?"

"It's not a philosophy. It's a fence." She traces a line on my chest. "You build it because the thing on the other side of it is you."

"You told me that once before."

"I'm saying it again." She lifts her head. "Because that night you heard it about your father. Tonight I need you to hear it about yourself."

"I hear it. Do you believe I hear it?"

"The fence held tonight, Lucian. You used the law, and you did it correctly. And the man who told you the law was a leash is the man who proved it wasn't."

I look at the ceiling, and the house settles around us — the small sounds of a building that has lost a heavy man and is finding its new weight.

"He was proud of me," I say.

"I know."

"He taught me the hands I used to kill him and he died proud that I used them well." I close my eyes. "I'm going to carry that, and I'm not going to put it down."

She puts her face back on my chest, her finger staying on the line she was tracing.

"Then carry it," she says. "I'll be here."

His last word is still in the room, and tonight I let it stay there.

Tonight the door is open and the chair is turned around and the man who sat in it is gone. His coat is still on the back of it. His coat is smooth, because he was neat his whole life.

I don't move her, and that's how I know.



CHAPTER

Thirty-Five

LUCIAN

I TAKE THE CROWN on a Thursday.

That isn't symbolic. Thursday is the day Marguerite had the chamber cleaned, the day the Roche brothers finished the new door for the dining room, and the day Silas told me the household had been walked and the count was accurate.

It's also the day a man in Barataria takes his boat out, and why do I remember that? Christ knows. The world goes on being the world while you attend to the parts of it with your name on them.



THE CORONATION is small, not humble. Humble means you want it noticed that you're not making a fuss. Small means you've decided how much room it takes up.

Marguerite, Silas, three Elders, and the Roche brothers at the door: no public gallery, no continental observers, and no Aldric, who was invited and declined, which is a sentence I'm going to remember when the time comes.

The chamber smells like wood polish and new putty. They've re-glazed the gallery windows where the wolves came through. The new glass is a shade clearer than the old, and nobody has mentioned it.

Marguerite puts the crown on my head, a piece of metal, lighter than the blade in my coat.

She steps back, and she doesn't bow, because Marguerite has never bowed to anything in her life. I would not ask her to start with me.

"Traditionally, God help us," she says, "this is where the King says something. One sentence will do. The continent needs to know you can open your mouth without starting a war."

I look at the floor where my father stood while a man with a blade walked across the room behind him.

"The door stays open," I say.

Marguerite waits for the rest.

"That's it. My father kept this door open because he believed people should be able to walk in, and I'm keeping it open because I believe they should be able to walk out."

She measures the sentence against centuries of coronation speeches, and her mouth moves.

"That's better than your father's," she says.

"What was his? Something noble?"

"He quoted a poet, badly." She adjusts a cuff.

"One more thing," I say. "The motion for war. Did anyone think I'd let it stand?"

The room goes still. Did any of them think I'd forget? Every seat voted for it, and every House has men at the river waiting for the order.

"It was moved on the testimony of a man who confessed, with the court watching, to arranging the thing it answers," I say. "Under the Code, a motion built on a false witness is void from the day it was moved. I'm not rescinding it, because it never stood."

Marguerite doesn't argue. She takes the pen from the clerk and strikes the motion from the record herself, one line through it, and signs the margin.

"The Houses stand down tonight," I say. "Nobody crosses the river, and Gaspard hears it from me."

"He'll hear it before you finish the sentence," Marguerite says. "Come. There's wine, and three Elders who want to tell you how they voted for your grandfather."



TOBIAS IS WAITING in the study with the coronation certification in continental form. It needs one witness of administrative rank, and he's written it in one pass, in a small, precise hand I recognize from the archive tabs.

"If you'll sign," he says. "Here, and here, and — sorry — here."

I sign, as I sign everything today.

He folds it into his coat without sitting down and leaves by the side door before the wine is poured. He spent a month indexing the evidence against his own cousin and never once put his name on the work.

A king should know who does his work without asking to be thanked, so I put his name somewhere I won't lose it.



GASPARD THIBODEAUX comes at dusk. He brings two of his men and walks in through the front door, the first wolf inside this house since the gallery. He looks like the bayou made him: salt-cured, wide-shouldered, with knuckles that haven't been clean since before I was born.

"Your Majesty."

"Gaspard."

"You pulled your Houses off the river," he says, "every one of them, before the ink was dry. You think the pack didn't notice?"

"It was never your war. Was it?"

"No." He studies me. "I've come about the boy."

Rémy, the wolf who killed a translator and his wife on their own porch, and carried the order ever since.

"He'll testify," I say. "After that, he's between him and the woman he wronged."

"The woman doesn't want him dead." Gaspard says it without expression. "She had a blade in her bag on my dock and she took her hand off it."

"I know."

"Then here's mine: exile. He leaves the pack and he leaves Barataria, and he doesn't come back until someone in this city tells him he can." His jaw works. "He took an order from a vampire and killed a human family. Our rules aren't your Code. They don't come with philosophy. They come with the door."

"Public? In front of the whole pack?"

"In front of the pack, tomorrow." He looks toward the courtyard. "Send the woman. She's earned it."

He turns to leave, then stops. "King of teeth," he says.

I go still, and he sees it.

"That's what we called your father. You know that by now." He looks at the crown. "He never used his on us. You used yours, on a man who earned it. That's a third meaning, and the pack will like it better than the other two."

He walks out through the front door and doesn't turn around.



SELENE IS IN the courtyard, on the bench by the fountain my father put there because he believed courtyards should have places to sit, even courtyards nobody sat in. Her father's ledger is open on her knee, and she's wearing the boots she bought on Magazine Street.

Marguerite invited her to the coronation, stiffly and in writing, which from Marguerite is a bouquet, and Selene said no. *That's their language. Let them speak it. I'll be in the courtyard.*

I go down. She looks up when I cross the stones, and sees the crown. Her face does something I've never seen it do: a woman who has been looking at a man for weeks, seeing what he was always going to become.

"It's smaller than I thought," she says.

"So I'm told, ghost. Disappointed?"

"Does it come off? Please tell me it comes off."

"It comes off."

"Good, because it's ugly. It looks like a hubcap with ambitions."

"It's four hundred years old."

"So's the ugly."

I sit beside her. The bench is cold, and the fountain makes the sound it's made since my father built it.

A door opens on the gallery above us: Roche, the younger one, leaving the chamber. He looks down and sees his King on a stone bench with a woman, her knee against his, no distance between them.

I don't move, and I don't create space.

He nods once, precisely, and goes back through the door, and by morning the whole court will know what that nod means.

"The pact," I say. "The terms are met. The arrangement—"

"The arrangement ended weeks ago and we both know it." She closes the ledger. "I stopped counting the night you turned my father's pages from the corner. Didn't you?"

"Selene."

"Don't. Don't say anything kingly, and don't say *mine* or *stay* or anything with a title in front of it. Say what's underneath."

"I don't want to do this without you, ghost. Do you understand me?"

"Do what? Say it."

"Any of it." I take the crown off and set it on the bench between us, a piece of metal on a piece of stone. "The house, the city, the morning, and the one after that."

"That's not a pact, is it?"

"No."

She picks up the crown and turns it over, and then she puts it back on my head.

"Still ugly as hell," she says, "but it fits."



SHE TAKES IT off me again that night, in my room, with the door open.

She lifts it off as if it's hot, then puts it on her own head. It's too big, and it slides down over one eyebrow, and she's naked under it.

"Your Majesty," she says, and climbs into my lap.

It's what she calls me when she wants to cut me, and tonight it's a different blade.

She settles on my thighs and rolls her hips once, slow. I'm hard against her before she's finished the movement. She's already wet. I feel it on my skin, warm. Her nipples brush my chest, and the crown tips further and she doesn't fix it.

"Say it," she says. "Your one sentence. Can you say it to me?"

"The door stays open."

"Mm. Is that the best you've got?" She reaches between us and wraps her fingers around my cock and squeezes, and my head goes back against the headboard. "Try again. The one underneath."

I look up at her: a half-wolf bartender wearing my father's crown crooked, slick against my thigh, waiting for me to say it properly.

"I'm yours," I tell her. "Whatever I'm king of."

She sinks down onto me all at once, and the crown slides the rest of the way over one eye, and she leaves it there.

"How do I look?" she says, rolling her hips once, slow, wet and tight around my cock.

"Like a coup."

"Good." She rides me with her palms on my chest and her thighs locked on my hips, and she doesn't hurry, and every time the crown slips she laughs, and every time she laughs her cunt tightens on me until I'm swearing at the ceiling. "Say it again. The underneath one."

"I'm yours."

"Louder, Your Majesty. The fucking gallery can't hear you."

I say it louder. She comes on the third time I say it, grinding down with her head thrown back and the crown falling off onto the sheets. I follow her with my mouth on her throat and her name in my teeth.



MUCH LATER, with her asleep across my chest, I hear the side door.

Silas, at an hour when Silas is never awake. He doesn't come up. His steps go down the back stairs to the archive. The lamp comes on under the door, and it stays on. He's been in there every night since the study.

What is he looking for? He hasn't told me, and Silas only keeps a thing from me when he's afraid of what it is.



C H A P T E R

Thirty-Six

S E L E N E

MY APARTMENT smells like dust and a coffee I made weeks ago and never drank.

I came straight here from Barataria, where this morning I stood at the treeline and watched Delphine walk her brother to the edge of pack ground while the whole pack watched. He didn't look at his father once, and she was the only one who walked with him.

I haven't been here in weeks, and shit, it shows. The plant on the windowsill is dead. It was dying when I left, and the leaving finished it. Rest in peace, you little bastard.

The deadbolt and the chain go on behind me, two locks Silas had his people put on while I was gone, the week somebody broke a window to get at me.

The knife is in my bag, where it's been since the shed, blade clean. I set the bag down next to the toaster with the intention of never opening it again.



I TAKE IT out. It's my father's, a short blade, wood handle, a nick in the bolster where somebody dropped it. I've sharpened it more times than I've used it. The last time I sharpened it I was sitting on this floor with a king on my linoleum and an intention so clean I could see my own face in it.

The intention is gone, like a word you've been using wrong for years, until somebody shows you the real one.

I was going to kill Rémy Thibodeaux, and that was the shape of my life for four years, every day arranged around it — the language learned, the schedules memorized, the bars worked, the bus rides taken — a woman building herself into a weapon aimed at one man on one boat.

And the man on the boat was a fucking instrument, somebody else's hand, somebody else's lie, a wolf sent to kill a translator by a vampire who asked about his mother first.

I didn't kill Rémy. I stood in a shed with a knife in my hand and a man with his hands down saying *go ahead*, and I lowered it. I haven't forgiven him. He'd saved my life on a dock days before, and you can't kill a man you owe. The debt was the only honest thing left in the room.

He's alive, and my parents are still dead, and that doesn't fucking change. The man who ordered their deaths is dead too, drained and beheaded in a study with the door standing open. I stood in that doorway and watched every second of it.

Does it even out? It doesn't.

Revenge promises you a clean floor at the end, and there's no clean floor.



I PUT THE knife in the junk drawer, next to the batteries and a menu from a restaurant that closed ages ago, something you keep but stop carrying. That's the whole ceremony.



THE BAR IS the same, and Antoine is behind the register. He looks up when I come in and his face lands somewhere between relief and the plain annoyance of a man who's been doing two people's work.

"You're alive," he says. "Where the hell have you been? I had to work a Saturday with Tanya. Do you know what that's like? She sings, Selene. She sings to the limes."

"I'm alive."

"You look different. You know that?"

"I've been sleeping somewhere else. Mind your own goddamn business."

"Yeah, I can tell. You've got that look. Like a cat that found the good windowsill." He shuts the register. "You sleeping somewhere better?"

"Somewhere with higher ceilings. And worse coffee, holy shit. It's like drinking a tire."

"We're short tonight," he says, "because Tanya quit."

"When?"

"Tuesday. She said the energy was wrong, if you can believe it. Said the bar had a ghost."

"Did it?"

"Only on the nights you worked, apparently."

"Jesus."

He shrugs. "Can you close? Or are you too fancy now?"

"Shut up, Antoine. I can close. Shit, I can always close."

"And some wolf girl came in asking for you last week, young, jacket about three sizes too big."

"Did she leave a name? A number?"

"She left a *tip*." He looks personally offended. "On a club soda. Five dollars on a club soda, Selene. Who raised these people?"



THE BAR FILLS like it always does. At nine o'clock the crowd turns over, and the room becomes the machine I know how to operate. I pour drinks and wipe the bar and listen.

A vampire comes in around ten, young, well-dressed, with the particular confidence of a man who knows what he is and enjoys the knowing. He orders a bourbon and looks at me like they all look at bartenders, briefly, like furniture.

Then he looks again, and his nostrils flare. He's caught whatever I am on the air, and he's trying to place it, and he can't.

"Do I know you?" he says. "Have we met?"

"No."

"You smell—" He stops. "Sorry. You smell familiar."

"I get that."

"From where, though? It's driving me crazy."

"No idea," I say, and slide him his change. "Somewhere you'd remember, probably."

"I'd remember a bartender who smells like that."

"Then I guess we've never met, sweetheart. Drink your fucking bourbon."

That's going to keep happening. How long before every vampire in the Quarter has caught it?

He drinks his bourbon and leaves, and the tip is extraordinary. I put it in the jar without looking at it.



AFTER MIDNIGHT the crowd thins and I'm alone behind the bar with two regulars and the television set.

Antoine comes out of the kitchen drying his hands and leans on the bar next to me.

"So," he says. "The tourist."

"What tourist?"

"Don't. Fifty-dollar bourbon, and he didn't drink it." He watches my face. "That's where you've been sleeping."

I don't answer, which is an answer.

"He treat you right? Because if he doesn't—"

I think about it, actually think about it, standing there with a rag in my hand, and he waits.

"He turns pages from the corner," I say.

Antoine stares at me. "I don't know what the fuck that means."

"It means yes. Happy now?"

"Then why do you look like you're about to cry in my bar? You never cry in my bar. You cried once in the walk-in, and you told me it was onions."

"Fuck off, it's allergies."

"To what?"

"You, you nosy bastard."

He shakes his head and goes back to the kitchen, and at the door he stops.

"Girl," he says, without turning around. "You're allowed."

Then he's gone, and I'm standing behind my own bar with my eyes stinging, like an idiot.

I wipe the bar and I think about what I know. What do I actually know?

My father was a translator, and he did private work for a man who used a hooked mark and paid too much and never gave a name. The man killed him to close the account, and the killing was done by a wolf, and the wolf was done by a lie.

The man is dead, and the wolf is alive. The lie is in a ledger in a house across the Quarter, being held by a king with an ugly crown and clean hands.

And Cray: somebody paid a broker named Cray, and Silas has been in the archive every night since the study, and he won't say what he's found. Silas doesn't say things he can't carry yet.

A grieving uncle killed a king and was killed in turn. The Code held, and that part of the story is finished.

Tonight I close a bar and count a register and walk home through a city that doesn't know what the fuck lives in it.

And tomorrow I keep asking. My father left me a ledger with *for S, when she asks* written on the last page, and I'm not done asking.



I CLOSE UP, count the register, put the envelope in the safe, and then I sit on my crate in the alley and take my phone out.

Three contacts that aren't the bar: my landlord, my dentist, and the woman in Tremé who sells me the tea.

I add a fourth, and it isn't him.

I already have Lucian. He's been in my phone since the night he texted me about the ledger, saved under a name I'm not going to share with anyone.

The fourth number is Delphine.

She gave it to me at the treeline, the day I came for Rémy. She wrote it on the back of a gas receipt with a pen that was running out, and she said, "In case you need a wolf who's not my brother."

Will I call it? I haven't, and I'm not going to call it tonight.

But the number is in my phone, and the phone is in my pocket, and for the first time in my life I have a wolf's number that isn't attached to an intention.

It's attached to something that started the night I walked into a club on Perdido Street and has been growing ever since, slow and stubborn, in a part of me I didn't know had soil.



I WALK HOME. A man on a corner is playing a trumpet with his case open. The notes go up into the warm air and stay there.

I pass the block where Lucian pulled over in Silas's car. I can see the spot — dark, residential, the exact stretch of curb where I climbed into his lap and the horn went off.

I don't stop, but I smile, and it's a new one, not the bar smile, not the one I used to practice in a mirror with a crack in the corner. Nobody sees it, and that's fine.



THE APARTMENT is dark when I get home, the plant still dead, the cup still in the sink.

I lock the door, deadbolt and chain, same as every night since the window, and then I unlock it.

I stand there with my hand on the chain and think about Lucian's house, where nothing closes all the way, and about my mother, who left a pack and never closed the door behind her because it was already closed for her.

I take the chain off and leave the deadbolt, one lock, not two, and I go to bed.



THE BED IS mine, and the sheets are mine. The window is the one that opens, not the one that's painted shut. I leave it cracked, because the air outside smells like rain and the Quarter and cut grass.

My phone is on the pillow beside me: my landlord, my dentist, the tea woman, and a wolf named Delphine.

And Lucian, saved under a name I chose, in a city that is afraid and alive and mine.

I close my eyes. The knife is in the drawer, the ledger is in the house, and Cassian's last word is in the air.

And the last thing I think about before I sleep isn't the man I came here to kill.

It's the man I'm going back to in the morning.

◆

Epilogue

WE'RE NOT FINISHED

SELENE

THE APARTMENT is empty and the house is full, and I'm standing between them with a bag over my shoulder.

It's the same bag I carried into Perdido the night I went looking for a way across the water, small, no room for anything except keys and a phone and the ready willingness of a woman who has decided where she's going.

The knife is in the drawer, and the ledger is in the house. The plant is dead and the cup is clean. I washed it this morning, standing at a sink I've stood at for two years. The washing felt like the last sentence of a chapter.

Less an ending than a translation: the same life, in a different language.



DELPHINE CALLED this morning, and it wasn't about Rémy, or the pack, or the bench I sat on. She called because the tea woman in Tremé had a batch ready. Delphine had been buying from her too, and did I want to split the order.

"You drink the tea?" I said.

"My aunt drank it. I drink it because she did, God knows why." A pause. "Is that stupid?"

"No. Is it any good? Tell me the truth, because the last thing you recommended was that bait shop and I'm still mad about the shrimp."

"It tastes like dirt."

"Good dirt. Hell of a recommendation."

She laughed, a young sound, younger than anything else about her. It came through the phone like her water came across the bench, offered without preamble, without expectation.

I said yes, so we're splitting the order. A wolf and a woman who smells like something a wolf can't place, buying tea from a woman in Tremé who has never once asked either of us why.

Is that a friendship? I don't know what it is. Pack has a word for two people who share a thing without naming it. The word has *adjacent* in it, and *parallel*, and something that means *walking the same direction without being on the same road*.



I LOCK THE apartment with one lock, and the chain stays off.

The walk to the house takes no time at all anymore, because I've been making it for a week — back and forth, apartment to house, house to apartment, living in both places and belonging to neither.

That ends tonight. Who told me to? Nobody. I decided this morning, standing at the sink with a clean cup in my hand and a dead plant on the windowsill.

I'm not leaving it. I'm keeping it: the lease, the key, the one lock on the door, my shitty little kingdom, a room in the city that's mine, that has my shape in it, that I can go back to if the house gets loud.

But I'm going to sleep somewhere else, in a room with a window that sticks and a door that stays open and a man who reads ledgers from the corner.

S HE COMES THROUGH the front door.

The front, not the side, not the service entrance, not the courtyard gate, the one with the fanlight above it that makes a stripe of light on the floor in the afternoon.

She walks across my father's stripe of light and she doesn't know it's his. I don't tell her, because some things in a house belong to the house.

She's carrying the bag, the small one, the one with no room for anything except the things she's decided to keep, and the knife isn't in it. I look for its shape like I've looked for it every time she walks in, and it isn't there.

"I washed the cup," she says.

"What cup? Did you finally kill something?"

"The cup in the sink. The one with something growing in it. Shit had a personality."

"Congratulations. Was it a fight?"

"It fought back like hell." She puts the bag on the table in the front hall, beside the lamp, in the spot where Cassian used to leave his gloves. "The plant is dead."

"I'll buy you a new one, ghost. What kind do you want?"

"Don't. I'll kill it. I kill every fucking thing green."

"I'll buy you one that's harder to kill."

"There isn't one." She looks at me. "I'm here, you know."

"I can see that. For how long?"

"I mean I'm *here*, not for the night, not for the pact." She holds my eyes.

"There is no pact, and there hasn't been one for weeks. I'm here because I'm choosing to be here, and I want you to hear me say it."

I hear her say it. In four hundred years, nobody has ever chosen to walk into this house. They've been invited, commanded, summoned, employed. They've come for an audience, for a favor, for the pull of a name that opens doors.

She's standing in my front hall with a bag over her shoulder and no reason to be here except the reason she just said out loud.

"Say it again," I tell her.

"I'm choosing to be here."

"Again."

"Lucian—"

"Once more."

"I'm choosing to be here." She says it the third time with a weight behind it that wasn't there the first two, a woman who has put a word down and is standing on it. "Now will you stop making me say things three times? It's a habit."

"It's a good habit."

"It's an annoying habit."

"Those are the same thing. Didn't you know?"

She smiles, and it's the real one. I've seen it three times, maybe four, with nothing in front of it and nothing behind it.

I cross the hall and I take the bag off her shoulder and I put it on the table, and then I take her face in my hands.

— ◆ —
S E L E N E

HE KISSES ME in the front hall.

There's none of the command in it, none of the controlled pressure of a man who knows exactly what he's doing to a body.

He kisses me like he read the ledger, slowly, carefully, from the corner, as though what's in his hands might come apart if he's not careful with the pages.

I hold onto his wrists, his pulse slow under my thumbs, the ancient, steady rhythm of a creature that has never once had its mouth on someone who chose to be there.

"Upstairs," I say. "Now, before I lose my goddamn nerve."

"Yes. God, yes."

"Your room?"

"Our room."

I pull back, because he said it — *our room* — and the word *our* sits between us like a key laid on a table.

"That's new," I say.

"Is it wrong? Tell me if it's wrong."

"It's not wrong." I look at him. "It's a word I haven't heard in either language."

"Then I'm saying it in a third one."



L U C I A N

I CARRY HER UPSTAIRS because she lets me.

She puts her arms around my neck and lifts her feet off the ground and lets me take her weight, and she has never let anyone take her weight. I know it the way I know the things her blood told me: the stubborn, bone-deep habit of holding herself up in every room she's ever stood in.

She lets go of it on the stairs, and she also bites my ear on the landing, hard, and laughs when I nearly drop her.

THE BEDROOM door is open, as it's been since I started sleeping here.

He gets as far as the doorway and I say, "Stop."

He stops, because he always stops.

"Put me down."

He puts me down, and I put my back against the doorframe and pull him in by the shirt. He comes, and the frame is hard against my shoulder blades and he's cold all down the front of me.

"Here," I tell him.

"The bed is right there. Have you seen it? It's a very good bed."

"The bed's been there for weeks." I get his top button open. "This door's been open since I moved in, and you love a door. Why not use one?"

His face changes into something I've never seen before, and it takes me a second to name it: he's delighted.

"I'm a man of simple tastes," he says.

"You're a man of *very* specific tastes."

"Those are the same thing."

I get his shirt off, and he gets my dress up. He lifts me against the frame with his hands under my thighs, and I wrap my legs around him. His mouth comes down on my throat, and the crown falls off his head.

It hits the floor with a clang and rolls, and we both watch it go. It wobbles down the hall in a slow, stupid arc, and bumps the wainscoting, and falls over on its side.

"Your crown," I say. "Lucian, your fucking crown. Marguerite will have a stroke."

"Marguerite's had eight centuries to have a stroke. She's saving it for something good. Let it roll."

“Lucian, that’s the *crown*—”

“I know what it is.” He gets a hand between us and finds me soaked, two fingers sliding through my pussy and circling my clit once, and I stop caring about the crown. “It’ll keep.”

He fucks me against the doorframe of our room. He shoves his trousers down and lifts me higher and sinks his cock into me in one long thrust. My heels dig into the backs of his thighs.

It’s fast and laughing and a little clumsy. My elbow knocks the light switch and the lamp in the hall flicks off, then on, then off again. He laughs into my neck so hard he has to stop moving.

“Are you *laughing* at me— are you seriously fucking laughing—”

“You turned off the hall light. How did you even do that?”

“You’re the one who put me against a *switch*—”

He shuts me up by driving into me so hard the frame creaks. My head knocks back against the wood, and I stop talking and start swearing.

“There she is,” he says.

I come the first time right there, legs locked around him, heels digging into his back, the doorframe biting my shoulders and the hall light still off. It’s quick and bright and it makes me laugh at the end of it, helpless, wrecked.

He doesn’t come. He holds me there while I shake and waits until I can see again, and then he carries me to the bed.

S HE PUTS ME on my back.

Of course she does. She climbs on top and sinks down on my cock and rides me slow, her tits in my palms, and looks down at me with her hair in her face and her mouth swollen, and she says, “You said *eventually*.”

It takes me a second: the shower, her forehead on the tile, my thumb pressing once, a promise, and what I said against her ear.

“I did,” I say. “Did you think I’d forget?”

“Is it eventually? Is it now?”

I look at her, flushed to the collarbone and grinning, and nothing about her is afraid.

“Is that what you want? Truly?”

“I’ve wanted it since you said it.” She rolls her hips and watches my eyes go. “I’ve been waiting for you to remember.”

“I remembered.”

“Then why haven’t you—”

“Because you hadn’t asked.”

That stops her. She sits very still on my cock, and looks at me, and her face changes.

“I’m asking,” she says.

So I turn her over, and I take my time about it.

I put her on her stomach with a pillow under her hips. I put my mouth on the back of her neck and work my way down her spine, slow, one vertebra at a time, the way I promised in a shower when she told me not to be gentle. Tonight I’m going to be gentle, and she’s going to let me.

The oil is in the drawer of the bedside table, where it’s been since the week of the shower, because I don’t forget promises.

"You planned this?" she says into the pillow. "Holy shit. You planned this? You absolute bastard."

"I prepare. Centuries of practice, ghost. I prepare like hell."

"You *planned* this."

"Same thing."

"Oh my God. Oh my fucking God."

I warm the oil in my hands first, so it won't be cold on her, and then I spread her open with my thumbs and look at her, all of her, every part, the way I said.

Her pussy is still wet and swollen from the doorframe. Her ass is tight and flushed, and it clenches when she feels me looking.

"Plain words," I tell her. "You say stop, I stop. You don't want to talk, you tap, same as always."

"Two taps," she says. "I know. How many times have we done this?"

"Say it."

"You stop."

"Good."

I put one oiled finger against her, and circle, and wait. She breathes out, and her whole body goes looser, one muscle at a time, and when she's loose I press in.

She hisses.

"Too much? Tell me."

"No. No, it's—" She laughs, short and shocked. "Okay. That's *weird*. Keep going."

I keep going, one finger, slow, in and out, until she stops hissing and starts pushing back, her hips lifting off the pillow to meet it, and then two. My other hand slides under her and finds her clit, and her hips jerk. She moans into the pillow in a voice I've never heard her use.

"Oh," she says. "*Oh*. Okay. I get it. I get it now."

"Do you? Tell me what you get."

"Shut up. God, don't stop."

By the time I line my cock up against her she's rocking back onto my fingers and begging, and I'm shaking.

I push in slow. The head of me stretches her, and she goes rigid, and I stop.

"Breathe," I tell her.

"I'm *breathing*—"

"Slower."

"If you say *slower* one more time— I swear to God, Lucian—"

She breathes, and gives me another inch, then another. It hurts her a little and she lets me know, and I wait every time. Every time she pushes back when she's ready, until I'm all the way in her and neither of us can move.

"Lucian," she says, her voice completely wrecked. "That's— you're— *fuck*."

"I know."

"Every part of me? Every single part?"

"Every part of you."

"Eventually." She starts to laugh again, into the pillow, shaking with it. "You fucking *said* eventually."

"I did."

"It took you *weeks*. Weeks, you bastard."

"I'm four hundred years old. That's quick."

She laughs so hard her ass clenches around my cock. I groan into her shoulder, and then neither of us is laughing.

I move in her slow, short strokes, deep, and I keep my fingers on her clit the whole time. She comes apart under me in a way I've never seen, loud and filthy and completely unafraid, pushing back, her hand fisted in the sheet, swearing at me and then at God and then at me again. She comes with my cock in her ass and my fingers on her clit and my name in her mouth. I feel every pulse of it through her whole body.

It drags me over. I come deep in her with my hips flush against her ass, my forehead on her spine, and a sound coming out of me that's older than English.

— ◆ —
S E L E N E

HE CLEANS ME up first, a warm wet washcloth between my thighs, fetched at vampire speed and then denied. Then he turns me over, face to face, on our sides, my leg over his hip. He's still shaking a little, and so am I.

He puts his hand on my throat, gently, cold fingers resting on my pulse.

I put my hand on his and hold it there.

"Ghost," he says.

Not the way he says it at the bar, or in the car, or with my back on a wall. He says it like a prayer. Then he says something else.

"My witness."

I go still, because he's said it before, on the night of the window, in the glass, when he made me look.

Now he says it in a bed with nobody listening through any wall, and it means something new.

Ghost was the first word. In the hallway it meant *you won't remember this*, and then it meant the one who did. Then *mine*, which I took apart and handed back to him, and then *good girl*, which I'm keeping.

My witness is none of those.

It means you saw everything: the club, the hallway, the dining room and the pantry door and the study floor, the man who said *good boy* with his last breath. You were there for all of it, awake, with both registers running, and you stayed.

It isn't a word that locks from the outside. It's the person who can testify to what I am, because she was in the room.

"Say it again," I tell him.

He almost smiles. "My witness."

"And the other one? You know the one."

He knows which one, of course he does.

"The ghost that stayed," he says.

"That's me." I pull him closer. "Both of those. That's what I am."

"Now," I say.

He knows what I mean. He puts his mouth on my throat, and I tilt my head. The offering is the simplest thing I've ever done.

He bites.

HER BLOOD COMES up into my mouth and it brings her with it.

Three hundred and six years since blood told me anything I didn't already know. I said that to myself in a service corridor, the night she asked whether I was a vampire, and it was true then.

It's been wrong since the second taste.

There's still grief in her, softer now, settled into the foundation where it belongs. There's still fear, but she's learned to carry it, like a bag with a knife in it she's decided not to use.

And underneath both of those, where the loneliness used to be, there's something else.

Is it happiness? It isn't. Love is too small a word for what she's handing me. She'd laugh at it, and she'd be right to. It's a room.

She's giving me the feeling of being inside a room with the door open, a room she chose, a room where the window works and the bed is hers and the man beside her reads the pages from the corner. She's at home.

For the first time in her life, she's at home somewhere, and she doesn't know it yet. I know it before she does, and I'm going to carry it now.

It isn't a burden, because it was handed to me.

I drink until I can't tell her pulse from mine, and then I stop, because she hasn't asked me to and I don't need her to.

AFTER.

The room is still, the ledger on the table, the crown somewhere in the hall, the window cracked and the door open.

He closes the wound with his tongue.

"Don't," I say. "Not yet. Can't you leave it?"

"It's done."

"I wanted—"

"I know." He puts his mouth against the closed mark. "It'll still be there in the morning."

I put my face against his chest, where the clock is still going, slow and steady.

"Are we done?" I ask. "With all of it?"

He says nothing for a moment, and then: "With tonight."

"Tonight's enough. Isn't it?"

I close my eyes, his arm around me, the door open and the city outside doing what the city does.

"Shouldn't somebody get your crown?" I say.

"Silas will find it. God help us both."

"He's going to be so unhappy. He'll polish it for a week just to make a point."

"He'll polish it for a month." He laughs into my hair. "He's always unhappy."

"Lucian."

"Mm."

"I'm choosing to be here."

"I know."

"I'm going to keep choosing it."

"I know."

"Even when you're a fist. Even when the room gets loud."

He tightens his arm, and his mouth is in my hair.

"Even then," I say.

— ◆ —
L U C I A N

S HE FALLS ASLEEP on me.

Like she fell asleep the first night: mid-sentence, with her face in my neck, as though the sentence and the sleeping were part of the same act.

Sleep? I don't want to sleep. I want to lie in this bed with a woman on my chest and a crown lying on its side in the hall and an open door letting the night in.

Cassian's last word is still in the room. He told me the truth, and I've let that be the end of him, and the rest can wait. Not tonight.

Tonight is the after.

She said *stay* once, in a borrowed room, and I stayed, and I've been staying since.

Her hand is open on my chest, and the bedroom door is open behind her, and the city breathes.

I don't move her, and that's how I've always known.



SILAS COMES in the morning, and he doesn't knock.

He stands in the doorway with a page in his hand and waits until I lift my head off the pillow.

She's still on my chest, still asleep, still breathing in the rhythm I've been counting for hours.

He puts the page on the table, beside the ledger. He's holding the crown in his other hand, and he sets that down too, without a word, and steps back, looking extremely unhappy.

"The poison," he says quietly. "Cray brokered it, and Cray was paid through a holding, and the holding has been buying in this city since before you were born."

I look at the page: a column of names down the left margin, a different one every generation, each opened and closed in a different hand, one account under all of them, and one line of money that starts somewhere older than this house and runs through every death we've been tracking.

"How long?" I ask. "How long has it been buying?"

"Longer than the records go." He looks at the window. "Whatever this is, it didn't start with Cassian. He was a client, not the source."

It has been buying in this city longer than Cassian's grief, longer than the Code, longer than the truce that keeps two species inside the same walls.

Selene stirs on my chest, and her eyes open. She sees Silas in the doorway and the page on the table and my face.

She reaches for the page and reads it, her lips moving — both registers running, even half-asleep, even here.

"It's the same buyer," she says. "Every one of these. Same grammar, different signature, see?"

"I want it," Silas says. "The account, whoever's at the other end of it."

He has asked me for a week and a writ. I understand now that both of them were for her. This is the third.

"It's yours. What do you need?"

"Time, sire. And her."

He nods once and looks at the window, toward the canal and a house that sits between it and the bayou.

Selene looks at me. The door is open, and the city is waking up, and somewhere in it, a very old account has just lost its best client.

"We'll find it," she says. "We're not finished."

The Ghost That Stayed

Chapter Eleven, from her side of the bed

HE SAYS *come here* like a man who has never once had to say it twice.

I should make him. That's what I'm thinking, sitting on my own kitchen floor with my back against the wall and a vampire king propped against my cabinets. He's gray around the mouth and bleeding on my linoleum, and he still says *come here* as if the floor is his and I'm the one visiting.

I should make him say it again. He loves that. *Say it again.* I've heard him do it to me three times since the sun came up.

Instead I get up, because the floor is a stupid place to do this.

"Not here," I tell him. "The floor is stupid."

He looks at the floor as though it's been accused of something. Then he gets himself up the cabinet, one piece at a time, and I don't help him. I want to. My hands actually move, and I put them in my back pockets so they'll stop.

He wouldn't forgive me for it. You don't hold a door for a man who owns every door in the city.

He makes it to the bedroom on his own. It takes him longer than the hallway is long.



HE SITS ON the edge of my bed. My cheap frame and my good sheets, the only thing in this apartment I ever spent real money on, and now there's a vampire on them with his shirt half open and blood dried brown down one forearm.

My mother would have had a lot to say about this. None of it in English.

"How do you want to do it?" I ask.

"You're the one giving. You decide."

Oh.

I wasn't ready for that one. I've been ready for a lot of things since the hallway — teeth, orders, a hand on my throat against a cabinet. Nobody has ever handed me the decision about my own body like it's a set of keys.

In English it's a courtesy. In wolf it's standing. He just gave me standing, sitting on my bed with his arm still open, and I don't think he even knows he did it.

So I decide.

I put a knee on the bed beside him and take his face in both hands. His jaw is cold. Of course it is. Everything about him is the temperature of a church in February, and my palms are so warm against it that I can feel the difference arguing.

Then I stop, because I've reached the part I didn't plan.

"You've done this before," I say.

"Given? No."

"No?"

"No." His eyes don't move off mine. "I've been offered. I've never taken it."

"Why not?"

"Because I'd have to know what they felt about it. I've never wanted to."

My breath goes out of me all at once. Four hundred years, and nobody's ever gotten close enough for him to want to know how they felt.

I know that sentence. I've been living in it.

I don't let go of his face.

"You called me ghost," I say. "In the hallway. Twice."

"I did."

"Why?"

"It's what they are, after. The ones I feed from. They walk out of the evening and it closes behind them. Nobody remembers a thing."

"I remember everything."

"I know."

My thumbs have stopped moving on his jaw. I'm about to ask the question I've been carrying since the corridor, and my voice comes out smaller than I'd like.

"So what does that make me?"

He doesn't look away. He doesn't dress it up.

"The ghost that stayed."



I KISS HIM before he's finished saying it.

I don't decide to. My body decides, and it's been deciding things about this man since he walked into my bar and didn't see me. It decided in the corridor. It decided on my floor last night, with a knife in my hand I didn't use.

His mouth is cold and then it isn't. It warms under mine, and that shouldn't feel like winning something, and it does.

His hands go to my hips. There's barely anything in the grip. I feel him notice, feel the tiny hitch in him when he tries to move me and can't.

Holy shit. The King of New Orleans can't move me.

I get his shirt open. The buttons are small and stupid and I hate every one of them. Then I stand up off the bed, pull the dress over my head and drop it on the floor.

And he looks.

He doesn't grab or reach. He sits on my bed and looks at me as if he's going to be tested on it later.

Nobody has ever looked at me like this. People look through me. Wolves look at me and decide to be somewhere else. Two boyfriends looked at me long enough to get my clothes off and not one second longer.

He's reading me. The scar on my hip I got climbing a fence at nine. My shins. My tits, which are small and which I have never once thought about as anything but inconvenient in a sports bra, and which he is looking at as if somebody should have warned him.

My nipples go tight. It's cold in here, and he's colder.

I know exactly what my underwear looks like right now. Black and plain and soaked through at the front, and he can see it from the bed. He could smell it from the kitchen. I watched his nostrils go when I sat down across from him with the water.

"You're staring," I say.

"Yes."

"You said that last night."

"I meant it last night. Come closer. I want to see what I'm getting."

"You're not *getting* anything. I'm *giving*—"

"Then give it closer."

The sound that comes out of me is half a laugh and half the worst thing I've ever called a man, and I do it anyway.



I STAND BETWEEN his knees.

He puts his mouth on my stomach, just under my ribs, and my skin jumps under it. Cold lips. His breath doesn't warm anything. He drags his open mouth down, slow, all the way to the edge of my underwear.

I put my hand in his hair. I don't push and I don't pull. I just need somewhere to put my hand that isn't the wall.

"Who's had you like this?" he asks against my skin.

I go still.

The grammar of it. *Who's had you*. As if I'm a thing that gets had, and he wants the list.

"Nobody's *had* me."

"Who's touched you, then." His voice has gone somewhere low I haven't heard before. "Standing in your bedroom. Letting them look."

"Is that your business?"

"Tonight it is."

In English, that's jealousy. In wolf it's a man checking the boundary of ground he's decided to stand on. I don't know which one he means. I think, maybe, he doesn't either.

"Two boyfriends. One bad, one boring." I take a fistful of his hair and pull until he has to tip his head back and look up at me. "Neither of them's in this room, Your Majesty, so you can put your teeth away."

His teeth are out.

I watch him realize it. Something crosses his face that on anybody else I'd call embarrassment. Then he puts them away.

He did that because I told him to.

"Good," I say, and I climb into his lap.



I STRADDLE him with my knees on either side of his thighs. His hands are on my hips, and they're so slow about going anywhere that I take one and put it on my tit myself.

"Lucian."

I say his name without the title. His whole body does something when I say it. A tiny flinch, as if I've touched a bruise.

"Say it again," he tells me.

Of course he does.

"Lucian—"

"Again."

"*Lucian.*" I bite down on it. "Are you going to do something, or are you going to make me say your name all night?"

He laughs.

It comes out of him like he didn't approve it. A real laugh, short and rough and surprised, and I feel it in my thighs where I'm sitting on him. I've never heard him laugh. I didn't know he could.

Then he gets his hand into my underwear and I stop being able to talk.

His fingers are cold. My pussy is so hot and so wet that the first touch makes me flinch, and then I press down on them harder, because the cold is the best thing I've ever felt and I want more of it.

He pushes two fingers into me. I drop my forehead onto his shoulder and a sound comes out of me that I would deny under oath.

"Oh, *fuck*."

"Good girl."

He says it like a fact.

My cunt clenches around his fingers so hard that I feel him feel it. I'm going to have to have a long conversation with my body about loyalty, because it just picked a side without asking me.

I ride his fingers because I can't not. His thumb finds my clit and my hips buck. I roll them, and roll them, and my breath goes short and wet against his neck.

"Tell me," he says.

"Tell you what—"

"What you want."

"You know what I want. You can *smell* what I want."

"I want to hear it."

"God, you're—" I grind down on his fingers and my voice climbs into a register I didn't know I had. "Your cock. Okay? I want your cock. Happy?"

"Almost."

Almost. The arrogance of this man, bleeding on my sheets.



I GET IMPATIENT with my own body before he does.

I reach down and get his cock out of his trousers, and then I just hold it, and look at it, and have some very fast, very unhappy thoughts about the next few minutes.

"Oh, that's—" I stop. "That's going to be a problem."

"It won't be."

"It's *thick*."

"You'll take it."

He sounds so sure. It makes me want to prove him wrong and prove him right in the same breath.

"Is that a fact." I stroke him once, root to head, slow and mean, and watch his face go. "Say please."

"No."

I sink down on him anyway.



IT HURTS.

I want that on the page of myself somewhere, underlined. It hurts, and I'm not a virgin and I'm not delicate, and it still hurts. The head of him stretches me open and I hiss through my teeth and stop with both palms flat on his chest, breathing through my nose, eyes stinging.

"Fuck. *Fuck*. Okay. That hurts."

"I know."

"Don't say *I know* like you're *proud*—"

"I'm not proud."

He is. I can see it on him.

"Breathe," he says.

"I *am* breathing."

"Slower."

I get a little further and have to stop again. I put my forehead on his and just breathe, loud and ugly, like something caught in a trap and deciding whether to chew.

"Don't move," I tell him.

"I can't."

"Right." It comes out wet, half a laugh. "Right, that's actually handy."

I take the rest of him in one long grind that has both of us swearing. My thighs shake. My nails go into his shoulders hard enough to break the skin, and the skin doesn't close, and neither of us says anything about it.

Then I'm all the way down, and I just sit there.

Full. So full I can feel my own pulse around him.

"Jesus Christ," I say into his collarbone.

"Wrong name."

"Shut up. Oh my God, shut *up*."



THEN I MOVE.

Three strokes in, I understand the situation. He can't drive it. He can't flip me or pin me or hold my hips down and set the pace, the way I've been imagining since the corridor. His hands are on my hips and there's nothing in them.

I have all of it.

"You can't do anything," I say.

"No."

"You can't—" I roll my hips, hard, and he makes a noise that goes straight to my clit. "Oh, I like that. I like that a lot."

"I know you do. I can smell it."

So I fuck him like I'm angry at him, because I am. I'm angry about the hallway. I'm angry that he didn't see me in my own bar, and that he calls me a ghost like it's a name you give a pet. And I'm angriest that a man I should be afraid of is the first thing in my entire life that reached back.

I lift almost off him and drop. Lift and drop. The wet sound of it fills the room. My tits bounce against his chest and my nails are in his shoulders, and I find a twist at the bottom of the stroke by accident. Then I do it on purpose, grinding my clit down on him every single time I land, and his head falls back against my wall.

"Bite me," I say.

"Not yet."

"Why not—"

"Because when I do, it's finished." He gets his fist in my hair, the first real strength I've felt from him all night, and pulls my head back so I have to look at him. "You'll go up like dry paper, ghost. You won't get another hour out of me after that."

My whole body hears that before my brain does.

"Then make it count," I say.



I COME BEFORE he touches my throat.

He has his thumb on my clit and I'm riding him with my mouth open against his cheek, and it goes through me hard. My back arches. My pussy clamps down on him in long pulls, and I hear myself cry out, high and broken, not a sound I would ever make on purpose.

I don't stop. I can't. I ride it straight through and out the other side, still shaking, reaching for the next one.

"Now," I say. "Now, now—"

He takes me by the back of the neck, and I tip my head and give him my throat.

Give. I've never given anybody anything I couldn't get back.

His teeth go in. It isn't the corridor. In the corridor it happened *to* me. This I did, and my body knows the difference and lights up like a switchboard.

The pull comes, deep and slow, and I feel it in my throat and my nipples and my clit all at once, as if every nerve I own has a line running back to his mouth.

He told me it goes both ways. He's in there now, in whatever I'm feeling. I know it the way you know somebody's reading over your shoulder.

What's he finding?

I try to think about something clean. I can't. There's only what there is. The fear I've been carrying so long I forgot it had weight. The grief. The want, so raw it embarrasses me.

And something small at the very bottom, something I would never, ever say out loud.

Please don't be another thing that leaves.



I COME AGAIN with his teeth in me.

It's bigger than the first. My whole body locks and I sob into his hair and my cunt spasms around his cock in wave after wave. It comes twice

somehow, once in my body and once a heartbeat later somewhere deeper, arriving the way thunder arrives after you've already seen the flash.

He goes with me. I feel him come inside me while he's still drinking, feel the noise he makes vibrate through my throat, and I can't tell which of us is making which sound.

Then we're just two bodies on a cheap bed frame, and I'm shaking, and he's holding me together with arms he can barely lift.

He closes the wound with his tongue.

"Don't," I say.

"It's already done."

"I wanted—" My voice cracks, and I hate it, and I say it anyway. "I wanted to keep it for a bit."

He goes very still.

"Next time," he says.

I laugh into his neck, wet and wrecked. "Is that a threat?"

"It's a schedule."

"Oh my God. You're so annoying." I don't lift my head. "Do you ever just *say* things?"

"I just did."

"Hm."

I'm smiling against his skin. He can feel it. I don't care.



THIS IS THE part he doesn't get to see.

His skin still smells like cold stone and my blood, and underneath it the cloves I couldn't place in the corridor. My thighs are sore. My throat is tender where the mark was. My nails left marks in his shoulders that haven't closed, and there's a sentence in my head I'm too tired to translate.

The ghost that stayed.

In English, a ghost is a thing that won't leave. It lingers, and it haunts, and it doesn't know when it's not wanted.

In wolf there isn't a word for ghost at all. Nobody who dies stays. The pack eats the grief and moves on.

In his language, apparently, it means the one person who remembers him.

I should be scared of how much I like that.

I'm going to be, tomorrow. Tomorrow I'm going to wake up and remember that this is a pact, with terms and an end, and that the end is Rémy Thibodeaux on the far side of the water. I'm going to remember that I'm paying him, blood for a boat, and that nobody gets to keep the ferryman.

But his hand is on my back, and it isn't moving me anywhere, and the door of my bedroom is open the way it always is.

For the first time since the funeral, I don't want to be anywhere else.

I start to tell him that. I think I get as far as his name.

THE BLOOD CODE



Five books. One city. A different couple in each, and one question under all of them.

King of Teeth — Lucian and Selene

Vow of Poison — Silas and Ondine

Son of Wolves — Rémy and Isabeau

Heir of Ash — Tobias and Severine

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Dark Paradise — Lana Del Rey

Wicked Game — Chris Isaak

Everybody Wants to Rule the World — Lorde

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THANK YOU



Thank you for reading *King of Teeth*.

If Lucian and Selene got under your skin, the single best thing you can do for this book is leave a review. A line or two on Amazon or Goodreads helps new readers find it more than anything else in the world.

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Silas and Ondine are next, and *Vow of Poison* is up for pre-order now. Turn the page for the first chapter.

A FIRST LOOK AT BOOK TWO

Vow of Poison

CHAPTER ONE · SILAS

THE WITCH WHO nearly killed my king is making soup.

I can smell it from the road. Onion, bay, the dark roux her grandmother taught her, and something under it that isn't food. Rosemary burned on purpose. She does that when she's worried and doesn't want the house to know.

I've walked past this house most nights for a year.

I walk past because some nights her bedroom window is open, and I can smell her from the gate: rosemary and warm skin and, late, after her lamp goes out, the sharp sweet musk of a woman touching herself in the dark. I know that smell. I've stood under her streetlamp with my cock hard in my trousers and my jaw locked, listening to her breathing change through the shutters, listening to her come, and then I've walked home.

I've never once gone in.

I tell myself it's the route. It isn't the route. The route goes along the canal and this house is a turn off it, and I take the turn, and I've never once written it down.

Tonight I stop at the gate.



SOMEBODY STOOD on her step.

A man. Good shoes, thin soles, the kind that don't know what mud is. He came up the walk slowly and stopped at the second board, the one that gives, and he stayed on it. Weight on the left foot. Then the right. Then the left again.

He didn't knock.

He wanted her to hear the board and wonder. He stood there long enough for the worry to get into the rosemary.

Then he left, and he didn't hurry that either.

I know the shoes. I've been following those shoes around this city since the crowning, a step behind, and every time I get close he's been somewhere else first and left a door open behind him, polite as a wedding guest.

Absalom Cray has been on Ondine Marchand's porch.

I was on the other side of the canal, asking a man about a boat.

I was—

It doesn't matter where I was.



SHE OPENS THE kitchen door before I reach it.

"You're letting the cold in," she says.

"I haven't come in yet."

"You're letting it in from out there. I can feel you thinking at my porch." She stands aside. "In or out, Silas. The roux's at the stage where it'll burn if I look at it wrong."

I go in.

The kitchen is what it always is. Jars on every shelf, labeled in a hand I can read and a script I can't. Bundles hanging from the beams. The long table scarred with a hundred years of knives, and at the far end of it, a working half-finished under a cloth. Her cat is asleep on the sill in a patch of lamp and pretends I don't exist, which is the only courtesy I've ever had from a cat.

She goes back to the stove. She's barefoot. She's wearing a man's cardigan with holes in both elbows, and her hair is up in a knot with a pencil through it, and there's flour on her jaw she doesn't know about. Her nipples are hard against the wool. Her bare thighs flash pale under the hem when she reaches for the salt, and I look at the stove instead.

She's forty-one. She looks thirty. She looks like she hasn't slept since the poison.

She looks like a woman I'd like to put on her own table. I'd like to push that cardigan off her shoulders and spread her thighs and find out whether her pussy tastes like the rosemary she burns. I've thought about her tits under that wool more nights than I'll ever admit. I've thought about her mouth. I've thought about her on her knees on these boards, and on her back on this table, and I've never touched her. Not once. Not a fucking finger.

"Sit," she says.

I don't sit.

"Suit yourself." She pours a cup from the pot at the back of the stove without turning around. Sets it at the end of the table where I always stand. Doesn't ask how I take it.

She's never once asked how I take it. She's never once been wrong.

I drink it.



"Somebody was on your step," I say.

Her spoon stops. Then it goes on stirring.

"Was somebody."

"Tonight. Before dark. He stood on the board that gives and waited for you to hear it."

"I heard it."

"You didn't open the door."

"I'm a witch, Silas. Not an idiot." She taps the spoon on the rim of the pot. "I heard a man stand on my step for as long as it takes to make a woman nervous, and then I heard him leave, and then I burned a great deal of rosemary."

"He left something."

She turns around.

"Under the mat," I say. "He crouched. The left knee. There's a mark in the dust where it went down."

She wipes her hands on a towel and walks past me, close enough that I have to turn my shoulder, and she opens the front door and bends and lifts the corner of the mat.

There's an envelope. Cream. Heavy stock. Sealed with wax, and pressed into the wax, a small neat mark I've never seen before.

She doesn't touch it.

"You picked it up with your eyes before I did," she says.

"Don't touch it with your hands."

"I wasn't going to touch it with my hands." She takes the tongs off the hook by the door. The fireplace tongs, iron, black with years of use. She lifts the envelope with them like a dead mouse and carries it back to the table and sets it down on the cloth over the working.

Then she looks at the seal and all the color goes out of her face.

"I know that mark," she says.



SHE OPENS IT with a knife that has never cut food.

Inside, one page. I can read it upside down. I read everything upside down. It's the first thing you learn when you're standing behind a man at a desk.

The Marchand obligation falls due at the new moon. A. Cray, broker, will accept the stated collateral.

Under that, a copy of a signature. Old ink, a woman's hand, careful and upright. Just the surname. *Marchand.*

Under that, the collateral.

One word.

Ondine.

She reads it twice. Her mouth doesn't move. The roux on the stove starts to catch, a sweet burnt smell creeping in at the edge, and she doesn't turn around to save it.

I reach past her and take the pot off the heat.

"She signed my name," Ondine says. "She signed my name before I was born."

"Your grandmother."

"She put up my name as surety. For the line. For the debt. And then she died with it in a drawer and never told me." She laughs, and it isn't a laugh. "You can use salt for bone, you know. If you have to. You can use bone for hair, at a pinch. There's nothing you can use for a name."

"Ondine."

"I brewed that poison to pay the interest on this." She puts the page down very carefully, like it might go off. "I didn't ask who it was for. I never ask. Not knowing was the only clean thing I had left in this house."

"I know."

"You *know*." Her eyes come up. "You've known since the day you walked in here with Lucian and a sick man's blood on his sleeve. You knew I made it. You sat at my table and drank my coffee and you knew."

"Yes."

"And you didn't take me in."

"No."

"Why not?"

I open my mouth.

I've answered most of the questions anyone has asked me. The ones I haven't answered are about me.

"Because I—"

The sentence has nowhere to go.

"It doesn't matter why," I say.

"It matters to *me*."

"It doesn't matter." I take the paper out of my coat. Mine, not his. Folded once, with my own hand on the front. "This does."



SHE READS IT standing up.

I watch her read it. I watch her find the seal, the King's seal, the wax gone soft from three months in a coat pocket, and the signature under it,

which is Lucian's and still looks like it was written by a man with blood drying on his wrists. I watch her get to the line that says *the Marchand house and its keeper* and stop.

"A writ of protection," she says.

"Yes."

"Signed by the crown."

"Yes."

"How did you get the King of New Orleans to sign a writ of protection for the witch who poisoned him?"

"I asked."

She stares at me.

"You've never asked him for anything," she says slowly. "Everybody knows that. Aurelian bought you out of that — out of wherever you were — and you never once said thank you, and you never once asked, and you *asked him for this*."

"He didn't read it."

"Silas."

"He'd just killed his uncle. He'd have signed a laundry list."

"*Silas*."

I don't say anything else. I've already said more tonight than in the last month, and my throat feels like it's been used.

She puts the writ down beside Cray's letter. The two papers lie next to each other on the cloth. One of them takes her name. One of them is my name, put where it shouldn't go.

She looks at them for a long time.

Then she crosses the kitchen to me, barefoot on the boards, and stops in front of me.

She's close. I can smell the rosemary on her, and the roux, and under that just her. Clean skin. Flour. A woman who has been afraid all evening in her own house and is done being afraid.

She reaches up and takes my hand.

My right hand. The scarred one. She turns it over and looks at the palm, where the old burns are, the ones that never healed right because I

was turned too soon after I got them. Nobody looks at that hand. I keep it in my coat.

She runs her thumb over the worst of the scars.

I don't move. I have stood still under a lot of things in my life. I've never stood this still. My cock is so hard it hurts. Her thumb is on my palm and every nerve still alive in that dead skin is standing up, and all I can think about is that thumb on my cock, her fist around me, her wet mouth, her thighs spread on this scarred table under the lamp.

"That'll cost," she says quietly. "You know that. A writ from the crown. It'll cost you with the court, and with him, and with whatever you are when you're not standing at the end of my table."

"I know."

"You spent your one favor on me."

"I had one." My voice does something I don't let it do. "I wasn't—"

"You weren't what?"

"Using it."

She smiles. It's small and tired and it goes straight through me.

"You're a terrible liar," she says.

"I'm an excellent liar."

"Not in my kitchen."

Her thumb stays on my palm.

I want her on her back on this table with her knees spread and her hips in my fists. I want to lick her until she's wet and shaking and coming on my tongue, and then fuck her until she forgets the man on her step. I want it so badly my throat aches.

I don't move.



THE KNOCK COMES at the front door.

Three knocks. Even. Unhurried. The rhythm of a man who has already decided what the knocking means.

Her hand goes still in mine.

I know the knock. I've never heard it, and I know it. It's the knock of a man who could have walked in and chose not to, so that the choosing would be the first thing you learned about him.

The cat on the sill wakes up and flattens itself to the glass.

"That'll be him," Ondine says. Very calm. Too calm. "He said the new moon. It isn't the new moon."

"He's early."

"He's never early. He's never anything but exactly on time."

"Then he's here for me."

She looks up at me. Her grip tightens on my hand.

"Stay behind me," I tell her.

"It's my house."

"Witch."

"It is my *house*, Silas Roche, and I have never once in my life stood behind a man in my own—"

"Tonight you do."

I watch her decide. I watch her not like it.

She lets go of my hand.

She steps behind me.

I cross the kitchen and put my palm flat on the front door and feel the man on the other side of it. Warm. Patient. Smiling, even through wood. Standing on the board that gives, and not shifting his weight at all.

I open the door.

Absalom Cray is on the step in a good coat and thin-soled shoes, holding a bottle of wine by the neck like a gift.

"Mr. Roche," he says, delighted. "I was so hoping you'd be here. It saves me a trip."



Vow of Poison — The Blood Code, Book Two. Silas & Ondine.

Available for pre-order now. Silas has been walking past her house for a year. Find out what happens when he goes in.

END OF BOOK ONE



The Blood Code continues with Silas & Ondine in

VOW OF POISON